Kingdom of Stars

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/32485318.

Rating:
Explicit

Archive Warning:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence

Category:
F/F, F/M, M/M

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Mermista/Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Perfuma/Scorpia (She-Ra), Kyle/Lonnie/Rogelio (She-Ra)

Character:
Castaspella (She-Ra), Finn | Adora/Catra Child (She-Ra), Netossa (She-Ra), Spinnerella (She-Ra), Huntara (She-Ra), Frosta (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Explicit Sexual Content, Blood and Violence

Language:
English

Series:
Part 2 of Tapestry of Time

Stats:
Published: 2021-07-10 Completed: 2021-10-09 Words: 128,646 Chapters: 13/13

Kingdom of Stars

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/32485318.

Rating:
Explicit

Archive Warning:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence

Category:
F/F, F/M, M/M

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Mermista/Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Perfuma/Scorpia (She-Ra), Kyle/Lonnie/Rogelio (She-Ra)

Character:
Castaspella (She-Ra), Finn | Adora/Catra Child (She-Ra), Netossa (She-Ra), Spinnerella (She-Ra), Huntara (She-Ra), Frosta (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Explicit Sexual Content, Blood and Violence

Language:
English

Series:
Part 2 of Tapestry of Time

Stats:
Published: 2021-07-10 Completed: 2021-10-09 Words: 128,646
Chapters: 13/13

Kingdom of Stars

by Faded_Glory

Summary

The ancient past begins to unfold, as Catra begins her journey towards her own destiny. As Adora is drawn into the mysteries of She-Ra that surround Mystacor.

Notes

This is Part Two: I hope you all enjoy this story as much as the first.

Hordak

Scorpia sat in silent awe. Watching the thin wisps of white clouds flowing swiftly over the view screen. As Mystacor ascended back into the heavens under its own power. The high pitched hum of Darla's engines began to abate. The low vibration created by the harmonics of the Thulite fell into the background. As Arxia cut it's link to Darla's crystal core. Scorpia's focus was drawn to the subtle weight of Catra slumped in her lap, her low soothing purr. That was easing the Scorpioni into a relaxed stupor. The rush of adrenaline and fear was ebbing away, leaving Catra in a peaceful state of pure exhaustion.

“That was close...” Scorpia breathed out in a hushed voice. Finally allowing her muscles to loosen and slump against the back of the command chair, her pinchers dangling low over the arm rests. She numbly watched Entrapta still working at the front terminals. Some screens had data code scrolling down while another was filled with the three dimensional network of the Clones, Hive Mind. The spider web connections slowly came alive as their combined consciousness began to seed themselves into the thousands of mainframes all over the planet. When the last of the connections began to glow, completing the download. Entrapta slowly closed all the screens, except for one. The screen that held the golden webbing of the hive mind network. Then she reluctantly closed that screen as well, her movements had a heavy finality to them. Then Entrapta raised her head up and screamed at the top of her lungs. Gripping the sides of the forward control panels, she screamed again at the view screen. Her voice cracking and becoming shrill and broken. She took a deep, shaky breath and flipped her mask down over her face. Her body slowly slipping onto the floor as if she was a deflating balloon.

“Entrapta...” Scorpia inquired, softly. As Entrapta folded into herself, her arms clenched around her middle, legs crossed tightly under her. Her pig tails wrapped themselves around her body several times over until she was completely hidden. As her

shoulder's began shaking violently, miserable sobs echoed from beneath her hair cocoon.

Scorpia was quick to sit up, as Catra scrambled out of her lap. Dashing to Entrapta's side, she knelt down beside her. Catra had her hands thrust between her legs, to prevent herself from reaching out, nervous about touching her. She was alarmed and shaken to her core by the sheer fury and unbridled emotion that had just ripped out of Entrapta.

Entrapta had locked herself away from them completely, forming a quaking ball of purple hair. They could hear her muffled whimpers, her low growling and quiet sobs. The raw devastation of a complete emotional meltdown. As she rocked back and forth, shivering and shaking from the aftermath of her emotional eruption.

Scorpia was overcome by the need to comfort her and crouched down, spreading her pinchers wide, ready to wrap Entrapta into a gentle hug. Catra had no time to react, or talk her out of it. Some people did not like to be held when they were so overwhelmed. She was speaking of herself mostly, she had gotten violent in the past when Scorpia had sought to touch her, or hug her when she was so raw with emotion. She was concerned, she didn't know how Entrapta would react to Scorpia's more aggressive kind of comfort.

Scorpia merely swooped in and picked Entrapta up, holding her gently against her chest, applying just a bit of pressure. The woman squeaked at suddenly being enveloped in someone's arms. As Scorpia merely settled herself down on the floor beside Catra. Her arms folded securely around Entrapta, who was now settled in her lap. The huge mass of her purple hair that was surrounding her body, now a big poof, overflowing Scorpia's strong arms. Entrapta's loud, gasping sobs turned silent in an instant and she began to relax into the shelter of Scorpia's weighted embrace.

“Did you squeeze her too hard and kill her?” Catra muttered, giving Scorpia a fearful glance at the sudden silence.

“No...She likes this.” Scorpia stated, somberly. “And I am not squeezing her hard at all!” She snapped back, aghast that Catra would think that.
Catras' ears twitched as she listened to Entrapta's soft breathing and now quiet crying.

“Holding her against me, like this. It makes her feel safe and gives her comfort.” Scorpia shrugged, “I've had to do this before, she had a similar meltdown after Shadow Weaver attacked us. I mean she kept it together for a little while, got the Black Garnet weapon up and running. But she had never dealt with another person trying to kill her before. The stress and anxiety of the event kinda gave her brain an overload. While you went to check on Shadow Weaver in the holding cells. I was dealing with Entrapta freaking out in her lab, screaming, throwing things and pacing for what seemed like forever. I didn't know what to do at first, then I just swooped in and hugged her, it was just instinct for me. She calmed down immediately. Then we had a long talk about what happened and how she just gets overwhelmed sometimes and freaks out. She had been dealing with a-lot of stress and anxiety since being left behind by the Princesses. Then Shadow Weaver's attempt to kill us was just the catalyst that set her off. She explained how she hates feeling so out of control of her emotions but has a hard time getting herself to calm down. She flips her mask down to try and cut back on the amount of stimulus unsettling her, but sometimes that doesn't work either. She thanked me and was intrigued by how my hug had calmed her so quickly. Soooo, this time I knew how to soothe her.”

“Scorpia...I.” Catra floundered weakly, at a loss as to what to say. She had been completely useless in helping Entrapta. She never put in the effort to get to know either of them. Selfishly caught up in her own bitterness and trust issues after Adora left. She had been so terrible to both of them. But Scorpia always put in the work, always tried to connect and be a good friend. To Entrapta and herself, even when she didn't deserve it. Scorpia was the sort

of friend, she aspired to become. Then she smiled softly to herself and chuckled.

“That's why you wrapped me up in that blanket when I was freaking out over Shadow Weaver escaping!” Catra stated, leaning back and regarding the taller woman with a knowing smirk.

“Yeah, I hoped since it calmed Entrapta it would work on you....cause you were scaring me, big time!” Scorpia sighed, casting Catra a small apologetic smile.

“I ripped that blanket to shreds and nearly did the same to you.” Catra groaned, feeling guilty about her violent over reaction.

“I was over bearing with you at the time. Forcing my embrace on you when you were not wanting it. I was insensitive to your feelings and need for personal space, sorry.” Scorpia stated softly.

Catra laughed, “I was rather prickly at the time.”

“You were honestly a real hot mess for years, Wild Cat.” Scorpia smirked, waggling her eyebrows teasingly.

Catra cast her a lingering stare of confusion. Wondering lamely if Scorpia had just tried to flirt with her. It brought into focus a-lot of other playful confrontations they had had over the years, that Catra had been honestly just ignoring.

Scorpia quickly cleared her throat and rolled her shoulders, focusing on Entrapta again. “Relax, Wild Cat.” Scorpia chuckled, catching onto her sudden unease, her words carrying a double meaning. “We just need to be here, let Entrapta know we care and that we are not going anywhere. Until we know she is feeling alright again.”

“Right.” Catra nodded, kneeling beside Scorpia. She reached up a hand and placed it tenderly on Entrapta's giant hair shelter. Slowly, gently stroking her fingers down her hair and repeating the process. She had her claws mostly retracted but the tips still

poked from her fingers. Combing soothingly threw Entrapta's long strands of hair. She didn't know if this action would help, but being petted soothed her when she was upset. At least when Adora did it, she still had trouble allowing anyone else to show her such gentle affection. Catra understood better than most the instinct to hide when you felt out of control and vulnerable.

"You hear that Entrapta. We're here. Scorpia and I are not going anywhere until you're ok." She finished, her voice quiet and full of empathy.

Scorpia held Entrapta as time passed, while Catra soothed her with soft pets from both of her hands. Gently brushing her claws threw the long strands of Entrapta's hair, combing it tenderly. As the clouds beyond the view screen started to glow with the brilliant hues of evening. The faint light filtering through the forward view screen. Casting the tender moment of sweet comfort passing between the three of them in a gentle, soothing aura.

Catra had sealed her heart away after Adora left, she had felt abandoned, rejected...betrayed. Unable to deal with being hurt like that again, she had kept Scorpia and Entrapta at arm's length. As the years went by, she ended up betraying one friend and pushing the other away. But slowly, slowly over the last half a year. She began to open up, but only around those she trusted. This tentative circle of trust had been expanding, now she had several close friendships that she had come to rely on. In turn she had begun to reach out and seek to reciprocate all the trust, kindness and understanding she had received. It was freeing and terrifying at the same time. But she was never going back to that lonely, dark place she had lived in for years back at the Fright Zone ever again.

In time, Catra had unintentionally brushed both ponytails free from being wrapped around Entrapta. Her long hair hung limply over one of Scorpia's arms, one lavender tail draped behind Entrapta's back, one hanging over her chest. The ends dangling over Scorpia's elbow, slack and lifeless. Entrapta had stopped crying and was merely leaning back against Scorpia's chest. Her

mask was down, her head bowed, breathing even and shallow as if she was sleeping. It looked more like she was meditating, but more deeply.

“You think she can, like, turn herself off like a computer?” Catra whispered curiously, in case she was just asleep.

“She went like this before, it's fine. She said after she has an 'overload', as she calls it. She needs to reboot her systems...this is what that looks like.” Scorpia smiled, fondly down at Entrapta.

“So she can turn herself off, like a computer.” Catra smirked, crossing her arms over her chest, smugly. “I want to learn to do that...it looks so peaceful.” She whispered to herself. She would love to just turn off her mind, her emotions and that awful voice that always taunted her with her insecurities. Needling her with doubt over the intentions of others. Mocking her, beating her down with her lack of self worth and her many, many shortcomings.

“Yeah, I guess so.” Scorpia chuckled fondly, her arms starting to relax. Adjusting them so they hung lightly around Entrapta’s knees.

Slowly, sluggishly, Entrapta came alive once more. Her masked face glanced up at Scorpia and then turned towards Catra. The large insectoid shaped visors that covered her eyes, reflecting the concerned faces of her friends. Silently, she acknowledged both of them. Then in time she started to shift in Scorpia's lap, flipping up her mask with a deep, settling breath. She pulled her knees out from under her and pressed them up against her chest.

Catra kept her expression calm, at the sight of the tear tracks down Entrapta's cheeks, her red and puffy eyes. Her marron eyes were dull, staring vacantly out over the command deck. Unwilling to make eye contact with anyone. Entrapta frowned deeply at her boots, her eyebrows furrowed in silent misery. Still dealing with her anguish but she had herself under control again.

“Hordak is gone, now.” She muttered, bracing her elbows on her knees and cupping her cheeks with both gloved hands.

Catra glanced up at the vacant control dash, her expression grim.

“But not forever, right.” Scorpia encouraged. “The sacrifice he made was important, but temporary. He and his brethren saved us. It's kinda bitter sweet but not without hope.”

Catra blinked in surprise at how attune Scorpia was to what Entrapta needed to hear. Now that she was putting in the effort to get to know the people around her, she was finding them all to be exceptional, in their own ways. Scorpia was so strong and resilient when it came to dealing with an emotional crisis. She never froze up like Catra. She knew exactly what needed to be done and went into action without any doubts. Catra admired her in so many ways.

Scorpia glanced sideways catching Catra smiling up at her with very clear admiration. The scorpioni blushed and refocused her attention back on Entrapta.

“I know that, but it doesn't make it less painful.” Entrapta sulked, rising to her feet.

“Thank you again, Scorpia. I am glad you are my friend.” She offered, cutting her eyes towards Catra bashfully. “I liked how your claws felt in my hair, too.” She gave Catra a small pleased smile.

“Anytime, 'Trapta.” Catra blushed as well, suddenly very nervous about the praise.

Comforting anyone other than Adora was way out of her expertise. But she was not going to ignore her friends when they were in pain, just because it made her feel uncomfortable or inadequate. She was going to put in the effort. Try to make them feel better in her own ways and not over think it too much.

“Well...are you ok now?” Catra stumbled, scowling down at her hands in her lap as she lost her nerve to reach out any more than that. She was really not good at this...friendship thing, but at least she was trying.

“Yes.” Entrapta stated, moving towards the control panel. “But I need to go up to the Sky Tree now and check on Hordak and his brothers....Wrong Hordak needs to explain to me exactly what Hordak's plan was. Since he never did.” Her face fell into a frustrated scowl.

“Ok...but we got a ton of people on board right now?” Scorpia stated, rising to her feet.

“Darla, set course for the Sky Tree.” Entrapta stated, as if she hadn't heard Scorpia. She was focused on what she wanted to do, blocking out everything and everyone else.

“Entrapta?” Catra moved to Entrapta's side, placing a hand on her shoulder trying to get her attention so she would listen. They couldn't just take off into space with a bunch of civilians on board.

[Course set, Entrapta.] Darla's voice echoed through the bridge, as the engine's thrum intensified. Catra and Scorpia shot their gazes to the view screen in fright as Mystacor fell away, replaced by the glorious evening sky streaming past at great speeds. Within seconds the expanse of starlight dominated the wall to wall view screens, as the glowing branches full of lush green leaves of the Sky Tree came into view in the distance.

[Incoming Communication.] Darla's voice echoed out a few moments later.

“Patch it threw.” Catra groaned, moving away from Entrapta to the other side of the bridge to receive the inevitable response. They had just kidnapped a bunch of citizens and were now dragging all

those innocent people into space against their will. Sparkles was going to be thrilled!

“What is going on!” Glimmer's frantic voice echoed, threw the Ship's glowing orb of communication.

“I guess we are taking a short detour up to the Sky tree.” Catra sighed heavily.

“What...why...Catra?” Glimmer was fighting to keep her voice calm. “You got a ship full of civilians...now is not the best time to go on a mission to space!”

“I will go check on the Etherian's.” Scorpia offered, heading out of the command deck. “ Frosta's down in the hold, I will let her know what's going on and that she's going to have to help us keep everyone calm, till we can get back planetside.” She called back before the doors hissed shut.

“Take a deep breath, Sparkles.” Catra stated, glancing back at Entrapta sadly. “I can handle all this.” She assured her, wanting to ease the anxiety she knew was now rushing over the Queen.

“Catra....what is going on?” Glimmer's voice was restrained, unwilling to lose her cool again with Catra. She had had a long talk with Bow after her last less than stellar Princess Alliance meeting. He had helped her work out some of her control issues. Advising her to ease up a little and perhaps have a bit more faith in her friends. So she had come to accept that they were both leaders and she would treat Catra with the respect she deserved. Catra had nearly led the Horde to victory, if it hadn't been for Double Trouble's betrayal. Or Horde Primes intervention and her bad decision of using the Heart. Catra would be ruling Etheria right now, under Hordak's banner. So Glimmer had to admit that she may have been a better commander then she was.

“Entrapta is having a hard time letting go of Hordak. She needs to check in on him. We shouldn't be gone long. I will get everyone home in one piece, I promise.” Catra stated.

“I know you will, Catra. Please keep me informed if anything goes wrong.” Glimmer conceded, her voice this time was calm and full of confidence.

“Thanks, Glimmer.” Catra smiled, gratefully cutting the communication. Glimmer's trust in her this time did not go unnoticed.

Finn shuffled their bare feet, as they walked in forlorn silence behind Prince Peekablue. They were slowly making their way down a dirt path. Heading towards the northern side of the island. The seer kept glancing over his shoulder, as if uncertain that Finn would keep their word and follow. The magicat was conflicted and very upset about leaving their mother's side. They kept glancing over their shoulder, as the outer walls of Mystacor fell away behind the distant hills. They had left the manicured Tranquil gardens a while back and were now treading into the more lush and natural landscape of the northern foothills. That surrounded the central mountain of Mystacor. Peekablue was slowly leading them upward, through the narrow rocky trails that winded towards the barren peek of the mountain.

“Finn...would you like to tell me what happened in the future that would push you to such a desperate plan?” He asked, gently.

“Don't you already know?” Finn asked with confusion.

“Not anymore.” Prince Peekablue laughed gently. “The future in this dimension is now in flux, the previous future has been wiped from my memory. Right now, the future...is completely blank.”

“oh...I guess I did that, huh?” Finn laughed nervously, rubbing the back of their neck with one hand, while their other hand was thrust deep into the pocket of their dark shorts fingering the shard of Kaydak nervously.

“Kiddo...you placed a really big responsibility on your own shoulders by traveling through the Crossroads of Worlds.” Peekablue sighed, turning to crouch before Finn and grasping their small shoulder's firmly.

Finn held their breath, their gaze once again held firm by Peekablues intense stare.

“Etheria was being purged...for it's magic.” Finn answered crisply, tears threatening.

“By Eternia.” Peekablue sighed, his eyes turning dark with turbulent visions of an all consuming void, devouring all life on Etheria. As Finn's words allow him to thread his magic of farsight to the alternate future that once was.

“The queens joined forces with other worlds, Etheria went to war....to defend Mara's legacy. The rebellion went far beyond Etheria this time, as the enslaved worlds rose up against the Galactic Emperor.” Finn sighed,

“Horde Prime is gone in this dimension.” Peekablue stated in confusion.

“Horde Prime did not enslave worlds. He annihilated them outright. In his efforts to wipe all the unworthy from the universe.” Finn growled.

“But Horde Prime chipped most of Etheria?” Peekablue arched a confused eyebrow.

“Because he wanted to hurt my mom, Adora. He wanted to use her closest friends to torment her, distract her, while he stole the Heart. He had already seen how effective it was at hurting her, when he had used my mom, Catra as a hostage.” Finn sighed. “Horde Prime was no conqueror, he was a force of mass extinction...a husk corrupted by a fragment of the Nameless One. Who sought only to bring oblivion upon our universe. The Galactic Emperor I speak of, is Lord Skeletor. He spent the last thousand years enslaving worlds, stealing their star seeds to make his own

magic more powerful. In my timeline, he managed to find all the shards of the Crystal of Kaydak and resurrected the Nameless One. He thought he could control Gorta's deep magic within the facets of an amulet, as if it was just a mere star seed. But in truth the crystal had been created by the combined magic of several worlds to trap Gorta's himself thousands of years prior. Then it was shattered over five thousand years later, to weaken Gorta. So that vile sorcerer could be sealed in the timeless dimension and never resurrect the Nameless One. So that the darkness he had sealed into his own soul, could not devour our universe."

Peekablue took a shaky breath, gripping Finn's shoulder's in horror. He knew some of the history of Gorta. He was an ancient mage who sought deep magic and was consumed by it. He had created the spell of obtainment, becoming a magical parasite who in the course of prolonging his own life for thousands of years. Had managed to absorb enough magic that his power would rival that of the Gods themselves.

"The queens tried to invoke Sanctuary but it was incomplete." Finn moaned, the tragic memories bringing them to tears. Their expression crumpled into anguish, tears flowed down their cheeks as they slowly bowed their head.

"Why?" Peekablue was unfamiliar with that spell, it sounded ancient like deep magic. Which made him wary, why would the Queens become so desperate as to rely on a dangerous spell?

"One of the Queens was killed before the spell could be completed." Finn moaned, squeezing their eyes shut with guilt. As a broken sob escaped their lips. They quickly clamped their mouth shut, stubbornly refusing to cry.

"Who?" Peekablue's eyes narrowed in rage.

Finn raised their head, eyes burning with self hatred. "It was my fault." They breathed out in a huff. As more hot tears streamed down their cheeks.

“Ok....Finn. Settle down.” Peekablue, shook their shoulder's sharply then pulled them against their side. Finn clutched onto Peekablues hip, their claws digging into the fabric of his frilly shirt, pressing their face tight against his side. Their muffled, heart broken cries rose faintly into the still air of the mountain pass.

Peekablue merely sighed and wrapped both arms around the young magicat, allowing the feline to grieve. Wondering grimly what tragedy awaited them so far in the future now. His vigilance upon the future would have to become even more serious. His magic took a lot out of him both physically and emotionally. He had spent years denying its existence, running from his responsibilities. Too selfish and too entitled to want to give up his life of pleasure and opulence for a thankless destiny. It had taken a vision of a severe elemental imbalance, that would wipe out all of Etheria if he didn't intercede. To finally give him the wake up call he needed to embrace his own magic. So he had made the trek to the Kingdom of Snows, using the Princess Ball as a cover for his true intentions. So that he could have a much needed audience with Princess Frosta. Who had no interest in joining the Alliance at all, nearly having him escorted out of her palace at the first mention of it. He had been polite, even kind at first. But she was far too proud and stubborn to hear him out. So he grew impatient and rather rude with his next attempt a few weeks later after the Ball. Threatening her with the consequences of her hubris. Convincing her not to ignore the distress beacon from Bright Moon when it came in a few months and to join the Alliance. Or suffer the consequences of her stubbornness, which would not just be her kingdom's demise but the whole world. If the princesses could not come together and fight as one, then all of Etheria would perish in the coming storm. Frosta had taken his words seriously and did as she was told. Going straight to Bright Moon to aid in the battle, when the beacon summoned her. With all the princesses fighting together, She-Ra's magic was able to balance all their magic once more. The princesses' magic had harmonized for the first time and beat back the Horde. It had been several years since that fateful vision and he was fully invested in the greater purpose of his magic. The threat of the

Nameless One that lay ahead for them all, left him cold inside with true fear.

“Well, Darlings. If it's not too much trouble. I would like to start my audition then.” Double Trouble stated in a silky smooth voice, as they cleared their throat to announce their presence. Striding into view around a granite boulder further up the path, moving briskly down the narrow bend of the well worn trail.

Prince Peekablue pulled away from Finn, who shot out of his embrace. Racing up the path to Double Trouble at full speed. The chameleon had been standing only a few feet ahead, their yellow eyes widened in shock. As they raised their hands up to try and ward off the young magicats charge. Finn slammed into Double Trouble at full speed, wailing in grief, wrapping their arms around the lizard with all their strength. Double Trouble had just enough time to spread their legs apart to absorb the young feline’s impact. They stared down in nervous dismay at the crying child, now clutching onto their waist as if their life depended on it. Soaking their dark leather bodysuit with their tears.

“There...there...” Double Trouble patted the young cats back awkwardly. Casting Peekablue pleading looks to come save them.

“I've missed you so much....Auncle.” Finn nuzzled their face into Double Troubles stomach, purring loudly.

“Wha...” Double Trouble's long pointed ears lowered, as they raised their hands up in shock.

“This little kitten is from the future, DT.” Peekablue smirked. “It seems you mean a lot to them.”

“I mean a lot to many people, Blue. For many different reasons...” Double Trouble started with mild humor, casting Finn an awkward, toothy smile.

Finn pulled away with a brilliant smile of their own, beaming up at Double Trouble. “You raised me and the rest of us kids, after....our parents were...” Finn's smile evaporated into a pained expression.

They quickly detached from Double Trouble and stood shamefully nearby, watching their feet kick at loose stones. Suddenly realizing that this Double Trouble was not their true Auncle. That they were just making the poor shape shifter feel uncomfortable with their affection.

“Were they killed?” Peekablue asked, softly.

“I don't know. After my mom was murdered, the spell sorta backfired and all the queens just disappeared. Uncle Bow and Uncle SeaHawk were taken prisoner and shipped off the planet to a prison asteroid. Uncle Hordak was executed as a traitor, before his brethren were exterminated from every planet under Skeletor’s control. Then Skeletor imprisoned each of us kids in our own castles. Double Trouble went to each of our Kingdoms and freed us. You gathered us all together and kept us hidden for years in a underground compound deep in the Whispering Woods. You would never tell us how you knew about that place. Or how you knew where Skeletor hid us. You were not around us kids much, always out on missions for our parents. Not until after the Queens disappeared. Then you never left our side. You looked out for us, kept us safe....right up until the end.” Finn offered Double Trouble a watery smile.

Double Trouble's hand was braced against their chest and they were breathing hard. Overwhelmed by Finn's heroic description of themself in the future and their eventual demise. “I died...”

“Yes...you stayed behind when the Nameless One devoured Etheria. You kept the Seeker Drones off of us, so us kids could board Darla and get off the planet.” Finn nodded, their eyes suddenly going wide in horror. As they snapped their gaze fearfully at Peekablue. “Will telling you guys all this affect the future?”

“No...right now your dark future does not exist.” Peekablue offered with a warm smile.

“Good riddance!” Finn grinned.

“Alright let’s get this over with.” Double Trouble huffed, transforming into Finn with a cocky smile.

Peekablue walked briskly up to Double Trouble, thrusting the broken amulet into their hands. The feline Double Trouble looked down at the broken metal blossom shaped amulet curiously.

“What am I supposed to do with this?” They inquired in Finn's melodic voice.

“The amulet holds the transformation you gave me to disguise myself.” Finn offered, crossing their arms behind their back. Bowing their head in remorse at breaking their Auncle’s hard work.

“Ah....a blind audition then.” Double Trouble stated in Finn’s voice. “I could never back down from a challenge.” They quickly transformed back into their original form, glaring down at the broken amulet. “I have no idea what this is.”

“Well, you have a debt to repay shapeshifter so I guess you will need to figure it out.” Peekablue smirked, crossing his arms over his chest.

Double Trouble scowled petulantly at Peekablue.

“You stole my identity for profit, DT.” Peekablue raised an accusing eyebrow. “Tarnished my reputation with that chipping fiasco you led all those innocent people into back at the Hidden Grotto.”

“That wasn’t my fault! How would I know that Prime was targeting Princesses?” Double Trouble groused, folding their arms over their chest in indignation.

Prince Peekablue merely glared threateningly at them.

Double Trouble groaned and rolled their eyes. “Fine, what is this thing kid.”

They shook the amulet pieces lightly at Finn in irritation. Their yellow eyes going wide in surprise when a couple crystal’s embedded into the amulet wobbled and nearly fell out. Mentally scolding themself to be more careful with the magic trinket.

“It's a transformation amulet but its broken...the magic glyph etched in the lotus will not activate any longer. It will not transform you.” Finn stated.

“But I don't need this amulet to transform, I need to know what your disguise looked like.” Double Trouble stated in a sickeningly sweet tone as they desperately sought to remain polite as their frustration rose.

“Oh....right.” Finn nodded eagerly. They pointed to the face of the amulet with a dark claw. “I was a Thaymorian boy if that helps?”

Double Trouble apprised Finn then, their keen yellow eyes scrutinized every physical characteristic, quickly coming to a conclusion. “My, my...looks like my kitten got busy.... Your cute, a bit slow.” Double Trouble smirked, shrugging their shoulders. “I can tell you’re Adora's kid. Tootles.” They called, giving them a flippant wave as they went striding away with a light, airy step.

Leaving Peekablue glaring heatedly at Double Troubles back at the snide remark, while Finn grinned proudly.

Finn watched Double Trouble until they had moved out of view behind an embankment of stacked stones further down the path.

“Com'on, Finn. Sweet Bee is waiting for us at the summit.” Prince Peekablue called.

“On my way!” Finn turned and dashed after the Great Seer. Their heart much lighter now. The future had been changed, they had a chance to save their mom’s and stop the Nameless One's resurrection.

When Darla docked once more within the cavernous hanger within the Velvet Glove. Catra found herself unable to leave the confines of the ship, stuck on the cusp of the ramp. Trembling in fear, as the primal echoes of feeling helpless and broken swept through her. The harsh memories of Horde Prime assaulting her mind and body. The brutality of having her identity forcibly taken away. Holding herself tightly, tail wrapped tight around her thigh, shivering like a coward. Staring out absently into the fathomless darkness that lurked out beyond the ship. Her skin was crawling, with both fear and disgust with herself. Her emotions roiled at the very thought of going onto Primes Ship. Her fur was standing up, shivering with apprehension. Her tail now puffed up and lashing anxiously. This place held far too much trauma for her to deal with rationally.

She had wandered these lonely halls...for months.

Falling into reflection...reviled by what she had allowed herself to become.

Sought to atone...she sacrificed herself…

Had willingly given up everything, including her life…

She had died...

here...

Entrapta had no issues with this place, not having endured the months of fear and slow torture Catra had. She watched bitterly as Entrapta strode off down the ramp, eager to get back to Hordak's side. Leaving Scorpia standing uncertain for a moment, glancing nervously between her and Entrapta's quickly disappearing figure. She could see how scared Catra was and wanted to comfort her, but Entrapta needed her too. She was at a loss as to what to do.

“Stop staring at me, like that, you big idiot! I don't need you! Just Go!” Catra shouted up at Scorpia, her tone furious and indignant. She hated looking so weak and Scorpia's worried, sympathetic looks were only infuriating her more. Unable to restrain her frustration and anger, falling back on old defensive behaviors to conceal how vulnerable she felt. She had once again lashed out and hurt her best friend. She ground her teeth in a low snarl at her fear and cowardice, quickly regretting her mean outburst. As Scorpia's face crumbled into hurt and distress.

She quickly calmed her heated scowl into an impassive stare. “I'm sorry...I'll be ok...but Entrapta is going to need you way more than me right now.” She offered Scorpia a small smile of apology then dashed back down the corridor. Needing to retreat back into the security of the ship.

“Wild Cat?” Scorpia called after her, confused and hurt by their latest exchange.

Catra cringed at the pained sound of Scorpia's voice, knowing she had once again lashed out and verbally abused her best friend. Who never deserved it...

Scorpia followed behind Entrapta at a discreet distance. Staring wide eyed around the empty, dimly lit, vaulted corridors. That was now invaded by thick tree roots that had punctured the outer walls, sealing the various holes they made with their wooden bulk. Curling and knotting along the corridors, creating a strange mixture of tech and nature. The walls seemed to glow with a faint hum of both power and magic. Stretching out in all directions in an endlessly twisting labyrinth. Scorpia could see the stars twinkling through half moon shaped windows mounted high between the rounded buttresses of the wide intersections of corridors.

The Velvet Glove held an eerie, almost timeless aura that penetrated your very soul. Making Scorpia shiver, as a vast sense

of loneliness fell upon her. Drawing her into grim thoughts of all the death and suffering, this ship had been the harbinger of. It left her unsettled and jumpy. To be surrounded by this sterile, unfeeling environment for months....She finally understood Catra's fear about coming aboard. This place was truly terrifying.

“This place is way....way.... creeper then Dryl...” Scorpia moaned, clicking her pinchers together nervously against her chest as she looked around. She had been in charge of the occupation of Dryl and getting Entrapta's stuff sent back to the Fright Zone. It had been a rather dangerous and confusing mission. With all the traps and labyrinth like halls inside the castle. Darting her eyes forward quickly in fear of losing Entrapta. She swiftly increased her pace as Entrapta turned down a side corridor.

The doors to the command deck were gigantic. They dominated the wall of the corridor, dwarfing any other set of doors Scorpia had seen on the way there. As Entrapta approached they parted with a low moan. Cool, stale air whooshed out into the corridor, blowing Scorpia’s hair back. The room beyond was shrouded in darkness, the thick musky scent that wafted out smelled like a long forgotten tomb. Scorpia was filled with anxiety and fear about entering, but Entrapta gave her no choice to back out from following her. As she rushed into the darkness without any trepidation at all. Scorpia swallowed and slowly shuffled through the entrance. She glanced left and right, finding a long, wide balcony stretching out of view. It was dimly lit by simple, round overhead lights. Illuminating a row of cylinders. She moved down one side, briefly. Glancing into the cylinders, finding the naked bodies of clones floating inside. The port at the back of their neck was connected to the back of the cylinder by an organic tendril. The liquid inside glowed an eerie green. The clone’s heads were bowed, eyes closed as if sleeping. The clone's resemblance to a corpse, locked in a container for dissection was creepy and sad. More cylinders were tucked into alcoves against the back of the balcony, rows upon rows both above and below. Wrapping around the command dais in the center of this incredibly massive room.

Soon she was trailing Entrapta down a long walkway that hung over a bottomless dark pit. Thousands of glowing green cylinders hung along the balconies that rimmed the side of the cavernous chamber. So far away the only hint that they were there, was the sharp glow of the lights that illuminated their balconies. Scorpia swallowed hard knowing that each cylinder held a clone inside. That they floated beneath the liquid, like lifeless corpses. Their eyes were open, staring unseeing through the glass, glowing a brilliant green as if they were chipped. Or their eyes were closed, body curled in a stiff sort of repose.

Scorpia cleared her throat and rubbed the back of her neck vigorously. The sight of the clones under the control of the Hive Mind left her feeling very anxious. She swallowed as she slowly took in the thousands upon thousands of lights that ascended out of view high above and fell out of view into the void of darkness far below. Knowing there was an unfathomable amount of clones that had willingly enslaved themselves to protect Etheria.

"How many of Primes clones....gave up their freedom?" Scorpia breathed out in horror.

"Most of them." Entrapta responded in a hushed voice from ahead. "Hordak and I had managed to recover most of his brethren from Etheria before the planet began to go offline. There are only a few left, who chose not to follow Hordak."

Scorpia cut her eyes away from the tragic sight of the enslaved clones, to find Entrapta standing just before a ramp. That inclined up through a small tunnel, to a huge dais that seemed to hover in the very center of this massive chamber of eerie light and deep shadows.

She swallowed again and nodded, dashing up to Entrapta who was waiting for her. She couldn't help the frightened tremble now affecting her body. As they walked up the small ramp together. Entrapta seemed unaffected by the sight of the imprisoned clones when they first entered the Command deck. Now confronted by Hordak sitting upon Primes throne, with several tubes running out

of the back of his head and shoulders. She was again striding forward without fear or hesitation onto the dais. While Scorpia was left dead in her tracks once again. Staring in awe at the massive glass, half moon view screen set behind the throne. The glowing webbing of the hive mind was superimposed upon a highly detailed map of first ones code in several pie shapes sections. A map of Etheria dominated the other pie shapes section, with yellow sigils of Entrapta's cute victory icon over every First Ones installation.

Hordak was sitting silently upon a white, unassuming throne. With several dozen docking ports attached to his armor. Glowing green cords were hooked into those conduits, attached to his shoulder's and the back of his head and neck. Trailing away into a massive control panel beneath the screen. Each tube was a sickly green, as the bubbles of moving liquid floated down the length into Hordaks various conduits. His eyes were open, staring blankly ahead and completely green as he was once again a part of the Hive Mind.The horrifying visuals were getting to be too much for her to handle. Scorpia rubbed the back of her neck more violently drawing blood, as her legs were shaking in fear. She felt like a coward, but she hadn't thought this through. She just wasn't prepared to confront all this bad stuff again. She just wasn't strong enough...

“Entrapta...” she moaned in a breathless whisper. “I can't go any further...” She squeezed her eyes shut, unable to deal with looking at the macabre statue Hordak had become or Entrapta's disappointment with her.

Entrapta offered her a small smile of acceptance. “Thanks for coming this far. I'll be ok.” She glanced back at Scorpia, before walking slowly towards the throne. Her hands were clasped before her, head bowed in somber reflection. She resembled a grieving widow as she stood before the prone form of Hordak. Who was sitting stiff and lifeless on Prime’s throne.

“I am really going to miss you, Hordak.” She acknowledged, with a sniffle. Unable to say anything more. She just stood before him,

staring down at his body for a brief time. Then flipped down her mask as her shoulder's began to quake, fresh tears cascading down her cheeks. The full extent of her grief hidden behind her visor.

Wrong Hordak, moved silently past Scorpia a few moments later. He never stopped to acknowledge her, intent on getting to Entrapta's side. He lightly brushed his fingertips across her elbow, quietly letting her know he was there. She turned and wrapped her arms around his shoulders, sobbing loudly.

"I wish. Hordak could have come up with another way to save Etheria. But we just didn't have the time." Wrong Hordak offered with sympathy, rubbing Entrapta's back lightly. Seeking to soothe her misery.

"No!" Entrapta snapped back at Wrong Hordak, shoving away from him angrily. "That's a lie!"

Wrong Hordak was taken off guard by her sudden burst of anger. Pulling his hands back and stepping cautiously away from her.

"He could have come up with a better plan, he could have asked me. I would have been able to help him. But Hordak wanted this!" Entrapta snarled, she spun and went storming towards Hordak. "You were a coward back in the Fright Zone, hiding in your sanctum. I thought you had changed...you finally fought back against Prime...claimed your life as your own...you saved me." Her voice was high pitched and clipped as she snapped her jaw shut in rage. " Then when you get a second chance to have real freedom, to make your own life with me on Etheria. You didn't....you retreated up here, imprisoning yourself on the Sky Tree...devising a plan...to imprison yourself yet again, inside Etheria's systems..." She ranted and fumed, pacing in front of the throne as her fury built.

"Coward!!!" She turned and screamed at Hordak, her fists balled tightly at her sides as her chest heaved for breath. "Stop...leaving me..." She finally moaned and crumpled onto the deck, wailing

with grief. Punching the floor with her fists with all that she had, the hollow impacts echoing throughout the dark chamber. Her sudden violence was enough to spur Scorpia past her fear and she scrambled back to Entrapta's side. She had no idea what had transpired between Entrapta and Hordak in the weeks that led up to his sacrifice. Or how painful Hordak's sudden departure with Horde Prime earlier that year had affected her. But Entrapta's heart was shattered and she was helpless as to how to deal with this amount of pain without also hurting herself.

"I got you..." Scorpia cradled her lightly, giving her space enough to deal with her emotions. But Scorpia was also prepared to intercede or even sting her if she tried to hurt herself more severely. Entrapta curled up in her strong arms, sobbing mournfully with the weight of her loss. Muttering and snarling out all her thoughts, verbally purging all her hopes and fantasies from her heart of what could have been, that was now never going to happen. As she rocked in Scorpia's lap, thumping the heels of her hands lightly against the side of her temples. Her mask concealing all the turbulent emotions twisting her expressions, as tears dripped from the point of her chin soaking the front of her overalls.

Wrong Hordak watched in stunned concern a few feet away. His mind racing, heart beating hard in his chest. Valiantly trying to make sense of the anguish and rage he was witnessing. He had barely been alive more than a day, just released from his cloning vat. He was in the process of being programmed when Bow and Entrapta had freed him rather violently from Primes control. He cocked his head to the side, finding a common ground to Entrapta's anguish. He had felt so lost and alone when he could no longer feel Primes light inside of him. He had been scared and he had also cried at the loss. Finding solace and a new purpose, with the acceptance of his new friends. With a resolute nod, he moved swiftly to kneel before Entrapta. Grasping her wrists and tenderly pulling her arms down, staring intently into the mirrored visors of her mask.

“You must understand, we have been nothing more than machines of war and conquest for thousands of years. We felt that we needed to atone…for the atrocities we inflicted upon the universe under Primes Control. We were given a chance to become more, a force of good...to save life instead of destroy it. We choose this...Hordak chose this. Please do not mourn us, celebrate us. We are finally free to choose our own fate...and we choose to protect Etheria.”

Entrapta gasped at his somber words, her sobs falling silent as she contemplated his words. Scorpia sighed deeply, glancing timidly up at Hordak. Who had always been so much larger and imposing in her youth. He still held that strong, authoritative aura as he sat upon his throne. But it had cooled now, to that of a king at rest.

Legacy

Catra closed her eyes, with a heavy sigh. Walking briskly down the corridor. Refusing to give the sickening memories of Primes assault upon her mind and body further power. Anger and frustration was broiling inside of her as she charged down the corridors. When the deafening chatter of hundreds of voices echoed out to her. Drawing her away from the mental turmoil in an instant. Her attention shifted to the massive bay door of Darla's main hanger. She stood for a moment, leaning casually against the cool metal doorframe. Arms crossed, merely observing the huddled masses of civilians scattered throughout the once empty cargo hold. Darla's main hold was a huge, cavernous room with no windows. Which was to their advantage as the civilians could remain oblivious to the fact that they were now hovering in the crushing void of space. It must have held more than just cargo in the ancient past. Perhaps building material to start a settlement or smaller support vehicles. Nothing much remained of Mara's ancient cargo or supplies. Most of the ship had been pillaged numerous times by the gangs of the Crimson Waste. A few crates of dried food were stacked in small piles, scattered throughout the hold but little else remained. What was left of Mara's supplies was being shared around the desolate groups of survivors. Catra's thoughts were now focused on the tattered and war weary before her. Reigniting the crushing guilt and regret, she bore towards the Etherian people that she had once tried to conquer.

They looked haggard and utterly miserable, with nothing left but the clothes on their backs. What they had managed to salvage from the war, they had most likely taken with them to Mystacor. Only to have it burnt away to ash, during the fire storm that had ripped through the enclosures. Small groups of surviving families sat in small circles speaking in hushed voices, with babies huddled in their laps. Toddler's and small children clinging to the adults, wide eyed and fearful. The older children and young teens never strayed too far, sitting within reach, playing quiet games with each

other. After what they had just endured they needed the security and comfort of the adults.

Young adults wandered aimlessly, speaking softly. Casting the families that surrounded them lost, wounded looks. Having endured their own share of loss and trauma for the last three years. These Etherian's were not soldier's, not heroes. Just simple farmers, or villagers that had flocked to Mystacor for help. They were not prepared to suddenly have magic and have no idea how to deal with such powers on a day to day basis. The people of Etheria over the last three years had been pushed to the brink of absolute despair. They had no concept of normal or security. Their whole world had been ravaged by decades of war and then occupied by alien invader's. Driving them from burnt villages and decimated crops into the Whispering Woods or the Crimson Waste. They had been living in a state of constant fear for far too long. That level of stress had taken a toll upon all of them. Catra could see the haunted looks in many of their dirty faces. They kept glancing around nervously, expecting another calamity to strike. It was painful to watch them, knowing that she had been the cause of some of that strife.

Catra lowered her gaze, her shame not allowing her to look any of them in the eyes. As she was slowly drawn into the cargo hold by a masochistic curiosity, to the misery within. Walking with a clipped step, she would glance up from time to time just to keep aware of her surroundings. As she reached out through her link with Melog, questioning where they might be. She really could use their companionship right now. She felt unmoored emotionally, floating aimlessly through her trauma of Prime, the war and her overwhelming guilt. But she felt no emotional response from Melog. Their side of the connection was oddly silent. After everything that had happened to them recently she couldn't help the sudden panic that sped up her heart beat. Then faintly, a smug, proud emotion whispered deep inside her. Melog was alright, but they were far away....perhaps they had left the ship and were planetside? Heaving a sigh of relief, she focused on tracking down the two children they had saved. Needing to make sure they were alright and Melog hadn't just left them alone. It

wouldn't be like them, but she still wanted to make sure. Those kids were far too young to be left fending for themselves in the trapped masses here in the cargo hold.

So she found herself wandering aimlessly through the crowds, feeling their eyes boring into her. Some regarded her curiously, other's paid her no mind, far too wrapped up in their own concerns to care. But a Magicat was a rarity on Etheria. She kept vigilant, uncertain of the shifting intentions of the crowds surrounding her. Her ears twitched as she picked up small pieces of hushed conversations as she passed. Keeping her head down, glancing up briefly to scan the crowds and kept moving at a quick pace. Starting to question if searching for those kids was a good idea?

“Was she with the rebellion?” A deep voice rumbled,

“I think I saw her with She-Ra at Erelandia?” Another responded lightly.

“Naw, She's was that Horde Commander. Hordak's second in command, was a Magicat... I swear, I saw her during the Siege at the Sea Gate!” Another man shouted in rage.

“You're full of crap, Devon. She's with the rebellion. My sister lived in the village of Tyr, just outside of Erelandia. She told me stories about a Magicat, who could turn invisible. That she single handedly took out over twenty clones and freed the villagers from the labor camp there.” Another young man's voice came to her defense.

“Let's find out then, shall we!” Another voice boomed out, deep and malicious.

Catra moved more briskly, sensing the threat laced in his tone. She had just wanted to find Melog, make sure those kids were alright and get her jacket back. She did not want to get involved in a dispute. Especially over something as stupid as her identity.

“Magicat!” The voice shouted, then a meaty hand clamped onto her shoulder and swung her around.

Catra hissed in fright, tail fur bristling and lashing, her claws snapping out in alarm. Her arms were stiff and sore from her fight with Mermista. She was not as limber as she used to be and his sudden assault had caught her off guard.

She found herself confronting four men, of various species. The one who had grabbed her was the largest. He was human and had short blonde hair that stood up in sharp spikes, dressed in the simple woven cloth and hide pants and a heavy woolen tunic. Perhaps he was of a farm hand or a sailor. His brown eyes were cold, as he scanned up and down her smaller frame. His leering smile sent a chill through her.

“What do you want?” Catra growled, taking a step back, raising both hands up as she moved into a defensive stance.

He hooked his large thumbs into the wide leather belt wrapped around his ample waist as he regarded her arrogantly.

“Just wanting to verify who you are?” His smile widened into a wicked leer. “My boys and I have a bet, going. I think you're Horde and in need of a good beating. My friend.” He nodded to a shorter, Salinean Hybrid, with thick, messy black hair. His skin was covered in blue scales and large webbed ears, flicked back and forth like fans. He might have been a sea elf from the northern coast? He stood nearby, dressed in similar clothes. He was nearly half the size of her assailant, far too thin and almost gangly. With nervous pale green eyes and a pointed chin, his expression was twisted into a sour frown.

“I don't think who I am is any of your business.” Catra countered, intending to leave. Slowly stepping back, further away from the men.

“Catra!” A bright voice exploded from her right.

Catra turned as the young girl she had saved came running at her. Catra was quick to fall to one knee to receive the child's excited charge. She wrapped her little arms tight around Catra's neck and laughed happily.

“Thank you for saving me and Vox. Your kitty is so soft and their purr is amazing. It put Vox to sleep. My Auntie found us...and we are looking for my mom right now. ” The little girl prattled on as she pulled away, grinning happily up at Catra.

Catra had no time to react, as the group of men moved to surround her. The other two were not as well muscled but still tall and burly. One was a Thaymorian with curved goat horns the other a grey scaled Lizard hybrid from the Crimson Waste. Both were dressed in little more than colored rags. Their shirts and thick cloth pants, stained with age. Worn tread bare and tattered from years of struggle.

Catra was quick to stand up and turn to confront them, corralling the young girl behind her. Sensing the men's sudden shift from mild curiosity to violent rage at the sound of her name.

“Catra! As in Force Captain Catra of the Horde!” A goat hybrid shouted, pointing at her accusingly. His dark brown eyes glaring at her with barely restrained rage. His beige linen shirt was tucked loosely into a dark cloth pants. A large pale blue, woolen tunic. Hung loosely on his slim shoulders. His dark hair tied back into a long pony tail with a string, darker brown fur shadowing his square jaw. As either his goat tuft that once grew upon his chin had been shorn or not fully grown in yet.

“I knew it!” The large human male, who had grabbed her, shouted then laughed mirthlessly.

“I remember you! I was at the Sea Gate that day. I saw you!” he snarled, “I was working on a merchant vessel docked in the port just out front of the Salineas Castle. I barely had time to jump into the water, before the Horde warships closed in and began to lay siege upon the gate. You were on the bow of the lead vessel,

directing the cannon's to annihilate the port! Sinking every ship that was docked there.” He seethed.

Catra quickly assessed her position as the three other men closed in. Guiding the young girl behind her as she was quickly surrounded. The little girl whimpered in fright, her eyes darting around the men, her finger's twitching at the handle of her knife that was still sheathed at her hip.

Catra passed her a stern look, shaking her head. Silently commanding her not to get involved in this fight. The little girl scowled up at her but complied, allowing her arms to fall to her sides in submission.

“I lost a lot of friends that day, when the gate fell!” The man raised his fists, his eyes burning into Catra's with malicious intent.

“You Horde bastards destroyed the gate, then levelled the castle. You burned down all the villages along the coast!” The rail thin, Salinean Sea elf added, his whole body vibrating with pent up rage. As he balled his fists tight against his thighs. The shorter, less intimidating human who had once vouched for her, defending the village of Tyr. Now glared at her with disgust. All the good she had sown, in the season leading up to the final battle with the Rebellion. Seemed rather moot when compared to the death and destruction she had caused in her time with the Horde.

“Murderer!” A young woman's voice echoed just behind the group of men. As the confrontation began to draw more enraged civilians to surround her.

Catra's heart was now hammering in her chest with fear. She hadn't even thought that she might be recognized. Silently cursing her desperation to find Melog that had clouded her rational thinking. Now she was in trouble and it was only getting worse. She laughed bitterly, eyes darting around the ever building crowds for pitchforks and torches. These Etherian's had every intention to lynch her right here for her crimes and she didn't fault them for it. She deserved what she got for her role in the war. She slowly

stood up straighter, eyes hardening with conviction. Slowly lowering her arms to submit to their judgement.

“I'll let you each have one go at me.” Catra raised her chin up in stubborn resignation, giving each man a cool, direct stare. Wanting to get this beating over with quickly so she could get the little girl out of there.

The larger human male’s penetrating gaze was rather unsettling. He swept his eyes up and down her body, quickly calculating her level of threat. Chuckling mockingly, not trusting her promises at all.

“So you are just going to stand there and let me and my boys each have a swing at you?” He asked incredulously.

“Yes, I won't fight back... “ Catra nodded, accepting that this would be her punishment. Hoping that after they got their punches in, they would feel vindicated and just leave.

“How magnanimous of you.” The thin Salinean Sea elf stated sarcastically, crossing his arms over his chest.

Catra glanced down, finding the little girl hiding behind her legs. Staring at the men with rising fear.

“I need you to step away from me, now.” Catra instructed the girl softly.

“But....are you really going to let them hurt you?” she whimpered.

“Yeah, but just a little bit. I gotta pay my dues.” Catra offered her with a slight shrug and a small, bitter sweet smile. As the little girl nodded and took several steps back. Disappearing into the crowd of bystanders.

Catra watched her slip between the legs of the growing mob with a proud smile. The little girl understood, having grown up in the cold, uncertainty of war. She merely accepted what was going to

happen and obeyed. It was a survivor's mentality, she understood very well.

The larger man's roar snapped her attention back. She had no time to brace herself, as his fist came crashing down upon the left side of her face. Catra fell to her knees with a sharp cry of pain. Then she slowly came back up to stand defiantly before the other three. The left side of her face was stinging and her blue eye was watering from the impact of the man's fist. She could feel a cool trickle of blood from a small gash just above her eye, where the solitary ring on his left hand had cut into her flesh.

The large man had circled around her, after he had struck her. Moving out of her line of sight as she fell to her knees, slightly stunned. When she slowly rose back up to her feet, he lunged out and grabbed a fist full of her short hair. Her heart leaping into her throat as she was once again off balance and desperate to reclaim her footing.

Catra cried out in alarm, as he yanked her head back. Snarling in her ear.

“You killed a lot of people that day!” His voice was raspy and full of rage and grief.

Blood from the cut above her eye was now dripping back into the fringe of her hairline, matting her fur upon her forehead.

“This is your chance to seek retribution for your homes! For your murdered loved ones! Let's show the Butcher of Salineas what she deserves!”

He shouted at the crowd, his words invoking more shouts of assent. The mob mentality was soon agreeing to participate in a proper and painful public lynching.

Catra couldn't help but try to defend herself at this point. These men had no intention of being honorable and soon she would have a whole gang of people beating on her. She kicked forward trying to put the man off balance, her hands clawing at his wrists.

As he grunted and cursed, pinning one of her arms behind her back, twisting it at an odd angle nearly dislocating it from her shoulder.

He released her hair, shoving her head forward violently. Catra's head lurched forward just in time to receive a backhand across her right cheek from one of his companions. Clamping her teeth upon impact, a fang cutting into her lower lip. She snarled and spat out blood, glaring up at the large man still holding her wrist behind her back in rising fury. She attempted to claw at his thighs with her free hand. With her attention still focused on freeing herself. She was repaid with a punch in the gut from another man. She grunted as the wind was knocked out of her.

The crowd roared with laughter and their triumphant shouts were so loud Catra had to fold her ears back to cut down on the ringing.

Then he tossed her forward, releasing her arm. She cried out in alarm, stumbling forward. As another man grabbed her arms, holding her firmly by the biceps for a moment. Catra cried out in pain, as his firm grip further bruised her tender arms. Before he violently tossed her towards another man. She realized too late that it wasn't just the four men that had come to take their pound of flesh, but now it was a whole crowd of angry men. They slapped her across the face, tossing her back and forth like a rag doll. As brutal punches and fierce kicks were hitting her repeatedly, over every inch of her torso and back. The mob was spinning her around roughly between them. Striking her every chance they got. Until she was too dizzy and stunned from the endless beating to stand. She felt helpless, like a mouse being played with by a cat. It infuriated her to be so weak and off balance. She was at their mercy, a mercy she knew would never come. There were just too many of them now, she couldn't regain control of the fight. She screamed in desperation. So disorientated, she swung her fist wide. Missing the blurry attacker, who was laughing arrogantly at her lack of coordination. While the rest of the mob mocked and jeered at her dizzy, sloppy attempt to

protect herself. Stumbling and falling to her knees as her magic ignited her body as a last line of defense.

The crowds cried out in fright, moving back. “She's a princess!” A bystander shouted in surprise. Other voices followed, some gasping in awe while others grumbled and scoffed. Harsh whispers of disbelief and disgust followed. Leaving the small crowd of men who had been beating her to move back a few steps. Glowering down at her with a mixture of loathing and wariness to continue their assault.

“What is going on here!” Frosta's high pitched voice exploded over the murmuring voices of the crowds.

The ice princess was quick to shove herself through the throng of onlookers. Her frown twisting into a look of pure fury when she found Catra's battered body amid the group of men. Curled up on her knees to protect her stomach, her arms wrapped protectively over her head. Her fire slowly snuffed itself out. Leaving her panting and gasping for breath. Every part of her body had been assaulted. Her arms and legs were burning, her chest throbbing, her back was in agony, the muscles in her stomach aching. As every part of her body was slowly forming ugly, expansive bruises. Her skin beneath the soft layer of fur was hot and tender over both her cheeks. The left side of her face felt tight, as her eye had slowly began to swell shut.

Frosta moved to stand in front of her, glowering at the men who were now sizing her up. They were so full of blood lust and adrenaline they had forgotten themselves and the fact that Frosta was a Princess. She raised both of her arms, sending forth a flurry of ice. Creating a short barrier wall that blocked the crowds further off from Catra. The civilians shouted in fright, cowering and moving further away. Frosta swept her cold glare across the slowly dispersing crowds, the intensity of her dark blue eyes silently instructing those who were still hell bent on continuing this public beating. To think twice about it. Her fierce glower stopped on the group of men who had started it. They stood just on the other side of the ice, glaring at her with disgust.

“She's not worth it!” The largest man scoffed, waving a dismissive hand towards Catra. Before turning and walking away. His band of brothers followed reluctantly behind him.

Catra groaned and slowly sat up. Hanging her head and lightly touching her swollen cheek with her fingertips.

“That did not go as planned.” She muttered bitterly.

“What were you even thinking?” Frosta huffed, sitting down beside her, leaning in to survey the damage. Before lightly holding her chin with her fingertips and guiding it up softly. So Catra was forced to confront her serious, unimpressed frown.

“I wasn't I guess.” Catra mumbled with a grumpy pout.

Frosta took in her cut, swollen bottom lip with a pained grimace. Then sighed at the sight of the dried blood smeared across her chin and her swollen black eye. Catra's blue eye was now forced into a narrow squint. The blue iris shimmered, as tears pooled in the corners. Seeping out through the red, puffy skin to fall down her cheek. She was a mess, her face was battered, her body riddled with ugly bruises.

“By the Seven Kingdoms, Catra.” Frosta groaned, shaking her head in dismay. She just could not understand what would possess her to allow those men to beat her so severely. It made no sense.

“Catra...” A soft, childlike voice floated before them. Catra sighed deeply and looked up to greet the little girl she had saved from the fires back at Mystacor.

Frosta took in the short, sweet scene with a small, sympathetic smile. The little girl crouched down offering Catra her leather coat.

“Thanks again, for everything. Sorry, I got you into that fight.” the girl offered nervously, dashing away into the crowds before Catra could ask about Melog.

“Wait...where's Melog?” She muttered weakly, to herself.

“Melog left before the ship took off. I saw them running down the exit ramp, something got their attention.” Frosta stated.

Catra sighed sadly and nodded, her theory verified. Her hope for Melog's comfort now dashed. She would be alone for a while longer.

Frosta regarded her with a curious frown, “You were defending that little girl?”

“No, she called out my name and some guys recognized me as the Horde Commander who sacked Salineas.” Catra moaned in sudden, sharp pain as she tried to roll her eyes with disgust. Grimacing in regret, as her whole face began to throb.

“Ahhh.” Frosta nodded, “So then you decided to fight them? Instead of just apologizing.”

“Not really.” Catra shrugged. “But I doubt, a simple. ‘I'm sorry, I destroyed the Sea Gate and turned the Salineas Castle to rubble, then sent the Horde army to burn down all your villages’ would have smoothed things over anyway.” She finished in a sarcastic tone.

“I doubt that too.” Frosta nodded.

They sat in awkward silence for a long time. Until Catra finally spoke up, reluctantly admitting what she had done.

“I let them hit me...” Catra's voice was thick with shame.

Frosta's mouth dropped low in surprise, then she just shook her head in disbelief.

“Wow....you are a sacrificial idiot of epic proportions, just like Adora” She scoffed.

“What?” Catra blurted out, her voice suddenly full of surprise. She turned to confront Frosta. Cringing in fright as the princess formed a block of ice around her hand. At first expecting to be punched again, her body went rigid. Then she moaned in both pain and relief as Frosta tenderly pressed the ice against her swollen eye.

“Hordak is as much to blame, if not more. For the atrocities of the War, you have no right to take on all the blame.” Frosta gave her a bitter smirk. “Adora always took on all the blame too. Every time things went wrong, it was a personal failure on her part. I get that everyone was putting an unreasonable amount of pressure on her to save the planet. But still....the rebellion was a team and defeating the Horde was a team effort. I hope this time she tries to depend more on others than herself.”

“Adora's always been like that.” Catra stated, softly.

“Well, I am starting to think you are not so different from Adora.” Frosta commented with a knowing smile. Silently affirming in Catra the honorable aspects of Adora she was referring to.

Catra gasped, Adora was selfless and brave and good! The comparison took her off guard and a warmth blossomed in her chest of pride. Catra couldn't help but smile faintly, humbled by Frosta’s unspoken praise.

Frosta was silent for a while, her eyes slowly taking in the damage of Catra's face and all over her body. Her expression fell into a concerning frown and bitter disdain at what had happened.

“Can you move?” She asked quietly. Glancing around at the now gawking crowds, milling past them. Her ice wall had long since melted and they were becoming a miserable spectacle for the Etherians trapped in the cargo hold.

“Yeah...” Catra groused, moaning and grunting as she sluggishly rose to her feet. Holding her jacket close against her chest like a shield. She meekly followed after Frosta. Who guided the taller woman out of the cargo hold, with an arm wrapped protectively around her waist. Keeping the curious voyeurs back with dark, threatening glares.

“Thanks for the save.” Catra offered, “I see you got your powers back.”

“No problem, I'm kinda used to dealing with crowd control.” Frosta smirked, striding ahead and raising two ice knuckles into the air. “Bouncer!” She cried, her declaration both enthusiastic and playful.

Catra laughed softly, then cringed as her ribs hurt.

Frosta jogged back to her side, wrapping an arm back around her waist. As they meandered slowly out of the hold. They headed down the corridor without much of a destination in mind, Frosta just wanted to get Catra as far away from the Etherians as possible.

Frosta was lost to her thoughts for a long time, casting Catra sideways glances as she worked out what she wanted to say.

“I know, you regret many things, Catra. That all the bad stuff you did eats away at you. That all you want is forgiveness and to be given a second chance. ” Frosta began, her voice soft and full of inner reflection.

Catra turned to regard her, her expression hard and impassive. She didn't like that the young teen had so easily noticed over the last season how tormented she was. That she could so boldly state how much the sins of her past affected her judgement. But she kept her emotions in check, not wanting to reveal how upset this topic made her.

“Your punishment should never have been delivered by the hands of a vengeful mob. I find the whole situation rather appalling,

honestly.” Frosta, sighed. Slowing her pace, standing in front of her. Reaching out hesitantly, grasping Catra lightly, high on her bruised arms holding her in place. She stared up at her, her expression was gentle but her stare was fierce, demanding that Catra gave her her full attention.

Catra blinked her one good eye, struggling to breath normally under Frosta's stern unyielding gaze.

“I need you to realize how wrong what happened to you, was. You are not qualified to be be the judge, jury and executioner for yourself!” She stated, giving Catra a brief shake as if seeking to wake her up. “Hordak just exiled himself and most of his brethren into Etheria's operating systems. Most likely as a self made punishment for what he had done to the planet, what his brethren had done to the universe. I'm ok with that, cause it was the only way to save us and it's not going to be permanent. What you just did....they could have killed you!” Frosta's voice was becoming more vehement. “How many more people would be hurt after your death? The people in that vengeful mob would have to live with your blood on their hands, Adora just got you back! She would never recover from your loss, it would shatter her completely.” Frosta sighed, letting go of Catra's arms. Allowing the Cat to take a step back from the intensity of her aura.

“You gotta stop obsessing over your mistakes, it makes you reckless and kinda dumb.” Frosta crossed her arms and gave Catra a grumpy frown. “You need to start thinking about your future. Where do you go from here? What do you need to do to achieve what you truly want?”

Catra opened her mouth to respond, but Frosta huffed.

“People think I'm just some dumb little kid!” Frosta exclaimed, flapping her arms out in exasperation. “But I'm not. I have never been allowed to be a kid. I was a ruler at eight years old. My father was a mighty warrior, a renowned General. He was killed protecting our kingdom from the Horde, when I was a baby. When my kingdom was still aligned with the first Princess Alliance. My

mother was lost during an excavation in the Northern Reach for First Ones tech when I was eight. She had hoped to fortify our border with some magical tech, so that the Horde could never threaten us in the future. Then I was left to rule and had the full power of the Fractal Flake thrust upon me as a child! I learned very quickly how to wield my powers. I had a legacy to forge, just like my parents before me and their parents before them. I pledged that I would protect the Kingdom of Snows and its people. I have never stopped working towards that goal. I'll be crowned as Queen when I turn eighteen, but that's just a title. I plan to achieve so much more in my lifetime. When I'm dead and my heir has taken over the throne. I want to be remembered as a strong and wise queen. Who was capable of protecting her people...all of Etheria. We survived the war...and are far stronger for it. I want Etheria to know peace and prosper, as we move forward into the future. That will be my legacy..." Frosta stopped for a moment, her eyes searching Catra's for understanding. "What will your Legacy be, Catra. When you're dead and gone. What will your descendants remember you for?" Frosta finished, offering Catra an encouraging smile.

Frosta's words carried such power it left Catra breathless. She could only stand against the wall of the corridor and stare down at the young princess in stunned awe.

"I...never thought about any of that." Catra cast her head down in grim contemplation. "Growing up, I always kinda lived day to day, really didn't think about having a future. I was always trying to stay one step ahead of Shadow Weaver's wrath or be of use to Hordak..or Horde Prime so they didn't kill me. I knew, I never really mattered." Catra shrugged, "I just had to do what I needed to...to survive."

"That's horrible." Frosta paid her a horrified look, shaking her head in disbelief. Then she quickly brightened her expression, regarding Catra with warm hopeful eyes. "Well, that bad stuff is all over with now. You're free to live your life on your own terms now. You got Adora and you got all of us, backing you up. So I suggest you make the most of it." Frosta stated, clapping her

roughly on the shoulder. Catra cried out in pain and Frosta cringed in apology. Before she headed back down the corridor to return to babysitting their cargo hold full of civilians.

Catra offered her retreating back a small, grateful smile. Her face hurt far too much to show much emotion. Then she wandered away not knowing where she was headed, still clutching her leather jacket tightly against her chest. Her mind now spinning over the concept of a future and what she would want to be remembered for.

“Wild Cat!” Scorpia's voice boomed out from further up the corridor. Catra stopped in her tracks, waiting as the echoing drum of her boots greeted her ears and grew louder. Within moments the Scorpion was standing before her, heaving for breath. Her eyes widened in appalled shock at the sight of Catra's black eye and cut lip.

“What happened?” She gasped, her pinchers were clutching something low against her waist.

Catra cut her one good eye downward, her breath hitching in surprise as she found Scorpia had retrieved her old mask from Primes Ship.

“Yeah...I saw this...back in Prime's central chamber. Figured you might want it back. A bit worried about asking you about how it got so dented and why it was left lying behind the guys throne.” She meekly offered the battered piece of metal.

“I don't want to talk about it.” Catra muttered, taking the mask hesitantly. She tossed Scorpia a curt wave, quickly moving past her. She needed to be alone for a while and work out her troubled thoughts. That just seemed to be piling up again, crushing her slowly. She was close to breaking down into tears and she wanted to be alone when that happened.

Scorpia watched her go with sad, sympathetic eyes.

“I'm here for you...if you want...” She offered lamely, before Catra turned down a side corridor and out of view. Scorpia didn't know if she had heard her. But she was used to Catra ignoring her attempts to comfort her. With a heavy sigh, she rubbed the back of her neck and headed towards the cargo hold to help Frosta.

Catra found herself sitting on the command chair on the control deck. Curled up on her knees, her legs tucked under herself. She leaned the bruised side of her face against the cool metal of the chair. Glaring down at the mask she held in her lap. Heaving a shaky breath. She tore her blurry sight away from the metal reminder of the monster she had once been. Gazing up at the serene blanket of stars covering the wide windows that took up the majority of either side of the room. This sharply angled mask was a symbol of the darkest moments of her life. When she was trapped, hiding behind her anger, her resentments, treating everyone around her so terribly...in her quest for power...for control of a life she never felt safe living.

“I am no longer that person...and I will never allow that time in my life to define me anymore!” She snarled, igniting her hands and melting the mask into a blob of bronze metal. She balled the metal up and tossed it with a sharp cry of release, into the far corner of the command deck. It struck the wall with a dull clang then fell to the floor, cooling into the corner.

Catra took several heaving breaths, releasing the last dredges of her bitterness and regrets over her past. She was going to take Frosta's advice and think about what her legacy might be and work towards those goals. She wanted to be remembered as an honorable defender of Etheria and burn that dark past away to ashes.

“Darla, is Entrapta on board?” She called to the A.I, as she stood up from the command chair.

“Yes, Entrapta is currently in the engine room.” Darla's bright voice responded.

“Good, then take us back to Mystacor.” She commanded, moving with purpose towards the control console as the glowing map of Etheria popped up.

“As you wish, Catra.” Darla stated.

Catra nodded, bracing her hands on the sides of the control console, watching with her one good eye as the ship pulled out of the hangar and banked away from the Sky tree, turning back towards the planet.

Penance

“Melog! Put him down!” Glimmer shouted, her voice rising in panic. She had teleported another group of mages and sorceresses from the bastions to the outer gardens. Only to find Darla gone and a giant Melog sitting proudly before the main gates with a badly burnt, beaten, half naked, waterlogged man. Hanging like a dead mouse from the hood of his grey cloak, in the alien cats tightly clamped jaws.

The sudden sickening feeling of her stomach, alerted her that the island was again ascending into the sky. Glimmer turned her attention towards the horizon, as the thin blanket of clouds began to fall below the lush edges of the island. A relieved smile pulled at her lips and her eyes misted with grateful tears.

Another disaster averted...they were saved once again...

Glimmer silently thanked Hordak and his brethren for their sacrifice. It was a selfless act for redemption. In their own ways, holding themselves accountable for all the atrocities they had inflicted upon the universe. Seeking now to protect the people that they had once sought to dominate to Horde Primes will.

Glimmer shot Melog a disapproving look, her lips thinned into an irritated grimace. As the cat remained sitting proudly, a strong confident purr rumbling from their throat. The unconscious man dangled limply from their teeth. The top of his tunic was hanging in shreds on his waist. Fresh claw marks adorned his bare chest, angry and oozing blood. Glimmer quickly pulled out her communication pad that had been attached to her belt and called Darla. Getting an update from Catra as to what the hell was going on. Now she stood, frowning up at Melog in frustration with her hands on her hips. As the man slowly began to moan and come around. He thrashed a bit, at suddenly finding himself hanging in mid air. Melog growled and clamped down on the scrap pieces of cloth in their mouth, causing the man to cry out in pain. As a sharp fang dug into his shoulder blades in warning. He muttered

and fell still, glaring menacingly down at Glimmer and then up at Melog.

“Melog, seriously put him down!” Glimmer shouted in exasperation, as Bow dashed up beside her, his weapon still in his hands. He had been helping with the evacuation of the lower Bastions. Not many trick arrows remained in his quiver. He had used up his explosive, goo and net arrows to keep the walls from falling on the people he was leading out. His expression was a mixture of confusion and worry, as he took in Melog and his captured prey.

“It looks like Mystacor's systems are up and running again. I am going to head back down to the Fail Safe, I can access the mainframe from Entrapta's computers. I want to make sure we are in the clear here.” Bow chucked a thumb back towards the gatehouse.

“Fine.” Glimmer nodded.

“You got this?” Bow waved a hand towards Melog, offering Glimmer a nervous smile.

“I doubt Melogs going to eat him?” Glimmer commented lightly, her tone laced with dark humor. “At least not in one bite.” She laughed softly with a dismissive shrug.

Bow thought she was serious, his eyes flaring wide in sudden fear. Glimmer laughed more loudly, the tension of the moment was cut instantly.

“Go!, go. I got this.” Glimmer raised up on her tiptoes and pressed a soft kiss to his cheek.

“See you soon.” Bow gave her shoulders a reassuring squeeze before trying to dash off.

As Swift Wind trotted up to him, blocking his path. “We got the Northern side of the island evacuated onto Horde, Scorpion Carriers, but it seems kinda pointless, now. Who’s that and why is

Melog trying to eat him?” Swift Wind pointed to the giant cat with the tip of his muzzle.

“See, I am not the only one that thinks that is a possibility.” Bow stated, eyes wide in horrific affirmation. His voice was shaky and high pitched, as he shook the tip of his bow sharply at Melog.

“That's our intruder.” Glimmer waved a hand towards the giant cat, “Melog, please release him.” Glimmer tried again, her voice a pleading sing- song. As several mages and Horde soldiers in full armor rushed out of the main gates, weapons trained on the poor man dangling from Melog's mouth.

Melog growled and clamped down more firmly, refusing to release their prey. Causing Jitsu to yelp again in pain. Clutching desperately at the collar of his cloak that was now starting to slowly strangle him.

“You will only listen to Catra...huh.” Glimmer grumbled. The cat merely growled, their acknowledgement to the fact. The sides of their mouth vibrate against their gums stubbornly. Jitsu sighed heavily, crossing his arms over his chest in resignation. At this point he was so humiliated, he was totally ok with suffocation. He just barely survived being drowned by several tons of water, only to wash up against the outer walls of the main gates. When the Melog, having grown to a giant size, had effortlessly plucked him from the ground. He had no time to react, soaked and barely lucid. Now he was caught and would never make the rendezvous with Tri-Clops. Jitzu had run out of options, he was now in Etherian custody. He wondered what kind of cruel torture awaited him, no doubt they would want to interrogate him for information. He had been through countless wars both on Eternia and on alien worlds. Survived for years in the most brutal prison in the galaxy...what could these backwater people possibly do to make him talk?

Several hours later, he found himself searched roughly by Horde soldier's and completely disarmed of his remaining daggers. His sword had washed away somewhere out in the gardens along with his communicator, he had stuffed in his ear. And now he was seated on a plush, elegantly upholstered chair. Locked in a small opulent study, within the upper bastion's of the Citadel. A binding glyph glowing beneath the chair, preventing him from moving. The room was beautifully furnished, with a marble fireplace, cluttered bookshelves on every wall. A simple, highly polished oak desk in the corner, the top still scattered with paper and quill from the previous occupant.

Which was not what he had expected at all. Leaving him feeling rather on edge more than relaxed. But he had to just roll with it right now. What were they trying to do by surrounding him with comfort? They hadn't manhandled him or even shouted any threats.. at least not yet. His incarceration so far had been efficient and strangely respectful. It might be a ploy to try to gain his trust or persuade him to talk about Lord Skeletor's plans? Or were these Etherian's just really nice? Or really naive when it came to waging war and interrogating prisoners? Either way, he slumped with exhaustion in the chair, glancing suspiciously at his ever growing crowd of captors.

The dark skinned archer leaned against the door frame of the heavy oak door. With his arms crossed over his chest, keeping a close eye on him. His expression was placid, giving away nothing as to what he may be thinking. His dark brown eyes were cool and cautious. The Melog was back to its normal size, sitting on the other side of the doorframe, both guarding the only entrance into the room. The sparkly Queen was pacing just in front of his chair. She would stop, turn and glare threateningly at him. Huff and then start to pace again.
"I sooooo want to hurt you...for what you did to Catra." She snarled, balling her hands into fists. He glanced down as her knuckles began to spark and flash with light. Jitsu licked his blooded lip nervously, wondering how much damage her magically enhanced punches were going to cause him. He was not relishing having to take yet another beating.

He noted there were two Horde soldiers stationed out in the hallway. Two just out front of his door and two mages across the hall. He had all these guards on one side of the room. But the other side was just long, open, arched windows. A acrid breeze of smoke and ash wafted into the room. The dull evening clouds, rolling lazily across the windows. That was the tactical weakness Tri-clops would use, if the cyborg cared enough to rescue him. More likely, the cold hearted robot would just send a Doom Seeker drone to shoot him dead and be done with it. Skeletor did not tolerate weakness, failure was punished with death. Jitsu groaned and thumped the back of his head against the chair, twenty four hours ago he had been fantasizing about grand parties in his honor, now he was dreaming about his own assassination. His luck had turned sour far too quickly for his liking.

“This is your idea of a prison cell?” He scoffed, with a nervous laugh. His dark eyes darted to the open windows nervously.

Glimmer was about to respond when Lonnie, dressed in full Horde armor stormed through the doorway. She pulled her helmet off in one swift movement and braced it against a hip.

“Trust me pal, we got a proper cell waiting for you back at the Fright Zone!” She threatened, waving an active stun baton in his face. It crackled menacingly against the tip of his nose. “The cell blocks are currently underwater right now, but we're draining them out. My troops have already taken several of your men into custody and they are going to rot in those cells along with you. This invasion is not going to happen!”

“Invasion....Eternia has no interest in colonizing Etheria again...that would be a waste of time and resources. Your planet will be harvested, like every other backwater world. To further our Lord's Empire.” Jitzu smirked. “Those Husks are expendable, do what you want with them.” He spat with a shrug.

Lonnie snarled and raised the baton intent on jamming it down Jitsu's arrogant throat.

“Lonnie!” Adora's voice thundered in warning, as she strode into the room and headed over to Jitzu. With her head held high, chin jutting out and chest thrust forward. Her aura was commanding and proud. Approaching her enemy from a position of strength. A power move she had perfected while in the Horde, to gain control of any uncertain situation.

No longer able to hold onto She-Ra's magic, she was once more just Adora. After destroying the sword and learning to live without She-Ra's power. She had been forced to confront how much she had come to depend on that power and not herself. Her self confidence and sense of security had all hinged on She-Ra’s strength in near invulnerability for many years. She no longer had to depend on Adora’s weaker body, or her limited senses while in battle. She was able to take control of the battles more easily, beat the enemy back quickly and protect the people of Etheria.

Without that magic, she had felt adrift, weak, and worthless. What could Adora contribute to the war effort...what could she do to fix things...But in time, with her friends' help, she learned to accept the loss and find strength and courage in herself again. That she may not be the most powerful person in the room anymore, but she could depend on her friends to have her back. Through teamwork she could help make a difference. That renewed self confidence allowed her to be brave enough to confront Prime just as Adora. Knowing full well that she stood little chance at winning, at actually saving Catra herself. But she hoped if she offered herself as a sacrifice, as a distraction. Then Glimmer could find Catra in the cells and sneak away with her. Thankfully, it had turned out well in the end, she had saved her dearest friend and reconnected with that magic power.

Jitsu's eyes flew wide in surprise as he recognized Adora's features, the piercing steel blue eyes and dusty blonde hair of the Eternia's royal line. But he quickly schooled his features, needing to keep his emotions hidden. He knew that she was on this planet, after talking to that Sunna magicat. But to see her, the long lost princess of Eternia. All grown up, it was still rather shocking. The soft elegance of her face, much like her mothers,

was unmistakable. Her blue eyes were piercing and stern like her fathers. Her movements are as strong and self possessed as her twin brother. She was royalty there was no doubt. Tri-clops had shown him the footage of She-Ra from the Whispering Woods. Her lineage was unmistakably that of King D'vann Grayskull. The blood of the First Ones flowed in her veins and so to the primordial magic of the universe. He quickly began to cultivate an angle he could use to his advantage. He needed to find a common ground, so that she would lower her guard. He could turn this to his advantage and perhaps she might come back to Eternia willingly....to fight for their side of the war? Jitsu couldn't help but grin, what a boon She-Ra would be...and he would so enjoy the pain and suffering her loyalty to Lord Skeletor would inflict upon the King and Queen. As his devious plans began to form, Jitsu became more hopeful, for the coming laurels his Lord would bestow upon him, upon his return with....She-Ra.

“Give me the star seed.” Adora demanded, thrusting her hand out towards him. She held her rage in check, wanting more than anything to pound him into the floor for nearly killing Catra. In the end she could only glare threateningly down at him, clenching her jaw as she seethed.

“Don't have it no more, Princess.” He arched an eyebrow knowingly. Her eyes flared wide in surprise for just a moment, before her expression turned to stone. Grinding her teeth, her eyes burning with irritation at his clipped response.

“Then what happened to it.” She growled, menacingly. Refusing to acknowledge his statement about her being a princess.

“A little Magicat stole it from me.” Jitsu shrugged, “No idea where the little brat went though.”

Adora groaned and rolled her eyes. Turning away from him to hide her surprise. Another Magicat?

“I'll get my people to patrol the island for a juvenile magicat.” Lonnie waved a hand at Adora, striding out of the room.

Adora gave her a curt nod of appreciation before turning to confront Jitsu again.

“How do you know? I'm a princess?” Adora crossed her arms over her chest.

“You look very much like your twin brother...Adora.” He breathed, a slick, cunning smile spreading over his face.

Adora gasped, eyes flying wide in shock.

“Eternia mourned your loss, but King Randor and Queen Marlena never gave up on finding you again. To find you were brought here so far from home...it's truly a miracle. You have been deeply missed.” Jitsu added reverently, lowering his head in a respectful bow.

Adora's mouth dropped open in shock, never expecting she was a Princess of Eternia. The sudden knowledge struck like a sudden blow. Glimmer sputtered in surprise and rushed forward, as Adora stood frozen in stunned silence. The heat of her rage evaporated as a new softer warmth spread through her chest. As hope and excitement grew in her heart.

Bow was stunned but also intrigued by the revelations of Adora's origins. He leaned off the wall and moved in close to Adora for support, as he noticed how shell shocked she was.

“I am from Eternia...” Adora breathed, finding her voice after a very long time. Her threatening demeanor shifts instantly to a restrained eagerness to know more. “I have a brother...parents...a family...” She no longer loomed over Jitsu but had fallen to her knees, overwhelmed by his words. She knelt before him, staring up at him, her eyes wet with longing tears.

“I want to know everything...” she offered him a watery smile.

“Yes...I will answer whatever questions you must have.” Jitsu offered her a warm, disarming grin, slumping his shoulders as he leaned forward over his knees. Giving off a harmless aura of a

long lost, beloved uncle. “You were stolen so abruptly from us as an infant. We had no idea what happened to you, the whole planet mourned you, my dear.” Jitsu smiled fondly down at Adora, as if she was family.

Adora released a trembling breath, blinking away her tears as a small, sad smile pulled on her lips.

“Adora...” Glimmer placed a steadying hand on Adora's shoulder, wanting to draw her attention away from Jitsu. She sensed that Adora was already losing her perspective. Jitsu was their prisoner, not their friend.

A horde medic rushed into the study. Wearing light grey combat armor, her helmet clipped to the back of her utility belt. Carrying a heavy medical kit. She was older, her face battle worn. With short curly black hair, sprinkled with grey. Bow directed her towards the wounded man in the chair.

Jitsu jumped to his feet, not used to being treated with compassion. He eyed the medic with suspicion as she approached.

“What are you doing...” he blurted out in confusion.

“We just want to treat your wounds, it's ok.” Adora stood up, taking a couple steps back.

Jitsu's attempt to manipulate her through a common bond, broken by the medic's sudden intrusion.

Adora hung back with Bow and Glimmer while the Medic treated Jitsu's wounds. Applying ointment and fresh bandages to the festering skin on his burnt arm. Cleaning the blood off his clawed chest. Wrapping his swollen wrist in tight cloth, worried it might be sprained and then applying ointment and bandages to his singed hand. Cleaning the gash on his temple and taking note of the severe bruising on his neck.

Glimmer and Bow spoke softly with Adora in the far corner of the study.

“You gotta keep your guard up.” Glimmer admonished, tapping Adora pointedly on her collarbone.

“He is still our enemy, Adora. " Bow started, glancing over to Jitsu briefly. “He is not our friend....at least not yet.” He finished offering Adora a weak smile, his eyes warm with understanding.

Adora merely nodded, her mind still reeling at Jitsu's words. Fantasies of going to Eternia and meeting her real family was running rampant through her mind. Teasing her with hopes and dreams of reclaiming the family she had lost.

As more of the alliance began to filter into the room. Mermista stormed through the doorway, her head held high a proud grin replacing her usually dower expression.
“Did you see that!” She shouted, her voice bright and full of excitement. “BOOM!” She thrust both fists high into the air. “ I put out all the fires in one go... I have never felt more powerful!”

“I am very happy for you.” Perfuma stated softly, with a sweet, genuine smile. As she breezed into the room after Mermista. Her hands folded demurely in front of her waist.

“All right Buster! You got some explaining to do!” Casta charged into the study, invoking a truth spell as she crossed the threshold and flung the glowing glyph at Jitsu. The medic was just starting to back away when she entered, blocking Jitsu's view. He didn't see the spell in time, as his eyes flew wide in terror as the glyph engulfed him.

King Micah ambled in a few moments later, standing with his staff gripped tightly in one hand, glowering down at Jitsu. Who had slumped into the solitary chair in the small study, hunched over his legs. Eyes wide in fear, his arms wrapped tight around his stomach, shivering from some unknown chill as the spell took hold over his mind.

“Speak, Eternian!” Micah's voice boomed with authority. “Why are you here!”

“I was sent to retrieve an artifact...stolen by Squadron Grayskull over a thousand years ago...I traced its energy signal here. On the Arxia starbase...” Jitsu's voice was soft, barely a whisper. He glanced up, his dark brown eyes darting around the room in fear. He couldn't stop himself, compelled to answer every question honestly. He felt trapped and no longer in control of himself. It was the most terrifying feeling he had ever experienced.

“The Fail Safe?” Casta mused, tapping her finger against her chin.

“No....one of the shards of Kaydak...” Jitsu answered, blinking rapidly up at Casta. As if holding back tears. He tried to fight the compulsion to talk but the magic was too powerful. Fear ran like ice through his veins as he regarded the spell caster with a placid, accepting stare.

Casta narrowed her eyes in distrust, searching the beaten man's face for any hint of emotion. He was under the influence of the truth spell, he had no choice but to comply. But did he feel shame? Or remorse over what he had done. His complacent expression seemed rather odd? There were some other emotions layered beneath that resigned despondency that she did not understand just yet.

“That strange Star Seed... ” Mermista stated. Adora nodded her own affirmative.

“How many shards are there?” Adora inquired, moving forward from the window ledge she had been leaning against.

“I don't know...the Crystal of Kaydak was shattered over five thousand years ago and cast to the cosmic winds.” Jitsu answered, glancing nervously towards the several arching windows that took up the outer wall of the study. The dim evening light was filtering into the room, casting the occupants into somber shadows. This would be the perfect time for Tri-clops to

strike? Why was Tri-clops not attacking? There was no way he didn’t have a Seeker Drone spying on Mystacor right now. That control freak had eyes and ears everywhere!

“Why?” Glimmer asked, moving on the other side of her father. Blocking one of the windows, so Jitsu could no longer see outside. Glowering down at Jitsu, who was becoming more and more agitated.

“So that the full might of the Nameless One could no longer enter our dimension.” Jitsu responded in a hushed whisper.

“Who or what is this Nameless One?” Bow shivered at the ominous name.

“I don't know....I'm just a soldier...I follow my orders...I don't ask questions.” Jitsu whined, then snapped his gaze to the windows again. As a glowing trail of light shot across the sky towards the outer gardens.

“Looks like Darla's back.” Glimmer stated with a curt nod towards the window.

“Darla, left?” Adora turned to Glimmer with an inquiring eyebrow.

“Long story...” Glimmer sighed, waving Adora off with a smirk. “I'm going to help Frosta, Scorpia and Catra. Keep me informed.” She gave Adora a warm smile. She was relinquishing the reins, trying to trust her friends and stop trying to control every situation. She found the whole idea as cathartic as she found it completely terrifying.

“Of course.” Adora responded, blinking uncertainty for a second. Casting Bow a curious look as Glimmer promptly headed for the door.

Bow heaved a sigh and then scrubbed the back of his neck. “We had a long talk and she's trying to ease up a bit. She knows she can't control every situation and everyone around her. Working herself up into a anxious fit that causes her to lash out at her

friends. Doesn't help anyone. So she's decided to take a step back and trust in her friends." Bow smiled fondly at Glimmer as she left the room. Heading down the hall with Melog trotting close behind her.

"Wow..." Adora breathed. This was a big and frightening step for Glimmer, who was more of a control freak then even Adora.

Brilliant sparkles of Glimmer's teleport, suddenly illuminated the dull twilight gardens beyond the main gates. Catching the attention of several Etherian's milling around the outside of the ship. They turned and mildly regarded the Queen of Bright Moon with small nods as she jogged past them, heading with purpose towards Darla. The ramp was extended and small clusters of Etherian's were disembarking. Melog sniffed and growled low as they neared the ramp, casting the civilian's disapproving glares. Now that they were in range of their connection to Catra. They got a brief glimpse at her most recent, violent memories. They could sense the physical pain she was in. But oddly she was totally calm about it. Melog shook their head in confusion, weaving through the throng and into the ship. Ignoring the crowds as they slowly made their way down towards the engine core. Catra's small room was just off the main engine bay, tucked at the end of a short hallway. Melog padded softly across the open archway that led to the Engine Core. Stopping briefly to take in the vast, cavernous room. It was nearly as huge as the cargo hold, with a massive glowing cylinder dominating the center. It rose high overhead and out of view, a simple metal circular balcony wrapped around the engine core several stories up. A large control panel sat just before the core, with several smaller control panels lining the outer walls around the core. Many smaller rooms webbed out on either side of the engine core. They could smell Entrapta inside, perhaps in one of those small work rooms. They could hear the clang of metal deep inside. She was working on something, they were curious to investigate. But the urgent pull to get to Catra could not be ignored. With a huff,

Melog swung their head forward and padded the rest of the way to Catra's room.

The door hissed open as Darla acknowledged their presence. Melog moved into the room quietly, finding Catra once more curled up under her blanket on the bed. She resembled a small, compact ball, huddled against the far wall. It spoke volumes about how ashamed and wounded she was.

(What happened?) Melog cocked their head to the side, as they sat down in front of Catra's cot. Their voice inside her mind held a slightly parental tone of disapproval.

“I did something stupid...Adora is going to be so upset with me.” Catra moaned, slowly pulling down her blanket to reveal her busted bottom lip and swollen, black eye.

(Is the rest of you as hurt as your face?) Melog meowed in sympathy, rising up on their front paws onto the bed and licking Catra's unwounded cheek tenderly.

“Yes...” Catra moaned, nuzzling into Melog's mane seeking more of their soothing comfort. Melog began to purr softly, curling their head around the back of Catra's neck. As her own soothing purr echoed with Melog's. Her recent memories flowing freely into Melog's mind, offering the worried cat all the clairity they needed as to what happened to their master.

(Why would you let them do this?) Melog sighed, their disapproval passing through their link like a scolding.

“Cause I deserved it.” Catra commented softly, her voice breaking as she slowly released some of the guilt and misery she had been feeling for several seasons.

Melog gave her a low disgruntled snarl, making Catra cringe and whimper in shame.

(You believe such foolish things.) They admonished gently. Pulling back and giving her a chastising bunt with their head to her

forehead. (You were raised to fight a war! Both sides suffered losses. You are not the only one to cause harm to others on this planet.)

Catra whimpered, “But I still did, Melog. I hurt so many people. I need to be punished...so that Etheria will stop hating me.” The man's words echoed in her mind....Butcher of Salineas...she was a mass murderer. It gnawed at her that she had killed innocent civilians in her pursuit to win the war. When she had come to some rather bleak realizations back on Primes Ship. Watching from the windows as he bombarded other worlds, she knew she was no better. It had made her blood run cold to realize the lives she had taken in her ambition. She had been so driven, so blinded by the prospect of power and finally being in control. To prove that she was worth something... No one would be able to hurt her then, she would be in charge and finally feel safe. She never allowed herself to think about it...what affect her actions would have on the world around her. Now the guilt and remorse struck her again and again, like a blade to the heart. Slicing through her attempts to be happy, leaving her cowed and miserable.

She had been such a monster....she needed to be punished...she needed to earn her redemption...

(Stop it!) Melog sensed her inner monologue of self loathing and quickly bunted her more forcefully with their forehead.

Catra choked back a sob, grasping Melog cheeks to keep them close, needing a few moments to collect herself. She was close to breaking down again, but she was also very tired of crying. It served no purpose and didn't help at all in the end.

(Let's get you back to your room, your mate is tired enough for today, She does not need to spend the portion of the night she has left looking for you.) Melog climbed down from the bunk, padding towards the doorway.

“I can't face her...not like this. Can you tell her I'm fine and that I will see her in a few days after I heal up a bit?” Catra offered

weakly, giving Melog a hopeful, pleading smile. Knowing full well that Melog couldn’t communicate with anyone but her. She was asking the impossible. But she was scared and desperate so she spat out the plea without thinking.

Melog lowered their head becoming frustrated with her hiding nonsense.

(Are you physically hurting that bad, that you need to hide, lest your weakness be preyed upon?)

“No...I just...” Catra started.

(Own your mistakes, child. There is no need to hide if we are not vulnerable or dying.) Melog scolded.

Catra groaned and reluctantly got off the bed, she nodded slowly as she approached Melog at the door to her room.

“Then let's get this over with.” She grumbled, as Melog shimmered them invisible.

Jitsu's interrogation lasted long into the night, when Adora finally made it back to her chambers, at the dormitory. The moons were high overhead, bathing the Basilica and all it's outer buildings in a gentle glow. This had probably been one the longest days of her life. She was exhausted in every way, but her mind was spinning with even more questions. Jitsu had revealed so much more to her about her biological family, of her proud royal heritage and the ancient majesty of her home planet...Eternia. The yearning to find her family and see where she had been born was even more pronounced now. But the pull to keep the planet that had raised her, cultivated who she was now....safe. Dampened those wants somewhat. She had to protect Etheria, it was more important than what she wanted. She laughed bitterly at that, she had finally given herself permission to want. But once again she had to deny her heart’s desire for the greater good. Forbidding herself from wanting, because she felt she didn't deserve those wishes fulfilled.

Or perhaps she was not even allowed to have them. She was used to that and could easily go back behind that wall of duty and sacrifice, but this time she resented it.

Scrubbing a hand down her face she heaved a disappointed sigh and pushed the wooden door open. Finding the room within was quiet, almost somber. The faint light from the moons hanging in the wide, arching window casting the four poster bed in pale blue light. Creating a heavy melancholy atmosphere that weighed upon her already troubled spirit. Pulling her despondent mood further down into despair. Sniffling softly as she stubbornly held back her tears. Adora glanced to Finn's cot, finding a small lump breathing softly under his blankets. She smiled fondly, her worries over the little Thaymorian finally put to rest at the sight of him sleeping. She had linked with Swift Wind during the fire storm, inquiring if Finn was with him. Swifty had responded through their bond that the little Thaymorian had no plans with him that day. So he had no idea where he was? Which had left an icy dread in her gut all day, over the whereabouts of the little kid. Curious as to why he had lied? But knowing that he was ok, warmed her. Soothing some of the heartache over having to give up her chance to reconnect with her own family.

She crossed the room as quietly as she could, pulling off her white long sleeve shirt and tossing it aside. By the time she made it to the bed, she had discarded her boots and pants as well. Melog was curled up at the foot of the bed, their iridescent mane and tail, glowing a soft white. Adora was so exhausted she barely registered that it was a new hue for the Alien creature. Melog raised their head as Adora approached, their mane returning to its placid light teal. Hopping off the bed to curl up on the pile of pillows in the corner of the room. Adora noted their departure, as she climbed onto the mattress in just her loose white undershirt and grey shorts. Thankful, to find Catra's warm body already under the blankets.

She lightly curled herself around Catra's lithe form, feeling the comforting warmth of her soft fur pressed against her skin. Humming contentedly as she nuzzled her neck for a second.

Pressing a soft kiss to her cheek in greeting. Her lips instantly felt the heat and tightness of Catra's skin under the velvet soft layer of fur.

Catra moaned in pain, shifting away from Adora as she slowly woke up.

Adora shot up on one elbow, her fingers strong but tender as she grasped Catra's shoulder and pushed her onto her back. In the pale glow of the moons, Adora slowly took in the deep cut over her left eyebrow and the swollen and bruised mess of her eye. The fat lower lip still crusted with blood.

With her heart now pounding hard in her chest, Adora swiftly cast the blanket aside needing to ascertain if there was any further damage to Catra's body.

Catra turned her head away in shame, whimpering sadly as Adora gasped in horror. Her once warm blue eyes turned hard as steel, as she took in the ugly bruises running up and down both of Catra's arms. The bruising was deep and dark, made by the impact of steel. The bandages wrapped around her wrists, spoke of being sprained or worse, broken. The Magicat was not wearing any clothes and she could understand why, her whole body was riddled with abrasions of all shapes and sizes. Small bruises were scattered all over her chest and lower abdomen. That looked very much like the impacts of fists and boots. The same type of scattered bruises was also running down both thighs.

Adora huffed, not even offering Catra a word of comfort as she lightly rolled the Magicat onto her side to inspect her back. Finding even more bruises from being kicked, repeatedly along her spine and shoulder blades.

“What happened...” Adora breathed, her voice was a low, harsh whisper. As her whole body was trembling with pent up rage.

“I got into a fight in the Cargo Hold on Darla...with pretty much most of Etheria.” Catra laughed bitterly, shrugging her shoulders

in an apathetic manner. Trying valiantly to make light of the mob assault she had suffered.

Wrath burned deep inside of Adora, as a deafening roar filled her ears. Not at Catra but at the bastards that had beat her up so thoroughly.

“Ok...I got this.” Adora nodded, releasing her possessive hold on Catra's shoulder. Allowing her to finally fall onto her back, where she lay complacently. Staring up at Adora's darkening glower in growing dismay.

Adora's mind was already formulating her plan. She would heal Catra first then head back to Darla and deal with all of the Etherian's involved in her beating. She would sort this all out, violently if necessary! But she would make them all see. That the War was over, it was time to move on from all this blame and hatred or suffer the consequences. She needed to protect Catra better! She needed to regain control of the planet before it's people restarted the war all over again, over petty resentments and prejudices. Her insecurities screamed at her, that she was failing at being She-Ra, at being Catra's protector, at everything!

Catra's eyes widened in sudden fear, as she found Adora's eyes were glowing...a deep crimson. Her expression pinched in frustrated anger. A seething fury, burning within those azure eyes.

“Adora...” Catra's voice was stuttering with fear. That wrathful gaze had once been trained upon her many years ago back in the frozen tundra of the Northern Reach. The cold, unmerciful rage that had burned deep in that crimson glow. Had seeded such an intense, almost primal fear in her, that she had been unable to confront Adora again, for over a year. Even then she never engaged in combat, stayed far away, seeking to use traps or bots to fight her.

To find that fearsome glow now directed towards her again, she could barely breathe and the sudden flight she took from the bed

was swift and filled with unbridled terror.

“Catra...?” Adora shouted in surprise as the Magicat flung herself out of bed and was now cowering behind Melog in the far corner of the room. Her whole body was trembling at the sudden fright. Her ears pressed flat against her head, tail, bristled and lashing anxiously. Her mismatched eyes staring up at Adora, wide and wet with a mixture of fear and betrayal. Adora was shaken out of her brooding by Catra's sudden flight and she found herself trembling as well. Her face flushed with sudden stress. Her heart was aching to reach out and reassure Catra. That everything was going to be alright. Adora had never seen her so scared before. Perhaps by what had happened to her, she needed some space. To feel secure enough to tell her the truth?

“Adora...your eyes..were..glowing red..” Catra stammered, curling against Melog's back for security. Who was now crouching sideways in front of her, their mane snapping and sparking as they responded to the sudden threat. Creating a barrier with their body to protect Catra from her...

Adora was stunned, blinking in confusion and slowly lowering her reaching hand. As shame, heartache flooded through her. Catra had not gotten scared by what had happened to her in the hold. It shook her to her very core that that intense fear was directed towards her.

“I don't understand...” Adora breathed, then groaned and flopped onto her back on the mattress in defeat. As an icy cold dread gripped her heart. What did that mean? The only time her eyes were red was when her old sword had been infected by that virus. That was stored in that ancient crystal disc? She had no memories while she had been infected. Those moments when she had lost all control over She-Ra were purged from her mind when she transformed back into Adora. Glimmer and Bow had given her vague recollections of what she did, at Dryl, at the Northern Reach. No doubt keeping the gritter details to themselves to protect her. What had she done to Catra as that monster?

Whatever it was, the poor feline had been severely traumatized by it...

Adora stifled a helpless scream as she pressed the palms of her hands firmly against her eyes in frustration. “What is going on with my powers...” She groaned. “I just wanted to heal you.”

“I don't want you to.” Catra responded in a small voice.

Adora rolled back onto her side and regarded Catra with a questioning frown.

“You've been She-Ra for most of the day and I know that you have been healing every badly hurt Etherian you came across during that fire storm. My injuries are minor, they will heal up just fine in a few days.” Catra stated, offering Adora a weak smile.

“I hate seeing you hurt, Catra.” Adora responded, tears moistening her eyes.

“I know...but this pain is...” Catra glanced meekly down at the floor for a moment. “I asked for it, Adora...I allowed them to beat on me...ok!” Catra admitted, her voice high pitched and desperate, then she bowed her head with a shameful wince. As Adora swung her legs over the side of the bed and sat up. Staring down at her both appalled and shocked by her admission.

“Why?” Adora breathed in utter bafflement.

Catra was silent for a long time, brooding at the throw pillows that surrounded her. Refusing to further admit how she wished to just be punished for her crimes, so that she could move on from the crushing guilt that gnawed at her every damn day.

“Catra?” Adora's voice was stern, pulling Catra away from her dark thoughts.

“Cause I...” Catra never finished her statement. She was having a hard time admitting why she had let the mob beat her up. It hurt and she felt ashamed that she had let it happen. She had hoped

that it might take the guilt away a little, but after talking to Frosta and gaining a better perspective. She only felt worse for allowing it.

So Adora finished for her.

“You do not deserve to be hurt...by anyone!” Adora shouted, scrambling to kneel in front of her.

Catra hissed in fright at Adora's sudden movement towards her. Melog had settled for a moment, but as Catra's sudden fight or flight emotions slammed through them. They jumped up, arching their back, fur bristling in fury. Their iridescent mane crackling, growling and barring protective fangs towards Adora.

Who scrambled back a few paces in fright, hands raised in a placating fashion at Melogs sudden threat.

“Just stay away from me, for a bit....” Catra heaved, she was still humming with fear towards Adora. The turbulent waves of her emotions, churning inside her, was not making calming down any easier.

“Ok...” Adora stated softly, her voice weak, eyes wet with remorse.

“Look, Adora. What happened at the Northern Reach between us, it was really bad. I was totally asking for it...just like today.” Catra laughed bitterly, at her toxic obsession at the time. So blinded by the idea of being able to control She-Ra and in turn control Adora. Force her to love her, and need her in the ways she craved. She had never thought the crystal would turn her into some raging monster hell bent on killing everyone in her path. She had fantasized about finally gaining approval from Hordak and humiliating Shadow Weaver. She had ignored Entrapta's warnings and paid for it, almost with her life. If Scorpia hadn't put herself on the line by tackling She-Ra, separating her from the sword...Adora would have killed her. Adora would have never forgiven herself if she had murdered her. It would have broken

her so completely she would never recover from it. That realization crushed Catra. She had been such a horrible person, then.

“You gotta give me a little time to calm down.” She raised a placating hand and winced, as the guilt at what she had done to Adora and the past trauma of that night echoed painfully in her memories.

“I don't think Glimmer and Bow told me the whole story...” Adora kept her eyes downcast in both fear and shame. Her index finger drawing absently on the slate stone floor, as she contemplated the full ramifications of not remembering that night.

“You really do not need to know, it would only hurt you.” Catra sighed, scrubbing her hands down her face, seeking to clear away all the lingering fear. It clung to her skin, like a vile spider web. Tingling and vibrating through her muscles. Making her fur stand up, as it sluggishly ebbed away. Melog, mewled softly, shaking their whole body violently, trying to purged the ugly emotions. As they slowly calmed down, their body returning to the dull blues and violets of a peaceful state of mind. They settled down on their stomach in front of Catra, keeping a close eye on Adora.

“I want to know though..” Adora stated sadly, glanced up at her briefly. Her moist blue eyes pleaded for the truth, that everyone had been keeping from her. To protect her it seemed from reliving something very awful.

“Maybe, one day...ok.” Catra took a deep, cleansing breath. What happened that night wasn't Adora's fault at all. She had been victimized...at Catra's cruel hands.

Catra pulled her knees up to her chest, tail curled around her ankles in a protective manner. Hunching forward, trying to make herself smaller. Ducking her face into her knees to hide her pain from Adora.

So many regrets....and that one was one of the worst.

Melog finally padded behind her and curled around her waist. The tone of their body had darkened, their mane was flowing low near their neck. The color drained of any vibrance, filled with a dull, melancholy aura.

Several minutes passed in heavy silence. Adora sat, watching Catra carefully. Observing how her ears twitched, the small movements of her tail, how just the tip was flicking anxiously around her ankles. Adora had found Catra hiding many times like this while they grew up. Dealing with her raging emotions in the only way she knew how, seeking to hide away. As she desperately sought to regain control of herself. But Adora would never let her suffer all alone, she would always find her and sit nearby in her hiding spots. A gentle, quiet support she could draw strength from. She knew all her silent tells, Catra had always expressed how she truly felt in more subtle ways. So Adora knew not to approach or force contact, until given silent permission. Adora had infinite amounts of patience in regards to Catra's needs, both emotionally and physically. Adora's presence was enough, it could always pull Catra out of her inner turmoil. Adora shifted closer, adjusting the pillows around her crossed legs in an absent manner, preparing for when she was allowed to hold her once again. Silently offering Catra, the love, understanding and security she needed to feel safe once more.

When the tight muscles of Catra's shoulder began to relax and her tail uncurled a little bit from her ankles. The very tip of it slinked forward to lightly brush against Adora's knees. Adora knew it was time to reach out again. To offer the woman who meant everything to her, more than just her quiet presence.

“Can I hold you now?” Adora asked gently.

Catra merely nodded wordlessly, ready to finally receive the comfort and protection only Adora could provide. Adora quickly crawled forward and wrapped her up in her embrace. As Catra took a shaky breath. Curling against her chest, seeking the security and reassurance of her strong arms. Adora always made her feel safe when she felt so adrift in her own darkness.

“I don't want you to allow anyone to hurt you ever again.” Adora chastised kindly, as she pulled her in.

“I won't let it happen again...I promise.” Catra whimpered, pressing her face against the crook of Adora's neck. Breathing her in with long, shuttering heaves of her own breath, as painful sobs threatened.

“I just want....” Catra started, her voice faltering into self doubt.. (Forgiveness) She spoke the last word only in her mind. How could she articulate how bad she felt about what she had done. How much she loathed the girl she had once been. How she just wanted to move forward and be given a second chance and actually believe she deserved it.

Adora held her close as she cried, her broken sobs of regret vibrating against her chest. As Catra pressed her face tight against Adora's shirt, clutching desperately at her broad shoulders. As her smaller body shook, purging the misery from her soul once more. Adora cradled Catra against her chest tenderly, slowly petting a hand down the back of her head, her fingertips lightly scratching the sensitive skin just behind her ears. Slowly, soothing her heartbroken sobs into a soft purr that vibrated against her chest. Adora smiled fondly. Pressing her face into the side of Catra's head humming, happily along with her purr. She loved that sound, it was always truthful. She could always depend on it, even when it's owner would use snark or deflection to hide her true feelings. Catra had become far more open and honest with her since Prime and Adora was thankful for it. But Adora had always been able to gauge how Catra was really feeling with the subtle sounds of her purr's. This time the low rumble was loud, filled with a sense of contentment. Their relationship had always been filled with an unspoken give and take. She took care of Catra and in turn Catra took care of her, in all the ways she needed most. The sound Catra made, calmed the emotional turmoil that was once raging deep inside of Adora. Lulling her exhausted body into a placid state of blissful peace.

“I love your purr...” Adora moaned, suddenly far too exhausted to continue to sit up. She drew Catra down upon the pillows. Never truly releasing her from her tender embrace, they nestled into the pillows with Melog. Curled up with each other, arms and legs intertwining effortlessly. This ability to mold themselves against each other like two puzzle pieces that fit together had been a coping tactic they had cultivated growing up. No matter where, no matter how, they would manage to wrap themselves around each other. To offer each other comfort and security, that was always so desperately needed growing up in the Fright Zone. It didn't take long for both of them to fall asleep, nestling perfectly in each other's arms. Their heads cradled tenderly in each other's hands, resting fitfully against each other’s shoulders. Adora took Catra's weight easily, settling on the floor amid the pillows. As Catra molded her sore body, slightly across Adora 's chest. Melog's mane began to glow a pure white again, as the two women fell asleep. Melog settled themselves against Adora's side, resting the subtle weight of their head on the feline woman's hip. As a warm, soothing glow enveloped Catra. Humming across her skin, easing her sore muscles like a balm.

Two yellow, reptilian eyes stared from beneath the blankets on the cot. A clear membrane flicked over the hybrid's eyes as they took in the tender scene between the two women.

“My, my kitten. You are still quite a mess...even after finally getting what you truly wanted?” Double Trouble whispered, a slow conspiring smile pulling on his lips.

“I think I am going to enjoy this recon, Blue.”

The piercing wail of an infant's cry echoed through the void. Adora once again stood alone upon the invisible precipice. Staring upward at the blanket of now, alien constellations. These were not the star patterns that graced the heavens above Etheria? Then the vision shifted. The stars were now framed within a large, oval window. She was staring up at them from inside what seemed to be a large woven basket. Her body was surrounded by soft, plush blankets.

"Where am I?" Adora questioned in a breathless voice. A cold pit of dread growing in her stomach, along with a sense of loss. She took note of two moons, hanging in the night sky. One a glowing celestial body the other looked like a dull and lifeless rock. Hovering high overhead amid the endless starlight.

"These are the final moments of your time on Eternia." Light Hope's voice filtered softly from beside her.

Adora was reluctant to draw her gaze down from the heavens. Her heart ached with guilt over Light Hope's fate at her hands. It didn't ease her shame that Light Hope had begged her to end it. She had fought her programming to the very end. Knowing what she had been doing was wrong, that she could not allow the First Ones to control her any longer. That her sacrifice, just like Mara's, would ensure the survival of the universe.

A deafening roar thundered from the distance, as a vortex of purple light enveloped the stars.

Once again the vison shifted. Adora cried out in alarm and fear, ducking and wrapping her arms instinctively over her head. The roar faded along with the light as quickly as it came. Adora cracked open her eyes, glancing nervously around a lush, green glade of tall grass full of wildflowers. It was midday, the day moons were glowing high overhead. They were back in the shadow dimension of Despondos, in which Etheria's sun no longer existed. But the magic from the two day moons was able to absorb the light of Etheria's sun from one dimension and cast it down upon the planet. Ensuring that the life would still flourlsh

while the planet was trapped in a lifeless pocket dimension. Adora came to understand all of this after Etheria was moved back into the wider galaxy once again. Adora took a deep breath, the air was humid and thick with the scents of wild flowers. The aroma was heady and made her suddenly very dizzy.

"This is Meadowlands..." Adora nodded, she had never gone to this kingdom before. This was where Princess Sweet Bee reigned. She had never met this princess either, like Prince Peekablue they had been missing or in hiding for years.

Raising a hand to cover her eyes, from the sharp glare of the moons. She squinted her eyes, so she could make out a tall figure in the distance, shrouded in dark horde armor. She quickly recognized the sharper, more gothic angles of his chest piece and shoulder pauldron. The rounded gorget, that rose high on the back of his neck to shield his connection port. The threatening visage of a tyrant, she had once known to fear in her youth. It was Hordak. He stood stoically before a pulsing vortex of violet light, waiting it seemed.

"You seem troubled. It's affecting your connection with She-Ra." Light Hope stated. "I felt it was time I interceded once again upon your training..."

Adora took a deep breath, seeking to calm her growing frustration. As always Light Hope's assessment was spot on, but provided no answers. As to why her connection to She-Ra had become corrupted. She turned to confront Light Hope, with a long suffering sigh. Finding the hologram, standing tall beside her. Glowing a pure white, her face was as impassive as ever. Her hands folded demurely before her. "You once told me babies do not remember. So I have come back, to show you what you have forgotten. So that perhaps it might give you some clarity. "

Adora's eyes widened with hope, as she released a brittle laugh at the irony. "Finally going to answer all my questions now, that you're dead."

“Affirmative., well at least the one that weighs on you the most. You had so many...” Light Hope nodded, smiling fondly down at her. Adora was taken off guard by the sudden show of emotion on the hologram's face. In life she had always been logical and impassive, only providing the bare minimum of information Adora needed to go forward with the mission. All a tactic to maintain control of the weapon she was programed to release upon the universe.

Adora waited with bated breath, from experience she half expected Light Hope to glitch, so that she could avoid answering. When it didn't happen and Light Hope spoke again, not even taking a moment in between statements. Adora breathed a sigh of relief.

“I was once again brought online when the Super Computer received a communication from Eternia that the Heir's of Grayskull had been born. I was given new orders to create a portal and return to the mission. So I rerouted power from the Heart to create a transdimensional link to Eternia, creating a Portal that would summon Hordak to this meadow to claim you.” Light Hope waved her arm towards the portal.

Adora returned her attention to the fateful scene playing out further in the meadow.

Hordak stood before the swirling gate of energy, as a small figure walked through. Cloaked in a feathered dress, with a falcon headpiece draped over her head. She was a tiny, waif of a woman. Who held herself with a regal grace, Adora felt she could never hope to obtain. She walked over to Hordak without fear, handing him a tiny, wailing bundle of cloth. Hordak took the wrapped infant with a look of disgust, resigned to the fact that he had no choice but to take the child. Holding the baby at arms length, he regarded the shorter woman standing before him with a vengeful sneer.

"Veena....Sorceress of Grayskull..." He growled, clawed finger's curling slightly into the babies swaddling blanket.

The smaller woman merely smiled, politely up at him.

"You exile me and my battalion...to this shadow dimension only to reappear years later to burden me with this useless creature?" Hordak snarled.

“You had fallen out of favor with Horde Prime. He had cast you aside as an imperfection, a failure. You had been tested and found wanting. Abandoning you and your crew on Eternia to die. But you survived Primes last ditch assault on our Planet. Your ship was crippled, your fate sealed. I could have allowed your ship to crash into the Ice Mountian's, leave you and your crew to slowly freeze to death, or rot in a cells under Eterno’s Castle for all eternity. It is what you and your wretched brethren deserve. But I didn't, the Great Unrest is over. Prime may not have a use for you but I do. Here you will be allowed to forge your own future. Do with it as you wish, but you will repay your debts, to the Immortals. Who's powers allowed you to escape your fate, Horde clone.” The small woman glowered at Hordak, accenting the fact that he was just a clone of Horde Prime. A mere tool to be used and thrown away and not worthy of respect.

The world flashed for a moment and then Adora's perspective changed, she was no longer watching the scene play out in the distance. But was now staring up at Hordak's glowering face from the eyes of her infant self. She turned her head and gasped, as she stared at the woman in the falcon cloak. Her face was identical to Angella's but so much younger...she looked around Frosta's age, maybe a year or two older. Her long platinum blonde hair was tied back into an elaborate braid that hung over one shoulder, dangly low near her waist. Larger, deep purple, tear drop earrings hung from her ear's and one adorned her forehead. Her simple feathered dress hung over her thighs and her slender feet were bare. Her wings were tucked at her back, not pure white like Angella's, but tawny brown like the predatory bird she wore on her head. She held a slender silver staff in one hand, with a bird in flight upon the crown. This bird was not a falcon, it looked more elegant, more magical. With full majestic wings, unfurled and pointing upwards. An angular head with glowing

eyes, that held a penetrating, almost timeless stare. It's slender body was curved into the staff, as if it was rising from the depths of the metal itself. The staff vibrated with great power, beyond Adora's comprehension. The magic it stored, seemed to sing towards Adora. The staff's essence was warm and welcoming, seeking to form a connection to her infant self she did not recognize.

"I am well aware of my failures to conquer Eternia, Veena. But I also fail to see this imprisonment on a back water world in a shadow dimension as a boon either. " Hordak spat.

"You are merely to keep her safe, keep her alive so that her destiny can be set in motion." The sorceress declared, her voice rising with both volume and power.

"Horde Prime is Eternal, you will never defeat him." Hordak scoffed, his thin lips curling at the edges in disgust. At the mewling baby currently blinking innocently up at him from the crook of his arm. Her pudgy arms reach towards the Sorceress staff, yearning to touch it.

"Horde Prime is a mere fragment of Gorta. He will be easily extinguished, when she comes into her full power. If you wish to live, I suggest you be on the right side of this coming conflict, clone." The Sorceress turned on her heel.

"What is this filthy creature's name?" Hordak called to the retreating woman.

"Adora..." Her voice echoed back as she faded through the swirling portal.

Leaving Hordak alone in the meadow, with a now sleeping infant.

In another flash of light, Adora found herself once more standing within the meadow, observing the scene from a distance.

"Light Hope..." Adora spun on the hologram, her expression full of hope and joy at finally getting some answers about her past. Yet

her eyes were uncertain, holding so many more questions now.

But the hologram was gone, the meadow faded away into the featureless void. Leaving Adora once more in that lonely world of nothingness. Adrift and utterly alone...this deep, impenetrable darkness felt predatory. Wrapping around her, caging her in and slowly seeking to devour her soul.

Adora felt a sudden rush of panic suffocating her, she clutched at her chest gasping for breath.

"Adora!" Catra pounded frantically on the blondes back with her fists. As Adora arms that were once relaxed, cradling her softly against her chest. Had crossed over her shoulder blades and drawn Catra up firmly against her chest. In a crushing hold, locking the magicat tight.

"Adora!...can't breathe!" Catra cried out in alarm, wiggling and pounding valiantly upon Adora's back seeking to wake her up, or free herself from this bone crushing embrace.

Adora jerked away and released her, pushing out of the pillows with a cry of alarm.

"Sorry..." Adora breathed, sitting up and clutching her head, as a pounding headache began to throb behind her eyes. That dream had been more intense than any of the previous nightmares. What did it all mean?

"What were you dreaming about?" Catra sucked in a welcomed breath, sitting up beside her and placing a comforting hand on her shoulder.

"Light Hope showed me how I got to Etheria...she was just a part of this whole destiny thing...so was Hordak and some other woman from Eternia called The Sorceress...who looked just like Queen Angella...but much younger." Adora was shaken by the

revelation, as she looked up at Catra with concern. Who wore an expression of stunned disbelief.

“Wow...Light Hope...but isn't she like dead and a program...so how?” Catra mused. “I mean, Queen Angella had been guiding me in my dreams. I figured because she's immortal and trapped between dimensions so it's a magic type thing she can do...but a computer program...that's just impossible. Right?” Catra was completely confused.

“At this point, I'd believe anything is possible.” Adora commented dryly.

“Queen Angella has a version of herself on Eternia?” Catra mused, “I guess that's as plausible as anything else. I mean we know nothing about Immortals...as far as I know she was the only one on this planet...” Catra kept working out the details, pulling them apart bit by bit, as if unraveling a thread from a tattered blanket.

Adora sighed, she was far too hungry and just bone tired to speculate more on the dream. “I want to go grab a quick breakfast then head back to the holding cell to ask Jitsu some more questions.” Adora groaned and slowly rose to her feet. Real people offered her more concrete answers than some cryptic hologram, who had never told her the whole truth ever.

“Ok...” Catra agreed, her stomach growling in response. Then her eyes widened in surprise. “You caught him? Jitsu?” Catra scrambled to her own feet, rushing for the pile of clothes she discarded beside the bed.

“Melog captured him yesterday, before Darla took off.” Adora answered, her voice slightly muffled as she was on her knees gathering her own clothes on the other side of the bed.

“Way to go, Buddy!” Catra laughed, giving Melog a beaming smile. Slowly easing her panties up her legs.

Melog mewled happily, as they stretched leisurely out of the pile of pillows. Raising their butt into the air briefly as they reached

out on their front paws, scratching the floor. Before gingerly stepping out of the pillows and padding towards Catra.

Catra's eyes widened in surprise as she found the wings that were once attached to Melogs sides were now gone.

“Adora! Melog lost their wings?” She exclaimed.

Adora moved to her side, full dressed. “I guess the magic wears off?” She shrugged.

“It didn't wear off for Swift Wind?” Catra commented, lightly.

Melog yawned and rolled onto their stomach, inviting Catra to rub their belly. Catra laughed lightly and compiled. Giving their belly a good rub with both hands and then petting them up their chest and around the back of their strong neck, to their ears and giving them a good scratch.

“They don't seem to miss them.” Catra stated with a laughing grin.

“Ah, well...” Adora laughed. “Giving Melog wings was not my intention anyway. My magic is not an exact science. More like good intentions, that work out or not.”

Catra sighed, “I know...I got my own magic to figure out.” She grumbled, picking up the tight dark fabric of her breast wrap off the floor. She pulled her breast wrap over her head. Wiggling her shoulders to get the tight fabric into place over her modest bossom.

“Finn, we are heading to the kitchen for some breakfast. Coming?” Adora called, turning away from Catra. Finding Finn's bedroll empty. She cast the empty bed a forlorn look, wondering where the Thaymorian was off too, so very early in the morning. She hadn't seen him in days?

As she heard Catra groan in discomfort.

“I'm coming.” she called, moving swiftly to Catra's side to help her get dressed.

Finding her beloved, had managed to pull on her black underwear and had her breast wrap half on. Which had no doubt caused her to cry out in pain. Her ribs were still discolored, but the bruises looked lighter. She had respected Catra's wishes and did not heal her, but her injuries still looked far better than they should. Certainly farther along in the healing process than just one night? Adora kept it to herself, casting Melog a strange look over her shoulder. The cat merely yawned and blinked innocently up at her from their sitting position next to the hearth.

Adora was all business, at least at first. Helping Catra adjust the wrap into place as gently as possible. Before, tenderly guiding Catra up off the floor with her hands under her armpits. Settling her on the edge of the bed, before gathering up her black, slightly torn leggings. Intent on slowly pulling them up her legs, as she knelt in front of her. Slipping a pant leg over her one arching foot, pulling the leg up and bracing Catra’s foot on her collarbone. As she started to work the fabric up her calf.

Catra giggled, “Hey, Adora…” She crooned in a low husky manner as Adora's feather light fingers tickled up her leg. Playfully, tracing the claw of her big toe against the plaint skin of Adora's collar bone. “I feel better this morning, still a little sore. I may take advantage of this situation.” She whispered in a sultry manner.

Adora sucked in a breath, turning her gaze upward, a slow, bashful smile pulling on her lips. Finding Catra gazing lovingly down upon her. The swelling that had nearly closed her blue eye had eased considerably. Leaving that eye now clear and open again, only a light bruise remained. Giving the skin around her eye a dusty grey shadow. Her swollen lower lip had gone down as well. Her face was once more as flawless and beautiful as it ever was.

“You need to stop being so reckless.” Adora reached up and cupped her cheek, rubbing her thumb along Catra's soft fur

beneath her golden eye.

“I'll try, princess.” Catra sighed into her caress, closing her eyes and turning her cheek into Adora's palm.

Adora nodded, lightly pulling up her pants. Taking slow, calming breaths as her heart beat began to thunder in her ears. Catra's legs were alluring, tantalizing her, with a need to explore them in more intimate detail. Her calves were toned, curving upward over gorgeously formed thighs and a firm butt. A sassy tail flicked teasingly against Adora's cheek as she valiantly tried to focus on her task. Catra was smirking down at her, observing proudly, how intensely Adora was staring at her legs. Catra arched an eyebrow, at Adora's quick intake of breath as her finger’s neared her upper thighs. Verifying for her that Adora was just as aroused by her body. As she was, to feel Adora's hands brushing against her skin. When Adora's hands drew closer, up near the apex of her thighs. Adora licked her lips, nervously.

“Ok, stand up.” Adora commanded softly as she knelt upward on her knees, seeking to finish her task. Clearing her throat and trying hard not to give into her more carnal desires to touch Catra more intimately.

Catra nodded and placed her hands on Adora's shoulder's, standing up slowly, her hips swaying seductively close to Adroa's face. Adora sucked in another breath, as Catra's groin was now right in front of her. Clearing her throat nervously, again. As Catra giggled in impish delight. How the tables had turned, now it was Adora having to confront her growing desires. But she was far more stubborn and mission focused then Catra had been. Who tended to give into her whims more often. So Adora focused on her job, wondering if Catra had felt just as aroused and scared when she had been disrobing her at the farm house. Slowing her movements as she pulled up the tight fabric and adjusting her grip on the waist band. Trying to be modest and not touch Catra anywhere that might be embarrassing or unwanted.

Catra took note of Adora's hands moving to the more strategically platonic location of her outer thighs. She was disappointed, but also thankful for Adora's respectful regard. But having Adora's hands on her body was highly arousing, but she was also still kinda sore and doubted she looked very appealing. With all the bruises covering her face and body. So she was content with just this brief moment of teasing, gratified by the minimal amount of physical contact Adora had offered. Even if it was purely focused on getting her dressed...and not seeking to pleasure her in all the ways she craved.

Catra groaned and rolled her head back, as erotic images of what they had done together so far, invaded her thoughts. Despite all her bravado, she was rather timid about being more intimate with Adora and was perfectly content taking it slow.

"Did I hurt you?" Adora brushed her fingertips away from Catra's waist, as she slowly rose up to her feet. Her face hovering just above Catra's head, her hot breath puffing against her short hair. As Adora was panting with the effort to contain her desires. She lightly brushed her fingers over Catra's ass, gently pulling her tail out of the hole in the back of her leggings. Catra gasped in surprise then released a soft languid moan, Adora had never touched her there before. The sudden intimate caress had jolted her body with pleasure...as Adora's other hand moved to massage the sensitive area just above her tail to distract and soothe her. Catra found her body becoming relaxed and pliant under her touch. Unable to control herself, as leaned against Adora's chest, her face tucked meekly against her shoulder mewling with need. Adora intentionally drew her fingertips up along her bare sides in a feather light caress. Worried she had caused her pain, but also wanting to tease her a little bit more. She wasn't so naive not to figure out that Catra had been teasing her the whole time she tried to pull up her pants. But her seductions had worked, Adora's body was now humming with a need for more. Her gaze was ravenous, as she devoured every inch of Catra's toned stomach and sultry curves. Wanting to touch...perhaps kiss every inch of her body.

Catra squirmed under her light caress, leaning her face upward as Adora was hovering over her. She wasn't much shorter than Adora. But enough that she had to incline her head a bit to look her in the eyes.

“Urgh...Adora.” Catra growled in frustration, bowing her head and pressing her forehead against the blonde's collar bone. Her whole body was tingling now and that dull ache was throbbing low in her groin again.

Adora smirked, delighting in how aroused her girlfriend was by her slow, seductive caresses. Unable to resist taking advantage of the situation more. Wanting Catra to know how deeply she was loved. Adora leaned in, gripping Catra's chin gently and pulling her face back up. Then she leaned down and pressed her lips softly against Catra's. The pressure was feather light at first, but as Catra began to arch against her. Adora could feel her breasts pressing up against hers. Catra’s nipples were puckered, into firm knots that caressed her own chest in a very tantalizing way. Adora moaned with need, as Catra pressed her lips more firmly against her's. Adora could not help but yearn for more. Darting her tongue out and licking, soothingly against the cut on Catra's lower lip. Catra sighed and opened, inviting her tongue to dance inside her mouth. Adora's hands tangled into the short hair behind Catra's head. Pulling her body more firmly against her, as the kiss grew more heated. Their lips sliding together in anticipation of more, tongues darting desperately as that familiar ache began to unfurl and blossom low in their groins.

“I love you...” Adora breathed against her lips, then reluctantly pulled away but just enough to grin mischievously down at her. Her blue eyes shining with a burning passion, yearning for more but reluctant to follow through with that desire. Trying to be considerate to Catra's still sore body.

Catra's eyes were still closed, relishing their soft, passionate kisses. She hummed happily, a pleasant rumble vibrating from her throat. She would never tire of hearing those words. Hearing them gratified her in so many ways, solidifying that she truly

mattered to the one person who meant everything to her. She offered Adora a small smile of understanding and thumped her forehead against her chest again. Willing her heart to calm down and her breath to slow. Adora got her so worked up so fast.

“Come on. Dummy. We need to go eat.” Catra giggled, finally pulling away when her cheeks had cooled. As Adora sighed and finally released her from her embrace, allowing her to move away. But not before offering her one more brief peck against the lips.

“Fine.” Adora grumbled, playfully. Bending down to retrieve Catra's white training shirt from the floor.

“Only you can call me names and make it sound like an endearment.” She commented dryly.

“Cause, I'm talented.” Catra smirked, shrugging her shoulders.

Adora turned from her bent position, offering Catra a sly, arching eyebrow.
“How talented?” She commented, tossing the shirt aside and rising up swiftly. Lunging forward and lightly pushing Catra back onto the bed. Wanting to kiss away that smug smirk she always wore when she felt she had gotten the best of her. They always seemed to spar, verbally or physically...it was just their way to flirt.

Catra yelped, all bravado gone, as she pinwheeled backward against the mattress. She had no time for a counter jibe or defend against Adora's playful shove.

As Adora slid onto the mattress beside her. Catra's body was flushed with both exhilaration and also shivering timidly with nervous energy. Over how bold Adora's seductive teasing had become.

Adora felt her past encounters with initiating love between them, had been awkward and clumsy. So she wanted to come off as suave, playfully assertive even. Her mental voice repeating a

mantra of self assurance. (Be smooth...be confident...be charming...what would Huntara do in this situation...)

Adora leaned over Catra, bracketing her head with an elbow. Cupping her cute dark ear with her hand and tenderly running her thumb over the velvet soft fur at the base. She held Catra's gaze, her baby blue eyes shimmering with want, with need and a depth of love she had a hard time comprehending.

“Idiot....” Catra breathed, trying to be obstinate. But there was no bite to her words, as a pleased smile pulled on her lips. A low purr of delight rumbling from her throat. As she was left prone and staring up at Adora, her eyes wide with awe. Overwhelmed by Adora's sudden advances.

Adora traced her fingers along Catra's lips, admiring the beautiful bow of her upper lip and the plumb fullness of her lower lip. Catra truly had a gorgeous mouth and she would never tire of kissing her. Her breath caught as she returned her gaze to Catra's eyes. They were gorgeous, one azure pool of tranquil blue the other burning with a passionate golden hue. Her eyes were a mirror to her soul, so pure and honest. Overflowing with the intensity of her devotion. Adora was left awestruck by them for a moment.

“Stop calling me names...” Adora demanded playfully. Her dazed smile fading as she suddenly regained her senses. She had been rather aggressive with Catra and did not want to scare her. She searched Catra's eyes for any hint of fear. She never wanted to see that again. Relief washed over her, as she found Catra staring back at her. A deep unconditional love burning in the mismatched depths of her eyes. It only emboldened Adora more. She then dove in, slotting her lips more forcefully over Catra's. She kissed her deeply with all the love and passion she could muster, before suddenly pulling back. The sudden onslaught of guilt and worry over what she might have done to Catra in the past. To cause such a primal fear, was crushing her in an instant.

“Forgive me....please...” Adora moaned, tears brimming in her eyes. Overwhelmed by the unknown trauma she had caused

Catra. She had no idea what she had done, but the repercussions had been so severe for Catra. She couldn't deal with hurting her yet again!

Catra was taken off guard by the sudden turn around from burning passion to utter misery.

“Adora...what...” Catra gasped, cupping her cheeks with both hands. Holding Adora away enough to fully absorb the woman's tortured expression.

“I can't bear not knowing how I hurt you....how I made you so very scared of me...I'm sorry. I'll never do it again...I promise...” Tears were now falling down her cheeks as she squeezed her blue eyes shut. The missing pieces of that night on the Northern Reach tore her up inside, she wanted to know but she was also very frightened.

“This has been bothering you for a lot longer than just last night...” Catra moaned, pulling Adora down on top of herself and holding her firmly. Seeing Adora so crushed by what she had done was shredding her heart. “I love you...it's ok.” She whispered pleadingly, against the shell of her ear. Holding her tight. Tears fell silently as she forced herself to stay strong. Adora needed her comfort right now, not to witness her own crushing guilt.

“For years...Catra...years. Please, Forgive me...I was a monster...wasn't I.” Adora choked out between broken gasps for breath, crying so hard she could barely speak.

“Shhhh....Oh, goodness...I forgive you, ok...but seriously...I'm still taking at least fifty percent of the blame for that terrible night. ” Catra attempted to lighten the moment with humor. What happened that night was all Catra's fault, Adora bore no blame at all. Catra laughed weakly, a bittersweet smile upon her face, finally allowing Adora to pull away.

Adora offered Catra a watery smile, her eyes warm and full of sweet affection for her closest friend...her one true love.

“I am so happy, I got you back.” Adora beamed, so relieved to have been given a second chance to cherish Catra in all the ways she had wanted to for years.

“Come here. Dummy.” Catra growled, playfully. Pulling her down by her cheeks, laughing blissfully into another tender kiss. Adora returned the kiss eagerly. The pressure of her lips were gentle, sweet. Moving slowly and without hesitation, more confident in her abilities. As she swept her tongue once more over the cut on Catra's lip, urging her to open her mouth more. Catra moaned as that familiar ache between her legs began to throb. She thrust her tongue demandingly into Adora's mouth, tangling for a moment before retreating. Taunting her for more, as she thrust then pulled her tongue back, urging Adora to kiss her more deeply. Adora released a long, drawn out moan; it was a low, husky sound, filled with desire. As the kiss intensified, Adora ravished Catra's mouth with long sweeping strokes of her tongue. Catra moaned pleadingly, against her lips. Her finger's clawing into her loose ponytail and pulling her long blonde hair free.

Adora grabbed Catra on the sides of her shoulders and rolled her on top of her body. Holding her securely with one strong arm across her back, locking Catra firmly against her chest. While her other hand crept upward into the short brunette hair at the back of Catra's head, keeping their lips together during the sudden maneuver.

One bracing hand crept below her tail, her fingers lightly brushing over the waistband of her leggings. As her fingers touched the overly sensitive area around the base of her tail, Catra mewled wantonly, ducking her head into the nape of Adora's neck. As Adora’s hand finished her languid trek down Catra's arching back, cupping her ass. Pressing her core firmly down on top of her groin. As Adora rocked her hips, seeking that delightful friction she had discovered when they were fooling around on her bed back in the barracks. Catra had yelped when Adora kneaded her ass with her strong fingers, but quickly adjusted. Slipping her legs on either side of Adora's hips, consciously grinding herself against her lover's core. She was desperate for that blissful friction as

well, she wanted to reclaim that pleasure, she had briefly felt back in the Fright Zone.

Adora cried out suddenly, arching her back and rubbing herself in rhythm against Catra. She had no idea what she was doing...she wondered if Catra knew? But she wasn't going to over think it either, just try and relax and chase the pleasure.

Their movements together became more heated, more desperate. Catra clung to her, as she rocked against her. Mewling softly, as Adora kissed every inch of her neck. Mouthing downward towards the underside of her jaw. Her warm, soft tongue darted and enticed the tender flesh beneath the velvet soft fur. Adora paid close attention to the small, breathy noises Catra was making, committing each wonderful sound to memory.

Then gasped and hummed with pleasure as Catra took her turn. Her soft sighs and rapid breaths, heating Adora's already flushed skin. As Catra ducked her head into the tender arch of Adora's neck. Paying loving attention to her warm flesh with her mouth in her own ways, nipping and suckling possessively, with the intent to mark.

Adora moaned at the sharp, exquisite pain she was causing. Her finger's curling into the feline's short dark hair and holding her firmly in place against her neck. The movement of their hips was becoming more frenzied. Adora fingers gripped and released, massaging Catra's ass in an insistent rhythm. Completely and utterly lost to the pleasure, as she pushed Catra down on her pelvis. Seeking to rub against her where she needed it most. Drawing the most exquisite sounds from Catra's lips, as she jerked and quivered against her.

They were intoxicated by the pleasure, kissing and ravishing each other's necks, while moving against each other like the ebb and flow of the tide. As the pressure built inside each of them, reaching an unbearable level. What had started out as a pleasurable tingle had grown into a deep, throbbing ache that had built into a demanding pressure, that needed to be released. They

didn't fully understand what was happening, only that it felt really, really good and that neither of them wanted it to stop.

“Adora...” Catra called out, her voice was strained and husky. As she squeezed her eyes shut and arched herself sharply against Adora. As she felt her insides suddenly clench, then spasm as the pressure finally released in waves of euphoria. All the aches and pain of her muscles eased as she was swept away by the breathtaking pleasure.

Adora gasped in shock as her own ecstasy cascaded over her body. Both of her arms crossed over Catra's shoulder blades holding her as if her life depended on it, as the sudden waves of her own bliss crashed through her. Her insides were trembling and convulsing, as if small explosions were going off deep in her core. It was the most exhilarating experience.

It took many long minutes to come down from that wonderful high, holding each other and panting against each other's necks. Then Catra started laughing, finally pulling away from Adora. She sat up languidly, to straddle Adora more properly. Staring down at her in astonishment, her eyes gleaming with a pleasurable afterglow. Finding Adora lying beneath her, her blonde hair fanned out over the mattress, wild and knotted from her fingers combing and pulling at it. Her face was flushed a soft pink, her blue eyes more warm and more brilliant than the sky.

“Wow” Catra exhaled with a beaming smile...they had been stumbling towards this ecstasy for weeks. But neither one of them knew what they were truly doing, just fooling around, loving one another. Guided only by their whims and pleasurable inspirations.

“That felt amazing. " Adora gazed up at her, her eyes shining with joyful tears. Her wide, honest smile filled with such a pure, blissful joy. That they were both laughing bashfully at their ignorance at making love, but not ashamed at all at how far they had come already.

In time their laughter turned into a quiet retrospective over the emotional storm they had just survived. How they both instinctively grew loving and intimate with each other, when their shared trauma grew too painful to deal with. Their love was a balm that seemed to always soothe the wounds of the past.

“Can I heal you now?” Adora questioned, cupping her cheek as she tenderly drew Catra out of her thoughts.

“No.” Catra answered crisply, lightly tracing her claws along the scars of Adora's jaw.

“Why?” Adora sighed.

“These bruises are my penance, I want to feel them and always remember the pain I cause others. So that I never do it again.” Catra admitted, with a small smile. Finally realizing for herself what Adora's scars truly meant. Why she seemed so protective of them. She wanted those scars...they were her own penance. To always remember how deeply she had hurt the girl who meant everything to her. In the hopes that she would never do it again.

“I love you...so, so, very much.” Catra leaned down and pressed, a tender, reverent kiss upon Adora's lips.

Adora kissed her back just as passionately. But before their kiss could become something more, Adora's stomach growled, interrupting the sweet moment.

Catra giggled and quickly crawled off Adora's lap.

“Let's get back on mission, princess.” She commented, as she retrieved her shirt from the floor once again. Adora knelt up on the mattress as Catra came to stand before the bed. Adora gently helped her slip the shirt over her head, before climbing off the bed. She moved to the chair by the hearth offering Catra her leather coat.

Catra shook her head. “It's too heavy right now, my muscles are still too tender.”

Adora nodded, casting the coat back to the chair cushion. She raised her arm, inviting Catra into her side. Catra smiled happily and nearly skipped to Adora's side. Wrapping an arm around the blonde's waist, while her girlfriend held her close. Catra sighed, she had never felt so happy. She wasn't going to hide and sulk about her mistakes, she was going to own them. There was just far too much to do and she was no longer going to allow her past to define her future. She was going to do better, be better and in time all of Etheria would see that she could be a good person. A princess they could depend on to protect them. That would be her legacy...

Remember the Fallen

Adora and Catra made their way slowly across the open courtyard, admiring the small flower gardens and freshly pruned hedges that surrounded the Elemental Basilica. Neither of them in much of a hurry, basking in the warmth of the early morning light. Enjoying the tranquility of the lush, well manicured gardens. It was the first time Catra had a chance to view the pure white stone structure of the Elemental Basilica. She had seen just a hint of its true majesty from the atrium balcony, back within the upper bastions of Mystacor. The ancient cathedral was immense, rising high into the vibrant fiery hues of the dawning sky. It dominated the central courtyard like a regal queen carved from marble and crystal, drawing Catra's focus and holding it firm.

"What is that building?" Catra breathed, directing a curt nod towards the Basilica.

"Casta called it the Elemental Basilica, it was the first structure built on the remains of Arxia." Adora answered.

"Have you explored it?" Catra stared up with awe and wonder, as they crossed in front of the massive, side doors of the northern portal to the Cathedral. A set of wide stone steps led upward to three vaulted arches, elegantly carved from stone. Flanked by two ornate marble spires that twisted like serpents, rising high overhead. The spires were connected to an elegant gateway by heavily carved buttresses that looked very much like wingless dragons. Their massive backs hunching between the spire and archways, glowering down at them with blank stone eyes. Just above the archways that covered the heavy wooden doors, was a circular stained glass window. The imagery upon the glass was of three serpents of various colors intertwined in a very complex rune.

"Not yet." Adora stated, slowly taking in the majesty of all the carvings that detailed the massive archways. Sharing Catra's

sense of wonder and excitement at exploring the majestic cathedral.

“Want too...” Catra grinned, mischievously. Her grin so eager and wide all four of her fangs were on display. Then she merely turned and dashed towards the stairs, not waiting to hear Adora's response. Forcing her to follow as always.

Adora laughed with nostalgia as she chased after Catra, up the stairs and threw one of the heavy wooden doors. Finding the feline standing within a radiant beam of sunlight, what was filtering in from the circular window above. Catra was standing just beyond the entryway, in the wide aisle. Her face cast upward in awe as she slowly turned in a circle taking in the ancient grandeur of the cathedral.

The gentle, yet vibrant light from the morning sun warmed her tawny fur, giving it a golden hue that seemed to cause it to glow. As if her whole body was now made of pure sunlight. The ethereal sight took Adora's breath, leaving her staring with reverent awe. Catra truly was magical...now. In so many more ways than just her connection to fire. Ever since the swamp, Catra had been moving towards a destiny far greater than she even knew. Adora was certain of that now. She watched her intently, as she moved with a regal grace down the wide aisle. Brushing her fingertips lightly against the thick, smooth marble pillars that were holding up the vaulted ceiling. Her gaze riveted to the elaborate carvings that decorated the pillars and balconies inside of the cathedral. The sun bathed her as she moved, illuminating her like a flame, while a long shadow drew out from her bare feet slowly fading into nothingness. The brilliance of the sunlight grew around her when she entered the massive naive. That was encapsulated in a crystal dome, the room instantly evaporated all the darkness once stretching from her bare feet. Refracting the intense sunlight, beating down upon the dome and casting it downward in a glorious halo of pure light. All the colors that seemed to exist, danced around her. Cascading over her body as she spun in wonder below the dome, in a surreal kaleidoscope of color and light.

(Always walk towards the Sun, my Wildling...and allow your shadows to fall behind you.) The Guardian of Fire's voice echoed in Catra's head, as she basked in the magical glow of the crystal dome. A soft, serene smile spreads upon her lips. This was the most at peace she had felt in months.

Adora stood motionless at the cusp of the naive, leaning a shoulder casually against a pillar of the huge archway. Admiring the ethereal goddess Catra had become. Mesmerized by the purity of the moment, as she was completely enthralled by her beauty. She was awestruck and completely enraptured, when Catra turned and regarded her with a warm, loving smile. That was so genuine, so pure and unburdened that Adora felt on the verge of tears.

"Hey, Adora." She called, her voice soft and alluring. Reaching out with a hand, beaconing her forward into the pure light she inhabited. Adora chuckled, slowly uncurling her arms from around her chest. Walking swiftly into the naive and taking her hand and clasping their fingers together. They moved down the aisle for a time. While they both cast their eyes upward taking in the beauty and wonder of the elaborate architecture in long sweeps of their gaze. There was just far too much to see, the pillars, buttresses and upper galleries were covered with carvings. Long murals ran along the central arcade, just above the archways. Adora was quick to take note that all the people were some kind of animal hybrid like Catra. She saw Tauran's with thick, sharply curved horns. Dressed in full plate armor, holding long pole axes and giant broadswords. Their weapons thrust forward, leading troops towards some strange horizon filled with sharp, tall spires. Wolf and Hound Hybrids prowling in full chainmail and leather armor with mighty hammers or spiked maces, braced on their broad shoulders. The shorter, lithe form of Fox hybrids in leather armor, were leading the charge. They were hiding amid the landscape, scouting the terrain.

Scorpioni, dressed in regal robes following the armies, holding long mystical staves and heavy tomes. Some Thaymorian's with

bows and arrows and Lizard kin with whips and nets were scattered amid the warriors. Elboroan's Moth hybrids and Bee hybrids were in flight above the armies with long spears. Octopus Hybrids and Selinean Sea Elves rose high into the sky amid crashing waves. Even the small Shroom folk were scattered amid the combatants, heavy packs on their backs as they marched. All the murals depicted some type of conflict. Adora scanned the murals finding only a handful of magicats like Catra, dressed in leather armor bearing swords, axes or long bows into battle. Above the battles a swirling orb of light was carved. As the images moved from war towards a time of rebirth, not a single magicat was seen. As only what remained of the hybrid nations began to rebuild after that great war. The swirling orb was now absent from these murals. The sky above was blank...illustrating the planet's move to the empty dimension of Despondos.

“There's no She-Ra...” Catra's voice echoed, softly from the other side of the vaulted room. She had released Adora's hand a few minutes back wanting to explore further ahead.

Adora nodded, “No...she's not here, neither are felines like you, Catra. At least not after the war?”

“My people were one of the first nations to rebel against Eternia. Senator Keldor purged the Sunna from Etheria. I am the last of my people here.” Catra turned and regarded Adora with a sad, resigned smile.

“I'm sorry.” Adora felt terrible, Catra had told them on the skiff about the Sunna people and what Etheria had been like a thousand years ago. But she never went into much detail about her own people's struggle to remain free from the First One's control.

“I guess there are a lot of different types of magicats out there on other planets. Jitsu said there are even Sunna on Eternia.” Catra's smile faltered into somber reflection.

“Would you...ever want to find them?” Adora offered, her eyes shining with hope. Wanting Catra to approve her yearning to go to Eternia.

“I guess...after we get Etheria back on track.” Catra nodded, reaching her arm out for Adora. Inviting her to draw closer so they could continue to explore the basilica together.

Adora grinned and dashed down the central aisle of the naive, grasping Catra's hand eagerly, again. As they walked towards the transept crossing and then mounted the grand staircase, heading upward through the massive vaulted archway into the large ambulatory. That took up most of the front of the basilica.

As they moved silently into the apes, taking note of the seven rounded chevets that housed beautifully carved statues. That had been carved from what looked like a deep azure, mahogany wood. Lovingly polished for over a thousand years. The sheen of the wood was deep, dark and glorious. The ancient swirls within the grain drew the eye and were amazing to behold. Each statue held a hybrid, holding a rune glyph in their hands as if offering it towards another. Dressed in the armor, robes or leather garments of their people from long ago.

Catra released Adora's hand, catching sight of a particular statue in one of the alcoves near the central chevets.

“Catra...” Adora called, her voice no more than a loud whisper. This place was filled with such an ancient, timeless energy, it hummed in the air. Invoking a need to be respectful and honor the history it contained.

“Mother...” Catra moaned, her voice was weak and full of grief. Slowly raising a trembling hand, timidly reaching towards a feline statue. The woman carved in the wood had a regal elegance to her features. With a wild mane hanging low down her back, her tufts were banded in leather. Hanging like two pony tails down the sides of her face. Dressed in a leather halter top that hugged her breasts. Leaving her toned stomach bare, with a leather skirt cut

up the sides to allow full movement of her muscular legs. The front of the skirt had an intricate knot woven with tiny beads. Thick leather bands adorned her biceps, with knotted tassels. Her features are very similar to Catra's. With high cheekbones and a sharp chin, that seemed to be jutting out in pride or defiance? Her eyes held a piercing stare that seemed to bore into you. The inner strength of will and unyielding spirit she had in life was unmistakable. She had the same sprinkles of freckles upon her cheeks as her daughter. Who now stood before her struggling to hold back her tears. Forced to confront once again the crushing weight of that great loss. Visions of her parents' brittle remains haunting her, as she took in the vibrant beauty her mother had once held in life.

Adora moved silently beside her, placing a comforting hand on her shoulder.

“She was beautiful.” Adora stated, giving Catra's shoulder a reassuring squeeze.

“Yeah...” Catra nodded, sniffling. “Her name was Aoi, she was the Rune Bearer of Fire...the Eternian's tried to shackle her elemental magic inside the Sunstone, but the Guardian of Fire...destroyed it. The fire serpent lost their life because of their defiance against the First Ones. My family had a price on our heads, we were forced into hiding. While the Sunna people were purged from Etheria, all because we defied Senator Keldor's will.” Catra spoke softly, recounting the tragic memories of that time with a heavy frown.

“My parents just blindly followed the Rune Bearer of Fate. I can’t remember the prophecy he told them...but they were angry, scared and then resigned to what they had to do. Putting me in that stasis pod, hiding me so deep underground entrusting me to the future..to you?” Catra laughed softly, bravely holding back tears. As she sighed heavily, offering Adora a grateful smile before turning back to the statue of her mother. “ I have a hard time believing my father would just accept that they were going to die and wait for it to happen back in that cavern? He was kinda hot

headed and easy to rile. My mom was the only one capable of controlling his rather wild and unruly nature. He was also one of our people's strongest hunters? ” Catra mused, taking a long, shuddering breath. She would never fully be able to piece together her parents' final battle...only the harsh truth that they had sacrificed themselves for her.

“I’m sorry, Catra.” Adora gently eased her away from the statue and into her embrace. Feeling the confusion and loss radiating from her. Catra went willingly into Adora's arms, holding her close as she hid her silent tears in the warmth of her chest. Absorbing all the comfort and strength Adora offered and letting it wash away the grief once more.

In time, Catra pulled away, wiping away the last of the moisture from her cheeks with her fingertips. Seeking some distance to collect herself, she moved to inspect the rest of the alcoves. Finding a Selinean Sea Elf, a Tauran, then a statue of Queen Angella, on the other side of the late queen was a Wolf hybrid and then a Fox Hybrid.

“Adora!” Catra waved her over, her excited voice shattering the tranquility of the cathedral. Making Adora wince at the sudden explosion of sound. She had remained before Catra's mother, staring at the feline with a mixture of adoration and respect. Aoi held such a self assured countenance, she must have been a very indomitable woman just like her daughter. Then, Adora was in motion, dashing to Catra's side a few alcoves over.

“Do you think Sparkles knows her mother was around a thousand years ago?” Catra stated, chucking a thumb towards the statue. Turning to regard Adora with a sassy smirk, shifting her weight onto one hip defiantly. As Adora crossed her arms over her chest in contemplation.

This new development only heightened Catra’s need for answers. How long had Queen Angella been around? Why did she have a look-a-like on Eternia? What was her true reason for guiding Catra in her dreams? Was it compassion fueling her actions? To show

her the past and the love she once knew with her parents. To reconnect her with the Guardian of Fire, Ouroboros. So she could learn about the threads of Etheria's magic. To find a strange kind of solace from her final conversation with Shadow Weaver. Or was it all orchestrated as a part of an agenda they knew nothing about? It had been a few days since Angella had visited her in her dreams? Would she return to offer her even more revelations, more puzzle pieces she would have to figure out. It seemed that these Immortals have had a hand in destiny for a very long time.

“She's an immortal, it makes sense she would have been alive back then.” Adora responded, taking in the timeless countenance of Queen Angella. Dressed in a flowing robe, that cascaded in thin layers down her tall, slender form. Her wings outstretched from her back, holding a glyph of her element between her hands, staring down at them. Her expression was kind, a sense of eternity held in her tender gaze. Her stiff posture was regal and strong, a perfect representation of the Queen in life.

“So she was the Rune Bearer of Light.” Catra moved her gaze along the statues. Nodding to each one in turn, amazed that she could just read the runic glyphs as simply as Adora could read First Ones writing.

“The Selinean...water. The Taruan was air, My mother...fire, the Fox hybrid was earth. The Wolf Hybrid...ice.” Catra smirked, crossing her arms proudly over her chest. Catching Adora's surprised expression as she read off the runes. Adora took it in stride though, giving her an encouraging smile of her own.

“Frosta's got Wolf in her blood...that strangely make a lot of sense...” Adora chuckled. Her laughter falling into deep contemplations.

“Why were there no humans here?” Adora inquired.

“Because humans are not native to Etheria.” Casta's voice boomed from behind them.

Adora and Catra jumped slightly, startled by her sudden intrusion. Glancing at each other with guilty looks, wondering if they were in trouble by coming in here without permission.

Castaspella, seemed to float up the stairs in her sorceress robes. Her warm brown eyes were direct, holding the two girls' focus. Her hands folded before her, as she instantly slipped into the role of an instructor.

“So they came from Eternia?” Catra inquired, seeking confirmation.
“Or many other planets, we have other humanoid species besides just humans here on Etheria. The giants to the North of Bright Moon and the Gar...like Shadow Weaver. The First Ones seeded thousands upon thousands of worlds. Etheria wasn't their only Colony.” Casta sighed, giving Catra a patient smile. “Or perhaps the human species came just from Eternia, since that was who primarily colonized Etheria.” She nodded a moment later, revising her information based on what Catra had explained about her dreams during the first Princess meeting in the Atrium.

“But I'm the only First One on Etheria?” Adora stated, her brows furrowed in confusion.

“You are the only pure blooded, Eternian here.” Casta nodded, “The rest of us have been interbreeding with the local hybrids for over a thousand years. So we technically are no longer of the First One's lineage.” Casta explained with a patient smile.

“Can you explain why Queen Angella had a statue of herself from so long ago?” Catra waved a hand towards the Queen's statue.

“She was an Immortal, her species has a very long life span. I really do not know much more than that, other than she was the Rune Bearer of Light over a thousand years ago. She made an alliance with the Eternian's and bonded her magic to the Moonstone.”

Catra’s eyes narrowed with distaste, her heart suddenly beating hard in her chest. At the revelation that Queen Angella had betrayed Etheria's native hybrids. Unwittingly or not, to the First Ones. The Moonstone was part of the Heart of Etheria project...Angella must have been appointed by the First Ones to steal the Rune of Lights power from the original Rune Bearer? Who were the original hybrids to inhabit the Whispering Woods? What happened to them….where did they go? So many questions were plaguing her now.

Now that she's gone, that duty falls upon her Daughter, Glimmer.” Casta turned her gaze upward to the huge circular stained glass window that dominated the back of the wall over the alcoves.

The morning sun had yet to reach this side of the cathedral, so the glass remained in shadow. The many colors of the glass muted. The serpent design was as elaborately beautiful as the smaller windows that hung over the entrance portals. But this design was far more intricate, as this one held thirteen serpents, of different colors. Twisting and knotting in a massive three sided glyph, the central knot where they all intersected seemed to glow a brilliant white.

“What is that?” Adora asked, taking several steps backward to take in the window fully.

Catra craned her head upward, tracing the serpent's paths. Slowly coming to realize that they were forming a Triquetra knot. Just like the knots Ouroboros had shown her in the world between.

“It is the most ancient glyph we know of.” Casta began, “A trinity glyph of all the magic elements, known only as Sanctuary.”

“My people, call it a Triquetra...it's a unity knot.” Catra began, “It can mean many things. Heart, Mind, Body...Mother, Father, Child....It is the eternal knot that binds.” Catra's voice was low, resonating through the vast chamber with ancient wisdom.

“What does it do?” Adora asked, gravitating towards Catra's side unconsciously.

“I have no idea.” Casta shrugged. “That is an ancient magic, those spells were lost to us long ago.”

“Why? Did something happen?” Adora breathed, reaching out and grasping Catra's hand to steady herself. Her heart was beating anxiously and she felt Catra might be just as on edge. Being surrounded so completely with the images of the past and the forgotten magic of an era, lost to history. It was making her feel rather small and overwhelmed.

“We came to depend on the Rune Stones...the princesses where the only ones with access to the Greater Magic. What the Sorceresses and Mages in Mystacor could tap into is but a fragment of that power. The Rune Bearer spells, since they were passed down orally, were merely forgotten.” Casta sighed deeply.

“So how were you going to teach us to use our magic then?” Catra snapped, her voice shrill and full of disappointment.

“I am fully capable of teaching you the fundamentals of magic...” Casta pressed her hands on her hips indignantly. “Just not your elemental magic...that was typically taught by...”

Catra cut her off with a knowing nod. “By our Elemental Guardian's.” She finished for her.

Casta merely nodded, “Some of them are still alive, so once they get their strength back. Frosta, Glimmer, Perfuma and Mermista can return to their kingdoms to be taught properly.”

“But Scorpia and I do not have Guardian's. Mine was killed a thousand years ago and Hordak killed hers.” Catra fumed, her hand gripping Adora's more firmly.

Adora cast her a sad, sympathetic look.

“That is unfortunate, to say the least.” Casta huffed.

Catra was crestfallen for a moment, her gaze falling heavily to the marble floor. Her Guardian had spoken to her in her dreams but that may just be a one time thing. She felt that she shouldn't put any trust that those dreams would recur.

“But not a lost cause.” Casta perked up. “The Guardian's are pure magic, elements once given physical form. So your Guardian's are not really dead...their form has just been changed. We just need to figure out how to get in contact with that magic again.”

Casta tapped her fingertips to her chin, walking past them and down the steps deep in thought.

“I will have to discuss this with Master Elys.” She was speaking to no one but herself as she merely wandered down the transepts and out the front doors.

Leaving Adora and Catra standing on the upper dais, staring after her with a mixture of confusion and hope.

Deep in the twisting corridor's of the upper bastions of Mystacor. The bent and withered frame of Master Elys. Was walking with a purposeful gait towards his study, the heavy fabric of his purple and grey robes whispered against the marble floors. Suddenly went silent, when a slender arm shot out from behind a velvet curtain of an alcove and pulled him out of view.

Master Elys grunted in sudden fright, as he was pinned against the cool stone of an empty alcove. His assailant, hovering inches away from his wrinkled nose. Their thin, wiry frame all wrapped up in the forest green and white hooded cloak of a librarian. They slowly pulled down the hood, revealing the blush pink skin and typically rounded face of a bee hybrid. With short curly blonde hair that swirled around two black antennae. Bright green eyes shone with silent laughter, at the old man's fright. As they politely greeted the old man. Their full lips pulled back in a brilliantly warm and disarming smile.

It took Master Elys a moment for his old eyes to adjust to the faint light behind the curtain. He chuckled and shook his head in disbelief, as he recognized his old student behind the disguise.

“Always one for the dramatic, Terrence.” He admonished, then sneezed.

“Ewwww.” Terrence pulled back, not having much space. He leaned against the curved wall on the other side of the empty alcove. The gossamer wings on his back, fluttered sharply in agitation. As their transformation faded away into the more natural state of Double Trouble.

“How has the village of Green Glade been treating you, since I kicked you out of Mystacor?” Master Elys mocked, cocking their wrinkled head to the side in a dismissive manner.

“I wouldn't know, I have been plying my trade everywhere else on Etheria but there.” Double Trouble scoffed, crossing their arms stubbornly to the mild inquiry of their village.

“Seriously, though. Mystacor has been going through some tough times, we really do not need any of the trouble you bring. Terrence.” Master Elys drew serious, his eyes scolding the Master of Lies and Harbinger of Chaos.

“I'm not here to cause trouble.” Double Trouble raised their hands, offering the old man an honest smile. “I'm finally working for the greater good and all that. I’ve been nothing but chivalrous and honorable for many seasons now. My empty purse can attest to that.” They grumbled, in a disgruntled pout.

“Really and what finally stoked your 'good heart.” Master Elys mocked.

“Lets just say the spy game for hire got boring and I changed careers as of late.” Double Trouble shrugged. Not willing to delve into how Bow's holographic message of unity that had been displayed over Primes Spires had driven Double Trouble to reassess their own life. Finding their selfish pursuits for fame and

fortune rather hollow. They wanted to help and could no longer just stand by during Ehterias final stand against Prime. If this was to be the final act they wanted to help. They wanted to use their magic to free Etheria, so they fought against Primes clones. Peekablue had found them a few weeks later, working at a bar in the Valley of the Lost and blackmailed them. Stating that since they had made money off his good name they had a debt to repay. Landing themselves on Mystacor, forced to play the role of a spy once again.

Master Elys grunted softly with indifference at Double Troubles story of redemption, then turned to leave them behind the curtain.

"I am going to need more than that from you. If you want my help. Come with me to my study, perhaps when we are in a more private setting you will feel more inclined to tell me the truth."

Double Trouble rolled their eyes and groaned, pulling up the hood of their cloak and trudging reluctantly after the frustratingly insightful old man.

The kitchen was its own solitary structure, a quaint two story building of mortar and heavy stone. With thick wooden beams that held up a clay tiled roof. It looked very similar to the rustic design of the northern villages that were tucked away in the rugged highlands beyond Bright Moon. The lower half of the building had a grand bay window just in front of a set of oak double doors. What seemed to be living quarters sat above the main floor, a smaller window gleamed in the morning sun, just above the main doorway. With a small balcony attached, with two chairs and a small iron table set to the side. The roof had several peeks, as the building seemed to form a large cross in design. A well used stone chimney dominated the back of the building, aged and blackened by soot. The kitchen was tucked in between the larger wooden stable and paddock and what looked to be a smaller storehouse for food and supplies.

Adora opened one of the doors, her lips pulling into a pleased grin as the pleasant sweet smells of pastries and savory spice of cooked meat wafted out. Catra sighed with delight and nearly darted through the door. Finding herself in a large main room filled with the heady smells of freshly cooked food. That was dimly lit by the light crystals tucked into several iron sconces attached to the walls. Several round tables and wooden chairs were scattered around the room. A long bar style island ran the length of the back of the dining room. With several covered platters, a wicker basket of assorted fruit and several glass pitchers of juice and milk. Just beyond the counter that separated the main room from the cooking area at the back, Catra watched several cooks moving swiftly. One was a larger woman, with a rosy complexion, soft green hair, that was tied up in a tight bun, with two darker skinned assistants. All wearing the white uniforms of professional chefs.

The warmth of the morning sun drew Catra away from the counter. Her eyes slowly adjust to the brighter light cascading through the large curved front bay window. Bathing the larger rectangular wooden table nestled before the glass in soft light. She found Glimmer and Bow already sitting just in front of the windows, plates filled with meat and fried eggs and something that looked like a crispy mound of hay? Curious, Catra walked briskly to the table and sat down in an empty wooden chair beside Bow. Months ago she would have been nervous about joining them. Worried about her presence being politely shunned or rejected outright. But that never happened, from the very first night after being saved. They had accepted her as she was, patiently allowing their new relationship to flourish at it's own pace. They held no grudges over the past, eagerly moving forward with her into a close friendship. That was easy going, loving and full of that back and forth banter of close friends.

So when Catra slipped in beside Bow, stealing a sausage off his plate with a mischievous smile. Bow merely gave her a stinky side eye, pushing his plate more firmly towards Glimmer and away from the feline thief.

Catra laughed brightly, chewing smugly at her pilfered meat.

“Morning, Arrows” She greeted brightly, “Morning, Sparkles.”

“Glimmer found out from Frosta what went down in the Cargo hold. She told me what happened.” Bow offered, lifting his mug of coffee to his lips. “I must admit you look a lot better than she described.”

Catra raised an eyebrow in surprise then shrugged in dismissal, as Adora pushed a plate of pancakes piled high with strawberries and cream in front of her. Setting down a tall glass of milk along with it. Then settled down on the other side of Glimmer with a heaping plate of fried meat, eggs, pancakes, toast and a mound of that crispy something. She also had a tall glass of orange juice, which she gulped down first before digging into her plate.

“What is that?” Catra pointed to the crunchy hay on Bow's plate.

“Hash browns.” Bow offered, scooping up a chunk with his fork and popping it into Catra's mouth. Resigned to the fact that if he didn't share she would just take some for herself, anyway. “It's basically, shredded potatoes fried in butter.”

Catra chewed thoughtfully for a moment, savoring the salty, buttery flavor.

“Thanks...” She muttered, it was good but not as tasty as the confection of fruit and cream awaiting her.

She dug into her plate with as much excitement as last morning.

“You guys have been holding out on me!” Lonnie exclaimed as she strode through the front doors, her eyes shining with anticipation at the breakfast spread laid out on the counter. She had discarded her Horde armor for the time being. Now dressed in just her short sleeve training shirt and black combat pants and boots.

“I got you, Lonnie. Go ahead and sit down.” Adora hopped up from her seat with a proud grin, dashing over to the counter to

spoil her old bunk mate with a heaping pile of food. Shooting a few smug finger guns at her childhood friend.

Lonnie laughed at Adora's silly antics and shook her head. Then she settled down next to Catra, watching the feline devour her plate of food with a mixture of cautious awe. Catra was hunched over the plate, an arm leaning on the table between them in a guarding fashion. A low threatening growl rumbled from her at the sudden proximity of another person. She never even looked up when Lonnie settled into the chair beside her. It was an unconscious behavior to protect what was her's, that had been instilled in the mess hall growing up. Since the older Cadets liked to steal the younger cadets, rations. If they could get away with it that is.

“I'm not sharing.” Catra commented, between mouthfuls.

“You can relax, Catra. I am not going to steal your food.” Lonnie sighed. A couple minutes later, Adora set a glass of juice beside her. Then her hazel eyes went as wide as saucers at the massive amount of food Adora served her. She wasn't used to eating this much normally, let alone such a grand amount of varying foods. The Horde wasn't known for variety, or volume. They only got enough to stay alive. After she had defected with Kyle and Rogelio, they had finally got to explore real food. But being on the run from the Horde and then Horde Primes forces. Left them little time to eat more than just dried rations and anything they could hunt down and cook over an open flame. The food looked absolutely wonderful and overwhelming.

She turned to Catra with wide, pleading eyes. “Help...” She muttered.

“Not a problem.” Catra advised, popping one of her sausages into her mouth.

Lonnie took a second, to survey the damage of Catra's face. “What happened to you?” She asked softly, not wanting to draw attention to Catra's wounds. Falling unconsciously into old habits.

One didn't broadcast they were hurt, just ignored the pain and moved through it. Squad mates if they cared would seek to protect their fellow cadet, by any means necessary until they were healed. The Horde did not abide weakness in any form.

“I lost a fight.” Catra grumbled, working through her stack of pancakes in record time.

“I gathered that.” Lonnie muttered around a huge mouthful of pancake herself. Syrup dripping off her chin as she hummed in delight.

“It's not any worse than the beatings we got during our yearly trials, so drop it.” Catra advised, her voice firm and clipped.

Adora listened intently to Lonnie and Catra's hushed conversation. While Glimmer glanced sympathetically over to Catra. She had found Frosta in the hold last night and got the whole story of what happened. While in her delirious state, when she had been poisoned. Catra had let slip some very harsh opinions of herself. Now Glimmer was worried. That overwhelming guilt over her actions during the war that had hurt so many people. Was driving her to do very rash and reckless things to try and absolve herself.

Bow's interest peaked and he glanced nonchalantly towards Catra and Lonnie. Adora never spoke of her time in the Horde unless absolutely cornered. Too many bad memories he figured so he never pushed. But when the opportunity to understand her and Catra arose, he wasn't going to let it slip by either.

“What were these yearly trials?” He asked innocently, chewing thoughtfully, as he nibbled on a piece of butter toast.

“It was a test of battle tactics and fighting prowess against other squads.” Catra bowed her head focusing on the mushed remains of her pancakes. Circling her fork in the sludge, creating swirling patterns as her thoughts drew inward upon bitter sweet memories of her youth.

“The squad that won the trial, could earn a day off or extra rations. So the competition was pretty fierce.” Adora stated around a mouthful of scrambled eggs.

“Rather, Cut throat you mean...” Catra growled under the breath. Lonnie merely nodded in agreement. The Cadet squads treated those trials like it was a real war. They would fight and strategize as if their very lives were on the line. Some squads were less honorable then others and would cheat and fight dirty just to win. Cadets could get hurt real bad during those mock battles, some even died. The staff sergeants who trained them, took those deaths in stride. Stating it was all a part of culling the weak from the Hordes ranks.

“As a Horde orphan, if you were found very young. Like Adora and Catra, you were sent to the Nursery first. After you graduated from the nursery, you became a junior cadet. I was older when the Horde found me.” Lonnie stated, not wishing to go into any further detail than that. “So I was assigned to a Cadet Squad.”

“We became best friends right away!” Catra mocked in a sing-song, wrapping an arm around Lonnie's shoulder and giving her a rough squeeze.

“Yeah and I got the scars to prove it!” Lonnie shot back with a dark glower.

Catra merely laughed sarcastically, snatching her last sausage of her plate in retaliation, as Lonnie started to reach for it.

Lonnie sighed, she couldn't complain about it, she asked Catra to help her finish her food. So she let the slight go and continued with her story. “Each squad was made up of fifteen or more cadets, who were identified by color. Our squad was Red.” Lonnie explained, leaning back in her chair and patting her stomach with contentment. Grimacing at the still rather full plate of food with shame.

Catra never even asked permission, pushing her empty plate aside and snatching up Lonnie's and setting it down before herself. You never left food to waste, when meals were not always a guarantee. It was a habit instilled in the Horde that was going to make her fat, she was certain. But she still couldn't let the food just rot, it was fuel and it was tasty. So she gave into the survival behavior, without a single ounce of guilt.

“That's why I was wearing a red jacket when you first met me. It was the uniform for the Squad Leader. Also the Horde insignia on my training shirt was red.” Adora admitted, casting Catra a silent look of inquiry as she stole Lonnie’s half eaten plate of food.

“Lonnie's done. If you're still hungry, dummy, then come over here and help me eat this.” Catra smirked, catching Adora's yearning look towards the food.

Adora nodded and quickly left Glimmer's side, slipping into a chair on the other side of the table across from Catra. So she could reach over and share the food now sitting between them.

“Then you just grew up together in the same bunk room. Trained together at your own barracks, under a Staff Sergeant.” Catra shrugged. “Our Sargent was a blue furred monster from Beast Island, I swear! That cruel taskmaster tried to kill us on a daily basis.”

Bow's and Glimmer's eyebrows raised in sudden shock.

“You are so dramatic! The Staff Sergeant never tried to kill us.” Adora admonished Catra for her exaggeration. “He just expected a lot from us.”

“Adora, his training regime could be rather brutal.” Lonnie nudged Catra's shoulder in a camaraderie manner. Catra turned, giving her an approving smile. “Especially, when someone refused to listen to his orders and did as she pleased, most of the time.” Lonnie finished, raising an accusing eyebrow.

Catra huffed, scowling at Lonnie. It was too much to believe that the woman would ever just take her side without a backhanded comment.

“He had us up way before dawn, running laps around the yard. Then he had us in the gym, doing weights and combat drills. We barely made it to the mess hall for breakfast some days. Then after our studies, he had us running more drills in the combat simulator until long after dark!” Catra shot back, stealing the toast out of Adora's fingers as punishment for her need to defend their old Sergeant.

“He was trying to prepare us for combat duty.” Lonnie jumped to Adora's defense. “It was your own fault you got punished so much, with extra training and chores. You were a stubborn brat that would rather argue than do as you were ordered.”

Catra huffed and sent Lonnie a dark look. “His orders made no sense half the time!” She grumbled.

While Lonnie crossed her arms over her chest, staring back at Catra defiantly. Silently pushing her to start a fight over the harsh truth. That she had been obstinate, outright insubordinate and wildly disrespectful and paid the price for it.

“He enjoyed seeing me suffer.” Catra muttered under her breath, not wanting to get into it with Lonnie but not willing to admit she was at fault either. For how brutally she had been treated by their Staff Sergeant. It always seemed that anyone in power had tried to harm her in some way. Always needing to assert their dominance over her, constantly seeking to control her. No one seemed to want to try and understand her or listen to what she had to say, except Adora. Yeah, she got into trouble often because of her loud mouth and attitude, but she could never just roll over and take the abuse silently. Like Adora and the rest of her squad.

“It was hard...I won't deny that. Most days when it got colder it was absolutely grueling.” Adora moaned at the painful memories. Both Catra and Lonnie nodded.

“Remember those one piece thermal underwear they made us wear during the cold season?.” Lonnie shook her head and laughed softly.

Adora groaned and scratched her arms unconsciously. “Urgh...those things were like itchy torture devices.”

“Try wearing one with fur and a tail!” Catra blurted out in a disgruntled tone, grasping her tail tenderly as if comforting a forgotten victim. Both Adora and Lonnie laughed for a moment, but quickly fell into silent shame at how honestly hurt Catra looked.

“Sorry...but yeah, I remember how it rode up your butt while doing laps.” Adora nodded. While Catra winced at the painful memory of having to tuck her poor tail around her waist because the thermals didn't have a tail hole. How hard running was when she felt so off balance. The constant discomfort as the itchy fabric sent static charges across her fur as she ran, or pulled and pinched her tail. How they overheated her body and when she finally got to take them off, her fur would be fluffed up and standing on end from the static. Being forced to march down to the mess, looking like a little ball of fluff. The older cadets would catch her in the corridors and laugh at her. Taunting her and making a game out of harassing her, as they tried to pet the static out of her fur. Adora had to fight them off more than once on the way to the canteen for breakfast.

“Oh...remember Kyle...had that master plan to start a bonfire in the middle of our training yard so we could keep warm between drills.” Lonnie slammed her palm on the table top as the hilarious memory flooded through her mind.

Catra started to laugh heartily as she remembered. “The old wood he found was oil stained pallets and machine part crates from the tank yard. They wouldn't light, remember. They were also wet too, I think.”

“He eventually poured gas on those stacks of broken wood. It exploded in his face and burnt off his eyebrows!” Adora finished, tears of glee slipping out of her eyes as she was laughing so hard.

“That was when we started the whole, blame Kyle, tradition.” Lonnie pointed at Adora.

“Cause pinning all our screw ups on him was totally plausible...and it kept us out of trouble. The Staff Sargent never seemed to punish Kyle to harshly, cause he was just so incompetent....at everything.” Catra sighed, as her laughter died down.

“Yep, Kyle was the perfect scapegoat back then.” Adora agreed.

They fell silent for a moment gathering their composure.

Glimmer and Bow glanced at each other laughing nervously and sharing awkward smiles. Wondering if it was ok to be laughing at someone else's misfortune. Or about how easy it was for the ex-Horde to rekindle their friendship on shared childhood traumas. Tragically coming to understand how brutal their childhood really was. That Horde Orphans were probably the strongest, most resilient people on the planet...they were survivors. Able to laugh and shrug off how harsh their upbringing was. Resigned to accept the shared trauma inflicted on them from their years of indoctrination into a military regime. It was what connected them, what made them the strange dysfunctional family that they were.

Lonnie noticed they were slightly off topic now and got back on track to answer Bows question. “So, you spent about seven years as a junior cadet. Then three as a sophomore and then three more as a Senior, by the end you would graduate into the main force. The best of your squad would be promoted to your Force Captain and lead your squad into battle.” Lonnie cast both Adora and Catra meaningful glares that made each of them glance away in shame. Adora had abandoned them and Catra had been more

driven to rise up in the Horde ranks then stick around to lead their squad. Which left Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio and the rest of the squad that remained to be broken up and forced into other strike teams.

“At the end of each year the squads were pitted against one another in a competition we called the Yearly Trials.” Adora explained, her stomach was upset now with guilt and she no longer had an appetite. The plate of leftovers had barely been touched, Catra as well had her hands folded in her lap. Staring downward in bleak reflections over her own selfish decisions.

“That's putting it mildly.” Catra scoffed, crossing her arms defensively over her stomach. As grim memories washed over her, making her stomach roil in protest.

“We do not need to scare them any further, Catra.” Adora sighed, bracing her chin despondently in her palm. Tapping nervously at the table, refusing to look at either Bow or Glimmer.

Who were now avidly upset about these unknown horrors their friends had endured growing up in the Horde.

“Neither of you have been to the Red Memorial in years.” Lonnie's voice was soft and despondent.

“I'm....sorry...” Adora started.

“You get a pass, cause you defected and it's kinda hard to sneak over enemy lines.” Lonnie gave Adora a small, understanding smile. Before rounding on Catra. “You on the other hand don't!”

“I know, I know...” Catra thumped the back of her head against her chair. “I was kinda busy trying to conquer Etheria, I kinda forgot about it for a few years.” Closing her eyes in remorse, Catra released a long, despondent sigh.

“Well, Kyle, Rogelio and I are making the journey to the Memorial in a couple days. I expect you two to be packed and ready to go, this time.” Lonnie demanded, pushing her chair away from the

table and giving them a curt toss of her hand as she bid them goodbye.

“I came here for a reason, before getting pleasantly sidetracked. Thanks for the meal, but I have to get back on mission. I came to find Scorpia and give her a report on our reclamation efforts and the sweep of Mystacor we did yesterday. So far no sign of any other Magicat.” She shrugged, as she stopped at the doorway for a moment.

Catra cast Adora a quizzical look.

“I'll fill you in later.” Adora sighed.

"She's also going to want to know about the weird, Eternian's we are holding back at the Fright Zone too.” Her voice faded away as she strode off briskly.

“Weird Eterians?” Adora asked.

“I’ll fill you in later.” Catra smirked, describing those magically powered cyborg's would be a strange conversation for sure.

Adora huffed at her angsty rebuttal.

“Red Memorial?” Glimmer asked quietly, suddenly very unsure if she should have asked. Wondering what terrible memories she might be dredging up for Catra and Adora, now.

“Not everyone in the Squad survived.” Adora offered Glimmer a tight, pained smile.

“Kids died along the way, some from getting sick, others from training 'accidents'. Poor Louis got killed during our first Senior Trial.” Catra offered, slowly reaching over the table to grip Adora's shaking hand. Knowing she blamed herself for his death.
“It was after that trial that the five of us ran away from the Horde.” Adora refused to look up from the table. It hurt to give voice to all the death and suffering they had witnessed growing

up in the Horde. It really wasn't a childhood, but a long drawn out fight for survival.

Bow's brow furrowed for clarification.

“Lonnie, Kyle, Rogelio, Catra and I.” Adora glanced up, catching Bow's confused look. “Went Awol for about a week or so.”

“The other five or our remaining squad stayed back to take whatever punishment the Sargent was going to dish out for us, taking off and to try and hold back any search parties, if they cared to send any after us. It was a good possibility since Adora was with us.” Catra gave her hand a squeeze. Shadow Weaver would never allow Adora to just leave. She had been a controlling, tyrant and losing Adora, was inconceivable to her. The vile woman had always been able to track them and her dark magic had seemed all powerful at the time. So all five of them knew it would only be a matter of time before Shadow Weaver decided to reclaim her Golden Child. They had all hoped to sneak back into the Fright Zone before that happened.

“Urgh..don't remind me of her.” Adora growled back. The bitter hatred she still harbored for Shadow Weaver tainted her voice and made the warmth in her eyes grow cold.

“So you guys built a monument to the memory of the kids that died.” Bow was tearing up, sniffing at how pure and selfless they had been to honor their fallen comrades.

“I wonder if any of the others survived the war?” Adora asked Catra quietly.

Catra merely shook her head. “I don't know, I was throwing troops against the Rebellion constantly at the end. As I pushed our forces to claim more ground. I sent the whole Horde army against Bright moon, only to be betrayed by Double Trouble.”

Glimmer cast her a mournful look, the grim reminder of how unforgiving and cruel the last few months of the war had been, reopening a lot of old wounds.

“The Horde was completely decimated by the time Prime showed up.” Catra admitted, squeezing her eyes shut tight as a few tears escaped, to trail down her face. Then she abruptly pushed her chair back and darted out of the kitchen. Knowing she was on the verge of another breakdown and refusing to do it in a public place.

“Catra!” Adora jumped to her feet and chased after her, once more regretting how tactless she had been.

Leaving Bow and Glimmer in dower spirits at the table, glancing awkwardly at the open door.

“What was that about?” Mermista chucked a thumb out the door, as she tentatively entered the kitchen. After both Catra and Adora had run past her outside, without acknowledging her at all.

Stumbling

The loathing throbbed, like a burning ache that pulsed deep inside her chest. As her toxic inner dialogue sought to crush her with it's cruelty. Speaking the harsh truths of who she truly was, what she truly was. In that same condescending voice of Shadow Weaver. She own voice taunting her with all her insecurities and her inability to be a good person. Claiming that all the injustices that had befallen her was what she deserved, that she had brought it all on herself. Primes voice was the last to echo out to her. His words are cold and indomitable. That it was just inevitable, some creatures were just destined for destruction. That she was simply cursed to have a bad life. One that had, so far. Twisted her heart and spat it out chewed and broken. The scars so deep and ugly she was unable to ever heal properly.

Her life had been a parade of bad choices, always fueled by anger or resentments. That she had began from a very young age, which had led her to this hopeless state of contempt for herself. She struggled to breathe, the air she could intake came in short, sharp, bursts. She had run from Adora, using all four limbs to sprint away faster than the blonde could ever hope to keep up. Now she was deep in the sheltering trees of the apple orchard. That took up most of the northern field out beyond the Basilica. She cast her blurry gaze over the natural labyrinth she was currently lost in, feeling rather apathetic about it. She would find her way out eventually, or Adora would find her, she always did.

Catra wanted to be alone, right now. But she had to fight for that solitude. Since her salvation from Prime, Adora had been struggling to give her space when she was hurting. Just like when they were kids. She had always wanted to help her, heal her, care and protect her at all times. Adora had always been trying to comfort her and fix all her problems. Which she appreciated, but it was also getting annoying, cause it never worked. She would be doing well for a little while, feeling that she was honestly happy and content. Then something small would set her off, or something big, or just something....and then she was spiraling

back into that darkness that always tried to consume her. Adora would reassure her, offer forgiveness if she had lost control and lashed out at her. Affection and understanding was always a given with Adora. She would offer it unconditionally and without reservation whatever might be needed to soothe the pain. But it wasn't the answer... Catra now just felt smothered and suffocated by her love.

Catra groaned then rolled her aching shoulder's, flexing her fingers as she released her claws. She needed to dig her claws into something, needed to feel that cathartic pull. As she picked and shredded. It was the only way she knew of to ease the restlessness she felt pulsing deep inside her every muscle. With a growl she lunged at a nearby tree, stretching her arms up as high as they would go and dug her claws in deep. Then ripped them downward with all her strength, purring angrily and growling with pleasure as the bark split and peeled under the power of her claws. A broad, blissful smile spread across her face as she received her pay off for her aggression. Her wet eyes brimming with tears were bright with the enjoyment of needless destruction. She gouged and ripped at the tree, over and over again. Baring her fangs and snarling as she tore into it's soft skin, beneath the dry armor of the thick bark. Relishing the feeling of the damp sap oozing from the deep wounds she was causing, coating the fur of her fingers and dribbling down her arms in thin streams. Leaving her fur sticky and matted as it slowly dried.

She worked through all her rage, her bitterness and her self loathing until all that was left was grief. With a low yowl, she crumpled to the grass beneath the now savagely mauled apple tree. Pressing her back against the dry, undamaged bark near the base. Pulling her legs up tight to her chest and hunching over them. Burying her face into her knees, trying to make herself smaller. Raising a trembling, clawed hand to the fringe of her hair that fell over her forehead, raking her fingers into her short bangs in frustration. Digging her claws lightly into her scalp, just enough to feel the sharp pressure and acute pain they could cause. As she seethed silently over her loss of control. Curling her tail around her ankles in shame.

Melog mewled softly, as they approached. They had been spending the morning enjoying the peace and tranquility of the orchard, content that their master was seeking food with her mate. They never expected to feel such a raging torrent of loathing and bleak helplessness. It had washed over them like a massive wave, full of malicious rage and drowning sorrow. Drawing them from their once chosen path, to the very depths of the orchard to soothe the unyielding pain now consuming their master. Melog moved with a slow, cautious gait towards Catra. With their head held low, ears pressed flat against their head. They padded up to her and gently bunted their forehead against the side of hers, chirping quietly. She whimpered and slowly uncurled the arm that once was holding her knees, raising it up for Melog to lean against her. She refused to lift her head from its hiding spot against her raised knees and beneath her tightly gripping hand. She pulled Melog in, holding them against her side as she moaned and rocked gently. With the overwhelming grief now ebbing from her and into Melog. Melog's mane turned a tranquil blue, their body deepening to a navy almost black tone. As they absorbed Catra's rage and grief, soothing her feelings of shame with their silent presence.

Slowly, silently Catra cried against her knees. Scratching her claws lightly down her scalp towards her forehead. As she sought desperately to change her focus away from the pain, seeking to find a solace that constantly eluded her. Valiantly struggling to silence that vicious voice that always dragged her down, leaving her broken and beaten, curled up like a weak kitten at its mercy. She hated feeling like this, hated that voice and how easily it crept into her inner thoughts to torment her. She just wanted to calm down, silence that voice and find some sort of peace.

“Catra, I want you to take a deep breath.” Perfuma's gentle voice penetrated the fog, muddling her brain.

She moaned in response and obeyed, taking that deep breath.

“Now hold it and count to six, then slowly release that breath.” Perfuma coaxed.

Catra obeyed, blindly listening to her, as the loud humming in her ears began to fade.

“Ok, again.” Perfuma ordered, her voice still soft but firm.

Catra obeyed, she never thought about why, she just did it. Like before she knew she could trust Perfuma to help her. Several minutes passed as Catra took deep breaths and slowly released the air against her legs. Heating her knees with each exhale, her muscles starting to loosen from the tight ball she had curled up into. In time her firm grip on Melog loosened and her arm dangled over their shoulders. Catra pulled her now cramped fingers from her hair and slowly raised her damp face up from her knees. A thin trickle of blood made its way down from her temples. Where her claws nicked her skin a bit more deeply.

She sluggishly raised her head from her knees and blinked. Half lucid and light headed, to find Perfuma sitting cross legged in front of her, smiling sweetly. Her peaceful countenance and calm aura, a soothing balm that soon enveloped Catra. Perfuma's breathing technique finally forces that wretched voice into silence and allows her to think straight once more. At first Catra was confused, her thoughts were sluggish. She felt like she was floating and not fully aware of her surroundings.

“Perfuma?” She heard herself say, her voice was husky and slurred.

“Ah, good. Welcome back Catra.” Perfuma nodded, her hands curled placidly against her thighs.

“Where did I go?” Catra breathed in confusion, glancing around the thick grove of trees, grimacing as she looked up and saw the massive amount of damage she had done to this poor tree.

“I believe you were merely lost for a while in a very bad place. But I managed to call you back.” She stated, her eyes moist with

sympathy and perhaps understanding.

“Oh...ok.” Catra offered her a small sheepish smile, that looked more like a sneer with a fang sticking out. They then sat in awkward silence for a long time. Catra kept her gaze averted to the ground, while Perfuma watched her with a warm, patient aura.

“Why are you here?” Catra asked, while Melog huffed and settled down on the grass at her feet. Having returned to their normal coloring. Keeping their weight against Catra's thighs, as she still had not uncurled her legs.

“I was in the middle of my morning meditations, when I heard your calls of distress. I was rather distraught when I found you in such a wretched state. Mind you, I had a hard time overlooking your obvious attempt to murder this innocent tree.” Perfuma added, her left eye twitching just a little bit as she covered up her own disappointment and perhaps anger.

“I'm sorry...can you heal it?” Catra asked, anxiously glancing back up at the badly mauled trunk.

“Yes, I can aid it while it heals itself. But the scars you have caused it's skin will always remain.” Perfuma answered, offering her a thin disappointed smile.

Catra moaned and bowed her head in remorse.

“This is what happens when you act, under the influence of a turbulent mind.” Perfuma sighed, reaching out and lightly fingering a loose stone, embedded into the grass between them. Silently, reminding Catra of their previous time meditating before the Singing River.

“I was very upset and clawing is the only thing that helps me work through all those...negative feelings.” Catra growled out, refusing to look at Perfuma. Her ears folded back, as she expected a scolding.

“Ok, then we need to find you an outlet for this scratching that does not harm the poor trees.” Perfuma nodded.

“I used to scratch the walls back in the Fright Zone when I got worked up.” Catra offered lamely, feeling slightly more secure about sharing since Perfuma merely accepted how she self soothed and sought to redirect it, instead of reprimanding her.

“I shall help you find a more suitable substance here in Mystacor. So you can soothe yourself with out worrying about destroying something precious. ” Perfuma announced with a gentle smile. Seeking to resolve Catra's needs in a positive, helpful manner. That was so strange to the Magicat, if she had gotten caught destroying things in the Fright Zone. She would have been sent to solitary for days if she was older or had her meal privileges taken away for the day if she was younger. There was always a consequence, but only if you got caught.

Catra merely nodded, so overcome with gratitude at Perfuma's acceptance and kindness she couldn't speak, fearing she might just break into another crying jag. Instead another long silence fell between them. Perfuma sat patiently, waiting, closing her eyes and basking in the warmth of the morning sun. Listening to the gentle sounds of small birds calling to each other from the shelter of the branches. Catra took note of how easily Perfuma could just exist, enjoying the moment for what it was and being at peace. She was jealous, she wanted to learn to just be content and enjoy the moment, too. She wanted to silence all those venomous thoughts that poisoned her and just be at peace as well.

“I believe you would benefit from a morning meditation, to help center you and perhaps focus you on more positive energies.” Perfuma gently advised, “I shall come to your room tomorrow morning, so you can join me from now on. If you wish.” She finished with a tender smile. As Catra merely nodded, still feeling very unsettled and vulnerable, unable to find her voice.

Another silence fell between them. As Catra leaned over her bent knees, digging her claws into the grass with her free hand. that

wasn't currently gripping her knees. Her nerves felt shot and she was growing more anxious in the silence. She curled her fingers feeling the cathartic pull of the soil and rip of thousands of soft roots. Then suddenly froze, her eyes going wide in horror.

“Is this ok...” She muttered, suddenly stricken that she had hurt the grass.

“That is fine.” Perfuma laughed, sweetly. “Grass is far more resilient than trees.”

Catra offered her a grateful smile and dug her claws deeper into the earth and curled her fingers, repeating the process until she felt calm. Slowly her knees relaxed, folding downward into a cross legged position. She allowed her other arm to fall limply at her side, digging her other set of fingers into the earth. Soon she was kneading the grass on either side of her, contemplating the ground before her, lost in grim retrospection over her less than ideal coping methods.

In time she regained her courage to speak.

“Why don't you hate me? After everything I've done.” Catra asked, her ears had drooped and her voice was soft, vulnerable and filled with confusion. While both Netossa and Frosta had attacked her on sight, when she first joined the rebellion. Her first real conversation with Perfuma hadn't been ideal, their discussion as to how to free Scorpia had turned rather tense. When Catra's blunt, if smug honesty about Scorpia's issues with standing up to authority figures, was volleyed back on her by Perfuma. Who had come to Scorpia's defense, putting her in her place firmly but not in a mean way. All and all, Perfuma had always been kind to her, always eager to help and seemed to genuinely want to see her happy.

“Oh, my. Catra. I believe that you are not as evil as you think you are.” Perfuma sighed, leaning forward and reaching for her hands.

Catra glanced down nervously as Perfuma gently folded her fingers around her hands, gripping them in a tender, compassionate clutch.

“I went for a walk with Scorpia a few days ago. She spoke very highly of you, by the way.” Perfuma's smile was honest, genuine.

Catra's eyes widened in surprise. She had figured she still had a long way to go, to earn Scorpia's adulation again.

“She told me how you saved her life, more than once, back in the Horde.” Perfuma stated.

“That doesn't sound like me.” Catra cast her gaze to the side shyly, suddenly feeling rather exposed and nervous.

“Well, it seems you are far braver and more selfless than you give yourself credit for.” Perfuma smirked, “She confirmed that even though she was big and tough, she had been a coward when it came to standing up to her superiors. So I apologize for my less than kind words earlier, you were merely stating facts to Scorpia's weaknesses at the time. I was not in a good place then and I took it out on you.” She sighed, her soft brown eyes searching Catra's for forgiveness.

“Sure...that's fine.” Catra started nervously.

Perfuma purses her lips, waiting for her to respond properly. Catra stared at her in confusion, her cheeks flushing under her steady, unyielding stare.

“Alright, yeah, ok, your forgiven.” Catra stumbled out.

Perfuma sighed, “Thank you. “ Then she began her story once more. “She told me the first time you saved her was in the Black Garnet chamber when Shadow Weaver attacked, then again you refused to let her break you out of prison. Offering her less than ideal advice about not getting emotionally attached to others. Instead, you took on all the blame of Shadow Weaver's escape. She was very ashamed at her cowardice, as she stood by while

Hordak threatened to execute you... She felt terrible for not stepping up to protect you from Hordak or Shadow Weaver when they verbally or physically attacked you. She told me that she had trouble standing up to authority. She had grown up believing that she had to always follow orders and the people in charge knew best. You showed her that her ideals about authority were misguided and wrong. She learned so much from you about never giving up and to always fight back no matter how badly the odds were stacked against you..”

Catra laughed and nodded. Scorpia could be a formidable fighter, but when confronted by anyone higher up in the chain of command she would fold like a piece of paper to their will. She had used that fear and blind trust to her advantage many times. Catra winced as the memory of threatening Scorpia after betraying Entrapta flooded her thoughts.

Perfuma smiled with understanding, her thumbs rubbing soothingly on the backs of Catra's hands drawing her back gently to the present. When Catra looked up, she found Perfuma’s gaze was soft and full of gratitude. Perfuma continued Scorpia's admission of salvation through Catra's mentorship. That it was thanks to Catra's influence over the years when they were together in the Horde. She now had an inner fortitude to stand up for herself, a confidence to think for herself and follow her own morality.

“When she was chipped she was able to fight against Prime and his control. Giving it her all, to be able to defy him back at the Fright Zone and allow Adora and I to escape and also stop herself from killing Bow at the Spire. Because you taught her not to be afraid, that it was possible to fight back and not to blindly follow orders if you didn't believe in them. So in a way, you saved three more lives.”

Catra was shocked and had no words, she merely opened and closed her mouth. As Perfuma grinned,

“You need to stop allowing the darkness that lurks in your past to taint your present. When you start to feel those negative energies welling up inside you. I want you to take a deep breath and think about all the good things you have done and the good things others have done for you. It really isn't like you to allow others to control you...even your past self.” Perfuma finished and released her hands. Standing up and brushing the dirt off her pink dress. “Well, I am off to meet up with Scorpia. She is going to join me for my daily tea ceremony before breakfast. Good day, to you Catra.” With that Perfuma merely breezed away, casting a hand behind her. The apple tree shone with a warm green light, the gouges filling with sap sealing the wounds as the bark regrew. Leaving long jagged scars down the trunk.

Lonnie found Scorpia, in her room on the second floor of the adepts dorms. She was standing just before her hearth, preparing tea on a simple iron table. She had draped a white cloth over top of the table and was adjusting ornate tea cups. That were inlaid with gold leaf on top of dainty lace cozies. A fat white tea pot dominated the center of the table with a small glass vase of wildflowers just off to the side. It was obvious the amount of hard work Scorpia had put into the presentation of the table.

It was so quaint and domestic that Lonnie was left standing at the open doorway, staring at her old Force Captain turned Queen, with a sweet smile at how cute this scene was. Not really knowing how to start her report, she merely cleared her throat and rapped her knuckles on the wooden door nervously.

“Oh...Lonnie...yeah...” Scorpia turned so suddenly, her claw hooked on the thin handle of the tea cup she had been fiddling with and sent it flying towards Lonnie.

Who yelped in fright and ducked, as the fragile ceramic cup went sailing out the door, falling to the slate stone below and shattering with a sharp cracking sound.

“Oh...damn...I did not mean to do that.” Scorpia apologized, bouncing on the balls of her feet for a moment with uncertainty.

“It's ok, Scorpia.” Lonnie offered, moving into the room and out of the way. As Scorpia dashed out onto the upper walkway and leaned over the short iron railing of the balcony, staring down at the broken remains of the tea cup in dismay.

“Perfuma is not going to be happy...that was her favorite tea cup.” She moaned, rubbing the back of her neck despondently with a claw as she reentered the room.

Lonnie chuckled, “This might be a good opportunity for you to take her shopping for an even better tea cup.” She offered her forlorn queen. Who instantly raised her head with a beaming smile.

“That's right, stay positive! I'll just apologize and then take her into the merchant quarter for a day of shopping...as soon as it's all cleaned up and the buildings are repaired and the shopkeepers have restocked all their wares that got burned up in the fire...so yeah, not for a while...but definitely we can do that in the future.” Scorpia prattled on cheerfully, her spirits lifted by the plan.

“Anyway.” Lonnie sighed, needing to bring her queen back on track. She was just about to take a deep breath and go into her report when her communication pad began to hum with an incoming transmission.

She quickly unhooked the pad from her belt and activated the screen. Rogelio's scaly green face dominated the screen, his yellow eyes wide and full of panic. Snarling and growling at the screen and shaking it violently. Lonnie could only stare in confusion at the lizard.

“Rogelio, calm down what is going on?” She asked, as Scorpia moved in beside her. Staring down at her screen with confusion, her eyes flying wide in horror as Rogelio turned his screen to show them the room. The small study had been destroyed, the

furniture was broken into pieces, scattered throughout the room. The marble walls scorched with long black marks from laser fire. The Eternian was cowering in the far corner, with two Horde soldiers in full armor guarding him. Then Rogelio panned the camera towards the large open windows. Kyle was standing right in front of a window. His expression was frozen in a look of shock and horror. As his entire body had turned to gleaming silver metal, his hands morphed into giant hammers that now held the crushed remains of a Doom Seeker Drone between the two anvils.

“I'm coming...” Lonnie attached her pad to her belt and bolted out of the door with Scorpia on her heels. They rushed past Perfuma as they ran down the main colonnade below.

“What's going on?” Perfuma turned and ran with them, her sandals slapping the stones in a frantic rhythm.

“Kyle's a robot or something now...” Scorpia responded, lamely.

“How...” Perfuma breathed, completely off guard and bewildered.

“Don't know, it's Kyle!” Lonnie waved her arms in the air in frustration, increasing her speed as panic set in. She needed to get to her friend's side and fix this.

“Go tell Glimmer.” Scorpia commanded.

Perfuma nodded and cut off towards the kitchens as soon as they cleared the last archway and entered the outer courtyard. Which had been her and Scorpia's final destination of the morning. As Glimmer had wanted to start an informal meeting of all the princesses over breakfast from now on.

Catra was enjoying the quiet of the orchard, laying out on the grass with Melog in a patch of sunlight.

Bathing in the warmth, filtering down upon them from the canopy. No longer burdened by the oppressive weight of her past sins,

feeling lighter and more hopeful, again. Reflecting on the positives of her current life and contemplating her future. When Glimmer, Adora and Bow flashed into existence beside her.

She yelped and rolled away, startled. While Melog hunched down and growled in warning, their coloring never changed as they knew they were not under threat, just surprised.

“Damn it! Sparkles.....” Catra growled as she used her forward momentum to roll into a crouch and glare bitterly at them. Who were all gazing back at her with stricken, impatient expressions. “We gotta go! Kyle’s in trouble.” Adora reached out her hand and Catra was quick to leap forward and grasp it. Melog dashed into their midst, as Glimmer teleported them away to the Citadel in a flash of light.

When they shimmered into existence within the small confines of the study. They were alarmed at the sight of scorched walls, the bare amount of furniture had been blasted to wooden splinters. Jitsu was now sitting in the far corner as far away from the windows as possible. Scowling up at the two horde guards in full armor standing right in front of him. He paid Catra a calculating glance, surprised to find that she was not dead. Quickly ducking his head, behind his crossed arms that were braced on his raised knees, wanting to keep his surprised expression hidden.

Lonnie, Scorpia and Rogelio were hovering around a silver metal statue that was standing right in front of the farthest window.

“What happened?” Adora was in motion, taking command as it was second nature to her.

Catra smirked, crossed her arms and cocking her hip at how easily Adora just took control. She had always been a leader even at a young age. She cut her eyes to Jitsu briefly, taking in his submissive, rather dejected pose against the far corner. He had been beaten by the enemy and captured, all of his smug bravado

was gone. His warrior spirit seemed crushed, so he posed no more threat. He had no more power to hurt her, or threaten those she loved. So she moved confidently across the room, with Melog.

“I left Rogelio and Kyle to guard the Eternian, while I went to deliver a report to Scorpia.” Lonnie turned, her eyes were moist with tears. Her expression was twisted into an angry scowl, as she refused to allow herself to cry.

Rogelio roared and pointed out the window, behind the metal statue that was Kyle. The marble around the window had been scorched, jagged cracks ran along the wall. The wooden window frame was busted along the lower sill, the damage illustrating that was where the attacker had blasted into the room.

Adora's steps faltered as she got a good look at the metal statue standing behind Lonnie and Rogelio. “Kyle...” Adora breathed in fear.

Scorpia had moved off, clacking her pinchers together nervously by the doorway. Bow was quick to go to her side, seeing how upset she was. He offered her quiet words of encouragement and a shoulder bump. Soon they were discussing what had happened quietly between them.

Catra was intrigued and moved cautiously towards the statue. While Glimmer stormed over to Jitsu. Light sparking in the palms of her hands so violently. Her fists looked like two blow torches ready to burn Jitsu into a burnt pulp.

“What happened in here!” She screamed, her heart hammering in her chest. With the cold realization that more civilians could have been hurt or killed by this attack. She needed to do better at keeping the fight away from her people. She just didn't think things through enough.

“I failed in my mission. Lord Skeletor will not abide failures. My death is inevitable now” Jitsu laughed, his voice was hoarse and

dry. As he bowed his head in resignation.

“Who is Lord Skeletor?” Glimmer growled, “That punishment seems rather harsh...” She muttered under her breath.

Jitsu merely heaved a great sigh and hung his head.

“Dammit Kyle!” Catra shouted, her voice trembling slightly with anxiety and fear as she drew near the metal statue.

Glimmer turned and walked over to the crowd needing to know what happened. Her breath caught in her throat, as the spark upon her hands faded away. She fluttered her hand to cover her mouth as she gasped in horror, when she realized that the metal statue was a person.

Kyle stood, half facing the window. His whole body had been turned to metal and his hands morphed into giant hammers. Between the two anvils was the crushed remains of a strange drone that looked like the head of a predatory bird.

“Is he....dead?” Glimmer whispered morbidly.

Rogelio raised his scaly head and howled in grief.

“Kyle!” Lonnie screamed, grasping the young man's metal shoulder and shaking him violently. Refusing to believe he was dead.

“How did this happen?” Adora lamented.

Catra moved slowly into Kyle’s personal space, her keen eyes slowly scanning his metal body. Taking in every tiny detail, as her tail lashed behind her in rising agitation. He was dressed in the same gear as when she had seen him back in the Fright zone. In a simple training shirt and combat pants and boots, with a utility vest over top. Melog chirped, from her side, as they threaded themselves between her and Kyle. Their smaller pointed ears twitching near Kyle’s lower chest. Catra glanced down briefly at Melog, her own ears flicking. As she reached out and pressed a

hand flat to Kyle’s chest. As soon as she touched him she could feel the slight tremor beneath the strangely smooth, warm metal.

“He's still breathing.” she stated softly, leaning towards his face, her nose twitching as she sniffed near his open metal lips. She could still smell the residual stale scent of a ration bar and feel the slight movement of hot air floating over his slightly open mouth.

Catra was certain he was still alive, excitement and relief flooded through her. She laughed excitedly and pulled away with a broad smile, her fangs showing clearly with her joy.

“He's alive!...” She announced, turning to greet the relieved faces of her friends.

“So how do we get him out of there?” Lonnie asked, her voice high pitched and bewildered.

“I could melt the metal off him?” Catra offered, raising a palm and igniting her elemental flame. She dramatically pulled her arm back, ready to thrust the now roaring ball of fire at Kyle.

“MWOOOOOO!” A muffled scream echoed from beneath the metal casing. As Catra taunted him with her fireball, a sly smile on her face. Holding the brilliant orb of fire in her palm, right up against Kyle’s nose.

She stopped and cackled with satisfaction, at the sound of Kyle’s frightened scream. Which only solidified that he was alright.

“Stop scaring Kyle!” Lonnie shouted, slipping in between Kyle and Catra. Arms outstretched in a pose of protection. Glaring intimidatingly down at the magicat as she was an inch or so taller.

Catra shrugged and snuffed out the flame, sauntering away with a smug grin. To lean casually against the edge of broken window frame. She had made her point, Kyle was alive and well under all that metal.

“How did this happen...did he do this to himself?” Scorpia's worried voice finally drew their attention .

They all turned, to face the Scorpion who was now pacing in front of the doorway.

Rogelio began to growl, snarl and wave his arms about as he sought to explain what happened.

Scorpia merely nodded and hummed in agreement as if she understood what the lizard was saying.

“You can understand Rogelio?” Glimmer stated in amazement. “What did he say?” She asked with a hopeful air.

“No one understands Rogelio.” Catra snarked, knowing full well this was just Scorpia being her usual

polite self. Not wanting Rogelio to feel bad as he valiantly tried to communicate.

“Yeah...Wildcats, right. I have no idea what he said.” Scorpia slumped her shoulder's dejectedly and rubbed the back of her neck.

Glimmer groaned and stomped, towards Jitsu.

“Talk.” She snapped sharply at the despondent prisoner.

“Tri-clops sent a Doom Seeker drone to kill me, that crazy horde soldier turned himself into metal and crushed the drone before it could kill any of us, including me.” Jitsu stated, looking at Kyle with a mixture of gratitude and confusion. “His actions were kinda heroic, putting himself on the line like that. But his magical counter attack was rather....” Jitsu was at a loss, what warrior would use such an amazing defense as being able to turn their skin to metal and then get stuck in their own armor.

“Lame.” Catra spat.

“Typical, Kyle.” Adora rolled her eyes and laughed softly. Not wanting to hurt Kyles feelings, but being around his unintentional screwups was rather nostalgic.

“Seriously, Kyle!” Lonnie rounded on the defenseless metal man, hands on her hips, glowering down at him with disapproval. “Why would you use magic when you have no idea how to use magic...” She ground out.

“Mwin, mwah, hub, whahhhh.” Kyle mumbled back, his voice was high pitched and frantic.

“We gotta get him outta there.” Lonnie sighed in frustration.

Adora approached Kyle, lightly prying the crushed drone from his fingers. “Great job, Kyle. We can get information out of this drone.” She gave Kyle a warm, proud smile.

“Tanks, Dra.” Kyle responded in a muffled voice.

Adora tossed the drone to Catra, who caught it easily. “We're going to get this to Entrapta?”

“Sure.” Catra responded, holding the drone securely in her hands. Cocking her head to the side as Melog mewled at her. “Melog says she was in the engine room on Darla last night. So let's go check there first." She gave them all a curt wave before striding out of the room after Adora.

“I'm coming with you, I want to help Entrapta take that thing apart. Maybe I can figure out it's communication frequency and modify our tracker pads to track this Tri-Clops, guy.” Bow dashed after them.

“What are we going to do with him?” Glimmer pointed towards Jitsu.

“Well, he can't stay here. It's too out in the open.” Scorpia huffed, bracing her hands on her hips.

“We could just toss him into one of the Horde Transports when they get here.” Lonnie offered.

“We got a whole convoy inbound with manpower to help with repairs and all kinds of supplies from the Hordes warehouses.”

“Thank you for all your help.” Glimmer spoke with a warm smile, casting both Scorpia and Lonnie a meaningful look of gratitude.

“Not a problem, The kingdom of Scorpania is here to help. Always.” Scorpia grinned, so full of pride to finally get to use her name for her new kingdom. Grateful, for Catra telling her all about the history of her people. She now had a glimpse of her lost heritage and a stronger foundation to build her kingdom up from.

“I like that name and we can get rid of the Horde Symbol off all our stuff, maybe put a scorpion tail on instead.” Lonnie was excited, her eyes shining eagerly.

“Yeah!” Scorpia exclaimed, “We can call the army the Scorp Squad.”

“No.” Lonnie quipped, folding her arms promptly over her chest.

“No, yeah...your right that sounds stupid.” Scorpia responded, bashfully. “But I was just spit-balling, anyway. We can keep thinking on that one.”

“I'll go find my dad, maybe he will know how to free Kyle.” Glimmer offered, flashing away.

“Well let's get the prisoner down to the main gates so we can load him onto a Scorpion Cruiser when it lands.” Lonnie circled a finger over her head, silently commanding the two guards to round up Jitsu and get him moving out of the room.

Within minutes they had Jitsu's hands shackled in a wrist bolt behind his back and were ushering him out of the room with a unlit stun baton press against his shoulder blades. Scorpia was leading them and Lonnie was taking up the rear guard position.

Rogelio moaned and slipped down the wall to sit next to Kyle, he was not going to leave his side.

“Ro,Ro....mha, wyte.” Kyle mumbled.

Rogelio just patted the toes of his metal boot, reassuring him that he understood his intelligible words.

It had been years since Double Trouble had been in Master Elys study. They scanned the room with a soft nostalgic smile, finding the cluttered study had not changed one bit. The bookshelves were still filled with odd knick knacks, scroll, maps and mystical artifacts.

“Still studying the ancient past, I see.” Double Trouble noted, fingering a scroll lightly on a shelf. “Did you ever find what you were looking for?”

Master Elys ignored their fake friendly attempt at small talk.

“So what brings you back here, Terrence.” Master Elys inclined a plush chair in front of his hearth. Taking a seat himself on the adjacent chair.

“As I said, I'm here on business.” Double Trouble sat primely, back straight, legs crossed.

“For.” Master Eyls was not playing their game.

Double Trouble rolled their eyes. “Prince Peekablue.”

Master Elys harrumphed. “I see, the absentee Seer is back, then.”

“I need to learn how to access this enchantment.” Double Trouble tossed the two broken halves of Finn's amulet on the small coffee table between them.

Master Elys leaned forward and slid the pieces together, reforming the rune back into the Lotus, tapping a fingernail lightly against an amethyst shard embedded on the underside. “I have never seen this magic before...” His bushy eyebrows drew together in deep contemplation.

“I doubt you have, it’s from the future.” Double Trouble smirked, crossing their arms smugly.

Master Elys shot his eyes up in alarm.

“It seems we had a visitor from an alternate future who really wanted to change things. They were disguised as a Thaymorian with the help of that amulet and I need to know the image it contains so I can take their place. I have to keep tabs of the princesses for Peekablue. He's taken custody of our time traveler for now.” Double Trouble shrugged, divulging just enough information to gain Master Elys's trust.

Master Elys slowly picked up both pieces of the amulet and closed his eyes. Then after a moment, a flash of light ignited between the crack that separated the two pieces. He tenderly set the now mended amulet back down with a sigh. Double Trouble looked down in awe, the metal along the seam had been wielded back together.

“Will it work again?” They asked in a hushed voice.

“No, the magic energy sealed inside has been freed when it was broken. I am sure Etheria has already absorbed it by now.” Master Elys, traced the lotus etching with a thin finger while tapping the shards of crystals at the back with his thumb. Rubbing his chin thoughtfully as he mused over every detail.

Double Trouble was growing impatient and began to tap one foot on the floor. Then a crisp knock on the old man's study door

echoed from the hall.

“Master Elys, I need to speak with you.” King Micah's deep voice rumbled out from behind the door.

“Come on in, Micah!” Master Elys rose to his feet, as Double Trouble instantly transformed back into the Bee hybrid librarian disguise.

Master Elys past Double Trouble a suspicious look, as King Micah and Glimmer entered into the study.

"I'm undercover." Double Trouble merely shrugged, with a playful grin.

Micah took a moment to regard the Bee Hybrid, his dark eyes narrowing in scrutiny.

“Hello.” Double Trouble waved sweetly.

“And who might you be?” Micah inquired, his tone polite but firm.

“Ah....this is my new assistant, Micah.” Master Elys played along, offering Micah a warm smile. While Double Trouble grinned happily, passing Master Elys a sly glance as Micah merely nodded.

“There has been an accident in the holding cell.” Glimmer dashed forward. “One of the horde guards, gained magical powers and turned himself into metal.”

“Transforming magic is a rare....gift.” Master Elys cast Double Trouble a strange look.

Double Trouble cleared his throat, a slow, calculating gleam now shining in his eyes.

“I shall come at once.” Master Elys nodded, ushering both Micah and Glimmer out of his study.

As soon as he got them back in the hall he slammed the door shut.

“You were the only mage gifted with such talents for nearly a generation? I have no knowledge of how to train another shape shifter...” He muttered.

“Which was why I came here as a kid, in the first place!” Double Trouble shrugged. “But I found soon enough, beyond just simple spells. Mystacor could or would not offer me any further guidance in my own magic talents. I had to teach myself.”

“To which you caused only strife and chaos on Mystacor on account of your personal training.” Master Elys huffed.

“Let's cut a deal, old man, you help me figure out that amulets' secrets. I will teach that young man how to control his new magic.” Double Trouble, grinned confidently. They knew they had the upper hand.

Master Elys groaned and trudged back to his chair. Sitting down heavily, he watched as Double Trouble reverted to their somewhat natural state of a green lizard kin and sat down as well.

“Why do I feel like I am making a deal with a devil?” Master Elys growled.

Double Trouble merely sat regally, their membranes flicking smugly across their yellow eyes.

“I can decipher the glyph etched in the lotus for you at least, give you access to the Master Library for your research. But meditation is the only way I can think of to access what remains of the magic inside the crystal shards.” Master Elys offered.

Double Trouble merely inclined with a hand for him to continue.

Master Elys stared down at the glyph for a moment before speaking. “The weaving is that of a Lotus blossom. It has several meanings: enlightenment, purity, rebirth and triumph over

adversity. But above all it is a symbol of transformation. So that makes sense since this amulet was to disguise this young time traveller. But the shards are all different. Amethyst? Which is an air element....tied to the spirit....which invokes healing? That choice confuses me. I would have chosen Obsidian...for protection, considering the child was partaking in a very perilous journey through time." Master Elys had begun to ramble. He quickly began to mutter about the other types of crystals and what magical properties they invoked.

Double Trouble snapped his fingers, seeking to get the doddering old fool back on track.

"Focus!" They snapped. This was going to be a long and frustrating conversation.

Rodak

“Rodak, mobility test...74...no, 75...no, 74. Definitely 74.” Entrapta sounded slightly confused. As her energetic voice floated out from just behind Darla. The ancient starship sat just outside the maingate of Mystacor. It’s sharply angled hull gleaming, as the bright morning light reflected off its smooth metal surface.

Adora and Catra both raised an arm to block the blinding shine from the ship, from piercing their eyes. As Entrapta's voice rang out, for her research log. Now moving more swiftly around it’s massive diamond shaped thruster, they glanced at each other briefly in confusion. Before jogging behind the ship. Bow latched his tracker pad on his belt and ran after them. They found Entrapta speaking into her voice recorder, as she hovered on her twin tails, over the prone body of a newly designed robot. Built from a macabre assortment of sharply angled scrap, pillaged from Darla, pieces of horde armour and no doubt powered by First Ones tech. The robot’s main body was a tall, cylindrical rhombus shape. That was broad on top to mimic shoulders and tapered down to a modest waist, flaring again with two rounded hubs to mimic hips. Entrapta had added pieces of Horde armor, such as black shoulder pauldrons, a silver chest piece. With long slender metal pipes for arms, with laser cannons attached as wrist guards. A rounded head that looked oddly like a modified Horde Soldier's helmet. That had been elongated and shaped to match Hordak's angular face. With two pointed pieces of metal wielded to the sides of the head that looked to be ears. The robot was face down on the ground, it's long arms pin wheeling as it sought to stand upright again.

“Entrapta?” Adora called out softly in greeting.

Both women gasped in alarm, when Entrapta looked up at them. Her eyes were bloodshot and heavy with exhaustion. Very apparent discoloued bruises hung under her eyes. She hadn't slept...perhaps for days now.

“Entrapta….Are you...ok. I’m coming to help.” Bow was quick to offer aid, jogging to Entrapta's side. Needing to assess her physical and emotional state more closely, under the guise of helping her with the robot.

“Hello.” Entrapta stated briskly, ducking her head back down seeking to avoid eye contact with everyone. Slowly lowering herself onto her feet, her pigtails reaching for the robots flailing arms and pulling the glitching hunk of metal upright.

Bow took the subtle hint that she wanted some space and cleared his throat. Moving off to her computer monitors to see if he could understand what was going wrong with her robot. He had dabbled in many different types of tech, being part of the Maker community. He might be able to offer advice if nothing else.

Adora and Catra were both blinking rapidly in silent alarm, as they were greeted with the rudimentary countenance of Hordak in robot form. They both sought to move towards Entrapta, wanting to offer her their support. This was not a good sign … She was definitely not dealing with Hordak’s self exile well. She might need some help working out her grief and coming to terms with letting him go. As her friends they were ready and willing to be there for her in any way she needed.

The robot swung it's angular torso around, alerted to their presence by it's proximity alarms. It's eyes were flashing red as it glowered down at the two women.

[**Get Out!]** It bellowed in a very loud, very artificial voice. That sounded very much like a sound bite, Entrapta may have used from off her recorder.

Adora and Catra were taken off guard by that sudden and very familiar outburst. They stopped in their tracks instantly, both moving into defensive stances. Melog had been padding at Catra’s hip, instantly went translucent. At the robots rather sudden, rather ear splitting, rather intimidating command. Bow groaned from his position in front of Entrapta's three computer screens, pulling

out his tracker pad cause he could not make head or tails of the data scrolling over her screens. He needed to take his own readings.

“Entrapta....how are things going?' Catra asked nervously, crossing in front of the robot, a good distance away. Hands raised, using the Seeker drone as a shield, half expecting the robot to attack her.

“What do you have there?” Entrapta avoided the question about her well-being. Pointing towards the busted drone in her hand.

“It's an Eternian Drone, we need you to hack into it and gather any data you can on our intruders.” Adora asked, she had moved in behind Catra, protecting her back. Glancing warily back at Entrapta's new robot. It was very weird and unsettling to see a robot version of Hordak.

“Oh...ok, I'll add that to my list of tasks.” Entrapta hummed with a curt nod.

“If you have too much on your plate right now, I am sure Bow would love to help.” Adora offered, nonchalantly sliding past Entrapta. Subtly seeking to keep more distance from her eerily arcuate robot of Hordak.

Bow raised his head from his tracker pad, nodding towards Entrapta with a bright, encouraging smile.

Catra handed the crushed drone to Entrapta. Who immediatly started turning it in her palms searching for an access port so she could plug it into her computers. As she was carrying it over to her computer terminals.

Catra regarded the robot with an indifferent air, crossing her arms over her chest and scrutinizing it carefully. “Sooooo,” Catra drawled, bluntly acknowledging the elephant in the room. “Who's your new friend?”

“Oh,” Entrapta's face lit up as she dropped the drone to the ground, losing complete interest in it.

Bow whined and tenderly picked up the drone, turning it in his hands hoping the internal parts hadn't been further damaged.

While Entrapta strode eagerly with her hair back to the robot, patting it on the back proudly.

“May I introduce you to Rodak!” She exclaimed.

“Why does it look like Hordak.” Catra waved a dismissive hand towards it. The creepy visor- like eyes were glowing a deep red as the robot glared down at both her and Adora, rather menacingly.

“Well, since Hordak's gone and I may never see him again.” Entrapta began, her voice was modulated as she concealed her grief. A lengthy pause followed as she gathered herself. “I did not like that idea,” Her eyes grew moist and she glanced down, avoiding their sympathetic looks. “ So I built myself a robot Hordak to replace him.” She finished with a tight smile and a curt nod. Feeling the conversation was over, she walked away. Gathering up a data pad from nearby and absorbing herself in her readouts from Rodak's current test run.

Adora moved towards Entrapta, her expression bleak, eyes wet with sympathy. But determined to try to help soothe her heartache. As she closed in on the tech genius. Who was crouched on the ground completely absorbed in her data. Bow incepted her.

“I got this, Adora.” Bow offered, moving in front of her and stopping her gently with a hand braced against her collarbone. He had spent a great deal of time with Entrapta during her time before she joined the Horde. She could be rather unpredictable, when stressed or anxious. Sometimes how she responded emotionally didn’t make much sense to the situation. He figured she had locked herself away on Darla as a way to ease the amount of stressors she felt. Becoming obsessed in building her a

new robot as a way to cope. If she got too much unwanted attention she might just close herself off more. Retreat into her lab and never come out again. She did better with less people. Perhaps he could reach her, by engaging one on one with her on dissecting this drone. Draw out her pain in more subtle ways and show her that she was not alone. That her friends were still here to comfort and support her as she grieved. He watched Entrapta with concern as she fussed with her new robot.

Adora sighed, turned and walked away. Catra followed, casting Entrapta worried looks over her shoulder. Without Scporpia's guidance, she felt inadequate to comfort her. They both could see how much she was hurting, but neither of them knew how to help or if their attempt to ease her suffering would be appreciated. Entrapta was very independent and had never really opened up to either of them on a personal level. They knew next to nothing about her past.

"Back at Dryl, Entrapta had this portrait on the wall of two robots and her as a child." Adora began, her voice distant, lost in troubled thoughts. As they walked away from Darla, a cool breeze rose up and tossed both their hair. Rustling the sparse patches of grass that had survived the fire, Darla Little Sister had started days ago. Melog phased back and brushed up against Catra's thighs to alert her they were still there.
"Do you think she lost her parents and built them as replacements, like she just did for Hordak?" Catra offered, giving Melog a reassuring pat on the head. It was a very bleak observation, thinking that Entrapta had been alone for most of her life.

Adora felt tears pricking the corners of her eyes and she silently reached out for Catra's hand.

"I was so lucky to have you, growing up." She whispered brokenly.

Catra grasped her hand and held it tight, tears of her own filling her eyes. "We will always have each other, Adora. Forever." Catra

responded, her voice barely a whisper as the weight of her emotions overwhelmed her. They shared so many memories both good and bad. Being apart during the war had been the hardest to live through. But now they were together and Catra promised her back in Erelandia. That nothing would ever come between them again.

They made it back to the stone steps that lead up to the main gates, just as Scorpia pushed through the heavy iron doors. Leading the prisoner, two Horde soldiers and Lonnie out of Mystacor.

Adora and Catra fell in step beside Scorpia, who's expression was a hard mask of grim determination.

“We can't hold prisoner's in densely populated areas, that was really poorly thought out on our part. Civilian's could have gotten hurt. ” Scorpia stated. “From now on. I think we should use the Fright Zone as our main Military compound. All prisoner's should be sent there. We have trained personnel, the weapons and fortified facilities to defend against combatants and hold prisoner's with very little chance of civilian casualties. At least until we get a better handle on all our new 'guests'.” Scorpia turned to Adora for confirmation.

“I agree.” Adora nodded, “I never liked having Shadow Weaver in the palace, back at Bright Moon. I felt she posed a danger to the royal family, to everyone. But I wasn't calling the shots then, I couldn't argue with Queen Angella...Or Glimmer.” Her voice tapered away into nothing, as her frown deepened into a pained grimace. Her mind dwelled upon bitter memories. It still stung to recollect how fragile her friendship with Glimmer had become after the loss of Queen Angella. Glimmer had been so consumed by sorrow, fear and rage. She had lashed out at Adora in her grief, pushed all her friends away as she sought the power she felt she needed to end the war. Trusting Shadow Weaver over everyone else, even though she knew the woman was vile and

manipulative. Who was more than likely using her to achieve her own agenda. Adora could do nothing to persuade her otherwise. As Glimmer continued to flout her powers as queen. Ordering the Bright Moon guards to lock her and Bow in their rooms when they did not agree with her about using the Heart. It was the most betrayed and powerless she had ever felt...at least in a long while...at least not since Catra had left her for dead at the Crystal Castle.

"Well, this time. We are the ones in charge..." Catra grinned, squeezing her hand and drawing her back.

"Along with the rest of the Princesses...of course." Adora added on with a tight smile.

Catra nodded in agreement. Feeling scolded, the beginnings of her statement sorta made her sound like a maniacal tyrant and that was the last thing she wanted. But she could not help but smile proudly. Her and Adora had always dreamed about one day being in charge and finally being able to do things their way. They had achieved that now, in a way.

"Perhaps, we all need to have a serious meeting about what our plans are, going forward now." Catra amended. Adora nodded, scanning the rolling hills of dried, yellow grass. That spread out beyond the burnt gardens. They were heading out beyond the city and through what remained of the tranquil gardens. Heading towards the more green, open fields that led to Mystacor's edge. The floating islands that attached Mystacor to the mainland would be hovering just below. A Scorpion Cruiser was supposed to land there to pick up their prisoner and his two escorting guards.

"Definitely." Scorpia nodded, "By the way Wild Cat. You are looking so much better. I figured it would take at least a week for those bruises to fade."

"What are you talking about?" Catra, muttered. Glowering at her feet for a moment. Bow had made a similar comment. She quickly

rounded on Adora, poking her in the chest. “Did you heal me?” she accused in a low snarl.

“No!” Adora raised her hands in submission, shaking her head.

(I believe I healed you, but it was not my intention.) Melog padded up to Catra, sitting just to the side of them. Their glowing blue eyes were soft, holding only a silent resolve to admit the truth. They felt no shame or guilt over what they had done.

“Melog...” Catra groaned and crouched down in front of them. She was upset but she couldn't chastise them either. “I wanted to heal naturally.” She grumbled, as Melog ducked their head and nodded.

(I was only trying to ease your discomfort so you could rest.) Melog answered, casting Adora a meaningful glance. Who was standing nearby watching their exchange with concern. (It was a spell my previous master taught me. I used the Etherian magic, She-Ra infused into my body. I guess that kind of magic has healing properties.)

Catra sighed and stood up. She did not like how easily Melog admitted that they had a previous master, as if they truly were just a slave or a tool. She cast Jitsu a dark glare, he had treated Melog like a possession in the brief time they had been collared. It turned her stomach.

The Eternian remained silent, glowering at the ground refusing to look at any of them.

Catra had as many questions to ask him as Adora. There was just so much about the wider universe that she knew nothing about. Jitsu could answer all her questions, but would he be truthful about his answers. Or use her ignorance as an advantage to control her? Now that Etheria was out of Despondos, no longer hidden, no longer protected. They were now a part of a galactic society. That had grown and evolved under Primes rule for thousands of years. They were completely ignorant to what was

out there beyond the stars and that was dangerous. Entrapta had released all the clones on Etheria... when she hacked Primes' control spires. Did her program download further then just Etheria...did she destroy the hive mind galaxy wide? She-Ra had freed countless amount of planets when she had defeated Prime. There could be many more planets just like Etheria struggling with the aftermath of Prime.

Catra sighed heavily, her mind wandering to another kind of aftermath she was still dealing with.

Shadow Weaver's death...she had avoided bringing up Shadow Weaver again. Adora had not dealt with it well. She always got so prickly when Shadow Weaver came up, changing the subject or avoiding the conversation all together. She understood, she wasn't ready to move past all that hatred, resentment and grief. She was still working through her own tortured feelings about the woman. But she felt that conversation was long overdue, she needed to find the courage to talk about it again. Catra's gaze was drawn upward to the clear, morning sky overhead. The future that lay before them was as exhilarating as it was terrifying. Adora had told her all about the previous She-Ra, during their time travelling home on Darla. She knew about Mara, her sacrifice and what she did to Etheria. Mara had put them in a protective bubble for far too long, why? What had stopped her from using the Fail Safe, then? Why did she think that hiding Etheria was the answer...

"Catra...we need to keep going." Adora's quiet voice penetrated her wandering thoughts.

"Yeah." Catra slowly raised her eyes from the ground and reached for Adora's hand.

Jitsu cut his eyes towards their clasped hands, his eyebrows raising in surprise at this new development. The princess's consort was a Hybrid...and even worse a Magicat? Relations of any kind with a hybrid was taboo on Eternia. He kept his head bowed, seeking to hide his revulsion. Wanting to seem as cowed and subservient as he could. Needing to bide his time for now. With

Tri-Clops out to exterminate him, he felt safer around a cluster of Horde guards then out on his own. He would have to work on his plan to befriend Adora. Perhaps he could use her love for that magicat to turn her against her family. King Randor was a purest, he would never accept that his daughter was in love with a hybrid. A new angle was slowly unfurling in his devious mind to turn her against the Royalty of Grayskull....and perhaps he could convince her to kill Lord Skeletor too? It seemed at this point the only way to stay alive would be to take the throne of the Dark Lord for himself.

Huntara was perched upon a barren slab of granite, on a rocky overlook off the narrow footpath. That led up the central mountain of Mystacor. She leaned heavily on her metal staff, sipping from her flask as she watched the small group of ex-horde leading the prisoner across the gardens far below. Her eyes were sharp, her observation skills honed from her years as a bandit, surviving in the Waste. Trained to pinpoint small details within the group, to quickly find any weakness she could exploit. The group slowly passed beneath the last grand white arch and into the grassy field beyond. The Scorpion Princess was in the lead with both Adora and Catra flanking the guards from the left. The prisoner was shackled, with his arms behind his back and a stun baton at his back. Which meant he must be a very formidable fighter. They were heading towards the edge of Mystacor to the floating islands that connected the citadel to the mainland below.

Huntara heaved a heavy sigh, she had been dragged out of bed late last night. To help the horde soldier's search for some young magicat, who had stolen a star seed from the Eternian they now had in custody. Sleep hadn't been much of an option for months now, so she was grateful to have something to do. So she left her room back at the dormitories and headed back to the north side of the island to see if she could find the cat's trail. It hadn't been hard, the child had walked up the foot path without even trying to hide their tracks. But the kid hadn't been alone, an adult was with them. She followed the larger boot tracks up the mountain to the

summit. Finding the swirled, wind blown grass, a clear indicator that they had been picked up by a flying machine. The delicate pink and yellow petals of Honey-Willow blossoms, scattered amid the disturbed grass. Led her investigation to Meadowlands, those flowers only bloomed on a tree that grew there. The soft, pliable branches of the Honey-willow were woven into the basket like hulls of the Bee Hybrids airships. The leftover petals still attached to the branches would fall off during flight, leaving a trail for her to follow. But it would take time to find the trail on the mainland below.

She assumed it was Sweet Bee's Airship...she was the only hybrid brave enough to ever leave their kingdom. The only person who could pull Sweet Bee away from her kingdom was Prince Peekablue. The boot prints were large, the imprint was heavy and perfectly spaced. The easy stride was that of a seasoned hiker, which was even further proof.. they were the seers. As all the pieces came together she nodded with certainty. She knew the little cat was gone, taken by Peekablue and Sweet Bee. To where she hadn't figured that out yet. As much as she loathed the idea, she might have to retrace Peekablues path into the Dark Edge Canyons. Try and piece together what the Seer's intentions might be with that cat..or the Star Seed they stole. Huntara groaned and rolled her head back stretching out her neck, trying to loosen the stiff muscles on her shoulders. Then hopped down from her perch, heading down the path. She needed food and some rest, before heading back out on the hunt again. She was fine with that, she was getting used to being a lone warrior for hire again. A transient lifestyle suited her better anyway, it left no room for attachments.

When Adora saw the tall, muscular frame of Huntara striding into view from across the field. She instantly let go of Catra's hand and dashed across the long grass to the Crimson Waste's warriors side. Catra's eyes went wide in surprise at how quickly Adora released her hand. One moment they had been speaking softly, enjoying the playful banter passing between them. Then her girl

was gone, abandoning her for another. She couldn’t help the sudden burning sense of betrayal. The familiar hurt of feeling second in Adora’s heart, that washed over her. This moment reminded her so vividly of when Adora had left her for Glimmer and Bow, back at Thaymor. She always had a hard time sharing Adora with others, especially when they were kids. She was better about it now, able to squash those irrational thoughts and insecurities. But Catra's heart clenched anyway, at how excited Adora was at seeing Huntara. How warm and exuberant her smile was. How her blue eyes shone with an eagerness to be near the burly, platinum blonde. So she watched from afar as Adora happily greeted Huntara, giving her a hearty punch in the arm. Her sweet laughter rang out like bells, when the giant woman glared playfully in response. Catra flinched as if struck, as she watched how joyfully Adora interacted with Huntara. How she unconsciously moved closer, laughing at some smart quip Huntara had responded with. Illustrating painfully to her, that they were very close friends. Huntara would lean in and say something close to Adora's ear then feint hurt feelings when Adora quipped back, pushing against Huntara's collarbone in a friendly manner. Adora's fondness and admiration for the woman was on full display. As the blonde laughed and smiled shyly over every little thing Huntara said.

Then the slow burn of jealousy ignited within her and Catra crossed her arms over her chest. Heaving a great sigh of bitter disappointment before slowly approaching Huntara, herself. She wasn't willing to just let Huntara flirt shamelessly with her girl. Feeling overly possessive, she felt she needed to remind Adora she was still there.
“Hey, Adora.” Catra crooned, as she moved in close to Adora's side. Her tail tip brushed lightly across the blondes cheek, as she pressed her back against Adora’s side.

“Catra.” Adora turned and greeted her sweetly, slipping her hand back into Catra's easily.

Catra sighed, relief flooding through her. She quickly carded her finger's with Adora's. Giving Huntara a smug, satisfied smile, as if

daring her to continue to flirt with Adora in front of her.

“Have you met Huntara yet?” Adora turned to smile softly at her, inclining Huntara with a curt wave.

“Sorta.” Catra huffed.

“So I guess you're on our side now. Kitty.” Huntara stated, unlatching her flask and taking a short sip. “Last I saw you, our dear Adora here was caging you up nice and tight against the rocks back in that canyon in the Valley of the Lost.”

“I was never there.” Catra stated sharply, “You guys were playing with my spy at the time. Double Trouble.”
“The shape shifter?” Adora gasped, “Explains how you...I mean they got out of that cage.”

Catra merely smirked at Adora's sudden bitter realization that Catra had outsmarted her. Adora squeezed her hand roughly, giving her a dirty look. “I thought I finally got the upper hand.” She pouted.

Catra giggled, “You know me, gotta make you earn your win's Adora.” She quipped, squeezing her hand back just as roughly. Her nerves settled just a bit more, at their fond reminiscing.

Then Scorpia moved briskly to their side, giving Huntara a curt nod of greeting.
“Been out here long?” She asked, scanning the fields absently for a sign of her Cruiser’s. She didn’t like being out in the open like this, with no cover. She kept a close eye on Lonnie and the two guards as they stopped a few meters ahead of them all. Hovering close to the prisoner keeping vigilant upon the barren sky above. It was now mid morning and the thin layer of clouds did very little, to filter out the blinding glare from the sun. If another drone was hovering around they would have a hard time spotting it.

“What are you doing out here?” Adora stared expectantly up at Huntara. Who now leaned heavily on her staff, as she had thrust

the pointed tip deep into the ground. Rubbing at the back of her neck, trying to work out a kink.

Catra's eyes narrowed, it was a tell she knew well. She had noticed Huntara rubbing at the back of her neck often during their meeting in the atrium. The giant warrior always tried to conceal the action by mixing it up by rubbing her eyes or scrubbing a hand down her weathered face. Her dark eyes looked dull and the circles of exhaustion had grown deeper.

“Got yanked out of bed last night to track a little magicat." Huntara began. "Looks like your kitten got picked up by a Meadowland airship at the peak of Mount Mystacor. I think they might be with Peekablue and Sweet Bee.” Huntara regarded Adora, with a thin, exhausted smile.

Catra's eyes flared in surprise for just a second, as she quickly concealed her worry behind a mask of indifference. She had just found out about the little magicat this morning. But knowing now that they had been taken off Mystacor. Made finding them the much harder. She wanted to connect with them, find out if perhaps they were other Magicats left on Etheria. How they got involved with this Eternian and why they took that crystal shard?

Huntara's concerned gaze lingering a bit longer. As Adora's smile fell, her brows furrowing with worry. Huntara was quick to reach out and clasp Adora on the shoulder, trying to ease her disappointment.

“I'll find them, Blondie. Get your little bauble back. Don't worry.” Huntara offered, giving Adora a hardy clap on the shoulder that nearly toppled the blonde over. Catra yelped and unintentionally released Adora's hand as the blonde stumbled backwards.

Adora merely nodded, rubbing her shoulder ruefully, but her expression was still grim. The star seed was gone, an airship could take them to the other side of Etheria in hours. How would they ever find them again?

“Our prisoner got attacked by another Eternian, that goes by the name of Tri-Clops.” Scorpia interrupted, inclining Jitsu. “We're headed to a Scorpion Cruiser to escort him down to a Horde transport on the ground. That will take him to the Fright Zone, I mean Scorpania....Honestly that name change is going to take some getting used to. Anyway, we plan on locking him up nice and tight in our cells, and keep the fighting as far away from the civilians as we can.”

“Good idea.” Huntara nodded.
“How many cruisers do you have at Mystacor right now?” Catra asked, a plan formulating slowly.

“Two...why?” Scorpia asked.

“Well, Meadowland airships are not all that fast. They are basically blimps with a basket. They couldn't have gotten far.” Catra advised. “Could you send a cruiser out to do a quick sweep of the sky around the island? ”

“That would slow down the supply transports up to Mystacor but only by a few hours. But yeah, of course. You're so smart. Wild Cat.” Scorpia stated, smacking a pincher into the palm of her other pincher.

Catra offered her a thin smile, she found Scorpia's need to praise her over every little thing rather embarrassing.

“Where do you think the airship might be headed?” Adora spoke up, once again filled with hope.

“Well, they could be headed back to Meadowlands or to the canyons past the Fright Zone. Peekablue hid in the Dark Edge before, he might do it again. Both places are to the southwest of here.” Huntara responded.

“So let’s get that cruiser searching the southwest, I know we will find that airship.” Catra smiled, bumping her shoulder against Adora's. Seeking to perk up her spirits even more.

“Alright, we got a plan!” Scorpia thrust a claw into the air, then pulled out her communicator pad from her belt. Moving away from them briefly to relay her commands to one of the cruiser pilots.

“Well, do you want me to track this Tri-clops fella for now?” Huntara offered.

“We got a busted Doom Seeker drone that Bow's going to take apart. He wants to try and modify his tracker pad to pick up Eternian tech signals.” Adora shrugged, “If it works we'll know where he is right away.”

“Ah, ok then.” Huntara nodded. More than happy to let that mission remain on standby for now. She was far too exhausted to want to go off into the wilderness for weeks on end, tracking another enemy.

“Do you want to come with us?” Adora offered, her voice was bright and hopeful. Chucking a thumb towards the field. “The transports coming in are loaded with supplies for the refugees. We sure could use another set of strong arms to help load the supplies. ” She wiggled her eyebrows playfully.

“I definitely got some strong arms, girlie.” Huntara laughed, flexing her huge arms for Adora's pleasure. She knew Adora had a thing for her muscles and showing off for her was always appreciated by the blonde. Her laugh grew, as Adora's eyes widened with awe and very obvious approval. The blonde was instantly enraptured by Huntara muscular physique.

Catra rolled her eyes, as Melog sensed her hurt pride and need for comfort. They rubbed up against Catra's hip, as her hand instinctively reached for Melog's mane, petting them lightly. Turning her focus to Melog, she crouched down with her back towards Adora and Huntara. Refusing to watch her girlfriend fawn over another woman. It was embarrassing how Adora was acting towards Huntara. Practically drooling over how much of an adonis

Huntara was. As Huntara flexed and posed a few more times for Adora, laughing and enjoying the silent adoration she received.

“Ah, well. I would love to show off how many crates I could carry.” Huntara smirked.

“I bet She-Ra could carry more.” Adora crossed her arms, smiling smugly. The competition was on!

“She-Ra's cheating, Blondie.” Huntara narrowed her eyes playfully, spinning her staff and tapping the button in the hilt to reduce its size. Then she attached the weapon to the back of her belt.

Adora raised a finger to protest, her words falling silent as she contemplated if She-Ra was cheating. Technically her body was powered by magic while transformed so maybe? But the magic was just amplifying her own physical body so it was still kinda her...just enhanced...so...maybe not? Or maybe she became a totally different person...which was really kinda scary...considering how her eyes flared red the last time she tried to use her magic.

“Fine.” Adora huffed, coming begrudgingly to the conclusion that She-Ra might be cheating. But she couldn't compete with Huntara in brute strength as Adora. She had trained hard for years and was strong for a human now. But she was nowhere near Huntara's strength, since the woman was half Tauran and half Gar.

Catra couldn't watch them flirt any longer, with a snarl she stormed away. Heading over to a nearby standing stone, that had a magic glyph etched on the front. She leaped up and sat down, with her back facing both Huntara and Adora. Tucking her knees up against her chest, her tail wrapped around her ankles, the tip flicking angrily. Brooding towards the now barren mountain slope that once held the waterfall. Her keen sight, tracing a small trickle of water still cascading threw the rocks towards the empty basin.

Huntara glanced up at Catra's sudden departure. While Adora turned in confusion, watching with concern as Catra stomped off

to sulk on the top of a standing stone.

“I'm going to head back for now. I need food and I need sleep.” Huntara waved to them absently and began to stride away.

“But...we could really use your help?” Adora called after her.

“I don't think your Kitty likes me very much, Blondie. I'd rather not stick around and get scratched.” Huntara called. Leaving Adora to stare with disappointment, as she left. It was going to be a long, hard day of manual labor. Adora squared her shoulders and prepared herself for the grueling work ahead.

Catra couldn't help the jealousy, bubbling up inside of her. She briefly sent Huntara's retreating back a heated glare. Before huffing and returning to glower at the rocky slopes of the mountain.

Adora definitely had some intense feelings toward Huntara. She got so excited to see her and had practically hovered inches away from the woman the whole time they talked. Staring up at her with such fond admiration. Their banter was warm and easy like they were really good friends. Perhaps more...who knows if they had had a relationship during the war. It wasn't like Adora had warm, fuzzy feelings for her then. Catra had been on the fence if Adora was honestly attracted to Huntara. Or if it was just some kind of weird hero worship. Huntara was not Mara...she was the antithesis of everything that Mara had stood for...so...

Catra sighed dejectedly. It was definitely an attraction and it left her feeling rather inadequate.

“Hey.” Adora knew something was bothering her, she just didn't know what. She quickly assessed Catra’s body language. How stiff and tense her muscles were hunched up tight over her knees. How just the tip of her tail flicked. It was obvious, Catra was furious. So she approached with a certain amount of caution.

Leaning her shoulder casually against the standing stone just below Catra's perch.

“Hey.” Catra acknowledged sullenly, slowly uncurling her legs and letting them dangle. Her feet hovering just above Adora's head. Her tail slipping down and lightly brushed Adora on top of the head. Letting her know she was mad, but slowly getting over it. Melog chirped from their position sitting beside Adora. Leaning their head into Adora's hand, as she lightly stroked their head.

“Are you still upset with me about what I said earlier?” Adora asked innocently. Wondering if Catra had been brooding over her insensitive statement about the fate of their bunk mates.

“I was never upset with you about that.” Catra sighed, pulling one leg back up to rest her cheek against her knee.

“Ok...but something's bothering you now?” Adora inclined her head backward, smirking up at Catra.

“Yeah, obviously.” Catra scoffed, rolling her eyes.

Adora sighed, prying out her girlfriends feelings was sometimes so difficult.
“Wanna, share....or are we going to keep volleying one word sentences back and forth till noon?” Adora crossed her arms over her chest in frustration.

“You can be such an idiot....you know that.” Catra huffed, leaping down from the stone and combing her short hair back with her fingers. Seeking to calm her rising anger.

“That has been established, yes.” Adora noted, rounding on Catra and grabbing her shoulders so she couldn’t run off, if that was her intention. Pushing her lightly, up against the side of the stone, gently trapping her.

“Do you want to kiss Huntara?” Catra blurted out, jutting her chin up. Confronting Adora with how hurt she was, by the tearful glare in her eyes. Getting right to the point.

Adora's mouth dropped open in complete surprise and she blinked awkwardly for a moment unsure how to respond. Catra's abrupt accusation felt like a slap in the face.

“What!” She finally shouted. “No....I mean...no...Uh...why would you think that.” She stumbled out, suddenly feeling rather nervous and embarrassed that Catra would think that. Did Huntara think she was being more than just friendly too?

“Because you act like a love sick idiot around her!” Catra shouted back, balling her fists at her sides. The hurt and inadequate feeling bubbling out in her seething fury. As she snapped her head down and to the side refusing to look at Adora any further. Feeling raw and vulnerable and needing a moment to fortify herself.

“I do not!” Adora protested, it was really bothering her now how Catra had misinterpreted her interactions with Huntara. If she thought she was acting like that...did Huntara think like that too.

Adora groaned, both embarrassed and worried that Huntara had gotten the wrong impression of her feelings.

“I just....admire her...like...a-lot!” Adora stated, bowing her head. Her shoulder's sagging and heaving a long sigh. The humiliation and regret burned on her cheeks. As she was forced to confront once again. How awkward she was expressing her feelings properly with others.

“I figured it was that...or you wanted to kiss her.” Catra shrugged, seeing how upset and stressed Adora suddenly was. Catra was quick to forgive, turning and grasping her chin in her fingertips. Pulling Adora’s head up to face her. Offering her a warm, loving smile before rubbing her cheek along the underside of Adora's chin and down her neck. It was a possessive behavior, to rub your scent on the people you laid claim to. She was no longer going to deny herself, the instinctual behaviors of her race. She finally had the freedom to embrace them.

“What was...” Adora breathed, sensing that Catra had just marked her in some way.

“You belong to me...now.” Catra smirked, bracing her hands on Adora's cheeks and pulling her down. Bunting their foreheads together, Catra gazed lovingly up into Adora's eyes and smiled sweetly.

Adora giggled. “Ok...” then pecked a kiss on the tip of Catra's nose. “You promise.”

“I promise.” Catra sighed in relief.

The light was starting to fade into the muted grey's of evening, when the last of the supplies were loaded on the Scorpion Cruiser for its last flight of the day. Lonnie had Jitsu secured in the hold of one of the transports all day. The Eternian sat on a metal bench on one side of the now empty compartment. Sweating from being stuck in the humid cargo hold, that had barely any air circulation all day. Glowering down at his feet, with his hands bolted behind his back. While Lonnie stood in front of him speaking softly into her communication pad. The rest of the convoy had already departed, heading back to Scorpania.

Adora stood at the back of the last transports' open cargo doors, rolling her shoulders and neck. Everything was sore. She had not turned into She-Ra, preferring to haul the crates and building materials as Adora. It didn’t help that she was honestly quite scared about her magic right now, worried about what her red eyes meant. She needed a good work out anyway, it helped to ease all the stress and anxiety that was gnawing at her.

“Adora.” Catra acknowledged with a smirk, as she leaned casually against the side of the hold next to her. Catra had been working just as hard all day and the slump of her posture showed how exhausted she was.

They watched Scorpia commanding the transport personnel, giving them instructions with her pad as to what she wanted them to do once they got back to the Fright Zone.....or Scorpania as she wished to call her kingdom. In time it seemed the Fright Zone would fall away into history and both Adora and Catra were more than fine to see it disappear. Adora watched the glowing lights on the underside of the Scorpion Cruiser's hull, as it lifted off with the last bit of cargo for Mystacor. Adora sighed and crossed her arms over her chest, as she craned her head back to keep the airship in sight, as it faded into the heavy clouds high above.

"I'm so sore..." Adora moaned.

"and so tired...." Catra responded in kind, slipping down the metal hull of the transport to sit on the ground.

"and so hungry..." Adora smirked down at her, keeping up their new game.

"and so hot ..." Catra quipped, casting Adora a meaningful look. That she was totally oblivious to. But what did Catra expect. She had flirted with Adora for years and the dumb blonde never caught on. Seriously...how blunt did she have to be to get Adora to notice? All her sultry "Hey, Adora's....or her playful "It's not because I like you...statements. Those words could not have been that vague of a flirt? Either way it had taken both of them nearly dying to finally get them to have the courage to say the words. They had always wanted to say to each other for years. Both of them finally getting what they really wanted.

"and so sweaty..." Adora pointed out, picking at her long sleeve shirt in disgust.

"and so horny." Catra's eyes flared wide in horror, she had just blurted that out...without thinking. Her mind just taking that lewd leap after their last, very hot, very pleasurable, make out session that morning. Now she was blushing profusely and ducking her head away shyly.

Adora gapped down at her and then laughed, finally catching on to her previous attempt to flirt. Catra giggled, as she braced herself for Adora’s, awkward, perhaps humorous comeback. When Melog cantered up to her and gave her an affectionate head butt as well. Their mane was glowing a soft pink, only heightening Catra's perverse mindset and humiliation.

“Well...yeah...ditto.” Adora reached down and scratched Catra behind an ear. A low, contented purr rumbled from deep in the hybrids throat at Adora's soft affection.

“Guys!” Lonnie burst from the transport, shaking her pad at them. “Kyle's back to normal, some sorcerer's apprentice spent all day teaching him how to turn his magic off.”

“That's great!” Adora beamed at Lonnie, relieved that one problem got solved today.

“Well, we should head back up, Glimmer wants us to have supper together, since the whole breakfast meeting was a flop.” Scorpia approached them, announcing Glimmer's plans.

Catra groaned, slowly rising to her feet. “Why didn't we go up in the Cruiser?” she whined, as she trudged up to Scoripa. “My feet hurt...” she complained, shoulder’s hunched and arms hanging limply at her sides.

“I could carry you, Wild Cat?” Scorpia offered, placing a comforting pincher on her sore shoulders. Scorpia had worked just as hard as the rest of them, yet she was still so chipper and energetic.

Catra groaned, glancing up at the Scorpion's hard, pointy carapace. Honestly debating how comfortable sitting on her shoulders might be. There was no way she would let Scorpia carry her in her arms. That is far too intimate and only for Adora.

“We're heading out in two days.” Lonnie started, “I expect you two at the fortress. “

Catra was in a very happy and playful mood, so she snapped to attention and gave Lonnie a sharp salute. Her purr, rumbling.

Adora laughed even harder, then followed Catra's lead. Coming to attention and giving Lonnie a firm salute.

“Ha, Ha, Ha. You two idiots just better keep your promises this time.” Lonnie folded her arms across her chest, staring each girl down with a hard, serious glare.

“We will.” Adora clasped Lonnie on the shoulder, before turning and heading up the ramp. She wanted to talk to Jitsu for a bit before the transport left.

Catra followed her, her expression was cold, unreadable. All humor and cheer washed away, replaced by a firm resolve. She was not going to leave Adora alone with that guy, from her fight with him earlier. He might spout off about being all honorable, but he was sly and devious. Adora was far too naive and trusting to handle him on her own.

“I just wanted to let you know that we will find your friend.” Adora advised sternly.

“He is not my friend.” Jitsu grumbled back, he had been forced to sit, chained and bolted to the bench all day. His back hurt and his muscles were sore from not being able to move. He was sweaty and uncomfortable. He leaned back against the curved metal wall as much as he could. Gazing up at Adora with a bitter smile.

“Well, you will be safer back at the Fright Zone then here at Mystacor.” Adora shrugged.

Jitsu started to laugh, it was a harsh, brittle sound. “Do not underestimate Tri-Clops. He is stubborn and rather enjoys a challenge. My advice...don't wait too long to go on the offensive.”

“We can't fight him, if we can't track him.” Catra snarled, “The coward has been hiding out of reach for days, sending his drones to do his dirty work.”

“Find my sword, Give it back to me, I can track him, kill him for you. ” Jitsu offered.

“We have a Seeker Drone, we'll use that tech to find him.” Adora nodded, ignoring his promise outright. “If we do find your sword, it will be locked up the same as your daggers.”

Jitsu’s eyes narrowed, as he seethed silently at her refusal.

“It's surprising that Tri-clops didn't blow it up?” Jitsu stated, with a shrug.

“Well, I guess Kyle managed to destroy the detonator when he squashed it.” Catra shot back, hiding her sudden fear behind an indifferent expression. She had totally forgotten about the drones self-destruct capabilities. She passed Adora a meaningful glance, the blonde groaned and squared her shoulders she had forgotten too.

“Good.” Jitsu sighed.

“Why are you helping us?” Catra inquired.

“I have no reason not to, my own people want me dead. I'm a liability to Lord Skeletor's plans...at least a part of them.” Jitsu started, bowing his head and heaving another great sigh. “I have been loyal , to my Lord Skeletor for most of my life. That devotion has amounted to nothing. Perhaps it is time for my loyalties changed. ” He stared up at Adora, his eyes resolute, that she was that change. “I hate your father with every fiber of my being, princess. But perhaps, Eternia needs a new ruler. Someone whose moral compass has not been corrupted by a thousand year old grudge.”

Jitsu had been offering her crumbs of information since last night. Again he was subtly dropping more information about her home planet. Like a moth to a flame Adora was eager to know more. So she sat down beside him, lightly grasping his good hand, seeking to comfort him. He looked so broken and lost, at being betrayed by his own people.

“I want to help you...” Adora stated. “But you need to tell me everything about Tri-Clops and Lord Skeletor and what he wants with Etheria?”

Jitsu nodded, “I am just a soldier, Princess...I know very little about my Lord’s plans for this planet. He has been fighting to reclaim the throne of Eternia for over a thousand years.”

“How...can he still be alive?” Catra scoffed, her mind reeling with the possibility that Skeletor was extending his life in the same unnatural way as Prime.

“My lord is a Dark Mage...a Necromancer.” Jitsu stated proudly. “He is a master sorcerer of the Dark Arts and has made himself Immortal.”

“Creepy.” Catra muttered, now convinced this Skeletor was exactly like Prime.

“So my family has been fighting a war with him for a thousand years?” Adora was shocked and saddened by that. The wars on Etheria had gone on for countless years with Hordak and then Prime. Rebuilding from that would take decades. What did Eternia look like after enduring war for so long?

“Yes, your ancestor’s stole the throne, banishing my Lord and all who were loyal to him to the dark side of the planet. It's a cruel, lifeless land with no sun. Full of deadly predator's, barren mountains and endless desserts of grey sand. A wasteland your ancestor had hoped, my Lord and the people loyal to him would die in.” Jitsu's eyes dimmed as he lost himself to the memories of his time on Eternia. “But my Lord persevered, his stubborn pride would not allow him to give up and die. So he tamed the dark magic that lay within that side of the planet. Dominating it and bending it to his will. He has ruled his dark kingdom from the peaks of Snake Mountain ever since. With that power he built his kingdom and was able to adapt his people to the harsh climate of the dark side of the Eternia. We have been fighting a civil war ever since.”

“That's terrible.” Adora groaned.

“Perhaps you could come home, get your father to see reason. Princess. ” Jitsu offered, his eyes hopeful. “Lord Skeletor and King Randor know only hatred and war. But the people on both sides are tired of fighting, we just want peace.”

“So it's true, Adora really is a Princess from Eternia.” Catra moved to stand in front of Adora, not liking how cozy she was with the man who days earlier tried to kill her.

Jitsu nodded. “She is an Heir of Grayskull.”

Adora’s expression was grim as she glanced up at Catra. Who's mismatched eyes were growing moist with dread. Catra quickly cleared her throat and crossed her arms over her chest, needing to hold in her emotional turmoil that was roiling inside of her.

“I want to go home.” Adora gave Jitsu’s hand a comforting pat, reassuring him of her future intentions.

“Wait...Adora...Etheria's your home...” Catra nearly shouted on the verge of panic. Her heart jumping in her chest and hammering with anxiety at hearing those fateful words.

Her rising dread screamed in her head. Adora’s leaving...she wants to leave...she’s going to abandon her again!

Adora smiled softly up at Catra, but her blue eyes mirrored a deep and sad longing for more. Catra had seen that look in Adora's eyes before back at Thaymor and it never ended well for them.

“I know that Catra, Etheria will always be dear to me. But Eternia is where I was born, it's where my brother...my parents are. I have no intention of leaving Etheria just yet.” Adora stood, clasping her hands, seeking to reassure her. Catra sniffed, her eyes growing wet with unshed tears. This conversation felt just like Thaymor. She could feel that axe of fate, hovering over them. It was going to drop eventually, severing them forever.

“But Eternia needs me, Catra. I have to go home and fix things. Everyone deserves to live in peace.” Adora stated, There was finality to her words that made Catra's heart start to crack all over again. “This time, you will come with me and we can heal Eternia just like we healed Etheria.” Adora's smile was bright and hopeful, an eagerness to push forward yet again towards a brighter future gleaming in her eyes.

“But Etheria isn't fixed yet.” Catra countered, her voice low and raspy as she tried to keep the tears at bay. She couldn't do this again...it was too much...Adora was going to leave her...she might not be able to follow? The heavy sense of foreboding was wrapping around her, squeezing her chest and she suddenly couldn't breathe.

“I know...but when Etheria is on track again, I want to go to Eternia.” Adora nodded, not picking up how scared and upset this conversation was making Catra.

“Fine.” Catra snarled, yanking her hand free from Adora's grip and stomping out of the transport. She couldn't deny Adora's need to reconnect with her family or her birth planet. But she didn't like it either.

She was slowly becoming overwhelmed by fear that she was going to lose her yet again for some greater purpose. That Adora would leave her behind, for some heroic mission that only she could fulfill. Just like Thaymor...just like the Fail Safe...

Adora watched her go, her eyes shone with disappointment. Why couldn't Catra be supportive? Why did she always have to be so stubborn...and scared of change?

Catra’s mind was spiraling back into that dark place and she needed space. Melog chirped softly as they fell into step next to Catra.

“Adora's a princess....back on Eternia...I'm scared Melog.. that I'm going to lose her again.” Catra swallowed hard, the ache in her

chest becoming unbearable. She rubbed her chest with her fingers, as if that might soothe the throbbing pain of her heart breaking all over again.

Melog stopped in front of her, preventing her from walking off in some random direction, as dusk settled over the mountains.
(Sit and wait.) Melog ordered, they really did not want her running off like last time. Her need to run instead of confronting her feelings was dangerous. But they thought perhaps now, after everything. She might realize that you could not outrun your emotions, they merely followed you.

Catra huffed and compiled, sitting down on the dried grass a few meters away from the transport.

Glancing bitterly over her shoulder back at Adora, who had returned to sitting next to Jitsu. Continuing their conversation, so selfishly driven towards her own goals. She was completely oblivious to Catra's pain yet again. Catra pounded a fist into the hard ground, taking a deep breath. She was not going to allow that toxic voice to start poisoning her thoughts again.

She started to recite all the good in her life just like Perfuma had instructed. Adora loved her, she needed her, wanted her. She was in a good place now...with people who cared about her. She had Glimmer and Bow...Scorpia and Entrapta...everything would be alright. Adora wasn't going to leave without her....but she always wanted more...she was always restless and striving for the greater good for all... would she be enough this time? Adora had such unbelievably high standards that she set for herself. That Catra could never hope to achieve. What if Adora grew tired of her...she always held her back? What if she disappointed her by not being able to keep up with her? What if....

Catra gasped for air as panic set it. Melog mewled and jumped at her, pushing her over onto the ground and pressing their weight upon her chest.
“I can't do this....again...” Catra clutched at their fur on their shoulders and pressed her face into the cool, soothing fog of their

mane. Trembling and gasping as she finally broke down into frustrated tears.

Building a Future

A radiant flash suddenly illuminated the grey evening, announcing the entrance of Glimmer. Catra had been sitting nearby with Melog, lightly petting her companion, lost to her troubled thoughts. When the sudden flash of light caught her eye. Catra glanced up to find Glimmer with both Rogelio and once again a human, Kyle. Rogelio looked sick to his stomach, his usually green scales now looking pale and rather gray. The tall, husky lizard was hunched over, crossing his arms over his stomach.

“I feel for you...” Catra whispered, already dreading that instead of a grueling hike back up the mountain to use one of the floating islands to get back up to Mystacor. She would no doubt be teleporting up into the sky instead.

Kyle on the other hand was absolutely ecstatic, a huge beaming smile lighting up his face as he whooped and thrust his fists into the air.

“That...was...awesome!” He exclaimed in crisp staccato. “Magic is so cool. I really don't understand why Hordak was so freaked out about it.” Kyle mused.

“He was trying to take over Etheria. But most of his troops were Etherian's? He needed an easily acceptable belief to make his troops want to fight the Princesses.” Glimmer instructed. “Stealing you as young children from your families or orphaning you by destroying your villages. Raising you in a group environment, surrounded by people who all believed the same thing. Raising you to be soldiers. Teaching you to believe that magic was dangerous and that you need to subdue the evil princesses to bring peace was the easiest way to indoctrinate you into his war. To keep his ranks expanding so he would have enough resources to continue to push the Fright Zones borders forward, to eventually overwhelm the Princess Alliance and take over. ”

“Ah...I see...” Kyle took it all in and nodded. His expression was reflective but not stunned, as if the full weight of what she said had not sunk in yet. Then he finally noticed how unsteady Rogelio was. Quickly rushing to the lizard’s side and wrapping an arm around his shoulders. Guiding Rogelio away to the transport to help sit him down. As Rogelio looked very close to vomiting.

Adora exited the transport, as Kyle and Rogelio boarded. She passed both of them a warm smile of greeting. Offering Kyle kind words of relief that he was alright. His cheeks flared for a moment, warm blue eyes shining with happiness at Adora's concern. He merely nodded and took a step back out of her reach when she tried to hug him. Suddenly very overwhelmed and bashful at receiving her affection. Showing affection and kindness to others had always been frowned upon back at the Horde, resulting in punishment. The cadets back at the barracks learned early on to show their more tender emotions to only those they could trust and only when they were alone. Hidden away from prying eyes, in the dark, secluded areas of the Fright Zone were it was safe. Having Adora so openly offer him friendly affection would take some time to get used to. Kyle's wariness and awkward dismissal to receive or reciprocate affection was very common for ex-horde soldier's. Adora had already worked through the guilt and fear of casual affection during her years in the rebellion. The princesses were naturally loving and kind, which took some getting used to. Kyle was starting that journey to understand that affection was not wrong, it was needed and it was ok to want it.

Adora took his rejection in stride, dropping her arms and giving him a weak nod. As Kyle awkwardly averted his gaze, focusing on getting Rogelio up the ramp and on the bench.

“Well, the meals being served so lets get our last wayward princesses to the table.” Glimmer smirked, bracing her hands on her hips. As Scorpia and Adora moved in close.

“I'd rather walk.” Catra grumbled, slowly rising to her feet. Lightly scratching Melog's neck nervously.

“Don't be a brat.” Glimmer responded, offering her a hand.

Adora smiled sadly at her, knowing how uncomfortable teleportation made her.

“It will be over before you know it.” Adora consoled.

Catra closed her eyes and groaned in dread, trudging reluctantly towards the group with Melog in toe.

In a flash the ground disappeared and the sickening feeling of passing thru space surrounded them. Catra hated teleportation, the sudden shift from one place to another overloaded all her heightened senses. Leaving her sick and disorientated. When the firmness of the ground hit the bottoms of her bare feet she heaved a great sigh of relief, then groaned with disappointment when she opened her eyes. Finding that Glimmer had transported them to the Tranquil Gardens just outside Mystacor. The heavy metal bulk of Darla loomed just ahead.

Catra crumpled to her knees, as the ground tipped sickeningly. Adora was quick to wrap a bracing arm around her shoulders and guide her back up to her feet. Her blue eyes filled with sympathetic concern, as she braced Catra softly against her side. “One more Blink and it's all over.” She soothed, Catra merely nodded bitterly. A Blink was a nickname the Best Friend Squad had given Glimmer's teleportation years ago. But to Catra, giving Glimmer's powers a cute little nickname did not make the process any better.

Adora moaned in dismay, at how sick Catra got while teleporting. Cupping her cheek tenderly, as Catra leaned her head heavily against her shoulder. Her hot breath tickled Adora just behind her ear. Adora sighed in resignation, rubbing her thumb across Catra's cheek trying to soothe her girl.

“Oh, goody...” Catra groaned, leaning heavily against Adora. Wrapping an arm securely around the blondes waist, as she rolled

her head away from the blondes neck to gaze up at the stars.

The sun had set into the mountains below Mystacor. As Etheria welcomed the coming night, the largest of Etheria's moons was cresting over the rim of the gardens. It's soft, gentle silver light bathing the garden and shining off the underside of Darla's metal hull. High above the stars shimmered amid the dark backdrop of space. The majestic void looked cold, lonely as it stretched endlessly overhead. A heavy melancholy settled over Catra. Now that she was back on Etheria after being trapped in space for so long. She was really having a hard time getting excited about their upcoming trip to bring Magic back the universe.

She knew that no matter what Adora was set on going to Eternia. She had brought it up many times over the last few days, trying to get Catra used to the idea. When Adora was set on accomplishing something, she strove towards it with a single minded determination. Nothing and no one would get in her way to achieve her goals. So Catra had decided that this time she would follow Adora anywhere, even back to Eternia, even if that meant never setting foot on Etheria again. She growled softly, the thought still making her upset. Adora held her close, rubbing her hand briskly up her arm seeking to warm her. Frowning down at her with growing concern. Offering her comfort and security as always, not understanding why she was upset. Figuring she was just sick to her stomach.

Catra had always kept a certain amount of how she truly felt hidden from Adora. Not wanting to upset her, or just too scared to confront the harsh truth or repercussion of those feelings. At first she swallowed her feelings as an act of kindness. Never wanting to burden Adora with things she could not control. After their fateful encounter in the Black Garnet Chamber. Catra had to confront the truth that Shadow Weaver did not love her, that she allowed her to live only because Adora was fond of her. That had shredded her heart and kindled her hatred for the old crone. Adora had never known how resentful and hurt Catra was. Growing up in her shadow...until the Crystal Castle forced them both to confront the past. Catra wasn't oblivious to the stress and

anxiety Adora dealt with. On a daily basis while they grew up. Shadow Weaver's expectations of Adora had been a soul crushing weight that the blonde had carried silently. She never complained, just learned to work harder. Prepare obsessively for tests, combat scenarios and endurance training so that she would always achieve the highest scores. So Catra had willingly played the role of supportive best friend, keeping that unaffected smile on her face. Pretending to be a slacker who didn't care about achieving anything. Knowing her place was as Adora's side kick, that as long as Adora wanted her, she was safe. She had long since given up the hope that Shadow Weaver would ever offer her any of the affection or praise she so craved. So she swallowed her pride and followed in Adora's wake. As Adora strived for excellence, receiving all the praise and recognition...something Catra envied. Those unspoken feelings had accumulated over time into a silent festering hatred which sundered their friendship. Catra cast her a brief glance, she would never allow that to happen again. Another heart to heart was coming between them, but it could wait for now.

"Gotta pick up Bow and Entrapta." Glimmer announced, starting to walk off when two silhouettes moved towards them in the dim light.

"I have got so much to do still, can you just bring me back some tiny food?" Entrapta beseeched Bow, as the young man was guiding her away from the ship. Pulling her gently by the hand, as she kept glancing back at the ship anxiously.

"Entrapta you have been alone for days, we miss you and want your company for supper." Bow responded, his voice was stern but gentle.

Entrapta groaned, "But....my experiment's need me!"

"We need you, too" Glimmer reached out a hand, her smile was warm and inviting. Bow had filled her in today with how out of sorts and obsessed Entrapta was with her new robot. That she needed a break from her 'lab' to reconnect with real people. She

was not in a good place, emotionally speaking and needed her friends right now.

“Com’on Trapta, it’ll be fun!” Scorpia encouraged with a bright cheerful exuberance only the kind hearted Scorpioni could pull off.

Entrapta glanced away briefly, thinking things over then nodded reluctantly. Allowing Bow to take her hand and lead her to the group willingly. One more flash and the group was huddled in front of the cozy stone and mortar building that was the kitchen.

“I'm gonna hurl...” Catra made a sick sound and pulled away from Adora. Racing away to the side of the building to dry heave.

“Do you have to be so dramatic!” Glimmer complained, glowering in frustration at Catra's hunched form in the shadows at the side of the kitchen. Adora ignored her, having raced after Catra the instant she had pulled away. Now rubbing the feline's back in small circles, seeking to ease how dizzy and woozy she felt. Melog meowed piteously nearby, head hanging low and ears drooping.

“We'll be in, in a minute.” Adora called over her shoulder.

As Bow opened a heavy wooden door, offering for Glimmer, Scorpia and Entrapta to enter the kitchen first.

“See you inside.” He called before walking through the door, letting it close behind him.

Catra bid Melog farewell, they wanted to head back to their room to rest. They had no need for food and found banquets rather noisy, anxious affairs that they would rather avoid. So Catra and Adora were the last to arrive, finding that all the princess's were seated at the back of a long table. That ran the length of the main room. With Micah and Casta seated on either end and Glimmer right in the middle. Netossa and Spinerella were seated just to the right of Casta, speaking softly with one another. Discussing the

repairs they had helped with today in the Merchant Quarter and the distribution of supplies that Scorpia had flown in. While Huntara was seated on the right side of Micah, slumped slightly in her chair, picking at the fancy white table cloth absently. A look of tired disinterest, clear in her sallow expression and bent posture. Her metal flask was gripped in one hand, hidden just under the table.

The table was dressed in a pure white cloth, with fine china and silverware set before everyone. Tall honey wax candles were set along the table, set in elegant silver holders. The candlelight casting the dark room in a warm flickering incandescence. Adora felt a little out of place, after a day of physical labor. She was rather dirty and sweaty. Catra was in a dark mood, so didn't really care, she had far too much on her mind. They took their seats next to one another in the last two open chair's on the back corner beside Netossa. Who offered both of them a warm smile of greeting. Once everyone was seated, Glimmer stood from her chair in the center of the table. She clapped her hands twice, announcing to the kitchen staff that everyone was ready to start the meal.

The cook and her two assistants were quick to start pushing carts laden with covered platters to the table. Soon the table was set with a tiered platter of tiny food beside Entrapta, who offered the green haired cook an excited grin before digging in.
“I am glad you and your staff are doing well.” Entrapta offered her old cook politely.

“Yes, very well indeed. Mystacor is taking good care of us, Princess.” The cook responded softly.

The other female assistant set out steaming platters of grilled meats, boiled potatoes and spiced fish. Raw vegetables sliced into stripes, was set before Perfuma, along with an assortment of fruit. Large tureens of soup, along with platters of fresh breads and assorted cheeses followed. The other assistant was busy pouring drinks. Entrapta was offered a fizzy soda, while others had more choices, such as water or wine.

Once again Catra was left overwhelmed by the variety of the food. The many savory smells now encircling her slowly settling her queasy belly. She turned to Adora, pleading silently for her guidance. Humorously, finding Adora's attention riveted upon the food. The ravenous blonde was beaming, nearly hopping in her chair with excitement over the delicious choices. Her eyes sparkling when she caught sight of the dessert offerings still sitting on the carts. There were small cakes, decorated with candied fruits and icing. Two pies decorated in sugared lattices and various tarts all organized in a delightfully colorful manner on a final platter.

Catra found herself laughing softly, a fond smile pulling on her lips, as she took in Adora's childlike joy and excitement over the meal. Catra sighed and leaned back in her chair, figuring she would just enjoy the show for a few minutes till Adora calmed down.

As the food began to be passed around, Adora was very attentive to her. Offering everything as the platters and tureens were served. Soon Catra had a plate full of various meats, vegetables, bread and cheese along with a bowl of some kind of cream soup. As soon as Adora felt they were ready to dig into the meal, she scanned the table one last time.

“Where's Finn?” She asked, leaning forward to confront Glimmer. Hoping she might know.

“He's eating in the back kitchen, he didn't want to join us. Said grown ups were boring and he wanted to eat fast, cause he's working on some kind of surprise for you two.” Glimmer shrugged, with a coy smile.

“Awww, your kid is sooo cute!” Bow crowed.

While both Adora and Catra ducked their heads and blushed.

“He's not our kid.” Catra mumbled back, scratching her nose nervously.

Adora bumped her shoulder against Catra's, a proud smile gracing her adorable face. Adora really liked the sound of Finn being theirs. Catra groaned and bumped her shoulder back with a giggle. Perhaps she kinda liked it too. Finn had been with them for close to a month now. He had become a part of their daily lives, even if they hadn't seen much of him lately. They had both grown rather fond of him and really couldn't see a future without him in it.

It didn't take long for the various conversations to grow in volume. Laughter and excited shouts echoed through the room, as the princess regaled each other with stories of how they got their powers back. Except Scorpia, who remained sullenly silent. Listening attentively to each story, nodding and smiling at the appropriate times. But once more left behind as the only Princess not to regain her powers. Adora was quick to slip her hand into Catra's underneath the table. The cacophony of sound was just like eating back in the cadets mess hall. Adora had always held her hand when they ate together, supporting her silently. Knowing that the crowded table and loud room put her on edge. Already, Catra had her ears folded and focusing on her plate. Trying to eat casually and not rush through the meal so she could get away. Catra relaxed instantly, at Adora's subtle reassurance.

Casting Adora pleased smiles from time to time as she savored all the different meats. Humming with approval when she took that first spoonful of soup. As the spiced cream and vegetables warmed her belly. Finishing her meal by picking at the crusty bread and cheese while sipping lightly at the bitter glass of wine. Enjoying every bite as she listened to the ebb and flow of the various conversations among her...friends. The thought gave her a pleasant warmth, but it was tempered. Far too used to having things she wanted, or cherished quickly taken away from her. So she lived in the now and right now she seemed to be accepted, she seemed to be wanted...right now she felt like she belonged. But it would only be a matter of time before she was going to screw things up somehow and they would all come to their senses

and realize she wasn't worth their time. Catra heaved a sigh and rolled her eyes, stopping those toxic thoughts. By reminding herself about all the ways each princess here had shown her they honestly wanted her around and enjoyed her company. She needed to keep reassuring herself that she mattered to them, that for the most part had been forgiven.

Bow was in a rather heated but friendly debate with Entrapta over how they were going to dismantle the Doom Seeker drone without blowing themselves up. Bow felt they should just take out the components they needed to figure out it's communication frequency and track that, avoiding the core of the drone completely. While Entrapta stated that she needed to figure out how the drones work as well, so they could develop countermeasures against them.

Bow conceded that was true, but it wasn't safe to take the drone apart on Mystacor. They needed to find a place away from civilians. At that point the conversation fell silent as they both contemplated where it was remote enough to set up a lab.

“The sooner you two get that tracking system working the sooner I can go take care of things with that Tri-Clops’s fella.” Huntara stated gruffly, she had pushed her chair away from the table, stretching her legs out. Picking at her teeth with the tip of a dagger.

“Beast Island!” Entrapta shouted, her eyes gleaming with excitement.

Bow went pale, blinking a few times in dismay. He suddenly looked terrified and ready to bolt for cover. The sudden exclamation quieted all other conversations for a moment, as several princesses gave them strange looks.

Catra chuckled, Entrapta wasn't scared of anything. She saw life as one big challenge to conquer. Catra admired her for that. She

was already debating her points to Bow about how it was a good idea. That the island had tons of tech they could use to build a blast proof lab and that she could finish her research with the beacon. It contained so much information about the First Ones.

While Bow whined about how creepy and scary that place was. Then Entrapta went off on another excited tangent over her seeing her robot protector again, that she had made a promise to come back for her. So the plan to leave in the morning for Beast Island was pretty much set in stone.

Bow groaned in dread, Glimmer patted his hand reassuring him that since the beacon was no longer working the island was mostly beast free. Which only soured her own mood, she turned to confront Scorpia.

“Your troops, have they captured many beast island monsters on the mainland?”

“Well, our holding cells have just been drained.” Scorpia began.

“Sorry about that.” Mermista grimaced.

Scorpia turned to her with mild humor. “We both did things back then that were out of our control, no need to apologize.”

Catra had been watching the conversations happening further down the table, noticing how Huntara lowered her head and rubbed the back of her neck at Scorpia's comment. Which confirmed her theory, Huntara had been chipped.

“Still...” Mermista shrugged, poking her fork sadly into the remaining bits of fish on her plate.

“Well, we are holding all the Weird Eternian's in the cells now.” Scorpia stated.

“Why do you call them weird?” Glimmer asked.

“They're some kind of Cyborg, connected to a magic crystal in their foreheads.” Catra responded.

“Jitsu called them Husks and stated they were completely expendable?” Adora added, her voice thick with distain at how callous Jitsu was toward other living beings.

“I got Jitsu on the way to a nice holding cell. The reports I've got on the Beast Island creatures is that they've started to migrate into the Crimson Waste.” Scorpia explained, tapping the tip of one pincher on the table nervously.

Huntara's eyes widened in alarm for a second, before her expression went slack. Falling into a grim, despondent frown.

“I sent several squads into the waste to protect the outer villages near Scorpion Hills and the Valley of the Lost.” Scorpia stated, offering Huntara some reassurance.

“My people are tough, they can handle those monsters just fine on their own. You're wasting resources.” Huntara growled back, taking a long sip from her flask.

Catra's eyes narrowed, Huntara had been sneaking drinks from that flask all through supper? Catra began to review the last few encounters with Huntara. The woman had been short tempered, exhausted and aloof towards her so called friends. She had been leaning on her staff during their conversation back in the tranquil gardens and then used it as a walking stick to keep her balance when she left them. Catra crossed her arms over her chest, as she came to a silent conclusion that Huntara was drunk....had been for the last few days. She rolled her shoulders, resolute to keep a close eye on her. She would talk to Adora about it later, maybe this was normal for Huntara. Either way the woman could be a liability during a mission.

Her ears swiveled, as she eavesdropped on another conversation between Mermista and Frosta. They were speaking softly so she

only got a few choice words. But what she did hear, made her smile.

Frosta was so forthright with her opinions, Mermista merely nodded and laughed. The water princess did not find Frosta rude at all, she actually appreciated how honest and upfront she was. Catra filed that away, wanting to be able to talk to Mermista and not feel awkward or nervous. She was oblivious to the fond looks both Adora and Glimmer were casting her. As she had been completely focused on her meal and the conversations happening around her. This might have been the first time she felt content and happy surrounded by others.

“I am so glad you're here.” Adora breathed softly against her ear, before pressing a gentle kiss to her cheek.

Catra squeaked at the sudden affection, blushing and chewing her chunk of bread, as she turned to regard Adora with a confused look.

“You are so beautiful.” Adora stated, her blue eyes shimmering with love.

“I'm beautiful, when I'm stuffing my face?” Catra laughed softly, shaking her head as if to discredit the compliment.

“Breathtakingly Beautiful..” Adora professed, bunting her forehead against Catra's. Her blue eyes are warm and tender. The feline merely turned slightly to scoff at the praise. Feeling embarrassed by Adora's public affection.

Catra swallowed and then sighed. “Love you...” She whispered back, so only Adora could hear.

“I love you too...Forever and always...”Adora responded, then turned away. When Frosta jumped up on her chair, thrusting both fists covered in ice into the air as she regaled Mermista with the climax of her story. Catra smiled tenderly at Adora as a tear escaped her golden eye and trailed down her cheek. She quickly ducked her head and sniffled.

“You’re such a sap.” She tossed back at Adora, she was overwhelmed and needed a few moments to calm down.

Adora merely squeezed her hand as her response, picking up her wine glass and taking several deep gulps. She hummed with approval, not noticing the shocked look she was receiving from Catra.

“Slow down Princess, that's wine.” Catra leaned in and whispered against the nape of Adora's neck.

“It's good!” Adora licked her lips, guzzling the last of it. Catra groaned and shook her head, now wondering if Adora knew what alcohol was? Her first experience with alcohol had been in the Crimson Waste at the celebration party her gang held in her honor, after capturing Adora and the Sword. Getting drunk while being upset and angry was not a good combination. She didn’t remember much of that night, but Scorpia had taken care of her. The hangover the next morning was hell and she promised never to get drunk again.

As supper finished and the desserts were served, the topics turned more serious. Micah and Casta laid out the council's plans for their education. That they wanted to have the Rune Bearer's close for a while to observe and document their abilities. It had been well over a thousand years since Etheria last had Rune Bearers. Etheria's magic had been shackled for so long. They had no idea what to expect now that the magic had been freed. As it had become more powerful and far more abundant. So for now, they would be expected to attend classes like they were students of Mystacor. Learning everything from history, glyph creation, to potions, herbalism and offensive and defensive spells based on their elemental magic. All the princesses seemed eager to get started, while Scorpia looked distraught. Catra leaned forward and cast Scorpia a concerned frown. She was the last princess without powers. Her confidence and self worth had never been all that high. Having grown up thinking her Rune Stone did not want her...what might she be thinking now? Catra had helped Mermista find her powers, perhaps she could find a way to help Scorpia?

Perfuma kept leaning over and whispering discreetly into Scorpia's ear, seeking to keep her calm and reassure her. Catra noted how wet Scorpia's eyes had become, how her chest heaved and her lower lip trembled at every breath. Then her lips thinned to a narrow line as she clenched her jaw. Focusing intently on her lap. She looked close to breaking down into tears.

She wasn't the only one to notice, Perfuma was trying to cheer her up, while Frosta glanced over at her nervously. It looked like she wanted to say something but this time she didn't know what. Mermista as well had picked up on Scorpia's unease. She was lightly tapping a finger on the table top, giving Casta an agitated frown.

Catra cleared her throat, interrupting Casta's long winded speech about the benefits of a good magical education. "Ok, sounds like a plan..moving on!" She stated rudely, circling her clawed finger in the air.

Casta clamped her mouth shut and nodded, no longer oblivious to how upset Scorpia was.

Glimmer moved the conversation naturally towards the rebuilding of Mystacor, the supplies allocation from Scorpania. This engaged Scorpia on things she could be proud of, answering all Glimmer, Casta's and Micah's questions as to what her kingdom could provide. Soon Scorpia was sitting taller, her tracker pad in her pinchers, tapping down the cargo list as she answered detailed questions.

Micah then moved the topic to sending the civilian's back to their villages.

"So we will be sending sorcerer's to set up general magic schools among the larger villages, so that the people who gain magic abilities will have access to an education closer to home." Micah stated, tossing his cloth napkin to the table and sighing in delight as he popped the last morsel of a tart into his mouth.

“The village leader's will be sending petitions for supplies and material to Bright Moon, I will relay the requests to your kingdoms. If you can provide anything to help those villages rebuild it would be appreciated. Then we can start our rebuilding efforts throughout Etheria.” Micah stated. “I'll be heading back to Bright Moon Castle in the morning to oversee our Kingdom until you can return.” He nodded towards Glimmer seeking her approval.

“Thanks, Dad.” Glimmer smiled and nodded back, affirming her fathers plan.

“Well, the citizens of Scorpania are currently tearing down most of the Fright Zone. So we got a-lot of scrap that could be used elsewhere. We should have the forge, refineries and several factories up and running in the next few months. As soon as the supply lines can be cleared of debris we can start shipping material and manufacturing equipment and supplies for all of Etheria. Scorpania has the resources to start to rebuild the villages around Bright Moon as well.” Scorpia offered, still tapping away on her pad. Sending commands back to her kingdom for reallocating supplies and manpower.

“That would be wonderful.” Micah responded.

“My people along the coast have scattered into other kingdoms right now. But I would like in on those building materials and supplies as well Scorpia.” Mermista stated.

“Not a problem.” Scorpia responded. “I could send out personnel in a few days to assess the damage along the coast. Then I could send out cargo transports and material to begin the restoration efforts.”

Mermista's face lit up for the first time in weeks, as she eagerly leaned in over the table. Scorpia set her pad down between them. As their conversation grows more urgent and hopeful.

Adora folded her arms over her chest and smiled proudly towards Scorpia. “Well, that should get things on the right track. I am sure the Horde will be able to fix their relationship with the rest of Etheria if they help rebuild what they destroyed.”

Catra swiftly released her hand and moved briskly to Scorpia's side. Eager to offer her expertise to the rebuilding effort as well. Adora's hand suddenly felt cold and she sighed, bracing the elbow of her free arm on the table and cupping her chin in her hand. As she gazed fondly at the woman she loved. Admiring her with a soft smile, as Catra leaned over Scorpia's shoulder, pointing with a claw on the coastal map of Salineas currently up on her pad. Advising her on the most efficient way to survey the damaged villages and get the building materials to the coast quickly.

“If we set up a supply depot in Sea Worthy, it would cut down on transport time along the coast.” She stated, tapping her claw over the coastal city on the map.

Scorpia nodded, blushing as Catra's hot breath puffed against her ear when she spoke.

Perfuma passed her a cool, disgruntled look. As Catra was on her tiptoes behind Scorpia's chair, leaning over her carapace on her shoulder and reaching her arm over the table. Perfuma understood how eager she was to fix her mistakes. But she was practically climbing onto Scorpia's back just to reach the pad. Her body hovering far too close to Perfuma's face for her liking.

“Ok...This is great and all. But how about you three take the pad to another table while you figure this all out.” Perfuma offered, with a tight smile.

“Oh...yeah...of course...” Scorpia stuttered out, Mermista pushed her chair away from the table and pointed to the oval table in front of the main window that was currently bathed in silver moonlight.

Catra quickly backed up, walking briskly towards the front of the room. As she passed behind Adora's chair, her tail lightly brushed against the back of the blonde's neck. Adora grinned and craned her head back to look up at her as she sauntered passed. Catra took two steps past Adora's chair, casting her a sly smile, then abruptly turned, swiftly ducking around Adora's side. Snatching two caramel tarts from her plate with a teasing giggle.

“Hey!” Adora complained playfully, knowing she had been distracted by the tail so Catra could steal her sweets. With a huge, triumphant grin spreading on her face, Catra turned and jogged backwards. Smiling sweetly back at her, while taking a meaningful bite of one of her stolen tarts.

It had been a long time since Adora had witnessed her acting so relaxed and playful. An even longer time since she had seen her truly happy and content.

Her chest swelled with happiness. This is what she had wanted for Catra for years. For her to know and accept that people could honestly like having her around. That she could be loved and deserved to be happy.

Supper went on for another good hour or more before plans to head over to the Steam Grotto were made. Casta and Micah declined, heading to their rooms back at the Citadel. Bow and Entrapta declined as well, stating they still had more work to complete back at Darla. Huntara had to be convinced to go to the Steam Grotto with them. She was reluctant to go at first, until Adora piped up about how the healing waters of the hot springs had finally got her to sleep. When she had trouble, relaxing enough to sleep years earlier. That was enough to perk Huntara's interest and she was more than happy to come along then.

So now, Catra found herself trailing along with the rest of the Princess's through the moonlit gardens towards the southern caverns of Mystacor Mountain. Adora had a firm hold on her hand

as they paraded through the tall grass, along a well worn footpath, laid with flat stones. That threaded thru the rolling hills that surround this side of the mountain. Lantern’s glowed along the path, sitting in iron lamps upon the small stone altars set along the path. The path was elegant and magical, leading them at a leisurely pace up the mountain. Catra's ears swiveled as she listened to the princess's cheerful voices floating around them. Scorpia and Perfuma led the way. Catra took note of how Perfuma was always touching her pinchers. Lightly brushing the taller woman's claws with her fingertips as she spoke, blushing and then withdrawing her hand. Perfuma's excited actions were very animated and joyful as she spoke of her kingdom and her people. Scorpia was attentive and hung on every word, wistfully speaking of how she wanted to be able to talk about her own kingdom with as much pride one day. Perfuma affirmed for her that after all the help her kingdom was providing Etheria. Scorpania would be seen as a strong, loyal and proud kingdom in no time. Frosta was at the back of their group with Netossa and Spinerella, tossing an ice ball as they walked. While Huntara had gone off ahead of them, wanting to check the springs out on her own. Stating they were too loud and too energetic for her to handle. Catra kept silent wondering if any of the other princesses had figured out Huntara had been in a constant state of intoxication for days.

Catra glanced over her shoulder with an amused smile, hearing soft footsteps approaching quickly. As Glimmer jogged up behind them, the exuberant queen leaped onto their backs and wrapped her arms around each girl's shoulder. Giggling and thrusting her head between theirs, planting firm kisses to each of their cheeks.

“This is going to be so awesome!” She exclaimed, her lavender eyes shining with barely contained excitement. “I have always wanted to have a hot springs party!”

“Urgh...Sparkles...take it down a notch. It's just hot water.” Catra stated gruffly, teasing Glimmer with her sour attitude. Who rolled her eyes and teleported in a flash of shimmering light to the front of their little parade.

“At what point did this become a party?” Catra inquired in a loud whisper.

“With Glimmer...anything that involves more than two people is a party.” Adora chuckled back.

“Ahh, that explains the whole Sleepover obsession in your room for the last three years.” Catra countered.

“Yeah...well. That routine starting up was your fault.” Adora stuck her tongue out at her.

“What?” Catra stated, totally confused.

“Well....I wasn't used to sleeping by myself...thanks to you.” Adora started, her cheeks flushing.

Catra rolled her eyes and smiled, knowing where this was going.

“Hey, that was for survival....at least at the start.” She countered her own cheeks growing warm.

“Yeah...” Adora heaved a sigh, the cold season could be rather grueling in the Horde. The barracks were barely heated, when they were small the cadets would bunk together at night to keep warm. As they got older and bigger the cold didn't bother them as much. She quickly brushed off the bad memory. Though Catra's sleepovers in her bunk never truly stopped. “You always made the bad stuff better. I am so grateful I had you growing up.” She ducked into Catra's side and gave her a quick kiss on the temple. Needing affection to soothe the sudden awful feelings those bleak memories brought on.

“So how were they?...as bunkmates, I mean.” The feline nudged her with her hip.

“Poor substitutes, honestly.” Adora responded, releasing Catra's hand and dancing behind her. She wrapped her arms around her middle and lifted her into the air. Catra yelped and started laughing. As Adora never broke stride, confident in her physical

strength. She carried Catra as if she weighed nothing, nuzzling her face into Catra's warm neck from behind with an approving hum.

“Nothing can compare to snuggling with my warm, fuzzy, Bestfriend.” She whispered huskily, kissing the arch of Catra's neck and rubbing her face down her nape.

“Put me down, you idiot, before you trip and we both get hurt.” Catra chastised, her voice high and anxious.

“Fine...you are no fun.” Adora pouted, setting her down. But quickly reclaiming her hand in hers.

“I'm fun!” Catra shot back, sticking out her tongue. “I just don't want either of us to get hurt...I want to arrive at this fur destroying bath in one piece.” She grumbled.

“I know you don't like soaking in water, but the healing properties of the springs will help with all your bruises.” Adora offered with a fond smile.

“My fur does not do well when it gets waterlogged.” Catra sighed in dismay. Once she got out of the water and her fur dried, it would puff up and curl as always. Surrounded by these princesses who were so, kind, compassionate and understanding to one another. She figured they would not be cruel when her fur went all wild and crazy. Perfuma might offer to help try and tame her fur. Scorpia would want to spend hours combing her, but that would be Adora's responsibility. Glimmer though, she might give her a hard time. But it would be all in fun, fully expecting Catra to retaliate later.

Catra glanced sideways towards Mermista who had strode up beside them.

“I never got the chance...but...thank you. Catra. For everything. ” She regarded her with her first friendly smile.

“No problem...” Catra smiled back, her cheeks flaring. “Are we good...” She whispered thickly, hoping that she could finally put Mermista into her friend column.

“With you now helping me rebuild Salineas, we are more than good. Kitty.” She grinned, wrapping a strong arm around Catra's shoulder and pulling her in for a quick side hug.

The sweet warmth of acceptance and forgiveness spread through Catra's chest, her weak smile now spreading into a happy grin.

“Awwww....” Adora crooned, her eyes shimmering with tears of joy. About to spout about how cute they were acting.

“Stop....do not even...” Mermista shook a warning finger at her, silencing Adora's sugary sweet comment about their blossoming friendship.

Catra couldn’t help but laugh, as Adora clamped her mouth shut. Pouting dramatically at Mermista for spoiling her fun. Catra gave the sea princess an approving smirk, she was really starting to like Mermista.

The moss covered footpath slowly inclined up the side of the mountain, the flat stone now turning into large, worn, stone steps. That led them upward into the foothills, as they moved deeper into the mountain. The steps and plateaus, became slowly enshrouded with the ghostly trunks of elm trees. Small, quaint resting areas greeted them as they climbed. With stone benches, roughly cut into the granite of the mountain. With small alter’s, carved from similar stone. With simple statues, depicting the various animals, that could be found upon Etheria. Each animal blazed softly with a light glyph glowing deep inside. Casting a soft illumination upon the moonlit path, making the trek upward through the dense forest easier. The path was elegant and tranquil, leading them at a gentle pace towards the peak. The moons cast their somber light down upon the troop of princesses,

bathing them a gentle silvery light. As they wove out of the forest, along a cliffs edge for a time, before the path led back into the trees.

Climbing higher, the trees became thicker, darker. With the lush green needles of spruce and fir. Ascending slowly towards a large, flat plateau of manicured grass near the peak. The path of stepping stones turned into a finely laid, cobblestone walkway that led up to a grand, ornately carved building of white stone and slate roofs. The many angles and peaks jutted from the side of the rough hewn stone of the mountain. Ornately carved wooden beams and pillars decorated the front entrance, with huge bay windows on either side. The warm glow from inside welcoming them. It reminded Catra of the old inn they had stayed at back in Erelandia.

Two large, heavy oak doors dominated the front of the short entrance way. Glimmer cheerfully held one open, as the princess filed inside. Catra cast Adora a nervous glance, squeezing her hand as they proceeded inside.

The front entrance was huge, warmly lit by several fire glyphs etched onto the granite floor. The girls hummed in pleasure as their cold bodies began to warm. The cool season was just setting in and the nights were starting to take on a chill. As they moved into the large front room. Crossing beneath a thick wooden beam and pillar archway. The girls were chatting excitedly, taking in the soft opulence of the main resting area. Huge pillows were scattered around the room with small iron tables set between. The walls were a plain white clay, with ornate carvings of hybrids and elemental glyphs. This time the hybrids were dressed in plain clothes, going about simple daily tasks.

“This was built at the same time as the Cathedral?” Catra whispered against Adora's shoulder.

Adora had never paid much attention to the architecture the first time. Her body was so exhausted and tense, her mind all jumbled. Thanks to Shadow Weaver tormenting her for days with Shadow

Spies. Now she was taking her time. Moving with interest towards a back wall, as the elaborate mural has drawn her interest. Catra followed her, staring at the various smaller murals along the walls as she went.

“This looks very much like the symbol on She-Ra's chest armor?” Adora stated in a hushed voice. Her fingers lightly tracing an eight pointed star with a rune stone in the middle.

Catra nodded, pointing out the rune glyphs that surrounded it, once again forming a three pointed knot.

“The elemental glyphs surrounding She-Ra. In a triquetra knot. What does that mean?” Catra mused.

They never got the chance to discuss the murals in more detail as two attendants breezed into the room.

Both were female Thaymorian's, dressed in simple white robes with a wide, bright green sash tied around their waists. Both had soft tan fur and short, delicate horns. A lithe figure and gentle fine boned features of a Deer Hybrid.

“Good evening, we shall escort you back to the showers, so you may wash away the grim of the day. Before entering into our healing waters.” The taller of the two, waved an arm behind her. Her smile was warm and polite.

“We have to take a shower before we can take a bath...” Catra muttered bitterly.

“Yeah, it's a whole ritual thing but it will feel great, I promise.” Adora grinned, folding her hand with Catra's. Pulling her gently after the princess's down a long hallway, the walls adorned with dark red and blue tapestries.

“Can't wait...” Catra grit her teeth, starting to regret agreeing to this. Her fur was going to feel soggy and disgusting all night.

The attendants led them into a brightly lit room. One side of the room held a wall of wooden cubbies, with a wicker basket inside that held a crisp white towel. The back of the room was just bare stone with wooden stools and buckets. Wide wooden spouts were embedded into the stonewall at measured intervals, so that the water was cascading out like mini waterfalls. The floor was slightly tilted so that the water ran towards the back corner and drained away.

Catra was reluctant to enter the room, lingering nervously at the front doorway. Watching as the other princesses, started to undress before the cubbies. Tucking their clothes into the baskets and setting the towel down in the cubie, beside the basket for later. Then proceeding into the back completely naked. She stood there eyes wide and mouth hanging open in surprise and horror at how easy and uninhibited the princesses were with each other.

Adora chuckled, leaning against the doorframe and glancing over to Catra with an amused smile.

“Think of it like the group showers back at the barracks.” She offered.

“I grew up with those girls....they were used to seeing my naked, furry ass.” Catra cut her a heated glare.

“You do have the cutest furry ass.” Adora whispered, low and sultry into the shell of Catra's ear.

Who instantly shivered at her teasing. That familiar warmth of arousal, blooming in the core of her body.

“Com'on Catra...it will be fine. I promise.” Adora laughed, grabbing her hands and leading her into the room.

Catra groaned, but allowed Adora to pull her to the cubbies. Soon Adora had her sitting naked on a wooden stool, as she sat on a stool beside her. Catra was scared to look around at first, facing the stone wall in front of her. Laser focused on the water cascading down the surface from the wide, wooden spout above,

near the top of the wall. The laughter and hushed conversations surrounding her did little to ease her nerves. Sneaking a glance at Adora, she found the blonde scrubbing her body with a lathered sponge.

“So we have to wash our bodies first. Then what?” Catra asked, glancing down at her bucket finding the soapy sponge in one and the other held just clear water. She sighed and picked up the sponge, beginning to lather up her fur on her stomach.

“Then we head into the side room there.” Adora's voice trailed off.

Catra shot her eyes up, tracing the direction of her gaze to the other side of the room. Finding the nude Adonis, that was Huntara, striding leisurely down the small hallway, with her towel slung over one shoulder. Having just finished washing. Every part of her was hard and toned, her muscles rippling and tensing as she walked. She seemed to have no shame at all, her long platinum blonde hair was loose and swinging across her bare bottom. Drawing attention to her firm, well sculpted ass.

“Breathe, Adora.” Catra gave her shin a sharp kick.

“Ahhhhh....” Adora sucked in a breath... “So many muscles...”

“You got a bit of drool there.” Catra lightly tapped her chin. Her words may have been playful, but her eyes were cool. Hiding behind a mask of indifference about how hurt she was, witnessing Adora's obvious approval of Huntara's body. Made her feel uncertain about herself and her own appeal, yet again. She quickly squashed those insecurities. Knowing that Adora loved her, was attracted to her. She had literally proved it this morning while they were fooling around. But it still hurt to see her so enamored by another woman.

“I envy her. ” Adora sighed. “She has such a strong and powerful body naturally. I have to turn into She-Ra to look like that.” Her voice was low and thick with jealousy.

“That's why you gawk at her?” Catra laughed, as Adora continued look longingly after Huntara.

“You are such an idiot.” She shook her head in disbelief. Adora merely shrugged, lowering her chin to brood upon the floor.

“You have a gorgeous body...” Catra reminded her. Lightly touching Adora's toned, muscular forearm for emphasis. Adora offered her a small, weak smile of gratitude.

“Would you really want to be She-Ra all the time?” Catra teased.

Adora was quiet for a long time, as she thought it over. Catra had spoken in jest, the fact that Adora was thinking about it honestly as if it was a viable option. It truly frightened Catra. Who's teasing smile quickly fell into a concerned frown.

“Honestly, after my last attempt to summon her. I'm rather scared of my powers.” Adora admitted, staring forlorn down at the stone floor. Her fingertips gripping the sides of her stool so fiercely they had gone pale white.

“Adora...” Catra breathed, now understanding why Adora had worked herself into the ground today instead of transforming into She-Ra.

“It's not just that...I want to be more like Huntara.” Adora whined. (And less like me..) She finished quietly in her head. “She's so confident, charming and witty. I mean, I wish I could be that smooth around you...when we're fooling around. I just feel awkward and clumsy....about everything.”

Catra was stunned, she had never thought Adora could be insecure about anything. She always seemed so assured in herself and her abilities, coming off as almost arrogant. To know it was all just a front, to keep up appearances. It eased her own worries about not knowing how to be intimate, how to love Adora properly. That they were on equal ground for once, discovering love together.

Catra sighed, as a warm honest smile spread over her lips.

“Hey, Dummy.” Catra flicked her in the earlobe, needing to get her full attention. “I'm no expert at this stuff either. But I never fell in love with She-Ra and I certainly am not attracted to Huntara. So thank the celestial moons you don't look or act like either of them.” Catra, rolled her eyes and scoffed. Then tenderly reached over and rubbed Adora's knee. Adora turned, her blue eyes wet. Beseeching Catra to reassure her that she was not failing at loving her.

“I have always loved...Adora. My Adora. Who is my silly, stubborn, awkward, best friend? Who can never just relax and just roll with things. A girl who snorts when she laughs too hard, can't lie to save her life, always wears her heart on her sleeve and never gives up no matter how bleak things look...She is a truly beautiful woman inside and out. “ Catra moved swiftly to kneel before her and cupped her cheek tenderly with a hand. Adora sniffled and gave her a watery smile. Her honest confession soothed her worry’s and self doubts.

“Stop worrying so much about things.” Catra leaned up on her knees, pressing a sweet, tender kiss on Adora's lips.

“But...” Adora blurted, Catra sealed her coming statement with another more forceful kiss. Adora grinned, as Catra bunted her forehead against hers. Staring meaningfully into her warm blue eyes. Her own gorgeous mismatched eyes shimmering with devotion.

“But...Catra? ” Adora started again, only for Catra to sigh and cover her lips with hers yet again. This time her kiss lingered, against Adora's lips. As her hands left her jaw, her fingers combed into the long blonde hair at the back of her head. Holding her hair firmly, as she devoured her lips in a heated, urgent kiss.

As soon as she pulled away, her cheeks flushed.

Adora smirked, “But...” She giggled, turning it into a game and seeking another kiss.

Catra laughed and huffed, slamming her lips against hers yet again.

“Seriously, you two...” Glimmer's irritated voice echoed through the washing room.

Both girls pulled away instantly, laughing nervously as they had been so caught up with each other. Neither had thought much about the very passionate display of affection they were just showcasing to all their friends.

Catra ducked her head timidly, her arms dropping down to her sides. Her face now even more red than before. While Adora chuckled, glancing bashfully around the room. Finding thankfully that most of the other princesses had already left. Glimmer was waiting for them at the entrance to the short hall to the next room. Leaving just Netossa and Spinnerella smiling fondly at them, holding each other's hands. The older women had been headed towards the next room as well, but stopped to observe their sweet moment from a discrete distance.

“You guys are so cute.” Netossa cooed, pulling Spinerella close. “Do you remember when we were like that?”

“Yes, dear. That was this morning.” Sprinerella answered with a meaningful smile.

Netossa threw her head back and laughed. “Perhaps we can revisit those moments again tonight.”

“The honeymoon phase is always so endearing so watch.” Spinerella leaned her head against Netossa's shoulder as they proceeded down the hall.

Adora turned back to Catra. “Honeymoon...What does that mean?”

Catra just shrugged and shook her head.

Suddenly Adora figured her plan to emulate Huntara in her relationship with Catra had been all wrong. Perhaps she should be more like Netossa...or Spinerella. Perhaps they were better mentors, for a happy, healthy relationship.

“Alright, lovebirds. Let's get going.” Glimmer prodded, gently. Leaning her shoulder against the stone entrance way.

Both Catra and Adora nodded, holding hands and standing up.

“We're coming, Sparkles. Jeez.” Catra called, quickly washing the soap off her fur by pouring the bucket of clear water over her body and ducking under the Waterwall. While Adora did the same.

The next phase of their Steam Grotto adventure was even more out of Catra's comfort zone. She was now standing, nude. Arms raised and legs splayed before a different attendant, who was from Plumeria. Her golden hair plaited with flowers down her back, wearing the simple white robes and green sash as their first attendants. Her nimble fingers wrapping a subtly scented lavender cloth around her bruised wrists, upper arms, thighs and torso. Adora and Glimmer stood before other attendants nearby who were wrapping up their nude bodies in a different pattern. Each girl's cloth held a different soft scent, Adora's was sweet, while Glimmer's smelled more spicy. It seemed the pattern and scent was dependent on what healing was needed.

Nervous and trying to stay as still as possible, Catra glanced around the dimly lit stone chamber. Finding a similar eight pointed star etched into the stone over their heads.

“Adora, look up.” She instructed.

Adora did as she was told, with Glimmer following her gaze upward as well.

“What's up?” The Queen asked.

“Have you been to the Basilica?” Catra asked.

“Yeah. Numerous times over the years, why?” Glimmer responded.

Catra snapped her gaze towards her in surprise. “You never questioned why your mother had a sculpture there from a thousand years ago?”

“No, not really. She was an Immortal Queen it made sense to me that she would have been alive back then.” Glimmer shrugged.

“The carvings here at the Grotto are very similar to the carvings at the Basilica.” Adora kept them on track.

“Ahhh, well, yeah. These springs were said to have been created by She-Ra herself.” Glimmer nodded.

“How...wasn't Mara already dead? When the survivor’s of the war started to build on the remains of Arxia?” Adora asked.

“I don't know...they're just stories. ” Glimmer shrugged, as her attendant finished wrapping up her breasts. Rolling the cloth around her neck and tucking the end of it into the crevasse between her breasts.

Adora heaved a great sigh, as her own attendant slowly gathered her bucket of left over cloth and stood up.

“I get it...I think...” Catra muttered under her breath. Her mind spinning over theories and scenarios of how Etheria’s last days had gone, before being thrown into Despondos.

“There is so much I don't know about my powers, about She-Ra...” Adora, groaned in dismay.

“She-Ra is the planet, Adora.” Catra, offered, she had hoped Adora would figure it out on her own. But she promised to tell her

if she didn't. “At least that's what I think, Ouroboros told me, last time we talked." She shrugged then muttered to herself.

"Maybe the story is a metaphor for the magic used to create the healing springs?” Slowly working out her thoughts, putting the pieces together.

“I'm a planet.” Adora blurted out with a blank, dead panned expression.

“I don't know....that's what I think he said anyway. Your power comes from the heart and the heart is the source of all magic here on Etheria...so yeah...your the planet.” Catra groaned, all her thoughts now derailed by Adora's outburst. “Baby steps, okay. Let's learn about how magic works first, then maybe we'll get some leads as to where to go next for more of your answers.” She offered, with a sigh.

“If I'm the planet...then where does your magic come from?” Adora grumbled.

“The sun!” Glimmer offered, in a loud burst of inspiration.

“Makes sense...and yours comes from the Moons” Catra shot back...”Cause your Runestone was the Moonstone.”

“There are like twelve moons circling Etheria...Catra...” Glimmer shot back, her eyes wide with trepidation. “That's like....a lot of magic moons...” She breathed in terror at how much magic power she might lay claim to.

“Ok...well there were like thirteen alcoves of elemental Rune Bearers back at the Basilica.” Adora offered, “Some in the entrance, some in the crossing and some in the vestibule. Maybe the moons are linked to twelve types of magic on Etheria.”

“Makes sense.” Catra stated, while Glimmer nodded.

“My magical education thus far is pretty sketchy. But we'll figure it all out.” Glimmer sighed, refusing to say Shadow Weaver's name

in Adora and Catra's presence. “Don't get discouraged, Adora.” Glimmer offered, patting her shoulder.

Adora nodded, taking a deep breath. Light Hope was gone, but her spirit seemed more than willing to answer her questions now. How a hologram managed to have a spirit...was just another question that needed answering. As long as Light Hope kept coming to speak to her in her dreams...so her finding out the truth about She-Ra was as uncertain as it always was.

“The Crystal Castle...” She exclaimed, as they were heading down the last hall towards the grotto. Catra’s ears folded back. As Adora’s voice echoed painfully off the rough stone cavern they were walking through.

“I want to go back there, as soon as I can. I kinda broke the interface, when I killed Light Hope and destroyed the sword. So I can’t verbally ask it any questions anymore. But that was where the First Ones trained Mara....perhaps Entrapta can hack into its systems and download all the information it has on She-Ra.” She was excited now, her voice high pitched and speaking rapidly.

“Ok...once we get back from our little camping trip with Lonnie and the gang.” Catra bumped her shoulder with a smirk.

“Right....” Adora sighed, rubbing her nose. She completely forgot about their promise and had been making plans to travel to the Castle instead.

“I could teleport you guys to the Memorial and you could cut down your travel time.” Glimmer offered.

“No...we have a tradition. We only did it once, before I found the sword and things changed.” Adora slipped her hand into Catra's, needing to ground herself from being swept away into grim memories.

“It's important we travel together along the same route as the first time.” Catra squeezed her hand in acknowledgment. “It’s a bonding thing.” Catra shrugged, as Adora nodded.

“Ok.” Glimmer responded, her voice small. She wasn't disappointed, but knowing just that little bit more. Of how brutal her friend's childhood had been, it hurt her heart.

“But if you could blink us to the Fright Zone tomorrow morning, that would be great!” Adora asked, wanting Glimmer to know she was needed.

Catra groaned and hung her head in defeat. As Glimmer beamed and nodded.

A Crimson Reckoning

As they approached the mouth to the grotto, a blast of hot air greeted them. Making the temperature in the rugged cave they were leaving, cold by comparison. Catra instantly felt a shiver cascade down her body. Hunching her shoulders and growling softly, she did not like feeling cold! Adora led her into a vast cavern, filled with steaming pools of lightly fragrant water. Catra sniffed the air tentatively, wrinkling her nose in disgust at first. The sulphur was thick in the air, giving the cavern a thick musky overtone. What looked like natural crystal formations were jutting out of the walls, glowing a soft white. The intensity of their light was dependent on the size and shape of their clusters. Illuminating the walls of the cavern in a gentle, comforting glow. A huge natural skylight dominated the center of the roof. That was a weathered hole in the top of the cavern. It offered the bathers beneath. A glorious view of the blanket of stars overhead. One of Etheria's greater moons was already rising over the rim of the skylight, casting its silver glow over the clear pools below.

“This place is....kinda beautiful.” Catra whispered, her gaze slowly crossing the huge, ethereal cavern. She was filled with a silent reverence, sensing the ancient power, still humming within every facet of this hidden cave.

“It really is, I didn't get to enjoy my time here last time. Since Shadow Weaver was tormenting me with Shadow spies. “ Adora sighed, bitterly

“She was rather obsessed with getting you back at the time.” Catra responded quietly, as Adora led her by the hand towards a larger pool beneath the skylight. At the time Catra had felt her worth was being overshadowed by Adora’s even from afar. Which only amplified her bitterness and resentment towards her. Now years later she found herself rather apathetic towards those memories.

“That woman was a nasty piece of work...honestly.” Adora spat, she couldn't quite contain the venom and hatred she still felt and it seeped out in her tone.

“Yeah, but she did do one good thing.” Catra squeezed her hand. Coaxing her to speak more about their late mother, needing to know if she was ready to work through some on her own issues. Seeking to find the courage to confess how she had found a strange sort of connection with Shadow Weaver. Since they had both been corrupted by the same dark magic.

“Yeah...dying!” Adora growled back. The vitriol of her seething hatred, thick in her voice.

Catra sucked in a startled breath, swallowing her nerve. Knowing Adora was still not ready to discuss such topics. She did not want to taint Adora’s view of her, by comparing herself to Shadow Weaver. She wasn’t ready to take that risk. Adora's hatred and anger at Shadow Weaver had been very apparent during the rebellion's last days. Catra had missed that shared contempt they had for the sorceress during their time in the rebellion. For the most part it had always been them versus Shadow Weaver, growing up. Adora had never been as rebellious or insolent as Catra. Seeking to redirect her need for retaliation towards working out with her in the gym or exploring the Fright Zone. Smoothing over her volatile outbursts with Shadow Weaver so that she wouldn't be punished. Creating an insufferable dynamic, of Shadow Weaver controlling Adora by threatening to punish Catra. Who in turn sought to control Catra, through guilt and long winded speeches about how she had to stop antagonizing their Guardian. Leaving Catra feeling powerless and trapped in an endless cycle of striving and failing to appease either of them. Adora instincts were to protect, while Catra's was to fight back. Now that she knew their bond of shared suffering, their loathing for the sorceress. Was just one more manipulation Shadow Weaver had created. To shape who they would become in the future. To create a Shield and a Sword to protect Etheria...seeking to mold weapons from living flesh. It left a bitter taste in her mouth.

It was startling but Adoras hatred ran deeper than Catra's. Even though Shadow Weaver had abandoned her for Adora it earned her nothing. Adora had remained loyal to Catra even then. She offered Shadow Weaver nothing but the minimum of polite interactions over the years at Bright Moon. Her vocal disapproval of the woman being in the castle when she first arrived. Her silent disdain and obvious disregard of her presence as the years went on. Adora had punished Shadow Weaver in the ways she knew would hurt the most. Shunning her, discrediting her, showing her that she has no power over her anymore.

While Catra had come to accept the darkness that had consumed Shadow Weaver. Understanding it in a way, since they had both been corrupted by the Nameless One. And then purged of that darkness by She-Ra’s power. She wanted to talk to Adora about Shadow Weaver. Reveal to her the harsh truths about their guardian. That perhaps she wasn't evil, at least not a first. That she had merely overreached for the sake of the greater good and paid the ultimate price for it. That she had struggled every day not to give into that parasitic darkness. That had seeded itself inside her soul, slowly draining her life force and twisting her mind. Seducing her to give into her more toxic nature for power and control.

Catra sighed heavily, she hated that she could understand Shadow Weaver's pain. That she had allowed that same darkness to devour her in the portal. Twisting her into a vengeful monster, hell bent on destroying Adora. Their guardian had been flawed, as all Etherian's were. She knew better than most how one's flaws could drive one to make very bad decisions. She had come to terms with Shadow Weavers abuse and really wanted to talk things out with Adora but not until she could listen without bias. Otherwise she would not be able to move past what the woman had done to them as kids. She wanted Adora to find the same peace she had after her conversation with Shadow Weaver.

In time perhaps...

The low rumble of snoring drew her attention, as it vibrated in her ears. Catra turned her head, her ears twitching. Finding Huntara sprawled out in a smaller pool of steaming water, no bigger than a tub. Her long, powerful legs dangled over the rocky rim on one side, while her huge muscular arms were hooked over the rim on the front. Her head braced over the front rim, mouth hanging open and snoring deeply. Her long silver hair was loose and hung around her face like a damp curtain, the thin strands floating in the water around her shoulders.

“I fell asleep like that last time too.” Adora nudged her with her shoulder. A dopey grin on her face.

“Figures.” Catra smirked, as Glimmer exclaimed happily a few pools away. Slowly climbing into the hot water with a yelp followed by a languid sigh, as she slowly submerged herself.

Adora climbed in carefully after Glimmer, offering Catra both of her hands to help her ease into the water. Catra shook her head briskly, she perched herself on the edge of the pool. Uneasy about entering the water.

“I gotta do this on my own terms. Princess.” Catra groaned, nervously poking just a big toe into the water.

“Seriously, Kitty. Don't be a wuss!” Mermista strolled past their pool, flicking her hand at the water. A huge wave of hot water rose up and crashed against Catra's side of the pool. Splashing her whole front, soaking her from head to toes.

Catra hissed, her tail shooting straight out and bristled to twice its size.

“Oh, it's on now!” Catra called, dripping and glaring at Mermista's back. As the Salinea’s Princess strolled smugly away, laughing brightly.

“You better sleep with one eye open, cause payback is coming!” Catra shouted, even more irritated at being ignored.

“Looking forward to it! Kitty!” Mermista turned and smirked cockily back at her.

Catra looked down at her soggy front with a resigned sigh, she had no choice now. If she stayed hovering on the rim then she would catch a chill. With a long suffering groan she lightly slipped into the hot water. Humming and moaning as the scalding water soaked into her thin layer of fur.

“Come, here.” Adora called sweetly, raising a dripping arm from the water. She had settled herself against the far side. While Glimmer sat on the other side, watching her quietly. Catra slowly eased herself deeper into the soothing water. Wading over to Adora, who was giving her a warm, happy smile. As Catra leaned against her side with a lazy moan. She easily found her preferred nook, as she snuggled against her. Tucking her head into the crook of Adora's neck just under her chin. Wrapping an arm loosely around Adora's chest and draping a leg over the blonde's lap.

“Feels nice?” Adora gave her a goofy, lopsided smile that spoke of happy contentment.

“Yeah...” Catra breathed, snuggling in with a soft sigh. As every muscle, every ache and pain simply disappeared. She leaned her head back against Adora's shoulder, as the blonde wrapped her arms loosely around her waist.

“Wish. I had a snuggle buddy...” Glimmer pouted. “I miss Bow.”

"Come here then, Sparkles." Catra laughed softly and leaned over the middle of the pool. Not even thinking about her sudden affectionate actions. It was instinct, she wanted to make one of her trusted friends feel wanted. So she grabbed Glimmer's wrists with both her hands and pulled her across the pool.

Glimmer squeaked in surprise at first, since she had her eyes closed when Catra had suddenly grabbed her. She smiled fondly up at the magicat, as she was pulled gently across the water.

Catra had been an enigma at first. Seeking out her companionship back on Primes ship often, heedless of the punishments she might receive for disobeying. Their interactions were stiff and awkward at first, usually ending with Catra's snarking some mean comment at her before retreating. Catra was naturally distrustful of others and hid her true feelings behind walls of casual disinterest or verbal jabs. She would never open up or show vulnerability to anyone at first, never wanting to be hurt again. Their tentative friendship that had started on Primes ship, flourished into something deeper while they traveled home on Darla. She had tempered her anger, seeking to learn from them how to become a better friend. Still guarded and unsure how to interact with them. She had never returned any of her or Bows friendly hugs, or teasing kisses on the cheek. She had been reluctant to even compliment them. By the time they had freed Etheria, enduring many battles together in the rebellion. Always growing closer and more comfortable, as they continued to bond each night by the light of the fire glyph. Their friendship seemed as warm and solid as her relationship with Adora. Catra had been distant and aloof with her for days since the swamp and she thought she would never be able to reclaim that trust again. So this sudden initiation of affection from her was a big step! Glimmer's heart thundered in her ears, her eyes shimmering with gratitude and relief. As Catra raised an arm as she floated closer, inviting her to snuggle in.

Glimmer giggled and easily found a comfortable nook against Catra's side, as the hybrid held her close. A soft, gentle purr rumbling from deep in her chest.

The Queen sighed as she settled in, leaning her head against Catra's shoulder. Their friendship was restored and it seemed Catra was finally showing her the same level of trust and affection she showed only to Adora. Glimmer was so relieved that she hadn't ruined their friendship. She smiled softly as she leaned against Catra. Keeping her excitement hidden beneath a calm, relaxed visage not wanting to spook the magicat. Worried if she made a big deal about it, Catre would become reserved with her affection in the future. Catra did not like drawing attention to herself or overly mushy reactions when she showed kindness.

“You are surprisingly very soft and cozy.” Glimmer mumbled, her voice barely a whisper as the soothing warmth of the water soaked deep into her muscles. Lulled her into a barely lucid state. She couldn't have asked for a more perfect night, being surrounded by her most cherished companions at the Grotto.

A loud, contented purr began to rumble through the cavern, as Catra smiled dreamily up at the stars. The soothing vibrations of her purr affected everyone in the Grotto. Mermista sighed happily, lounging in her pool, her mermaid's tail swishing lazily under the water. As her mind eased into a tranquil state of euphoria. Scorpia leaned against the side of her pool, one arm draped over Perfuma who was snuggling against her dozing peacefully. Frosta had been splashing in the hot spring she shared with Spinnerella and Netossa. But quickly calmed down, floating on her back staring up at the stars enjoying the rumbling echo. Spinneralla and Netossa sat peacefully, eyes closed resting their heads together with blissful smiles. A faint healing aura began to hum around the grotto, as the princess's magic began to synchronize.

“What do you think we are going to find out there...when we go to space?” Glimmer asked, leaning heavily against the magicat with her head resting on her shoulder. She followed Catra's gaze upward to the stars.

“A crushing void...that wants to kill us. ” Catra snarked.

“**Adventure!**” Sea Hawks voice boomed out through the cavern, echoing like thunder.

Catra hissed and nearly leaped out of the water. As both Adora and Glimmer jerked away in alarm. All the languid effects of the water now rudely cast away.

They watched as Sea Hawk swaggered through the Grotto, scanning for Mermista. He had gone through the same process as everyone else, his nude body wrapped in scented cloth. Once he

had found the Salinean Princess he ran full speed for her hot spring and cannon balled into the water.

“What the hell!” Mermista screamed, as she was suddenly soaked in a cascade of hot water.

When Sea Hawk resurfaced, she merely pushed his head back under water with a disgruntled sneer.

Catra was cackling loudly, thoroughly enjoying the show of Mermista getting soaked.

Mermista flipped her a very rude Salinean hand gesture, which only made Catra laugh harder.

“Did Sea Hawk just get here, or has he been here the whole time and I never noticed?” Adora questioned.

“I have no idea, but if Mermista doesn't let him up in a few seconds she's going to drown the moron.” Glimmer was gripping the rim of their pool prepared to jump out and go to the pirates aid, as Mermista finally snapped her hand up allowing Sea Hawk to resurface. The man sprang from the water like a cresting dolphin, gasping for air. They watched Sea Hawk beseech Mermista for forgiveness, offering her excuses about being excited to see her after being apart for so long. Mermista merely folded her arms and scowled at him. With her temper starting to cool, Sea Hawk sat beside her in the hot springs. Yawning and stretching his arms over his head, slowly snaking one arm around her shoulders. Mermista huffed and rolled her eyes at his overly dramatic gesture to hold her, but also didn't move away or push his arm off. In time everyone settled back into their pools and quiet conversations.

“Well going to space is still a few months away at least.” Adora sighed, settling back down into the water. Glimmer easily snuggled up against Catra. As Catra resumed resting her head against Adora's shoulder, enjoying how the blonde slipped her

arms back around her waist. Her fingers splayed over her stomach.

“Darla’s going to need some repairs, maybe a few upgrades. The ancient rust bucket breaking down every other day, got really old, really fast..” Catra heaved a long, suffering sigh.

“I hope Entrapta comes with us...otherwise. Bow is going to be an absolute nightmare to deal with. ” Glimmer stated.

“Yeah, he can get a little uptight when Darla breaks down.” Adora stated, bitterly.

“We found you duct taped to the command chair....the last time you tried to help fix the ship on your own.” Catra reminded her.

“I was handling things just fine...but Bow can get really scary sometimes...so I let him tie me up.” Adora defended herself, pouting just a little. Bow had found her once again duct taping all the wires in the control panel after they exploded out and went absolutely unhinged. Adora was alarmed at how surprisingly strong he was now. Since he had started joining her in her strength and endurance training back at Bright Moon for the last few years. It had taken a bit of a struggle for him to subdue her. But rage and fear gave him the strength to confine her to the Command chair. So he could deal with the mess she had made of the wiring.

That was when Glimmer and Catra had found her. Wrists and legs taped up tight, a strip of tape across her mouth to shut her up.

‘Because Bow needed to concentrate!’

Glimmer had been shocked and gave Bow hell for tying her up. While Catra just laughed and rolled on the floor with glee at her predicament. Listening to Adora grumble incoherently and glare indignantly at her.

That trip had given them all time to reconnect, to forgive and harass one another like only best friends could. Entrapta's genius

and ingenuity had gotten them through some major pinches on the way home.

“I hope she comes...there could be so much more tech out there for her to explore.” Adora offered.

“It might get her mind off Hordak.” Glimmer stated.

“I am sure that her new, creepy robo-Hordak will be on board.” Catra cringed and shivered.

“Well, it just wouldn't be right to go on a space adventure without a clone.” Glimmer nodded.

Catra cast her a disgruntled grimace, while Adora nodded and laughed. As they naturally went into very humorous stories about Wrong Hordak. The clone had known very little about life beyond the Hive. It had been like raising a toddler then. He was so curious and clueless about everything. Sometimes his exploration of being independent turned out cute and rather harmless, other times not so much. Thankfully never life threatening, but he had caused them some rather unfortunate delays along the way.

The relaxing atmosphere of quiet conversations was suddenly shattered, as Huntara screamed and thrashed violently. Adora was in motion in seconds, climbing out of their pool and racing to Huntara's side.

“No....” Huntara grunted, her massive arm waving in front of her face as if defending herself from an attack. “Get away...” she moaned, rolling onto her front and pulling herself up on trembling arms. The days of alcohol, lack of sleep, mixed with the cleansing warmth of the hot spring. Had pulled her down into such a deep sleep. She was now struggling to regain consciousness, barely lucid and unable to keep her balance. She tumbled backward, submerging herself into the middle of her pool with a sharp cry of alarm.

“Huntara!” Adora cried, climbing into the water without a second thought. Reaching under the surface and pulling the warrior up by grasping her under her arms. “Its ok...I got you.” Adora reassured her, bracing Huntara's upper body against her chest with her hands under Huntara's arm pits.

Huntara blinked a couple times, sputtering and then groaned in humiliation.

“Awww, hell....” She sighed, as she moved clumsily to her feet. “Thanks, Blondie.” she mumbled, climbing out of the pool and shuffling out of the grotto.

Adora watched her go, her expression pensive, her eyes wet with worry.

“She isn't doing very well.” Adora turned to find, both Glimmer and Catra standing around Huntara's pool. Glimmer was curling and uncurling her fingers near her thighs, she was nervous and anxious about what happened and didn't know how to proceed. She wasn't that close to Huntara and felt out of place offering her emotional support.

“Cause she's drunk.” Catra stated in a clipped tone, crossing her arms over her chest. Her whole body was soaked, the hot water dripping off her fur and forming a puddle at her bare feet.

“That's not like her at all.” Glimmer offered, casting the entrance to the grotto a concerned look.

“Well, I think she got chipped.” Catra offered softly, ducking her head and rubbing at the scar on her neck nervously. As a cold shiver ran down her body, her tail puffing up slightly. Grinding her teeth, she resisted the urge to shake the water from her fur. She hated being wet...and then cold and the bad memories of being chipped herself wasn't great either.

Both Adora and Glimmer sucked in a cold breath, casting sympathetic looks towards the entrance. Catra sighed and thinned her lips, neither one of them truly understood how helpless and

terrifying being chipped was. The complete loss of all control of themselves, forced to be Primes puppet. Being trapped inside that white world, knowing your body was moving against your will, you voice speaking things you would never say. Unable to fight back or scream or do anything but sit in your cell created by Prime's light. As Prime invaded your very soul, invading every memory, every emotion, every thought. Dismantling all that you are and remaking you in his image. Making you hurt the one you loved, making you torment them...forcing them to watch you throw yourself to your own death...

She glanced sideways, finding Spinnerlla, Mermista and Scorpia standing up in their pools. Eyes cast downward with shame and anxiety, also rubbing the back of their necks. As they had overheard their conversation about being chipped. Catra growled, she hated seeing that echo of fear and trauma in the eyes of her friends. What Prime did to them...to her...it was unforgivable.

“Good riddance...” She hissed.

“I'm going to go talk to her.” Adora scrambled out of the pool and rushed out of the Grotto before Catra could say anything to stop her.

As Adora rushed into the changing room, she found Huntara already dressed in her black crop top and shorts. She was sitting on a wooden stool, pulling up her hide boots. Her dark vest was still crumpled in the basket, set on the floor by the stool.

“Huntara.” Adora called softly, approaching her cautiously, as Huntara snapped her head up. A venomous glare directed right at her.

“Leave me alone, Blondie.” She snarled, bending down to retrieve her vest and shrug it on roughly.

“What's going on, Huntara?” Adora was not intimidated by Huntara's dark scowl or her standoffish attitude.

“It's none of your business.” Huntara snarled, standing up and turning toward the doorway.

“I'm your friend and I care about you, that makes it my business.” Adora moved swiftly and slipped around her, blocking the doorway with her body. “I'm worried about you?” She finished gently.

“Move! Or I will move you!” Huntara nearly shouted, her voice cold. Dark eyes staring down at Adora with a fearsome, narrow eyed glare.

“No...you've been drinking.. ” Adora thrust up her chin defiantly. Raising her arms and blocking her path threw the doorway.

Huntara grunted, raising an eyebrow silently demanding she prove it. She could hold her liquor, she had never been drunk while on duty. It just helped take the edge off, dull the guilt and the pain she lived with on a daily basis. She had done nothing wrong.

“You've been a mess for days....I know you're hurting. You don't leave your room, unless you're given a mission. You always used to hang out with me...when you visited Bright Moon. Now you're avoiding everyone, even me.... But still you never even tried to spend time with your friends. I had to convince you to come here tonight....that's not like you. ” Adora rambled, valiantly trying to control the hurt and fear she felt for Huntara. Her earnest blue eyes shimmering with tears.

Huntara groaned and pressed her hands against her hips, ducking her head and gazing bitterly at her boots. Shamefully kicking at the floor.

“Yeah...that's about right.” She huffed. “I've changed.”

“You were chipped?” Adora demanded, cutting right to the core of the problem.

“Yeah...not proud of that.” Huntara growled, folding her arms over her ample chest and storming away to the more open, washing area at the back of the room. She needed some space, being so

close to Adora. Who kept gazing up at her with those wet, concerned eyes made her want to cry herself or punch something. Not knowing what was going to erupt out of her, she stepped away from Adora. She never wanted to hurt her...or anyone ever again.

“Tell me about it?” Adora followed her, keeping her distance sensing how strung tight Huntara was right now. She could lash out violently, or break down into tears...

“Prime got Bovia first....I didn't know what was going on...” Huntara scrubbed her hands over her head, brushing her long hair into wild tangles down her back.

“That Tauran bartender back at the Oasis Bar?” Adora inquired.

“Yeah...in the last few years, I managed to get that wonderful woman to fall in love with me!” Huntara offered her a bitter sweet smile.

“We had been living in The Valley of the Lost, in my old place. Best years of my life.” Huntara took a deep, shaky breath.

“She got a job bartending at a local pub and we started to build a life together. She came home late one night and she wasn't acting right...I thought maybe she had found someone else. I got mad, we had a real nasty fight...but then she got violent...that wasn't like her either. Then several of our friends busted down my front door and tried to subdue me. In seconds, I was fighting for my life!” Huntara shouted, her pacing becoming more agitated. She looked more like a caged predator, her muscles flexing and rippling with pent up energy.

“I wasn't strong enough....” Huntara's lower lip trembled as the walls she erected to keep her emotions in check, crumbled away.

Adora took a step closer, reaching for her hand. Huntara took it, squeezing lightly, taking a deep breath before continuing.

“Then everything went white....I lost months...when Entrapta finally freed me from Primes control. I found out from Grox that I had killed her...maybe that day...maybe her chip got damaged and she joined the rebellion in the waste and I killed her then...I don’t know how it really happened, it’s all just stories I’ve made up in my head...I just know...she’s dead...” Huntara broke at that point, falling to her knees as violent sobs shook her whole body.

“I couldn't fight him....his voice was in my head, making me do things, making me say things...forcing me to become a monster....I couldn't fight him...he broke me...” Huntara stutters out, her voice weak and brittle.

Adora released Huntara's hand and cradled her shoulders tenderly in her arms. Tears streamed down her face, as Huntara pressed her face into Adora's stomach, her powerful arms clinging desperately around Adora's firm waist.

“I didn't mean it...I was confused....I was scared....I wasn't in control....anymore.....I never wanted to hurt her...” She wailed into Adora's stomach.

Adora cried along with her, brushing her hands tenderly down the back of Huntara's head. Seeking to soothe the heartache that was drowning one of her closest friends. Her own chest was tight, her mind reeling with finally hearing the first honest truth about what it was like being chipped. Knowing that Catra had been violated and her mind broken in the very same way. Perhaps even more brutally, because of her betrayal...sacrificing herself to save Glimmer... trying to warn her, protect her...

“I'm so, so, sorry....” Adora apologized through her own sobs.

“I have no home anymore....I feel so....lost...Adora...” Huntara's broken voice echoed throughout the room. Adora held her, pushing her own raging emotions behind a mask of comfort and calm. Needing to be the rock Huntara could draw strength from. She could break down later and work threw these new revelations in private. Catra had been so brave....so selfless...the true extent

of what she went through for Adora finally coming to light with a little more clarity.

Catra hovered in the shadows of the short hall just before the washing area, watching the tragic moment with tears of her own falling down her face. If Prime hadn't wanted to use Adora, he might have forced Catra to kill her true love as well. That terrible thought tore at her heart, making her chest ache painfully. If She-Ra hadn't shown up...then Adora would have been chipped. Then Prime would have killed Glimmer, Bow and Entrapta. She would be dead, her body broken at the bottom of the pit below his command dais. Adora had no idea what she was doing...charging forward with a single minded intent on saving her, not taking into account any of the consequences!

Damit Adora! Her mind was screaming over how tragically that all could have ended for the Rebellion, for the entire universe. If Prime had Adora, figured out how to tap into her magic and used her connection to She-Ra to further subjugate the universe!

She took a trembling breath and backed up against the rough stone of the hall needing something solid to anchor herself. So that the dark, toxic thoughts now flooding through her didn't carry her away. She moaned piteously and closed her eyes tight....refusing to allow the rising trauma a hand hold.

“Everything's alright....Adora saved me...Prime's gone....I'm ok...” She whispered, tears dripping from her chin. As the memories of Primes mental torture and physical assaults washed over her. Her throat felt tight, her chest heavy as she struggled to take in air. The intense fear constricting her breath and leaving her nauseous.

“I'm safe....I'm safe....I'm safe...” She muttered, slowly slipping down the wall to curl up tight against the wall. Crossing her arms over her knees and ducking her head against her arms, taking deep breaths and releasing the air to the counts Perfuma had

taught her. Controlling her panic and slowly calming down. She could feel Melog, they had sensed her distress and were already running to her side. Sending calming waves threw their link. She smiled faintly, reassuring Melog through the link that she was alright. She lost track of time as her mind wandered, seeking to dwell on the good that occupied her present and bury that pain in the past. But her attempt to find solace was rather fragile, she couldn’t hang onto the pleasant memories long enough to soothe her turbulent mind. So easily falling into the painful what if’s of how badly things could have gone. Her ears started to flick sharply as she suddenly realized that Huntara and Adora's sobs had fallen into silence.

“Catra...?” Adora's gentle voice called her out of her head. Catra slowly raised her face from her knees. Taking in Adora's tear stained face with her own stricken gaze. She glanced at the open room, finding it empty. Huntara must have left, during the time she was lost in her tortured thoughts. She turned back to Adora, finding the blonde kneeling before her, arms open, inviting her into her embrace.

“I'm sorry....” Catra muttered, crawling into Adora's arms.

“What for....now..” Adora's voice was weak. Strained from crying and now confused.

“For what I did to you....what I could have done...back on Primes ship when he tried to use me. When he made me hurt you.” Catra stumbled out, her voice soft and broken.

“You were not in control.” Adora cupped her hands softly against Catra's cheeks, bunting their foreheads.

“You were so reckless....and stupid...you couldn't summon She-Ra....you never listen to me! It was a trap! I told you to stay away! You and the others should have never put your lives at risk for me...you should have left me there!” Catra cried with barely restrained fury. Gripping Adora's hands and yanking them away. Huntara's story had hit far too close and all her worst fears were

triggered. She couldn't hold back the cruel words that spit from her mouth.

“Catra...” Adora breathed, her eyebrows furrowed in sorrow. “How can you say that..." She gripped Catra's shoulders, giving her a firm shake. “I would have never left you there! Glimmer, Bow...Entrapta they knew what they were getting into and you were worth the risk!” Adora was close to shouting in her face, needing her to understand that she mattered. Catra had chewed her out on numerous occasions about going back for her, when they were on Darla, heading back to Etheria. Adora thought they had worked this all out, to have those fears come surging back again. It made no sense for her to still be so upset, that was all in the past they had all pulled threw and Prime was gone.

“If he had captured you....found out that you couldn't summon She-Ra...that you couldn't be used to activate the Heart...He would have killed you... or made me kill you!” Catra jumped to her feet, fists tight to her thighs. “I would be just as heart broken and lost as Huntara is...now...If he had even allowed me to live...” She stormed off, laughing with a dark humor. “Honestly, that sadistic bastard would have probably made me jump off that ledge to my death anyway.” She was spiraling...she knew it...but she also couldn't seem to stop herself. She needed to vent all the frustrations and fear that had been festering inside of her since being chipped.

Adora's heart lurched in her chest at the mention of that dreadful fight. The fear and misery resurfacing. Her chest constricted and breathing became labored. She had nearly lost Catra for good, she had literally been dead in her arms. It was the first time she had really acknowledged that she loved her and couldn't live without her. She had been so scared, so enraged by what Prime had done to Catra that the raw, unbridled emotion had finally awoken She-Ra.

Adora scrambled after Catra, needing to get this sorted out. Catra was so upset and finally she was opening up about what happened back on Primes Ship. She needed to keep her talking,

she wanted desperately to know what had happened before she arrived. Those traumatic memories were still poisoning her, she knew that the nightmare Catra had back in the cave was linked to Prime. She wanted Catra to purge all that misery. She wanted to mend the broken pieces of her mind, that Prime had shattered. Heal all the invisible scars Shadow Weaver had left upon her heart...for once in her life...she wanted her to be ok...

“Until I heard the communication you sent, I had no idea where you were!” Adora shouted back, following her back to the cubbies. Finding she was getting dressed, having shed her cloth wrappings and discarding the wet cloth in a heap on the floor. She had attempted to dry her body and short hair with the single towel that had been near her basket. It was now soaked and discarded on the floor as well. She had her torn leggings on and was fussing with her breast wrap. Catra's fur was still rather damp, the moisture was soaking thru the material, in several places along her thighs. Adora huffed and pulled out her own basket, unraveling her wet cloth wrap and tossing it into the cubie. Then pulling out her towel, wrapping it around herself as she sorted her clothes that lay at the bottom of her basket.

“Did you even look for me? ” Catra muttered scathingly. As she pulled the dark material angrily over her head. Grimacing as the cloth clung awkwardly to her wet breasts, forcing her to make minor adjustments to the material with her fingertips.

“Yes!” Adora shouted, back. “You just disappeared!” Her voice was strained as she pulled up her grey pants, reaching for her bra with an irritated huff. “I never stopped caring about you Catra...” She continued, her voice soft and thick with hurt.

“It sure felt like it sometimes.” Catra responded bitterly, unable to hold back her hurt feelings, now that she was being honest. Her voice was muffled as she pulled on her white shirt.

“You stopped caring about me first....I have the scars to prove it. ” Adora shot back, clamping her mouth shut. Her blue eyes burning with remorse and pain, the instant she spat out that ugly

truth. As Catra stood stunned but resigned to her confession. She had just finished pulling on her white shirt when Adora had spat out those harsh words.

“I didn't mean it...” Adora breathed, her lower lip trembling.

“Yes you did...” Catra responded her voice somber. As the fire of her anger was snuffed out instantly, her expression crestfallen. As she slowly bowed her head, ears dropping, clutching her arm as regret and guilt washed over her. Suddenly she looked so small and fragile. “And your right...I did stop caring about you first...I wanted you gone...” Catra swallowed hard, “I wanted you to hurt...I wanted...” Catra couldn't continue so she clamped her mouth shut, trembling with pent up emotions far to complex and painful for her to fully unpack right now.

They stared at each other for a long time, all the heartbreak and old grudges reflecting in their eyes.

“This is stupid...why are we fighting?” Catra rolled her eyes, reaching for Adora. Wanting to cool things down before they said something even worse.

“You started it!” Adora spat playfully, clutching her hand and giving it a squeeze.

“I did not...I got upset...you know how I get.” Catra groused, as if that was excuse enough for her getting so angry. “Now, I'm trying to calm down...cause I refuse to fight with you ever again!” Catra stated indignantly, looking down in shame.

“Catra...” Adora moaned her name, overwhelmed with regret. For engaging in this argument instead of being patient and understanding towards Catra’s pain. She gave the feline a soft, affectionate look, before moving closer, cupping her cheek and giving her a sweet, tender kiss.

Catra was trying so hard to stop her toxic ways. The old Catra would have let this fight escalate, wanting to win. She would use whatever means it took. Spewing ugly, mean, hurtful things to get

Adora to back down. To prove she was stronger and that no one could hurt her. Even though it was a blatant lie and she was just hiding her heart behind those self destructive tendencies. A way to keep others at a safe distance so she would never be hurt again.

“Lets go for a walk.” Catra offered, pulling Adora out of the dressing room. As soon as she got her, bra and long sleeve shirt on.

Between Mystacor floating in the sky and then the added altitude of being near the peak of the mountain. The air was much thinner. Moving from the hot steam of the grotto, to the colder changing area and then back outside and into the crisp, cool breeze of the evening. Catra was feeling more than a little woozy, she groaned deeply as they walked out of the front doors.

“Catra...” Adora gasped, taking several deep breaths. As she bent over her knees, suddenly feeling dizzy as well. “Lets head over there for now.” Adora pointed to a small, grassy plateau that jutted off from the path on the other side of the trees.

Catra nodded and pulled her across the stone footpath and onto the grass. They both collapsed to the ground with faint moans, flopping onto their backs and staring up at the night sky. Taking one long breath after another seeking to remain alert, as their whole bodies felt tingly and light headed.

“That feeling sucked....” Catra muttered. “The air is too thin up here...”

“Yeah....the last time Glimmer took me to the Grotto it was the warm season, so the difference in temperatures wasn't so brutal.” Adora stated, folding her hands over her stomach as she searched the constellations above. She was regretting leaving her cloak back in their room, it would have been nice to cuddle up with Catra underneath it.

Melog suddenly appeared in a flare of white fire. Catra stared at them in confusion, they had not used their teleportation powers since Krytis. When they had phased her out of the ruins of the spire to the ground below. It had not been like Glimmer's magic, that was more like fast travel between two locations. It had been far less confusing to her senses, more like passing through a curtain between reality only to pass back through somewhere else. They stated that teleportation took too much of their remaining wild magic and would only use it for emergencies. That fact that they had used it, meant she had scared them...big time! But the magic they used was more like Catra's.

"I'm ok...sorry I worried you so bad." Catra apologized.

Melog chirped and butted their head against Catra's shoulder.

“Hey, buddy...that's new?” Catra rubbed their ears as they settled down against her side.

(My magic is changing now, that my Master has her own magic.) Melog stated in her mind.

“uhm...ok.” Catra had no idea what they were talking about. “Stop calling me Master, we're friends.”

Melog purred and rubbed their cheek against Catra's shoulder in response.

“That was new.” Adora nodded towards Melog.

“Yeah...I guess since I have magic, Melog's kinda tapping into that...now...I think it's a bond thing.” Catra shrugged. Melog began to hum, a warm orange glow flowed over their feline body. Heating up the space in a soothing aura.

Both Adora and Catra sighed, as the warmth surrounded them.

“I should have thought of doing that...” Catra muttered, petting Melog's mane tenderly with one hand.

“Melogs been dealing with magic for a long time, I am sure they know a lot of spells. I bet they could teach you some.” Adora shrugged.

“That's a great idea! Want to be my teacher, buddy?” Catra turned with a wistful smile toward Melog.

They blinked slowly at her, purring softly.

(I could teach you simple spells...I am not capable of complex casting like you.) They stated.

“Well I know nothing about magic right now.” Catra sighed, “Including you, buddy.”

(I will answer any of your questions...you just need to ask them) They stated, bluntly.

“I don't even know enough yet to think of any questions.” Catra groaned.

Adora giggled beside her. Catra turned to her with a questioning look.

“What?” Catra huffed indigently.

“It is so weird listening to you talk to Melog...I can only hear half of the conversation.” Adora responded, tucking an arm behind her head seeking to get more comfortable as she stared up at the night sky.

“Oh...” Catra's irritation cooled instantly. As they lay in silence for a long time, staring up at the stars lost in their own thoughts.

“So Huntara headed back down to the Basilica?” Catra offered, her voice small.

“Yeah...I feel terrible about what happened to her. Sometimes...I wish I could just go back in time and stop all the bad stuff...?”

Adora rolled onto her side, bracing the side of her face on a hand.

“Yeah...I wish that too.” Catra released a long drawn out sigh, she had so many regrets. Bitterly she knew that wishing for that quick fix to change the past wasn't worth thinking about. All she could do now was move forward and be better.

“I'm sorry....for everything.” Adora, sighed. Reaching out with her free hand and brushing a damp strand of Catra's dark hair out of her eyes.

Catra turned her head with a smirk. “Stop...we gotta...just stop...ok.”

“Yeah, I know...” Adora groaned and flopped back onto her back. Staring forlorn up at the blanket of stars. “I love you...” She spoke softly, her voice breaking.

Catra knew that broken tone, Adora was overwhelmed by her own regrets and needed assurance that she was forgiven for all her past transgressions.

Catra was in motion, instantly. Snuggling into Adora's side, leaning over her chest and pressing her lips tenderly to Adora's.

“I love you, too. Dummy...please stop beating yourself up about the past.” Catra pleaded, kissing her more firmly for emphasis.

“Only if you start to forgive yourself, too.” Adora's steel blue eyes were firm but moist with unshed tears. Catra cupped her cheek tenderly, giving her that cocky, half smirk.

“I'm working on it.” She admitted.

“Good.” Adora sighed, slipping her hand behind Catra's neck and guiding her head tenderly down onto her shoulder.

“We got the rest of our lives to figure this all out.” Catra advised, with a fond smile. Snuggling in tighter, needing to absorb as much

of Adora's warmth and love as she could.

“Still cold?” Adora asked, quietly. Her eyes searching the heaven's absently for her favorite constellations.

“Nope....this is perfect.” Catra sighed.

Melog was laying against her back, a warm glow encasing all three of them.

“Did I ever show you my favorite constellations?” Adora offered, already pointing up into the sky.

Catra shook her head, turning her own eyes heavenward.

Adora chuckled and started to point out the ones she had made up. Catra's eyes slowly widened as she was struck with a familiar deja vu. The constellations Adora was pointing out were the exact same as Finn's.

“My favorite is the cake constellation...over.....there.” Adora pointed to the same circle pattern with the three stars that point upward.

“Adora...did you show Finn these stars?” Catra sat up halfway, leaning over Adora. A surprised, yet confused frown on her face.

“No...” Adora stated, her own expression falling into confusion.

“He pointed out all these stars to me back on the Plains of Thaymor...said his mom showed him.” Catra mused.

“Strange...” Adora shrugged, “But it's not like their not obvious shapes in the sky to pick out, it could just be a coincidence?”

“I guess...” Catra sighed, leaving the mystery for later. She was feeling rather tired and lazy, from the grotto.

Adora started to chuckle, twisting a fingertip into a coiled strand of Catra's hair.

“What...is my fur already curling...” Catra gasped in horror.

“Yes....it so cu....” Adora started but did not get to finish, as Catra pressed both her hands onto her mouth to silence her. Glaring daggers down at her.

Adora snickered and then her muffled laugh leaked out from beneath Catra's hands.

“Urghh...ok...I am not ready to reveal my fur issues with the princess's. We need to get back to our room and you need to brush me....all of me....before it gets any worse.” Catra scrambled to her feet, marching away in an irritated huff.

Adora giggled and followed after her, her cheeks flushing and eyes shining with glee.

Confessions

Huntara sat somber and withdrawn, in an armchair before her hearth. Absently watching the flames dance inside the stone firebox, the crackle and snap of the wood as it was consumed the only sound. Her room was dark, except for the flickering firelight. That illuminated her drawn, tired features briefly when the flames flared from a gust of wind howling down the open chimney. She was sitting slumped against the side of a highly polished wooden armrest. Her elbows hanging low, dressed in nothing more than her underclothes. A pair of black shorts and a simple breast wrap. With a nearly empty, brown tinted bottle of hard liquor clutch in one hand, it's bottom braced lightly on her bare knee. Having retreated straight back to her room at the Basilica, after her embarrassing display of weakness with Adora. She was now both physically and emotionally spent and wanting nothing more than to find oblivion at the bottom of the whiskey bottle.

A soft electrical crackling hummed from the far corner of her fireplace. She cut her eyes to the hide tarp wrapped around something long and solid. She had stolen the tarp from the burnt out debris discarded outside the walls of the Main gate. Needing something to protect her skin from the magically charged sword she had found on her way back to the Basilica that afternoon. A tiny ear piece sat on the thick wooden mantle just above the firebox. It had been silent so far, but Huntara recognized the compact, slightly curved design. It was similar to the communicator's the Horde used for reconnaissance personnel, who were spying within enemy lines. She had been sober enough at the time to pocket the ear piece, when she found it near the sword. With the intention of listening in to the next communication. This piece of tech belonged to their intruder and soon enough the guys giving him orders would start to relay order's to other operatives. Huntara had her pack waiting by the front door, ready to leave at a moment's notice, as soon as that ear piece came alive again.

Sitting around waiting for something to happen wasn’t her style, she was desperate to get back on the trail and hopefully bust some heads in the next few days.

The walk back to their room had been quiet, each of them lost to their thoughts. They held hands, but offered each other little else. Adora was sullen, reflecting on the cruelty inflicted upon both Huntara and Catra by Prime. Slowly being consumed by guilt and regrets that she didn't do more. To prevent all the trauma her friends had gone through because of that Galactic Tyrant. She would cast Catra small, sympathetic glances when she thought Catra wasn't looking her way. Catra hated feeling pitied and she didn't want her concerned looks to be misinterpreted. But Catra had caught her sad, wary glances. She would reassure Adora from time to time with short squeezes of her hand. She knew Adora was beating herself up over not protecting her or Huntara. Catra had once thought it was just a Hero complex. Some vain, attempt to gain praise and attention from her superiors. That Adora had cultivated while growing up as Shadow Weaver’s golden child. But it wasn't. Adora's heart was just so big, so loving and selfless she couldn't bear to see others hurt or suffering. She just wanted to help, to protect everyone she cared about to the detriment of herself. Catra just wished she would just let it go, come to terms with the fact that she couldn’t protect everyone from the unjust cruelty of the universe. Sometimes bad things happen. There was nothing you could do about it, but survive through it. Bitterly knowing that Adora was far too stubborn and determined to ever just let things go. She was desperate to know what happened back on, Primes ship. Determined to take away all the fear and helplessness that still haunted Catra...As always she wanted to make everything ok again.

Catra had been avoiding talking about it, not wanting to relive in any way the suffering and torment she had gone through. But since her nightmare back in the cave. The need to know, for Adora, had become more prominent again. It would only be a matter of time before Adora tried to coax her to talk about it.

“Still cold?” Adora asked, softly. As she opened the door to their room.

“No, I think my fur dried on the way here.” Catra answered, pulling down a tightly coiled strand of dark hair bitterly over her forehead.

Adora smiled fondly at her. “I think you look cute, when your fur's all curly.” She leaned in and bumped Catra's shoulder.

Catra gave her a dirty look, stomping through the doorway in irritation. Melog chuckled, as they padded quietly behind Catra. Making their way to their mound of pillows to settle down for the night.

Catra shot them a withering look of betrayal, at their obvious amusement.

“How was the grotto?” Finn leaned into view, around the arm of the chair near the fireplace. The little Thaymorian had a nice roaring fire going and he was busy writing in a leather bound book in his lap.

“It was fun, what have you been up to?” Adora asked, walking past him and ruffling his thick mat of brown hair.

“It's top secret.” Finn grinned, closing his heavy book with a resounding clap.

“Adora and I have to leave for a few days, so are you going to be alright here on your own?” Catra asked.

“No problem. I can take care of myself. But where are you going?” Finn's mouth fell open in shocked surprise when Catra walked past him. Her short dark hair had fluffed up into tight curls and waves around her ears. Looking twice it's natural volume, it was now an incredibly wild and untamed mass. The soft, layer of tawny fur that covered her arms and legs was now swirled into odd patterns. Making the stripes on her arms all wavy.

“We are headed back to the Fright Zone for a few days, going up around Scorpion Hill to visit some old friends.” Adora answered, crossing the room to dig into her pack for her brush.

“What happened to you?” Finn gapped at Catra. “You look sooooo soft....can I pet you?” He jumped off his chair, tossing his book down and scampered up to her eagerly.

Catra groaned, palming her face. “No, kid...”

Finn pouted and kicked a bare hoof sadly in protest.

“Catra needs to be brushed, you can help?” Adora offered, reappearing with her black, polished, wooden handled brush.

“Ok.” Finn beamed up at Adora, while Catra heaved a drawn out sigh of resignation. Pulling off her shirt and leggings and tossing them aside. As Finn dashed to Melog's pillow pile and snatched up a plush, marron throw pillow. Then placed the pillow on the floor in front of the fireplace, wanting Catra to be comfortable.

Catra watched the kid's natural act of kindness with surprise at first. Then cocked her head towards Finn, giving him a grateful smirk and nod of approval. As she settled down on the plush, velvet pillow. She hummed pleasantly as the heat from the fire warmed her once chilled body. All of her muscles once again began to relax. Adora knelt behind her, as this was a well practiced chore. She had brushed Catra countless times over the years when her fur got water logged, from outdoor training during rain storms. Or the time she had gone swimming with the rest of their squad, in the stream they found during their adventure. While seeking to find a beautiful, peaceful place to build an epitaph and mourn their fallen squad mates.

“Can you fix it?” Catra whined, trying not to pout too obviously, as she leaned back against Adora’s front. Resting her head against the soft mounds of her large breasts. Adora never even shifted when Catra's weight was suddenly against her. She was so strong

now, Catra could feel the blondes muscles on her stomach flexing as she held her ground.

Catra sighed, enjoying her soft, warmth for a moment then leaned forward again wanting to get this over with.

“I can try...” Adora leaned over her shoulder and placed a tender kiss on her cheek.

“I think Catra looks cute! And so....Fluffy!!!” Finn exclaimed, lightly brushing his small hands into the thick fringe of Catra's dark hair and pushing it back tight to her head. The wild mass of curls overflowed his tiny fingers like dark waves.

Catra's ears folded back as she scowled up at him, venomously. “Kid, never call me cute or fluffy again...unless you have a death wish.” she threatened with a growling hiss, flexing her fingers so her claws unsheathed to their full extent.

Finn's eyes flew wide in terror at the sight of her claws and instantly filled with tears. He looked truly scared for a moment, judging if Catra would really attack him. Then quickly covered up his fear. With an indignant huff and crouched down before her, his soft blue eyes staring up at her, hurt clear in his expression. “You are so mean...?” He commented.

“Catra...” Adora chastised, calling her name in a low whine of disappointment.

“...I hate being called cute....Fluffy is even worse...” Catra snarled, crossing her arms over her chest stubbornly.

“You don't have to be so mean and scary.” Finn huffed, turning on his heel and walking back to his chair and climbing up. He placed his heavy book on his lap and glowered down at Catra. “Do you really want to kill me? Just because I think you look cute?”

Catra's eyes widened in alarm. She had just retaliated venomously out of reflex. She had been embarrassed and snarled the first nasty thing she could think of to get him to back off. The

realization that she had just scared Finn. Threatened a small child with death in the very same way Shadow Weaver had done to her. It sent an icy chill down her back, as shame and regret took hold. The terrible memory of when it happened to her, foremost in her mind. Adora and her had hid behind the Black Garnet, when Shadow Weaver had sought refuge within the privacy of that chamber. They had unfortunately witnessed the Sorceress, at her most vulnerable. Shuddering and gasping in great pain. She had taken off her mask, hunched over her scrying pool. Her scarred and slowly decaying body on full display before her two wards. Embarrassed at showing weakness in front of them, she had taken her anger and fear out, on both of them. Intimidating Adora and then threatening Catra's life.

"Ah...crap..." Catra muttered, quickly shooing Adora away for a moment. She carefully crawled up to Finn, he was avoiding her eyes. Pouting down at his book, sniffling softly.

"I'm sorry...I get really mad sometimes about stupid stuff that shouldn't really matter. I'm working on it. Ok." She offered, placing a comforting hand on his shoulder. Her eyes stared up at him, pleadingly. She never, ever, ever wanted to reflect Shadow Weaver's toxic parenting ever again. She understood better than most how scary hearing a parental figure, who held all the power over you. So flippantly threaten your life. Being that helpless, weak and terrified little kid. That every time you got into trouble from then on. You were left wondering, worrying that perhaps this time her 'mother' would finally go through with it.

Slowly Finn raised his tearful eyes, meeting her own gaze meekly.

"I never meant it and I promise to never say that horrible stuff to you ever again." Catra pulled him into her, hugging him tight. Finn sighed and leaned into her, wrapping his tiny arms around her shoulders. Absorbing all the comfort Catra was offering.

"No matter how mad you get at me?" Finn mumbled.

“No matter what, I promise.” Catra smiled down at him, as he slowly pulled away.

“I promise to never call you cute or fluffy again.” Finn nodded, smiling sweetly up at her.

Catra ruffled his hair and crawled back to Adora. Finding the blonde grinning proudly at her. Her blue eyes are moist and bright with love.

Catra sighed and offered her a wiry grin of her own, before settling down cross legged on her pillow. Purring contentedly as Adora continued to work at gently brushing her hair out. Giving up with a disgruntled huff as she was only making it more fluffy and wild. Then proceeded to brush the fur down Catra's back. Adora worked with the natural growth pattern of her fur, attempting in vain to tame it. A good hour or more past in quiet companionship. Melog had settled into their pillows, napping. Finn sat in the chair with his pencil, tapping the end against his chin and scribbling things down in his book.

“What are you working on?” Adora inquired politely.

“Secrets...” Finn grinned mischievously up at her.

“Does it have anything to do with this surprise, your planning?” Catra chuckled, pulling at her curly bangs. Valiantly trying to straighten them out and sighing in disgust when they bounced back into place.

“Maybe.” Finn responded cryptically.

Adora laughed lightly, as she finished brushing out Catra's hair. The fur on her body was now laying down, but her hair as always was a lost cause. It looked nicely groomed but still curly and fluffy. It would take a day or two to calm down.

Catra sighed and stretched, resigned as always to her unruly mane of hair.

“Well, I think I'm gonna head to bed.” She stood up and headed towards the bed.

“Night.” Finn called.

“I think we should all go to sleep.” Adora stated, offering Finn her hand.

Finn shrugged, closing his book and tucking it up against his chest. He slipped off the chair and allowed Adora to lead him to his futon mattress, tucked in the corner of the room. Adora pulled back the woolen blanket as he settled down. Waiting as he pulled off his poncho and pants, tossing them aside. When he had his book stashed securely against the stone wall and his bed. She finished tucking him in.

“Swift Wind told me you never went to hang out with him the other day? I was really worried about you, when Mystacor was falling. I'm glad you're alright.” She cupped his round cheek tenderly, smiling fondly down at him.

“I'm sorry, I made you worry. I got distracted by the cloud beach on my way to see him. I found some really neat shells. Kinda weird to find them all the way up here in the sky, though. ” He offered with an excited grin. “It was just an amazing mystery, I was trying to figure it out all day. When I came back it was supper time and the nice lady who works in the kitchen, fed me and sent me to bed. I didn't even know Mystacor was falling. Every once in a while my tummy would flip, I just thought I had a tummy ache.” Finn shrugged, giving Adora a cute, dopey grin.

“Ok.” Adora giggled, at his obliviousness. Every time his tummy felt weird was when the island suddenly lost more altitude. She sighed and ruffled his hair affectionately. Finn could get rather caught up in his fantasies, when he was playing. So it was totally plausible for him not to notice what was going on. To be so caught up in his own make believe world, that he ignored a whole magical island falling out of the sky? Adora could totally imagine him strolling down the beach oblivious to everything, completely

absorbed in his treasures and his make believe games. " I know you're used to being on your own and you can take care of yourself. But you're part of a family now and you need to check in. I think, I am going to ask Glimmer, if Bow can make you a communication pad so you can call me or Catra. If you ever get into trouble during your adventures." Adora nodded, brushing his hair off his forehead tenderly.

"Ok...Momma.." Finn whispered faintly, his soft blue eyes were unfocused. His eye lids grew heavy, as he finally closed his eyes, sleep claiming him quickly. The endearment slipped out tentatively as he rolled towards the wall. Worried she might reject it and didn't want to see her expression. She never noticed the small sly smile that graced his lips.

Adora's eyes widened for a moment then softened as she smiled tenderly down at him. With a sniffle, she quickly rose and headed over to the fireplace. Keeping her happy tears hidden, as she tended to the fire for a moment. Securing the firebox with its chain mail curtain before getting ready for bed. She slipped into the bed in just her grey shorts and tank top a few moments later, finding Catra laying on her back. Arms folded behind her head, staring up at the purple canopy of their bed with a distant, solemn look in her eyes. When she felt the mattress shift, she turned and gave Adora a small smile, unfolding one arm and inviting her to snuggle into her side.

"I heard that...." Catra commented, her voice soft and full of tenderness.

"Yeah...he called me...Momma..." Adora whispered, her voice breaking. She curled herself up against Catra, pulling their blanket over them. Resting her head against the Catra's chest and draping an arm lightly over her stomach.

Catra held her tightly, stroking her back up and down gently with her fingertips.

“Never thought we'd be parents so soon...” Catra mused. “If ever...” She finished, her voice low and full of wonder.

“Yeah...it's a bit overwhelming.” Adora responded softly, slowly falling asleep in the security and comfort of Catra's embrace.

Catra laid awake for a long time, listening to Adora's soft breathing, enjoying the weight and the warmth of her body against hers. She was far too restless to sleep and needed to burn off some energy or she wasn't going to get any sleep tonight. She slowly disentangled herself from Adora. Standing by the bed for just a moment, watching the blonde moan sadly at her absence, but then snuggle her face deeper into Catra's pillow. As sleep dragged her back down, not allowing her to wake up.

Digging into her pack, Catra found another pair of old maroon leggings from her time in the Fright Zone and slipped them on. Entrapta must have packed everything she owned in this pack, whether it was useful or not. Catra chuckled softly. That was just how Entrapta was, needing to be prepared for anything. She remembered how much stuff she had packed for just a few days' expedition to the Northern Reach. She had filled the cargo hold of their ship with all manner of junk and gear! It had frustrated and irritated her at the time. But now, she accepted Entrapta’s rather eccentric idiosyncrasies and had grown very fond of her. Thankful to have received her forgiveness and be given a second chance at true friendship.

Catra sighed happily as she found her old baby blanket folded neatly at the bottom. She lightly pulled it out and gave it a quick embrace against her chest. It didn't smell musty at all from being open to the elements of an underground cave for over a decade. Strangely it still smelled like her, with just a hint of something else. It was a deep and woodsy smell that was very soothing. Reminding her vaguely of the scent of the Whispering Woods. Catra sighed one last time into the soft wool on the underside of the hide blanket. Then glanced over to Finn, finding the little boy curled up as always under his thin blanket. Wanting to show him that she also cared about his well being and that she was capable

of being soft and tender just like Adora. She slowly crossed the room, tucking her blanket against him.

Finn moaned in his sleep, his nose wrinkling as he felt the soft wool. Finding the scent and softness comforting. He hummed with approval, unconsciously nuzzling his face deeper into the baby blanket with a soft smile, his hands clutching onto the hide and pulling it tighter against his chin.

“Sweet dreams, kid. I hope this makes bedtime less lonely while we're gone.” Catra smiled gently, stroking his cheek with her claw tips. Then she sighed and stood up, grabbing her old, worn leather jacket off the back of the chair near the fireplace. She pulled it on, as she headed for the open window.

Melog blinked his eyes open as she passed, feeling her troubled thoughts, he padded after her as she slipped outside. Whenever Catra felt emotionally unbalanced, with more on her mind then she could cope with. The only thing that calmed her was to go up to a high place and think. She had retreated up to that platform, that overlooked the Foundry back in the Fright Zone. All through out her life, before and after Adora had defected. It had been her last bastion of solitude and safety. She had believed that only Adora had the guts and determination to climb that high. Scorpia had proven her wrong, though. That woman had so much courage and such a selfish, stalwart heart. She was lucky to still have her as a friend also.

So she now found herself climbing up the old weathered stone carefully, to the balcony above. Slinking silently along the upper balcony's iron railing, she began to shimmy herself up a stone pillar towards the gable overhang of the roof. Within moments she found herself on the roof, stretching out on the cold clay tiles with her arms crossed under her head. It was the cool season and the evening wasn't cold yet, but it wasn't very warm either. Catra shivered, fluffing up her fur to keep warm. Since the jacket opened and her leather sleeves never went down past her elbows. Leaving her lower arms and stomach bare, since she never put on a shirt and was just wearing her breast wrap. She was staring up

at the stars, as Melog settled themselves against her side. Their comforting weight and added warmth a security blanket against the cool night air.

(You are troubled) Melog's chirped, resting their head on her chest. Their ears twitching, as they listened to the gentle night sounds and Catra's soft breathing.

“That's sorta been a constant state of being for me...for forever. Melog, why are you surprised by this?” Catra tucked her chin down to her collar bone and gave her companion a wiry smirk.

(I am not, I merely stated the fact, hoping you might reveal to me why you are so upset?) They explained, a low purr rumbling from deep in their chest.

“I got a lot on my mind....like...A-lot...” Catra eyes flare wide for emphasis then release a long suffering sigh.

(Go on...) Melog butted the tip of her nose with their larger, more blunt, cold wet nose.

Catra laughed and grimaced as the tip of her nose was now wet and she shivered slightly.

"I can't stop thinking about that little magicat? Where did they come from? Why where they here? Why did they take that Crystal that the Eternian's want. Their just a kid and they are caught up in some very dangerous stuff...you know?" She started, "Finn...he survived on his own for a long time...has that kitten been on their own for a long time too? I want to find them? I need to protect them...just like Finn." Catra groaned, piteously and then huffed as her train of thought barreled away down a new track.

“Urgh...I'm scared, Melog. Cause this happiness, I'm enjoying. It's not going to last. Good stuff never sticks, ya know. At least not for me. I know that one day, somehow, I am going to lose it all and I'll be alone again. ” Catra took a long, shaky breath.

(I will always be with you.” Melog promised, purring and rubbing their furry muzzle across her cheek.

Catra laughed, but it sounded dry and brittle.

“Don't make promises you can't keep, buddy.” She scratched them behind the ears, affectionately.

Melog whimpered and grew morose, knowing that their promise was false. They had already been captured and almost lost Catra to poison, the future really wasn't something they could promise. Catra knew that better than most. Being abandoned by people she loved. She was no stranger to the heartbreak of being left behind. So she was tempering how attached she was becoming to Melog. Not pulling away, or denying or belittling their blossoming friendship as she did with Scorpia. But by trying to accept the unknowns that she could not control and coming to understand that all things were fleeting. Nothing can last forever and that was ok, she needed to enjoy what she had now. She would mourn when her time with them was over and try to move forward.

She stared up at the stars for a long time, lost to her thoughts. When she finally spoke, her voice was soft, wistful. “I only wanted one thing growing up...to always be with Adora. She was always the driven one, becoming the leader of our squad, then a Force Captain. I just followed behind her, her trusty best friend, second in command. The Horde was not a good place to grow up, but Adora made me happy, she made me feel safe...wanted...at least most of the time. But then she left me and I wanted to prove to everyone that I had worth that wasn't connected to Adora. The way I went about it wasn't stellar...I admit. But I'm starting to put it behind me. Now...I have so much more in my life. I'm a princess....and that's really...weird...but I'm ok with it. Cause it led me to my people and a heritage I can be proud of. I've got a place here, with Adora and all her friends...which are kinda...my friends too. Which is great....but kinda scary cause I'm not comfortable yet...being a friend to anyone else but Adora. I feel like I'm moving forward towards a better future now. I've found a purpose...I want to fix all my mistakes. Rebuild Salineas and all of

Etheria. Make this planet stronger...cause. I know, thanks to the Eternian showing up. That the greater universe is not going to wait for us to join them when we're ready. They know we are here now and they are going to come. Not all of them are going to have good intentions, some are going to want to use Etheria's magic for their own benefit. We need to be ready to protect ourselves, I think that's why Hordak was so adamant about keeping the First Ones tech online. So that we can use it to defend the planet if we need to. Hordak had been a reclusive shut in for most of his time here on Etheria. But he was also a general in Horde Primes galactic forces, he knows what's out there. He and his brothers sacrificed themselves to keep us safe. That in itself sets off some really big alarm bells, you know." Catra huffed, then continued.

I'm not surviving anymore...I'm happy...most of the time...which is definitely different but wonderful. Then there's Adora....for me...I've always just wanted her...she was enough for me. But Adora, she's always striving for more. I can feel she's moving away from me again." Catra took a trembling breath. "She wants to go to Eternia, wants to find her family and the answers to why she was stolen. I get that...but I'm worried that I won't be able to follow again...that she's not going to choose me again, that she's going to leave me behind...for an even greater destiny." Catra took a deep shuddering breath, as a couple tears fell, rolling down her temples and into her hairline.

(That is a-lot.) Melog sighed, licking her cheek as they sought to comfort her. (No one knows the future, but perhaps you need to find solace in what you have now?)

Catra sighed heavily and stroked her hand down their soft, iridescent mane. Passing them a thin sardonic smile that silently stated she understood that already.

"I think too much..." she mumbled, weakly.

(You think too much.) Melog agreed.

Adora stood once again in that timeless void, the stars that once hung heavy above her were now floating around her. Glowing sparks, fluttering and dancing like butterflies around her head and shoulders. Their brilliant light, flickering like living flames, illuminating only a portion of the darkness that surrounded her. Adora stood frozen within their cocoon of starlight, her body refusing to move and only her eyes flicked from side to side attempting in vain to find any kind of anchor. As misery, loneliness and fear began to consume her. She took one shallow breath after another, searching the predatory darkness beyond the floating lights for any coming attacks. She could feel malicious eyes of some kind of unknown evil, scrutinizing her from just beyond that impenetrable darkness. It was taking stock of this new vessel for She-Ra's magic and finding her lacking. The disdain and revulsion it felt towards her, hung thick in the air. It made Adora cower slightly under it's all consuming gaze.

Slowly, the lights floated away from her creating a path at her feet that hovered out of view. It was then her body began to obey her. She was compelled to follow the glowing starlight into the void, refusing to leave it's meager light to afraid of the darkness that lurked around her. She could hear the soft crunch of dried grass as she walked, glancing down she could just barely see the thin strands waving in the wind. It was strange as if she was moving between worlds. The earth beneath her feet seemed solid enough, yet the void that surrounded her was incorporeal but also absolute. As she crested a hilltop, the star path, flashed and then flew up into the darkness above. Forming a pattern she hadn't seen for years.

"Serenia?" Adora whispered. That star constellation only appeared during the hot season out in the middle of the Crimson Waste. That was where Mara's ship had crashed. She had never gotten much of an answer as to why she had been headed there. Either way she did not make it, having sacrificed herself by using the last of her ship's energy to pull the planet into Despondos and then crash into the middle of the dessert.

The withering gasp of someone's breath being crushed from their body, whispered from the darkness. Followed by the brittle snap of bones echoing through the dark expanse and then an overwhelming silence reigned. Adora snapped her eyes down from the sky. Finding a deep, dark crimson, glowing silhouette of She-Ra. Standing a few meters ahead of her. She had short, wild hair, that tossed in the same ethereal wind as the golden version, of this embodiment of pure magic. She stood in similar armor, the shoulder guards were sharper, the bracers on her arms, more angled as if this incarnation was more war-like. On her hips were twin hilts of two swords. She seemed to glower down at Adora in judgement. Apprising this new vessel with distrust, wondering if Adora truly had the strength of will and determination to tame her power.

"Who are you?" Adora was suddenly very frightened. More terrified of this malicious version of She-Ra than the darkness itself.

The menacing red glow of this magic never ebbed, but grew brighter. Growing into an all consuming flash that blinded Adora. She raised her arm to shield her eyes, crying out in pain as her sight was devoured by that vengeful crimson glow.

When the piercing light faded, Adora found herself curled up on a frozen tundra. Twilight was darkening into the deeper blues of nightfall. The heavy mass of clouds overhead obscured the stars, if there were even any stars to shine. The sky was a blank void, looming over the frozen landscape. She could feel the ice biting into her flesh, her cotton, long sleeve shirt and grey pants were no protection against the howling wind and sleet. She quickly scrambled to her feet, her old red and white boots sinking into the soft snow all the way up to her knees. She was soon frozen to her very core, hunched over, with her arms wrapped tight around her chest. Tucking her bare hands into the meager warmth of her armpits, her eyelashes drooped heavily over her eyes, crusted with snow and ice. She could no longer feel the skin on her face, the long blonde strands of her hair, pulled free from her ponytail from the wind, were frozen against her cheeks and down her

neck. She was lost, trudging with single minded determination threw the thick snow towards a barely visible horizon. As the storm pelted her with ice and snow. She had no idea where she was going, just needing to keep moving forward. Knowing that if she stopped, if she gave up then she would freeze to death in this barren wilderness. Red, painted in the snow ahead, it drew her attention. Adora quickened her stride, refusing to dwell on the fiery pain in her frozen muscles. As she neared the discolored ground, she found the red stain was blood. Splattered and pooled into a crude scrawl of first ones writing.

"Despara..." Adora whispered, the word itself powerful enough to evoke such dread, she fell to her knees in despair. Suddenly she couldn't breathe, couldn't keep her eyes open as the searing crimson light overtook her yet again. Adora screamed, her voice shrill and full of panic as it reverberated through the red light.

Her whole being was overcome by the exhilarating sensations of battle, the weight of twin swords heavy in both hands. She could hear the wails and screams of the fallen, as she moved with purpose through the ranks of her faceless enemies. Some wore the basic armor of Horde soldiers, others swathed in the flowing white robes of clones or merely dressed in the simple clothes of Etherian's. It mattered not, for they had all wronged her in some way. So she cut them down in a hailstorm of steel and fury. She felt her anger, as it deepened and intensified. The faces of her foes slowly come into focus. Gimmer screamed in anguish, as she was cut down by her swords. Unable to teleport fast enough to evade her blinding fast strikes. As her twin blades struck her down in a flurry of strikes, leaving her gutted. Her body was crumpled at her feet in a slowly widening pool of blood. Her eyes staring lifeless, face frozen in an expression of shock and fear. A sense of pride and justice, swelled inside her at the sight of Glimmer's final defeat.

Shadow Weaver bathed in shadow, was mercilessly cut down by her swords before she could conjure only the most meager of dark spells. Unable to counter or erect even a magic shield before Adora had the sorceress on her knees. Her many sword strikes

fueled by a child’s long held hatred and resentments. A fiery need to exact revenge for the cruelty and suffering inflicted upon her and her most cherished friend. She stepped over the old woman's broken corpse without a shred of remorse. Moving towards another foe, relishing the coming battle. She was going to enjoy every moment yet to come. Easily avoiding his laser cannon fire, as she charged through his Sanctum. Using his own clutter and equipment as cover. Allowing him to destroy his most precious lab as she slowly and strategically closed in on her prey. Leaping at him from behind a wall of stacked crates near the remains of a collapsed portal arch.

Taking down Hordak with swift strikes to the most vulnerable parts of his armor. Slicing threw his arm cannon, as she struck down with her twin blades. Then spun, as her feet hit the ground, cutting a path in an upward arc with her one blade. Slashing Hordak's throat. His hands flew towards his neck in a desperate attempt to stop the bleeding. A piteous gurgle was the last sound he made, as she pulled back with the other blade running him threw. Her blade shattered the data crystal that powered his suit, sliding easily through the metal plating of his armor. Sinking deep into his chest cavity piercing his heart. She felt nothing, as he crumpled before her, hanging limply off her blade like a broken puppet. She held no satisfaction for his death, as she did for Shadow Weaver. He had merely been a looming presence of judgement during her youth and nothing more. He had just been an overseer she had to conquer. His lackluster performance in battle had been a disappointment.

His dull red eyes stared up at her in both surprise and horror. Adora could hear her own manic laughter echoing, as Hordak's dead body slipped off the tip of her blade. When she raised her eyes up from Hordak's corpse, sprawled dead at her feet. The pristine white light of Prime flooded the dark crimson world she once inhabited. Obliterating all sight, all sound into a void of pure nothingness. From the brilliance Horde Prime swaggered forward, that same smug, repugnant smile gracing his skeletal features.

She wanted to wipe that self satisfaction off his face. Adora felt the rage building, rebounding and magnifying until there was nothing left but the fury of vengeance. For all the planets he had destroyed, all the people he had felt were unworthy and culled. The suffering and torment he had inflicted upon her most precious friend, upon her love, her Catra. She took a deep breath and with a fierce battle cry, she raised both of her swords into the air and charged. As an army of clones converged from the white void to surround her. Adora snarled, her lips curling into a malicious grin. Her red eyes glowing with both fury and delight, relishing the blood bath to come. She cut threw the throng of clones without mercy, slicing them apart as if they were nothing. Leaves in the wind, scraps of paper to be discarded. She cut a swathe threw the clones, leaving each one gored thru the stomach, various arms and legs severed upon the ground. Their cooling bodies curled up, moaning and wailing from grievous wounds that would kill them slowly. When she stood before Prime, his expression was of irate bewilderment. Her smile was smug, her face damp with the blood of her enemies.

Prime took a step back, raising his hands in defense. The coward always relied on his clones to fend off any threat. Now he stood before her, weaponless and afraid. Where was all his arrogance and pomposity now? An ancient tyrant defeated and alone, before the might of Despara!

She was going to take her time with him, she had a thousand years of punishments to dish out for the deaths and atrocities he had inflicted upon the universe in her absence.

She sensed his wrath, it hung between them like a vile miasma. His placid expression twisting with hate. As he lunged, she offered him a glancing blow across the shoulder, slicing through the white cloth and decorative metal pauldron of his robe. Then striking upward with the other blade, drawing blood as she sliced through his wide metal chest armor. What oozed from his wounds looked green, iridescent and smelled rancid. Just like Hordak's and the clones ichor, but far more potent. It stung her eyes, some of it had splattered upon her cheek and it burned her skin. Hissing

upon contact with her flesh, sending sharp waves of pain throughout her body as if she had just been poisoned.

Prime stumbled back a few steps, clutching his chest as more of that strange blood oozed threw his fingers. There was fear and desperation on his face, while she merely winced briefly. The painful grimace on her lips was brief, quickly pulling to a wrathful sneer. It took only two more blows to strike him down, but this time they were precise. Hacking deep across his chest and abdomen, eviscerating him instantly.

She watched with satisfaction as he withered before her, falling to his knees, clutching piteously to his chest and stomach as if that would save his life. His skin shriveled and decayed as the green ooze that was keeping his host alive drained away. Leaving nothing but a puddle of loose flesh and stark white bones. His once proud and domineering presence reduced to nothing but a putrid mess of decay.

Adora scoffed, kicking at his bones with the toe of her black boot in disgust then turned on her heel and walked away. Disappearing into the frozen tundra once more.

"Adora....Wait!" Catra's terrified voice screamed. But it sounded distant, discordant. Threw the howling roar that now filled her head. Adora stomped forward, her whole body was humming with the raw current of pure rage and unbridled fury.

She laughed maniacally as she backed Catra up against a glacier wall. The cat girl was much younger, with her long mane and silver tufts behind her dark ears. Wearing heavier clothing for the cold and fingerless gloves. Her leggings were torn along the thigh and her left foot was twisted slightly. Adora remembered vaguely having grabbed her by the ankle with a crushing strength, as Catra sought to leap over her head. She had slammed Catra face first against the snow, releasing her hold only when she felt Catra's body go limp for a moment upon impact. Now Adora had her caged against the side of a cliff, sword raised above her head preparing to finish her off. Catra's face was scratched and

bleeding along her temple and cheeks from hitting the ice so hard. Her frightened mismatched eyes stared up at her. Wet with unshed tears, silently pleading for mercy.

Adora was so excited about her upcoming kill, she was panting. Her red veined face twisting in malignant fury. She was going to enjoy this...

Catra screamed and crossed her arms over her face, as Adora brought the Sword of Protection down in a finishing strike. Adora's own screams filled the air, as she felt the sword sink into Catra's stomach. Felt the flesh give and the organs shift as the steel pierced them threw. The crunch of bone as it pushed threw her spine and embedded its tip into the frozen ground below her now limp body. Catra's eyes stared up at her, dull and lifeless, her expression frozen in a look of misery and terror.

A weak, gasping sound filtered thru the red haze as Adora finally regained consciousness.

Catra was in motion within seconds of Adora's terrified screams piercing the night. Leaping off the roof and landing on the railing below, just as her foot claws struck the iron. She was flipping off, to land on her feet on the slate stone on the ground. Leaping threw their open window, heedless of whatever might be attacking her true love. Needing only to get to her side as quickly as possible, she would deal with whatever the threat was without a second thought. What she found was their dark room and a very, stricken and frightened Adora, curled up against Catra's pillow. Howling into the fabric, with deep gasping cries of fear and distress. The bed was a mess, the sheets twisted and balled up at the foot of it. Adora's pillow and their blanket strewn upon the floor. Whatever she had been fighting in her sleep had been intense.

“Adora..” Catra tossed her jacket aside and scrambled onto the bed. Pulling the trembling blonde away from the pillow and

enveloping her in her arms.

“She's still in there....” Adora breathed, her voice hoarse and broken. “She's still in there...” She repeated over and over in a hushed horrified whisper. As she clutched desperately at Catra's back, pressing her face tight against her soft furry chest. Her whole body quaking as she released powerful anguished sobs.

“Who...” Catra tenderly stroked the back of Adora's head. Her blonde hair was damp with sweat, clinging to her neck and shoulders. Catra was scared and on high alert, her pupil's blown out and nearly engulfing the blue and yellow of her eyes. Hyper vigilant to her surroundings, her gaze darting around the dark room, wondering who Adora was talking about. That perhaps this intruder that had caused Adora so much fear was still lurking somewhere. Her night vision was more sharp than her sight during the day and she could easily see poor Finn, standing by his mattress, clutching her baby blanket tightly to his chest. His soft blue eyes were wide, a stricken and uncertain expression plastered over his face, unsure as to how to help.

“Go get Glimmer and Bow!” Catra instructed him, needing to get him out of the room for a moment.

Finn nodded and dashed out the front door, taking the blanket with him.

Catra couldn't help the pride blooming in her heart at how attached he was with her gift. How he had used it for comfort and security in her absence. But she quickly got herself back on track, focusing on Adora. Who was curled up in her arms, shivering and crying loudly. The intense level of fear and crushing sorrow washing over her was alarming.

“Adora....my love...you gotta calm down..” Catra kissed her temple gently, rubbing her back in small circles. Adora was taking too many small, shallow breaths. Unable to deal with the raw, overwhelming fear and panic that was now dominating her.

“Breathe with me, Adora.” Catra instructed, brushing her wet hair off her face tenderly. As Adora slowly drew away from her chest. Catra never let her move far, keeping her arms around her tense shoulders. Holding her only an inch away, bunting their foreheads together. Clasping her hands on Adora's cheeks, staring calmly up into her terrified eyes.

Catra took a deep breath and held it, as Adora panted. Catra released the breath a few moments later then repeated the exercise. In time Adora took one shaky breath after another, attempting to follow Catra's lead. As she mimicked the breathing exercises, Perfuma had taught Catra earlier that day during her own panic attack.

“You're doing it...good..that's good Adora. You got this...we got this.” Catra smiled encouragingly, planting a sweet kiss to the center of Adora's forehead. Before resuming the breathing pattern with her.

Emboldened by the praise. Adora slowly became more calm, her breathing evened out and her sobs softened into faint sniffles and small trembling breaths.

“Is there someone in the room?” Catra asked covertly, against the shell of Adora's ear. Not wanting to give anything away if she needed to protect Adora from some unseen foe. Who might think they were being sneaky by hiding somewhere in the room.

“No...it was just a nightmare...but...it was so real...” Adora groaned, as she pulled away and scrubbed a hand down her face trying to wipe away the yucky feelings that lingered inside her.

“About...” Catra coaxed.

Adora groaned again, leaning back against the headboard, turning her face upward to stare despondently at the roof. Her hand remained clasped tightly with Catra's, who knelt before her patiently waiting for her to open up.

“I'll cut you a deal...” Adora smirked. “I'll open up about this horrible nightmare if you tell me about yours back in that cave in the Whispering Woods.”

Catra groaned, “I should have known, you'd use this to your advantage.” She snarled, pulling her knees up to her chest and glowering bitterly at her girlfriend as she rested her chin on her knees. Her ears fell and her tail wrapped around her legs meekly.

Adora offered her a lopsided grin, squeezing her hand reassuringly.

“I think I liked it better, when we just internalized our trauma and dealt with it poorly...” Catra groused.

Adora laughed, “Yep, I'd prefer to just punch it out myself and not talk about it. But that isn't working anymore.”

Catra sighed heavily. “Tell me about it, Perfuma nearly killed me today over a slightly mauled apple tree.” Adora raised an eyebrow inquiringly, she knew Catra better than that. She doubted that the poor tree was only slightly mauled, Catra had completely destroyed things back in the Fright Zone.

Adora released a deep breath as well. “So we talk it out instead...what could it hurt?”

“My pride...” Catra groaned. “I am really getting tired of crying...I might not be able to keep it together if I talk about it.”

“It's not going to be easy for me either.” Adora responded bleakly.

“I hate this...I really do...” Catra whispered, cutting her eyes away from Adora's to the mattress.

“I know...I'll go first...we can do it in small doses, maybe that way we won't be overwhelmed.” Adora shrugged. “I dreamed, I was that monster...the infected version of She-Ra.” Adora blurted out. Then waited, staring expectantly at Catra.

“I was back on Primes ship, getting chipped all over again.” Catra heaved out.

“I was consumed by rage and hatred and a thirst for killing. I had never known before.” Adora shuttered.

“After I saved Glimmer. Primes clones subdued me and bound my hands behind my back. Then they hauled me before Prime at his throne. He looked down on me with profound disappointment. Being the smart ass that I am, when I'm really scared. I laughed in his face and called him out on his own arrogance at ever trusting me. He got so furious, that he stood up from his throne and back handed me so hard across the face. That my face mask went flying and the force of his strike knocked me out. I woke up drowning in his reconditioning pool.” Catra shivered, tears threatening as she stared fearfully at Adora. Clamping her mouth shut, unable to continue. Holding herself tighter as the tip of her tail flicked with her discomfort. Staring mournfully at Adora, waiting for her to continue.

“Catra...” Adora moaned, seeing the pain and fear that lingered in her eyes. Adora squeezed her hand, offering support before pressing on with her own nightmare.

“I was slaughtering them....all of them...innocent people...Glimmer...” She swallowed hard, her eyes shimmering with guilt. “Then Shadow Weaver...Hordak and finally Horde Prime. I cut them all down without mercy...and I enjoyed it...the killing...the terror I saw in their eyes just before I delivered the final blow.” Adora scrubbed a hand vigorously over her eyes, seeking to wipe away the gore she had witnessed in her dream.

Catra squeezed her hand, “It wasn't real...” she reassured her before continuing.

“When I woke up...Prime had me naked and shackled to a metal table...it was dark and I couldn't see anything. I was really, really scared...” Catra whispered brokenly. “I couldn't move...my body

would not obey me anymore...the clones cut my hair...and implanted the chip....it hurt so much...”

“This really happened...those were memories...” Adora reached over and grasped her other hand, holding them both tightly. Shifting her position on the bed to kneel before Catra, seeking to offer her more comfort. As she noticed how Catra's whole body was beginning to tremble.

Catra merely nodded, as silent tears fell down her cheeks. She was pale, her eyes were weary and the pain of having to relive the horror of that time was evident on her face.
“Prime....Prime...tore through my mind, invading all of my memories, I couldn't fight him...I couldn't move or talk...I was helpless. As he ripped away all that I was...he....he...he took everything from me...” Catra wailed, her voice broken and breathless as heart wrenching sobs tore from the throat.

Adora's concerned expression, crumpled into one of pure misery. Completely devastated by the harsh realization of the extent of Catra’s suffering. The guilt and an overwhelming sense of failure, pressed heavy on her chest. Making it hard to breathe once more. Prime had mercilessly tortured and violated Catra...in the days it took for her to get to his ship. Adora was quick to get a hold of herself, not allowing herself to fall apart. Pulling Catra into her arms, holding her close. As Catra curled into her, caged protectively between Adora's legs. Pressing her face against Adora's neck, ears folded back, holding on tight, as she cried in gasping broken sobs. Purging all the fear and anguish she had endured during her captivity.

Adora cried along with her, one hand pressed firmly against the back of her head, holding her close, the other petting slowly down her bare back. Adora's sobs were deep with long held grief and heartbreak. The unseen wounds upon her heart, reopened by the clarity of finally knowing what really happened to Catra. A bleak understanding was now woven into those brutal memories. Of seeing Catra chipped on Primes dais. As he gloated about how she had been frightened and suffered while waiting for Adora to come.

How she had given up in the end, how her mind had been so ensnared with hate and pain all caused by Adora. The realization of how deeply she had hurt her once best friend...it ripped out her heart and left it shredded. She had so much yet to fix between them, she would spend the rest of her life showing Catra how much she mattered, how important she was and how much she was needed. All Adora wanted to do was soothe her and let her know that she was safe and that everything from now on was going to be better.

“It’s going to be ok...we’re together now...and nothing is going to tear us apart again!” She promised, holding tight.

Catra merely nodded, choking on her sobs as she struggled to calm down. It took a long while, but in time they both grew quiet and reflective once more.

“I killed you...I had you pinned against a glacier...” Adora admitted in a heaving breath. Her chest felt tight and a painful knot had formed in her throat.

Catra curled her arms more tightly around Adora's shoulder's....“You would have if Scorpia hadn't tackled you and gotten the sword away from you.” Catra admitted softly.

“That really happened...” Adora's voice was barely a whisper. So stunned and shaken by the revelation that what she experienced in her dream of attacking Catra so viciously had actually happened.

Catra nodded shamefully against her skin, her hot breath bathing the crook of Adora's neck.

“Oh...I'm so, so, sorry.” Adora cried in anguish, her hand grasping the back of Catra's head and holding her firmly against her neck. Her other arm, wrapped around her waist, squeezed. Pulling Catra tighter as Adora's whole body shook with remorse. Suddenly she found breathing near impossible, knowing that she had nearly killed the woman she loved. Ravaged by guilt, more terrified than

ever about the nightmare she just had and the implications that. That monster....this Despara... might still be infecting her magic.

“I'm the one who's sorry....it was my fault you turned into that monster in the first place.” Catra sniffled, gasping for air as she confessed her guilt. “I was so terrible to you.” She stuttered out, as rage at herself and a soul-deep sorrow engulfed her.

“I forgive you...” Adora whispered the response coming automatically. Pressing her lips tenderly on Catra’s temple. Catra sighed with relief, accepting her words. Nuzzling against her neck. So thankful for Adora...If it wasn't for her kindness and good heart, Catra would have never survived as long as she had. She owed Adora so much...she would spend the rest of her life showing this wonderful woman how much she meant to her. Adora the girl whom she loved with every fiber of her being.

“Thank you, for loving me...after everything...I've done...I don't deserve it....but I'm so, so, so grateful. ” Catra whispered brokenly, kissing Adora’s throat reverently over and over again.

Adora sucked in a sudden gasp of air, as she felt Catra's lips move downward towards her collar bone.

The raw emotional toll passing between them was too much to bear and Catra was seeking pleasure to replace the pain. Wanting...no needing for them to both find solace, once more in the throes of ecstasy. Adora silently agreed that she wanted that too. Her hands trailing down Catra's back, moving past her breast wrap. Her fingers crept under the waist of Catra's maroon leggings. Her fingers carding into her the soft fur of her lower back near the base of her tail. This was a highly sensitive spot for the Magicat that Adora had discovered accidentally years ago back in the Horde. She exploited that special spot now, wanting to give Catra as much pleasure as she could.

She dug her fingers into the thicker fur that grew around the base of her tail and scratched.

A loud rumble grew low in Catra's throat, as she instinctively pushed her rear into Adora's hands. Seeking more of the blissful sensations.

Adora leaned back against the bed, pulling Catra down on top of her. Keeping her legs spread so the Magicat could sprawl comfortably over her stomach.

“I love you...” Tears of adoration and remorse still shimmered in Catra's eyes. Her voice was hoarse, but impassioned, each word accented with a kiss as she trailed downward towards Adora's breasts.

Adora moaned, watching Catra's sensual path downwards intently. Her hands trailing down from the base of her tail to grip her ass, squeezing and pressing Catra's groin against her own.

“I could never hate you...Catra.” Adora gasped, as she felt the first of those small explosions deep inside of her, as Catra rubbed herself against her. “Never, I've always loved you...I always will.”

Catra hovered her lips, nervously over the peek of Adora's left breast. Her hands creeped down to the hem of Adora's night shirt. She stared into Adora's eyes silently asking permission to lift her shirt.

Adora nodded ever so slightly.

“I will never hurt you again...I only want to protect you, love you...” Catra promised, lifting her dull grey shirt slowly up over her head and tossing it aside. She stared down at her full, perfectly formed breasts. The skin was silky, smooth. The hint of a warm pink blush anointed the center of her breasts. With a slightly darker nipple already puckered from the chill in their room. She had seen them countless times before while they grew up. But she had held her attraction in check, refusing to allow her feelings for her best friend to flourish. Because at the time, she felt Adora never wanted her in that way. But this time, she was allowed to

gaze at Adora with as much hunger and need as she ever wanted.

“I never wanted to hurt you, either. Even when we were fighting, I never stopped loving you...I mourned the loss of our friendship everyday...I was a coward...I should have told you how much you meant to me at Thaymor...” Adora reached up with trembling hands to cup Catra's wet cheeks.

Catra stared at her, wonder and relief glowing in her eyes. Then Adora pulled her down as tears rolled down her cheeks. Capturing her lips in a long, sweet kiss. Their lips moved tenderly at first, quickly growing more urgent as Adora thrust her tongue inside. Catra moaned, arching herself against her as she countered with her own tongue. Soon the kiss had become wet, loud and hungry. As Adora held Catra in place with her hands on her cheeks, dominating the kiss. She sucked Catra's bottom lip for a moment before once again stroking her tongue inside, curling and twisting insistently as she tasted every inch of Catra's mouth. Catra was overwhelmed by Adora's passion and was quickly swept away.

Moaning and pressing herself against Adora, mindless with need. Rubbing her sex against Adora's groin, her ears flickering as she listening to all the sweet, lazy sounds Adora made.

Catra was emboldened by the kiss and her hand bravely cupped Adora's right breast, her fingers splayed over the peek. As she pulled away, Catra stared down at her, gauging her reaction to her more intimate touch. Finding Adora had her eyes closed, moaning softly, enjoying her sensual caresses. As Catra continued to explore how pliant and soft her breast was under her fingers.

“Those years...alone...I have never felt so empty...I never want to go back to that. I am so grateful that you came back for me, that you....stayed...I can't live without you ever again.” Catra breathed, watching Adora's cheeks bloom with arousal. Her blonde hair fanned out over the mattress already more disheveled than when she had found her earlier. Catra realized she must have kneaded her hands in Adora's hair while they were kissing. Catra's eyes

trailed nervously back down to her breasts, finding her other nipple stiff and begging for attention.

Unable to resist the temptation, Catra leaned down, her hot breath bathing Adora's breast for a moment making the blonde shiver. Catra softly took her nipple into her mouth and suckled gently. Adora gasped, cried out and arched upward.

Catra was exhilarated by the soft, desperate noises Adora was making. The sensations of her soft yet supple flesh in the palm of one hand. The velvet soft, yet hard nub that her lips devoured, the delightfully sweet taste against her tongue. The burning ache between her legs began to throb and she rubbed herself against Adora's sex more urgently, knowing that would bring relief.

Adora’s was consumed by her desire, but she held herself back. Want to take things more slowly this time. Her body had become hyper aware of every soft touch, every sensual kiss, the alluring heat of Catra's breath that sent goosebumps along her skin. Savoring every sensation of their lovemaking, wanting it to last. She brushed her hands up from gripping Catra's ass. Her finger's caressing upward along the curve of her back, as Catra hummed against her breast. Sending delightful tremors down her spine and sending electric tingles across the flushed skin of her breast.

Adora threaded her fingers into the back of Catra's thick dark hair, holding her firmly against her breast. Urging her to continue to tease her, relishing every swipe of her tongue, every soft suckle and sharp nip of her teeth. Groaning and sighing in dismay, when Catra pulled away, intent on playing with her other breast.

Adora was mindless with pleasure, her thoughts in a blissful fog as she pulled Catra's breast wrap up and over her head. Just as the feline shifted to mouth Adora's other breast. Adora was eager to tease and anoint her girlfriends breasts in the same reverent manner. Catra squeaked at the sudden reversal, as Adora rolled her onto her back. Straddling her waist and hovering over her. A determined desire burned in her steel blue eyes, as her golden hair curtained Catra's blushing face.

Catra was breathless and more than a little nervous at seeing such a fierce passion glowing in Adora's eyes. This was everything she had truly ever wanted, this complete surrender was also kinda scary. She had no time to protest or blurt out a snippy comment to ease her nerves. As Adora leaned down and devoured her lips with her own. Exploring her mouth with her tongue, nibbling her lower lip and tasting every inch of her mouth. Then moved to mouth a wet trail down her neck towards her collar bone, her destination clear.

“Adora...” Catra gasped, as Adora moved her mouth down Catras neck. Her kiss swollen lips, pressing sensually down the elegant curve with self assured intent towards her pert breasts.

“I want to touch you...kiss you...the same way...can I?” Adora whispered, her voice husky and low. Filled with a need so overwhelming Catra could only nod and moan in pleasure. As she felt Adora's lips surround the nipple of her left breast. Adora other hand, cupping her other breast perfectly.

So consumed by their desires they never heard the low creak of the front door opening.

“Adora...are you...” Glimmer's concerned voice went suddenly silent.

“Nope! They're doing just fine...” Bow's deeper voice cracked in sudden alarm.

Catra groaned in humiliation, pressing both hands to her now heated face. As Adora leaned over her, laughing hysterically. Then she looked shyly over her bare shoulder, finding a stunned Glimmer in her lavender nightie, being escorted away by a very red faced Bow wearing nothing but a pair of white boxers. They must have ran straight out of bed in complete terror when Finn rushed to them for help.

“Is Adora alright?” Finn's innocent, yet concerned voice echoed from outside.

“She's great!” Glimmer responded in a high pitched, nervous shout.

“Your having a sleepover, kid.” Bow responded more calmly.

“Oh...ok.” Finn added, his voice nervous and confused. As they listened to the best friends' bare feet slapping the stones and Finn's hooves clicking into the distance.

Catra had totally forgotten she had sent Finn to get them....

Adora turned back to Catra, her eyes wide and shimmering with both embarrassment and bliss. Catra started to laugh. It was an honest, joyful sound that echoed off the walls of their room like the chiming of bells.

Adora joined her laughter with her own, curling up on the bed beside her. She wrapped her arms around Catra's stomach and pulled her back against her front.

“You think we scarred them for life?” Catra asked quietly, when their laughter died down.

“Naw...that was payback. I caught them doing far worse, back on Darla.” Adora shrugged.

That got Catra's interest and she rolled in Adora's arms so they were facing each other.

“Tell me all the dirty details!” She demanded, her eyes wide and eager.

Adora laughed. “Only if you promise to be nice...” She smirked, knowing Catra would tease Glimmer mercilessly about it, if given the chance.
“I promise..." Catra groaned begrudgingly. "but it doesn't hurt to have blackmail material...just in case” Catra finished with a playful grin, a devious gleam in her eyes.

“Ok, I am definitely not telling you now.” Adora sighed, rolling onto her back.

Catra pouted for a moment then, a sly, mischievous smile graced her lips. Leaping on Adora, straddling her hips and digging her retracted claws into her sides.

Adora squealed and writhed under Catra, as the cat mercilessly tickled her.

“Tell me!” She commanded, attacking all of Adora's most vulnerable spots.

“No!” Adora cried, lunging out with her hands and infiltrating the tender spot under Catra's arms.

The hybrid wailed and twisted off Adora, soon finding herself under the blonde. As Adora straddled her waist and hovered over her. The tickle fight continued, Catra gave no quarter and Adora never gave up. Rolling and giggling, laughing and crying with glee as they fought. Until they were gasping for air, dozing in each other's arms. As the faint warmth of the coming day filtered into their room through the open window.

Adarion

A crisp knock on their front door, intruded rudely upon their sleep. Catra moaned plaintively and shifted beneath Adora, refusing to wake up. Catra's tail had curled unconsciously around Adora's upper arm in her sleep. It now flicked sharply and tapped Adora on the temple a couple times to wake her. Adora groaned in annoyance, as she felt Catra's intrusive nudge with her tail. Catra had fallen asleep on her front, with Adora hugging her from behind. The blonde slowly pulled herself off the soft warmth of her girlfriend's shoulder blades to kneel beside her. By the end of their tickle fight, Catra had fallen asleep on her stomach with Adora pinning her down, by sprawling over her back and promptly falling asleep along with her.

Feeling guilty about using Catra as a pillow, Adora gave her back a couple gentle strokes, smoothing the soft fur and massaging her shoulder's briefly. Catra's low contented purr resounded through the quiet dawn, as Adora sighed and reluctantly climbed from their bed. Groggy and uncoordinated, she managed two steps before tripping on their blanket that was balled on the floor at the foot of the bed. Yelping in alarm as she landed on her stomach, face first on the cold floor.

Catra was awake in seconds, lifting herself up off the mattress on all fours. She had fallen asleep on her front, angling sideways across the bed. Bleary and semi-alert she looked down at her girl, flat on the stone floor on her stomach grumbling.

“You're such an idiot...are you going to answer the door topless?” Catra commented lightly, curling her knees beneath her and arching her back to work out some kinks.

Adora rolled onto her back. “Right, right...so where's my shirt...” The cold stones on her hot skin, shocked her muscles and cleared the sleep deprived fog from her mind instantly.

Catra stretched her arms forward languidly, pointing vaguely to the other side of the bed.

Adora nodded and crawled over to where Catra pointed. Calling to whomever was at the door.

“Be right there..one moment.”

“I am here to gather Catra, she promised to join me in my morning meditations.” Perfuma's gentle voice filtered thru the heavy wooden door.

“Urgh...forgot about that.” Catra groaned, now in motion herself to gather up her breast wrap from the floor. “You're coming too.” She demanded, pulling on her black breast wrap. Then working on putting on the white, short sleeve training shirt. Then snatched her jacket off the floor. Slipping her bare arms into her leather jacket to cut the chill in the room that was now seeping into her body. Now that Adora wasn't keeping her warm.

Adora popped her head up from the floor on the other side of the bed. Her hair was a knotted, staticy, mess as she had just pulled on her white long sleeve shirt.

“Why?' She was dumbfounded by the suggestion.

“Really..” Catra arched a sarcastic eyebrow. “After your freak out last night, your going to just play stupid...like you don't need to learn to find some inner peace too?”

Adora merely shrugged. “I would much rather just talk it out with you and punch things.”

“Well I'm not qualified to actually help exercise your demons, Adora. But Perfuma might be.” Catra argued.

Adora rolled her eyes and groaned. She had one demon and it had a name...'Despara.' She didn't need to learn how to tame her, just purge that virus from her magic. Perfuma couldn't help with that.

“Just this once...please...try meditation. For me.” Catra pleaded.

“Alright...fine.” Adora releases a long, drawn out sigh. As if Catra was really asking a lot of her.

Catra chuckled, “Your hair...it's awful by the way. You might want to brush it.”

Adora narrowed her eyes, giving Catra a bitter pout. “Your hair isn't perfect either, Ms. Fluffy. ”

Catra groaned, remembering how crazy her hair was going to look now. All curly, fluffy and probably sticking up at odd angles in the front from how she had been sleeping.

“Adora!” She whined with embarrassment.

“You look cute, Catra. You just need to embrace it.” Adora quipped, running the brush through her long hair as she stood up.

“Can I come in?” Perfuma called, her voice rather high pitched and impatient. Still asking politely, if a bit more urgently. Since she had been standing out in the cool morning air for a long time.

Catra huffed and stubbornly planted herself in the chair, giving Adora a curt nod that she was ready to deal with Perfuma's reaction to her crazy fur.

Adora gave her a warm smile and moved briskly to the door and let Perfuma in. She gave Adora a thankful smile, bustling towards the cold fireplace. Still wearing her flowing pink dress, her green long sleeved shawl wrapped tight over her shoulders and around her waist. Adora was quick to pick up on Perfuma's gentle demand, to start a new fire. Adora closed the door and then moved to the fireplace, she crouched before the cold firebox, pulled back the chain mail and began to add dried logs to the iron cradle.

“Thank you.” Perfuma shivered and sighed gratefully, as Adora stacked the wood. Catra pointed a finger at the wood and called forth her fire. It sparked from her finger, shooting towards the wood in a tiny burst of flame. The fire was roaring in seconds, the sudden heat it gave off was soothing. Adora cast her a grateful smile, Catra nodded smugly in turn. While Perfuma stood before the fire, warming her cold hands and stomping her sandled feet. Glancing over her shoulder at Catra, offering her small, gentle smiles. She never said a word about her wild and crazy looking hair. Even though Catra had been fussing with it ever since she had entered their room. Combing her claws through it. Licking her wrist as she sought to groom herself. In a desperate attempt to tame her fur and wild, unruly mane.

“Catra, relax. I am a safe space...offering only peace and positivity.” Perfuma sighed, finally turning to regard her with a soft smile. Sitting on the stone lip of the fireplace to warm her back.

“There are times when things in our lives aren't how we want them to be. We must accept it and move on from it. If we can not change it, then we must learn patience. To allow those things that are out of our control the time to mend themselves.” Perfuma glanced up at Catra's wild hair briefly, acknowledging it.

Catra sighed, allowing her arm to drop from behind her left ear. In her attempt to get her hair to lay down she had given herself a huge cow lick instead. She glanced up at Adora as the blonde reappeared with her brush in hand ready to help. Catra shook her head and waved her off, she needed to just accept her fluffy, curly hair. Being self conscious and defensive of her appearance, worried about being picked on or harassed about it. Was just another toxic response to being bullied and picked up by older Horde Cadets in her youth.

“I'm cute...right?” She whispered nervously, struggling to accept herself as she was.

“The cutest!” Adora responded, pressing a tender kiss to her cheek. A low, contented purr rumbled from deep in Catra's throat

as she blushed under Adora's affection.

“It is rather chilly outside this morning, would it be alright if we meditated here. Your room is warm and it has a very happy vibe in it.” Perfuma glanced around the room, her expression relaxed and content.

“Sure.” Adora nodded.

“Will you be joining us?” Perfuma asked, moving from the fireplace to gather up some pillows from Melog's nest.

“If you don't mind, I guess.” Adora sighed heavily with indifference.

Melog watched her from their curled position against the wall, as Perfuma lifted three pillows. She smiled and held up the pillows towards Melog. Silently asking if it was alright for her to borrow them. Melog nodded, adjusting themselves and falling back to sleep.

“Of course, we would be more than pleased to have you join us.” Perfuma responded, as she turned and breezed back to the fireplace with her pillows.

Soon Perfuma had them sitting on the floor, on either side of her, on the pillows. With their backs to the crackling fire. Adora glanced over her shoulder with a smirk, as the fire danced and flickered towards Catra. Her element naturally being drawn to her presence, acting like an excited pet eager for attention.

Catra glanced back too, noticing how the flames had moved on the logs to her side of the fireplace.

“So...weird...” She muttered.

Perfuma laughed softly. “Being a Princess can be... a little weird...but it is also very rewarding.”

“Or terrifying...” Adora muttered under her breath.

Catra's ears flicked, hearing her bitter comment. She frowned in worry, Adora had been so elated to get She-Ra back. Now she was afraid of that power. Between seeing those red eyes again and hearing about Adora's nightmare. Catra had to admit, she was kinda scared of She-Ra too.

“Alright, lets get started.” Perfuma turned to Catra, pulling the strings of a small velvet bag that had been tied to the woven hemp belt she was wearing around her dress. “I was going to try something new with you Catra...”

Adora shifted nervously on her pillow, suddenly feeling like she was intruding. She had promised to try but she also felt rather foolish.

“I think maybe...I'll bail...” Adora chucked a thumb towards the door. Refusing to look at Catra, feeling her concerned stare.

“NO!” Perfuma's hand darted out and grasped her arm when she shifted to stand up. The flower princess's strength was surprising. She held Adora in place, her soulful hazel eyes boring into her. “Stay....mediating will be good for you too.” She promised gently.

“But...” Adora attempted to speak, her voice falling silent under Perfuma's now stern gaze.

“Adora....I can feel your aura...its all kinds of messed up. Your mind, body and soul are imbalanced...I can fix that.” Perfuma sighed, her hand flippantly waving up and down Adora's body.

“Ok...” Adora nodded, sitting back down and crossing her legs. Hoping that perhaps learning to focus better would be enough to bury if not purge that darker version of She-Ra that was currently haunting her.

“What I am going to do is guide each of you in meditation, ok.” Perfuma smiled sweetly when they both nodded in unison. Then

she nodded back in agreement. Before returning her focus on her bag, she poured out the contents on the stone floor.

Adora and Catra stared at the small assortment of various colored, smooth, shiny stones that were on the floor.

“Why did you bring your rock collection” Catra's eyebrows furrowed in confusion. “We planning on skipping some stones after?” she quipped with a smirk.

Perfuma groaned, “I understand you need to crack jokes when you're feeling nervous, Catra. But these Meditation stones are sacred to my people.”

Catra cringed with remorse, her joke suddenly feeling rather mean spirited.

“I brought them, because I feel you need help staying focused while meditating.” Perfuma continued.

“Why?” Catra asked leaning over to study the small stones.

“Because you fell asleep last time.” Perfuma sighed with exasperation.

Catra never realized she had fallen asleep.

“Sorry...” Catra muttered.

“These stones will help with your healing and allow your mind, body and soul to find harmony more easily. “ Perfuma glanced over at her, scanning up and down her body.

“What are you looking at?” Catra suddenly felt rather on display, like some specimen under a microscope. Her ears folded back and she wrapped an arm around her chest protectively. She didn't like Perfuma's unblinking, penetrating stare. It made her feel nervous and vulnerable.

Perfuma merely grunted and turned back to her stones. Then gathered them all up and put them back in her bag as if rescinding the offer to help.

Suddenly Catra was worried she had done something wrong.

“What's the matter?” Catra sputtered, suddenly feeling like maybe she was a lost cause and Perfuma was giving up on her.

“I am working out my thoughts...Catra.” Perfuma offered her a knowing smirk. “Before I decide, if this is the right course of action to take to help you.”

“Ah...” Catra rolled her eyes at the gentle nudge at her less than ideal tendency to react impulsively. When things don't go in her favor instead of quietly and rationally thinking things out first.

Adora snickered and Catra cut her a scathing glare. “You don't get to talk, princess. You are just as impulsive as I am.”

Adora raised a finger in protest. “I am not!”

“You offered yourself to Prime on a silver platter, just to try and save me....” Catra snarked back. “You didn't even have She-Ra at the time...how is that a well thought out plan!”

“I couldn't just leave you there.” Adora snapped back. “I had to try...”

“You never listen to me!” Catra sniped back. “I would have....been”(*fine)* Catra clamped her mouth shut, not finishing her statement, knowing full well it was just false bravado. She would not have been fine, she would have eventually been devoured by Primes Light (*the Horde chip*). If Adora had left her there, like she had wanted. The thought made her whole body shiver with fear. She had become so toxic and destructive to everyone around her. Never wanting to be vulnerable or get hurt by anyone ever again. Ultimately losing everything that truly mattered and being utterly alone. She was more then willing to sacrifice herself, then. To do that one good thing and save

Adora....be the hero for once. She quickly curled her knees up to her chest, wrapping her arms tight around her legs. Her ears folded back as her tail lashed behind her anxiously. Melog grumbled a low growl, rising from their nap to pad behind Catra. Sitting behind her and lowering their head over her shoulder. Pressing their weight against her back, offering their support and comfort, subtle as always.

Catra heaved a shaky breath and palmed Melogs's cheek lovingly.

“Thanks buddy.” She leaned the side of her face into their soft fur, absorbing their calm presence into herself.

Perfuma observed the encounter with interest. Watching curiously as Catra's agitated aura began to flow in tune with Melog's soothing frequency. The magic alien cat was able to harmonize with Catra's aura and influence her emotional state. She could see how quickly Catra's agitated expression softened into one of calm reflection.

“Catra...” Adora leaned around Perfuma, her voice soft and full of worry.

Perfuma groaned, rubbing two fingers into her temples in frustration. Adora’s intrusion had sent Catra's aura spiking back into turmoil. Melog chuffed and padded back to their pillows to watch them intently with their softly glowing eyes.

“You guys are going to be...a....challenge...” Perfuma ground out, dumping her stones back out. She glanced over at Adora for a moment then nodded.

“These stones are going to help both of you to heal and open yourself up to more positive energies. Stars alive....you need it!” She continued, methodically sorting out the stones into two piles. She nodded when she felt they were correct, then picked up the first pile of stones.

“Catra, I want you to hold these before I guide you into meditation, alright.”

Catra nodded, unfolding her legs and tucking them under her, holding out her hand for the stones.

Perfuma poured them into her palm and waited to see if they harmonized with Catra's aura.

The stones were cold at first but then quickly grew warm against her palm. Catra's ears swiveled as she heard a low humming vibration coming from the stones. She snapped her head up in surprise, finding Perfuma smiling knowingly down at her.

“Are they magic?” Catra asked quietly.

“In a way.” Perfuma nodded, turning to pour the rest of the stones into Adora's palm.

Adora curled her fingers over the stones, holding them a little too firmly. Nervous about losing them.

Perfuma tapped her knuckles lightly.

“You are too tense, Adora. I need you to relax your muscles so that your mind will be more receptive to the Stones healing frequencies.”

“Good luck with that.” Catra muttered dryly, Perfuma gave her knee a swat.

“Not helping Catra.” She commented sharply.

Adora huffed indignantly, she could relax....right. Meditating was easy, you just had to sit still and be quiet...she could do this...she could do this....?

“Alright, I want you to close your eyes and I want you both to repeat these words after me.” Perfuma wiggled her butt into her cushion, resuming a lotus pose with her back straight. Both Adora and Catra adjusted their sitting posture to mimic hers. Closing their eyes and bowing their heads.

“I am present.” Perfuma stated, Adora and Catra repeated.

“I am here.” Perfuma continued. “I am breath.”

Perfuma repeated the focusing phrase several more times, listening for when both Adora and Catra's breathing began to deepen and became calm. Knowing that all the muscles in their bodies would follow, becoming relaxed and receptive to the Stones.

Perfuma opened her eyes, glancing at either woman gauging their auras. Finding the stones had helped, their auras were glowing softly around their bodies slightly less jagged. Their energies are humming over their skin now, in softer, throbbing waves. She waited for a few more minutes, repeating the mantra. When there was no further change to their aura's she continued.

She shrugged and moved into the next healing phase of meditation.

“I am strong.” She whispered, Adora and Catra responded in turn.

“I am healthy.” Perfuma stated, “I am whole.” She had them repeat the mantra several more times. With a calming sigh, she opened her eyes again. Finding their aura's had finally evened out, glowing harmoniously with the vibrations of the stones. She let them remain in the healing phase for a long time, having them slowly and methodically repeat the phrase. Giving the stones time to open all the blockages in their mind and body to allow the energy to flow freely through their astral spirit.

With a resolute nod, Perfuma finally moved into the final, affirming mantra.

“I am happy.” She whispered softly, they repeated the phrase just as quietly.

“I am worthy.” Perfuma stated, “I am capable.” She finished.

Then had them repeat the mantra several more times, before opening her eyes to gauge the change in their auras. She glanced at each woman with a proud smile, that slowly fell into a disgruntled frown.

Both Catra and Adora were still gripping the stones, if a bit more loosely. With their heads slumped forward, chins resting against their chest, still sitting upright and perfectly balanced on their crossed legs....fast asleep. Their aura's once again vibrating out of sync with the harmony of the stones. Pulsing aggressively with their turbulent emotions.

"Honestly..." Perfuma stood up and dusted off her skirts, proceeding to procure the kettle from the side of the hearth and begin to prepare some tea. Wondering bitterly if this was a Horde Orphan thing...the ability to fall asleep in any given position. Scorpia kept falling asleep too, when she tried to meditate with Perfuma.

Adora

The heat from the sun was far hotter than it should be this time of year. She could feel the soft grass and moist earth pressed against her back. Slowly she opened her eyes, releasing a deep groan. She felt dizzy and out of sorts, her mind was sluggish and it took a bit to clear the haze. Staring up at the clear sky above, instantly aware that she was not on Etheria. Not only had the season's changed, but also her location. It had been early morning back on Etheria and she had been trying to meditate in her room with Catra and Perfuma. Now she was laying out on some lush glade amid a strange corpse of fir trees. It was mid afternoon at best, perhaps the day was even winding down towards evening? The air in this place was different, heavier and

more musky. Etheria's air was always light and fragrant with the soft, sweet scents of life and magic.

She slowly sat up to take account of her surroundings. Finding a long, dusty road a few miles away down the hill from her shelter of trees. She squinted and raised a hand to shield her eyes from the suns glare. Finding a dust cloud rolling down the road, signaling the approach of someone. She could see a lone rider, sitting on the front bench of a simple wooden cart. Pulled by a strange, grey scaly beast. With a thick, blocky head and black beady eyes, tiny pointed ears jutted from the sides of it's broadhead. They twitched at every sound, as it trudged up the hill. It had heavily muscled legs with flat, three toed feet ending in blunt black claws. A wide barrel chest and thick torso. The tiny stub of a tail at the end of its ample rear flicked at fly's, as they attempted to land on it's back. The beast was harnessed to the cart, by a simple wooden pole-collar and thick metal chain traces. It's thick shoulder pulling the cart forward, laboriously up the hill towards the corpse of trees Adora was resting in. Two other people were walking beside the cart. The hulking lizard plodding at a lazy pace so it would take a while for them to get here.

Adora couldn't afford to be too trusting in such an alien place, she had no idea how she got here or how to get back to Etheria. So she darted into cover behind the shelter of thick bushes and dried bramble that grew along the tree line. As the dust cloud grew thicker, signaling the group's arrival. The cart held several barrels and loose straw. She could see the two men walking by the cart more clearly now. They were both rather tall and burly, with dusty blonde hair and deep blue eyes. They looked like identical twins. Wearing unfamiliar clothes. A tunic that was simple in design and knee length brown pants, she guessed they were peasants. Adora listened to the men as they spoke to each other. Watching their lips form alien words she could not understand at first. Her eyes throbbed and watered, irritated by the kicked up dust as she lay flat against the ground behind the hedge. When suddenly the throbbing eased and everything became clear. Their words became fluid and understood, as her mind grasped onto the

ancient language of the First Ones...they were speaking Eternian...

As the cart rumbled past, Adora's eyes widened in both surprise and alarm. The driver of the cart had tan skin and long dark brown hair tied back and braided loosely. With a fierce beauty to her features and piercing blue eyes. It was....Mara...She was younger...years younger. Wearing the same strange common clothes as the men. Adora's heart leaped into her throat, she jumped up and lunged forward, without thinking. Breaking cover with a sharp cry. Seeking to alert them of her presence over the rumbling din of the cart's wooden wheels. She needed help, answers...and Mara was the only familiar face she had seen so far. The cold dread of being displaced in both time and place, held firm and clenched her heart. How did she get here....how was she going to get back to Etheria?

The cart never slowed, the troupe of Eternian's acted as if they never heard her as if she didn't exist. Adora stood dumb founded by the road, watching bleakly as the cart and its dust cloud faded out of view down the road. A strange sense of calm overtook her, she was not going to dwell on how she got here. Whatever the reason, she was here now, she needed to gather information and figure out how to get home. Adora watched the cart descend the hill, winding around the base and out of view. Adora sighed and headed off down the road, intending to follow the cart to its destination.

The countryside was lush and full of slopes and valleys. When she had ascended to the crest of another steeper hill. She looked out over the countryside in awe. The late-afternoon sun was warming the pastures and fields within the valley below in blankets of gold. This strange land was beautiful. The colors of the grass and wheat were verdant, almost glowing under the heat of the hot sun. She could hear the vibrant sounds of herd animals, crooning from the pastures. The twittering sounds of small birds within the canopy of trees that stood in small groves in the meadows below. The air was rich with the scents of life and a welcoming aura greeted her

as she gazed down at the rustic farm houses and quaint village nestled near the valley's center.

Adora drew in a deep breath, as she scanned the farmlands that stretched out beyond her. Her eyes tracing the sparkling path of a solitary stream, that cut a lazy path through the valley. The tranquility and sense of home felt heavy on her heart. This was Eternia....her birthplace...and it was absolutely breathtaking.

"It was a beautiful planet...ancient...much like Etheria." Light Hope's voice invaded her reverie.

Adora sucked in a cold breath, at the finality in Light Hope's voice. What had happened to Eternia? She knew it was still around. Jitsu had spoken in length about her family and how his people had been banished to the dark side of the planet. Was this what the light side of the planet once looked like. Prime had mentioned that he had fought a war with the First Ones, that he had thought he had wiped them out thousands of years ago? The fact that she existed was proof that some faction still remained. That she was taken from Eternia confirmed that the planet had not been destroyed. But Jitsu had explained that Eternia was slowly dying for a thousand years. The First's Ones War with Prime had come with a tragic cost. She slowly turned to find the Hologram standing regally beside her once more. Her silver eyes scanning the valley, her expression as always stiff and clinical.

"I'm dreaming then." Adora concluded upon seeing Light Hope. This dream was so vivid, so real. Light Hopes presence for once offering relief and not more disconcerting questions. "How am I seeing Mara...so young?" Adora huffed, staring up at Light Hope with grim determination to know the truth. This dream was far more detailed and real than her limited imagination could come up with. It was as if she had entered a memory? One of Mara's….perhaps?

"These are your memories, just like before." Light Hope stated.

Adora's mouth dropped open in stunned confusion.

“These would be Mara's memories...not mine.” Adora stated defiantly

“Ahhh...I must clarify then. These are She-Ra's memories.” Light Hope nodded.

“What?” Adora huffed, even more confused.

“She-Ra, is a being of pure magic..she is eternal and has retained the memories of every vessel she has inhabited. So in essence since you are the current vessel of She-Ra, you also hold the memories of thousands of previous vessels.” Light Hope gave her a patient smile.

Adora was suddenly overwhelmed by that knowledge. How would she even be able navigate the lives of thousands without going completely insane!

“That is one of the many functions of the Crystal Castle.” Light Hope offered, seeking to calm the panic she saw in Adora's eyes. “That is why it can project memories...it is capable of helping you navigate through the lifetimes. It is an archive of all the She-Ra's that once lived, that is why it scanned you in that room of darkness. It encoded your memories into its data bank so that the next She-Ra could use them, learn from them when the time came.”

Adora scrubbed her hand down her face, her mind was churning with the ramifications of what Light Hope was telling her.

“The Crystal Castle...would it have a record of an evil She-Ra called Despara?” Adora inquired, not having much hope that the hologram would give her a proper answer.

“Despara....” Light Hope's sight was drawing inwards, her lips pulled into a concentrated frown. An expression Adora had come to know when she was scanning her internal database. “I am sorry, I have no record of a Despara?” She offered a few moments later.

“I didn't think you would know of her.” Adora sighed, but at least she had been pointed in the right direction to get answers. As soon as she got back with Catra from their journey to the Red Squad Memorial. They were going to head to the Crystal Castle. If it held all the memories of all the She-Ra's from the past then she was confident they would find this deviant She-Ra...this Despara as well.

“Oh, Look to the skies, my Wildling.

Chase the sun, until forever comes.

and let your shadow's fall behind you.

For we will be together again,

within the eternal flames, of Adarion. “

A deep, melodic voice echoed from beyond this distant memory. The mournful song, called out to her from the old world...of ancient Etheria. It was a voice that had been weathered by sorrow and loss.

“Oh, Look to the skies, my Wildling.

When daylight's fading, still your breath.

Be safe in the arms of love.

For we will be together again,

within the infinite starshine, of Etheria."

The soothing sounds of a mother, singing to a much loved child. As a thick fog rolled in, covering the valley and cloaking both Light Hope and Adora in it's murky depth.

"Oh, Sing to the skies, my Wildling.

For destiny calls, to the brave.

The fire within will light your way.

For we will be together again,

Beneath the skies, of Serenia."

Adora spun around in alarm, as the dulcet tones of the song began to lull her senses. Her heart was hammering in her chest as she lost sight of Light Hope, the trauma of the malevolent fog from the lowland marshes slamming through her. Sending her body into a fight or flight panic. She raised her fists, scanning her feet, anticipating being attacked by tendrils of darkness. That might try and snatch her ankles.

"Oh, Sing to the skies, my Wildling.

Chase the sun until forever comes,

and let your shadow's fall behind you. "

Then Catra's beautiful voice joined the harmony of the deeper, mournful singer. The sound of her love soothed Adora's fear instantly.

"Catra?" Adora called out, now having the courage to walk forward into the unknown gloom. As long as she was moving towards Catra's voice, then she knew she was going somewhere safe...she was going home...

Catra

The dark sky above was filled with stars, twinkling down upon her like tiny sparks of flame. She marveled at how vast and fathomless the universe was, stretching out endlessly over her head.

"The night sky always was a magnificent sight from this outlook." A soft, melodic voice called out to her.

Catra sucked in a sudden breath, darting her gaze down. Finding that she was once more standing on the very peek of the stone monolith that once dominated the savannah of her people. Her mother sat demurely on the flat boulder that once hid Loo-Kee. Dressed in her lighter, sleeveless, deep orange tunic with the white threaded patterns, woven with sunstone crystal shards. That she wore during the hot season, during their first hunt together. Her dark hair was tied back in a simple braid, her crystal beaded headband keeping her bangs and beaded tufts tucked away along her temples. Her darker brown ears twitched lazily, tail swinging behind her, brushing the dirt on the side of the boulder in long sweeps. She stretched out her hands, offering her daughter a warm smile of greeting. Her clear blue eyes were gentle, filled with love and a yearning to hold her.

Catra could feel the tears welling and she cried out in glee, running for all that she was worth across the barren ground and into her mothers waiting arms. She wailed and clutched at her mother, she had dreamed of this moment her whole life. She might have boasted to Adora growing up that she never cared about her real mother, that she had been abandoned and never even thought about her. But as most things with her growing up, she never told Adora how she truly felt...ever...To scared or to proud, or to insecure. It was safer to wallow in her bitterness and rage then confront her vulnerabilities, her loneliness and fears.

Aoi held her tight, loud, heart felt sobs rocking from her own body. As she was petting a hand down the back of her daughter's short mane. Cooing and humming soothingly, as she might have if Catra was still a baby. Seeking to calm both her and her daughter and heal the pain and sorrow created by their unjust separation.

"I have missed you...my little Wildling." She pulled Catra away from her neck long enough to press a fond and loving kiss to the middle of her forehead. Catra had seen her kiss the infant version of herself many times in her dreams. To finally feel the adoration and warmth of her mother's lips against her fur, it was beyond her ability to comprehend. She gasped and broke into a new bout of sobs, grinning happily and clutching onto her mother yet again.

"Mother..." Catra breathed a few minutes later, sniffling and whimpering as she attempted to quell the last of her tears. Grinning up at her mother, her cheeks flushed and eyes shimmering with even more joyful tears.

"Let me look at you, my dear girl." Aoi gave her shoulder's a quick shake. Her smile is warm and full of pride.

Catra laughed and pulled out of her mothers arms, standing up and smiling sheepishly as she spun in a small circle before the boulder.

“My you have grown into a fine young dame. A little too skinny...” Her praise turned playfully sour.

“I am eating better now.” Catra shrugged, scampering back to her mothers side. “The Horde...” Catra was quick to silence the rest of her explanation, not wanting to make her mother feel guilty or upset about how cruel her life had been growing up. It wasn't her fault..Catra held no grudges towards the feline. She did the best that she could to keep Catra safe, to keep her alive. Their people were being purged at the time, the Rune Bearer of Fate also played role in her parents sealing Catra away in a stasis pod. Committing her to the future in the hope that this prophecy would come true, that she would be alive to play her part in saving the Universe.

“Come, sit...this may be the only time we have to speak.” Aoi sighed, her eyes darkened with guilt. She quickly covered it up with a small smile, patting the stone beside her. What was done, was done. She had to make the most of this time.

“How are you here?” Catra mimicked her mother's posture on the boulder, tucking one leg under her butt and leaving the other leg to dangle over the side of the stone. Her ears were perked, eager to hear more of her mother's voice. Her tail was swinging joyfully behind her, as she lightly thumbed away the last of the moisture from her cheeks.

“You called out to me, Kaira.” Aoi lightly took both her hands in hers, smiling sweetly. “So the Immortal helped guide me here...to this place between...woven with the magic of Time, of Dream...of love. ” She glanced around the now warming savannah mildly. She knew it wasn't real, that she was not alive, that all of this was a fantasy that lay within her daughter's spirit, created by Etheria's magic.

Catra chuckled darkly, “Seeing you is so much better then Shadow Weaver.”

Aoi, eyes narrowed and her grin fell into a furious scowl. "I am truly sorry, that fate led her onto your path."

Catra's laughter died. "How do you know...about...her?"

"Upon her passing, her soul entered the afterlife. She has been judged by the Immortal before being allowed to cross over to the Eternal Realm. We have had words..." Aoi smiled, sadly. "I despise what that vile woman did to you...but I was thankful you had Adora. You are in a better place now, with good people and Adora....she is your mate?" Aoi nodded, wanting confirmation that Catra was doing better now. Catra smiled and reached out and took her mother's hands, giving them a soft squeeze. Catra swallowed hard, nodding happily. Confirming silently that she was in a better place and had finally claimed her heart's desire with Adora.

"I am stronger for it." Catra offered, wanting to reassure her that she survived and was moving forward to a happier, more hopeful future.

"Ah, that you are Wildling. You are far stronger, braver and more cunning than any Sunna Warrior. I have ever known. That makes me so proud. You are going to do great things! Amazing things and you will bring our people home. I know it!" Aoi's pained expression brightened back into a grateful smile. Catra grinned, her eyes shining with joy and personal pride for the very first time. A fire bloomed in her chest at the praise. She finally felt validation, that she was worthy and had the power to achieve anything she set her mind on.

"The Immortal...is Angella?" Catra inquired softly, as all that her mother had said slowly sank in.

Aoi merely nodded as if it was common knowledge.

They sat in silence for a few minutes.

"You want me to find our people?" Catra finally spoke up, her voice was soft. Trepidation and doubt hung heavy upon her

deepening frown.

“Yes, they are lost...scattered among the stars. You must bring them home, Kaira. Rebuild our kingdom and honor Ouroboros everyday for his sacrifice.” Aoi instructed.

Catra swallowed that was a tall order, considering she had no idea even where to look. The universe was far too big to just pick a direction and hope for the best. The pressure her mothers request put on her was suddenly very unbearable. Jitsu had stated there were lots of Magicats on Eternia...well maybe that was where to start?

“You look ready to bolt, Kaira. Take a deep breath, my Wildling. It isn't a quest you must fulfill in one day. You have a lifetime to devote to this task, my daughter. It is your destiny as the Rune Bearer of our people to guide them, protect them. Give them a home to come back too...that's all I ask.” Aoi sighed, pulling her into another more gentle hug. Catra embraced her, nodding mutely against her shoulder.

“I will bring them home...I promise.” She whispered, basking in the familiar sweet, smell of her mother. Subtle yet fragrant like the burning of spruce wood and honeysuckle.

As the sun's warmth began to glow upon the horizon. Aoi released her and turned towards the light, bowing her head in reverence.

“Bow your head, Wildling. Pay your respects to the Sun, Adarion. Threw this act, you renew your connection to your element.” Aoi instructed.

Catra watched in awe, as her mother began to sing. Her voice was low and full of sorrow and loss. As she sang to the rising sun, an eternal and mournful love song.

Catra sat in silence, the lyrics calling to her, searing themselves into her mind. This was her mother's lullaby to the sun, a song she had heard by firelight from within the confines of her crib. A crooning dirge sung to her, day after day, night after night as they

were on the run from the Eternian hunting them. As an infant it had brought her solace and consoled the fear and uncertainty she felt moving from place to place, never knowing what awaited her on the coming dawn. It was easy for her to add her own voice to her mother's cherished lullaby. Her voice was more vibrant, ascending with love and hope towards her peoples guiding star, Adarion.

She had experienced much hardship and cruelty in her own young life. It gave her voice strength and cadence, but her soul was yet unbowed by the weight of true loss. So had yet to carry the full burden of grief and sorrow that her mother's voice echoed with. When they finished, the sun had crested the horizon bathing the sky in brilliant bands of pink and orange hues. The clouds hung heavy on the horizon, just above the morning glow, threatening rain. As the twittering calls of birds began to echo down in the ancient oasis below.

"That was beautiful..." Catra breathed.

"That is my Aubade to the Sun." Aoi smiled, fondly, cupping her cheek with a tender hand. Catra hummed and pressed her face further into her touch. Closing her eyes and basking in her mother's warmth and love.

"You may sing this every morning as the sun rises and then again at dusk as the sun sets as requiem. It honors your star and helps to focus your magic. But in time, I want you to sing your own love songs, so Adarion may truly see your soul. " She instructed gently.

Catra nodded mutely. It wasn't so far-fetched to believe, her people were very lyrical. During her time living among them in her dreams. She had seen many Fire Dances, in which minstrels played all manner of instruments while young or old bards sang all kinds of different songs. Some were beautiful, some eerie others were just raunchy shanty's.

"CATRA!!!" Adora's voice boomed out over the savannah, echoing off the rock monolith.

“Adora...” Catra was stunned, she scrambled off the boulder and raced to the edge of the barren stone. Scanning the field of yellow grass below, searching for her love.

“I heard you singing....I followed your voice...from my own dreams to yours...” Adora chuckled, marveling at this new magic. Raising her head and giving Catra a proud if goofy grin.

“That's really...sappy...magic is so weird!” Catra laughed nervously, she didn't know if this was some strange new She-Ra power or maybe it was a part of her magic...or maybe it was Angella's doing. Either way it was as much endearing as it was unnerving. She really didn't want Adora to have the ability to sneak into her dreams...cause sometimes they could be rather erotic. Currently centered around Adora, wearing nothing but strawberries and cream...

Catra groaned as those sensual memories flooded her mind, leaving her flustered and blushing.

“How did you get up there!” Adora's voice screamed from the bottom of the massive lone rock.

“I climbed up, dummy.” Catra called back, cupping her hands to her mouth to help the sound carry.

“Well, I don't have claws so how am I supposed to climb up this thing?” Adora hollered back in frustration.

Catra clutched her stomach laughing at her girlfriend's predicament, as the blonde stomped around the base of the sheer stone mountain. Then clumsily scrambled up a few feet then lost her footing sliding back down to the ground with an angry shout.

Aoi had come to hover beside her daughter, staring down at Adora with pity.

“I can do this...I can do this...” Adora was pacing and muttering below. Her blue eyes, fierce and unyielding. Staring upward and memorizing her path along the rock wall. Her expression is mulish

and stubborn. Refusing to be bested by a giant hunk of smooth sandstone.

"That is your Adora.." Aoi mused, with a curious shake of her head. "She is the current She-Ra, yes?"

"Yes...but her powers are a little messed up right now. So I doubt she will summon that magic any time soon." Catra sighed heavily, as she watched Adora try to climb the stone again. Making it just a little higher before promptly loosing her footing and sliding back down.

Aoi paid her a strange look, "Odd..." she muttered, then her eyes flew wide in surprise as Adora fell once more. Screaming and cursing as she slid down the rock face back onto the ground.

"Human's can not climb Mount Sunna ...it is impossible." Aoi stated, placing her hands on her hips as she watched Adora start her climb yet again. She was going slower this time, moving methodically. As she used the various hand and foot holds she had already memorized from previous falls. Gaining more ground each time she attempted the climb. Deducing what crack or crevice would hold her weight, as she pulled herself up one inch at a time. Using the tips of her finger's, to hang from narrow ledges several feet below them and then swing her legs up, almost vertical to her own body. Wedging her feet into a deep crack before pulling herself over by one reaching arm. Slowly, climbing upward again, giving them a triumphant grin as she got closer.

"Adora never gives up. She can do this...she has always been able to do the impossible." Catra smirked at her mother, watching Adora with pride as the blonde eventually climbed to the top.

When she finally crawled over the edge, Catra helped her to her feet.

"I knew you could do it." She grinned proudly at Adora, giving her cheek a sweet kiss.

“Well, I had a really good teacher growing up.” Adora huffed, leaning over her knees to catch her breath.

“You taught a human to climb...that is quite a feat, Wildling.” Aoi laughed.

“We had lots of high places we liked to climb to, back in the Fright Zone.” Catra stated, wrapping an arm around Adora's waist and guiding her to the boulder to rest.

The blonde merely nodded still far to out of breath to respond.

When Adora finally regained her composure she stood up and regarded Catra with a smug grin.

“Told you I could do it!” She proclaimed proudly.

“Never doubted you for a second.” Catra smirked, knocking her shoulder against hers.

Adora groaned, her arms were far to numb and sore to lift. They hung at her sides limp and lifeless, tingling as they slowly regained proper circulation.

Catra grimaced and then giggled softly, offering her a sad mournful look.

“It's ok...I'm just tired..” Adora heaved, sliding down the side of the boulder to the dry scrub grass.

Aoi approached quietly, crouching down in front of Adora. Her eyes took in all of Adora with silent scrutiny.

“This is my mom!” Catra pointed with a huge smile.

“Who?” Adora sighed, looking around blankly.

Catra's smile fell in confusion.

“My time is up, Kaira.” Aoi stood. “Your mate is strong and pure of heart, I approve.”

“Wait...” Catra darted away from Adora, tears already streaming down her cheeks. Desperate to get to her Mother's side as she began to walk towards the edge of the cliff. Heading forward into the glare of the sun and the lush grotto below.

“Always walk towards the Sun, my daughter and let your shadows fall behind you.” Aoi called, her voice fading along with her body within the morning glow of the sun.

“Mother.!” Catra screamed in anguish, reaching for her fading silhouette. “Don't go!”

“Catra...” Adora's concerned voice called her back and Catra spun from the edge of the stone, to find Adora standing just behind.

Unwelcome images of her past life, memories both dear and agonizing, that she fought daily to stay at bay. Became a roaring flood through her mind. Images of her mother, her father..dead a thousand years. The comfort and security she felt while playing on the rug, with homemade toys, before the fireplace in their small cottage on the outskirts of the Sunna village. The innocent joys of wrestling with the other kittens of her village, while her mother or father did business with the merchants or spoke to the elders. The excitement of the feasts and fire dances she had been able to attend during the few seasons she had lived in the Serenia Savannah. The joy and exhilaration of climbing and listening to the timeless rumble of Ouroboros as he told her tales in the deep cavern beneath Mount Sunna. Finally she lost the struggle as it all became too much. She wailed in sorrow, grieving the loss of her parents and her world all over again. Darting into Adora's arms, who held her tight, offering soothing words of comfort and tender kisses to her temples, to help alleviate the pain.

Perfuma sat on the chair, sipping tea, observing Catra and Adora with a curious frown. Their hands had crept towards one another in their sleep. Too far apart on their pillows to hold hands properly, just their pinkies were intertwined overtop her

abandoned pillow between them. Their aura's pulsing and humming in sync with each other's. Adora's expression was deeply furrowed in pain and confusion. While Catra's had crumpled into sudden and profound anguish. Silent tears falling down her bowed face, dripping off her chin. Perfuma heaved a great sigh and set her tea down on a little wooden table set beside the chair. Feeling that now was a good time to take her leave. She moved first to Catra and then Adora. Scooping up her centering stones from were they had fallen to the floor by their knees. Pouring them back into her velvet bag. She stood silently and padded quietly out of their room, closing the door softly behind her. Giving them their privacy. Catra's grief and Adora's fear and confusion was personal. When they were ready and if they wanted to confide in her then they would. Perfuma was not going to put them on the spot by hanging around. Her friends were troubled and she would do everything in her power to help heal them, to offer them ways to find peace and work towards a genuine happiness in their future. But for now...they needed time to process the trauma.

Back to the Beginning...

Chapter Notes

> Fair warning this is the longest chapter I've written so far. But I guess you guys are used to reading long chapter's by now. Anyway, I hope you all still enjoy it.

Catra gasped sharply back into consciousness, snapping her eyes open as her head jolted up from her chest. Fully alert and aware of her surroundings, her body felt strung out and overly sensitive from the intensity of her recent dream. Her heart felt heavy with sorrow, the image of her mother's spirit fading into the dawn haunting her. Stiff and sore, she arched her back, as she turned her head to the side, finding Adora crawling towards her. Silent tears streaming down her face, her whole body trembling, overwhelmed by what they had just shared.

Catra took a shaky breath and opened her arms, welcoming her into her embrace. As she curled up against Adora's chest, shivering with the aftershocks of their dream. The fire now burned a pure, vibrant blue, but only Melog seemed to notice. Padding towards them and curling their body around the two women, purring softly. They held each other for a long time, absorbing all the comfort it provided. Neither of them spoke, lost to their own thoughts. When they had calmed down, they silently focused on packing for their journey. Neither was willing to talk about their dreams yet. Needing time to absorb the new revelations and reawakened sense of loss. Adora would offer Catra small touches as they passed one another, a brush of fingers across an arm or the lower back, just above her tail. A brief clasp of hands as they bustled around the room, gathering clothes and their communicator pads. Offering fleeting touches again as they gathered provision in the pantry. Adora would stroke her fingers up Catra's arm, before she reached for an item on the top shelf in the cupboard. Catra's tail would wind around Adora's wrist or slide across her cheek as she breezed past her. The comforting touches were familiar and long memorized from their time in the Horde. As

cadets they didn't always have the time or opportunity to talk and hold one another when they were upset. So they had devised ways to offer each other support in more subtle ways.

It took a while to pack, the grey pre-dawn light had warmed just a little beyond their window. The dawn might be happening below the island, but it had yet to reach the heights of Mystacor. Melog padded threw the open front door, sitting out on the cobblestones of the colonnade, waiting. While Catra leaned against the doorframe with her arms crossed, dressed in her black leggings, white training shirt and leather jacket. Her backpack hanging loosely over one shoulder. A sleeping bag rolled and tied to the bottom of her pack. Watching as Adora clipped her maroon cloak around her own shoulders with her wing pin and pulled on her backpack, that had an identical sleeping bag rolled and tied to the bottom. She slid her Quarterstaff into its sheath at her back with a resolute sigh.

“We should speak to Sparkles and Arrow boy.” Catra offered.

“Yeah, we gotta let her know about...my issues...with She-Ra.” Adora sighed and rolled her shoulders in discomfort.

Catra merely nodded solemnly, rubbing Adora's back soothingly as the blonde past her threw the door.

“We'll figure it all out, ok.” Catra gave her a small reassuring smile. Closing the door to their room as Adora exited.

Adora nodded, clasping her hand with Catra's, as they walked down the colonnade. Heading towards the kitchen to find the Queen of Bright Moon.

They found Bow and Glimmer at the table in front of the bay window. Glimmer was reading a thick, musty, brown leather, bound book. That was resting in her lap, she was thumbing through the pages as if searching for a certain passage. Absently forking pieces of scrambled eggs off her plate and chewing

thoughtfully. While Bow sat beside her sipping his coffee and tapping anxiously on his Tracker Pad. Finn had been sitting at the table with them, nibbling on some toast. He had Catra's baby blanket, clipped with a silver star shaped pin, around his neck. The blanket hung down his back like a cloak. As soon as he saw them he bolted off the chair. The blanket fluttered behind him as he trotted over to them.

“Morning!” He grinned, a bright and eager smile spreading over his round face. That fell slowly into a frown of concern as he approached. “Are you alright?”

“I will be.” Adora offered, giving his cheek a tender pat as she passed.

“Looks good on you kid.” Catra smirked, at her blanket. Ruffling his dusty brown hair as she passed. Catching him flicking an admiring gaze up to her fluffy, curly hair. Quickly, ducking his head, trying to seem disinterested.

“It's the best present I ever got.” He looked back up with a beaming smile, spinning on his hooves and making the blanket float behind him like a cape. “I'm a real hero now! Like She-Ra!” He exclaimed.

Catra's smile broadened with pride at how much he liked her blanket.

“Take good care of it, ok.” She stated, he nodded and fell into step beside her. As they made their way over to the table.

Adora sat facing Glimmer who was so absorbed into her reading. She had to tap her index finger sharply on the table to get Glimmer's attention. Glimmer looked up from her book with a warm smile of greeting. Her soft lavender eyes snapped over to Catra, eyebrows raising in surprise at her fluffy hair but kept quiet. Catra sat down beside Adora, giving Bow a curious look. Bow looked stressed, with his eyebrows furrowed and brown eyes glossy with fear.

“You ok there, Arrows?” Catra asked, gently.

“Fine!” Bow nearly shouted, as he snapped his face up from his pad, his voice high pitched and expression tight with worry. Then his eyes warmed at the sight of her cute hair, he swallowed and muffled his adoring compliment by clearing his throat. Knowing from past experience not to call Catra cute or suffer 'clawful' retribution.

“You don't look fine...” Catra snatched his pad from his hands, staring at the coordinates for Beast Island with dismay. Ignoring his obvious swoon over her hair, thankful he swallowed his comment about her being cute. Having to scratch him so early in the morning was more effort than it was worth.

“That place was....horrible...” Bow breathed, his brown eyes turning distant and haunted. He groaned and cupped his head in his hands. “Everything was trying to kill you...that signal at the center of the island slowly made you go insane and the vines....the vines...” He shivered.

Catra eyes widened, it sounded like dark magic. The kind of predatory spells Shadow Weaver had used to try and control her growing up. Now she felt even more guilt about sending Entrapta there and inadvertently sending Bow and Adora there to save her.

“But Entrapta actually liked being there... she was totally in Mad Scientist mode! With all that corrupted tech and the database she was decoding from the Beacon.” He stated incredulously, giving Catra a tight smile sensing her guilt. Catra raised an eyebrow in surprise. She knew that Beast Island had been hard on Entrapta, it had left trauma. She had never thought she had enjoyed her time there?

“Kinda freaked out about how excited Entrapta is going to be there with all that ancient tech. More freaked out about what kind of Apocalypse creating tech she might trigger….when she tries to figure out how it all works... She's kinda hard to handle when she

gets all hyper focused and obsessed...” Bow was starting to ramble. Entrapta was fearless and didn’t always take into account the consequences of her experiments. Bleak memories of the bots she created that nearly killed him and the rest of the rebellion flooded over him. A shiver of fear ran down his spine, as he recollected the joy and excitement she felt at messing around with powerful forces she didn’t understand.

“Maybe you need to ease up a little, with Entrapta. Let the girl have her fun. What's the worst that could happen. ” Catra shrugged.

Bow and Glimmer shared a meaningful look before scowling at Catra.

“You can't be serious.” Glimmer laughed nervously. “Would you like a brief synopsis of all the times Entrapta nearly ended the world?”

Catra arched her eyebrows pointedly. “I'm just saying, You're not the one to cast stones, Glimmer.”

“One time! I nearly destroyed us all...one time!” Glimmer shouted back in exasperation.

Bow nervously glanced between them, as they glared heatedly at each other.

“Ok, let's just calm down.” He attempted to ease their temper’s, not wanting things to escalate since both Glimmer and Catra had a tendency to be hurtful to each other.

Catra blew out air between tight lips, feeling like she had to come to Entrapta's defense. Because Glimmer and Bow just didn’t get her. Honestly she could be an enigma to her too, but she would never admit it. Super Pal Trio loyalty and all that, Catra was not going to concede, even if their argument made complete sense.

“Entrapta can be overly enthusiastic about her experiments. I get that she likes to push past the safety boundaries that most other tech makers wouldn't. But that's why she's the best, why she is capable of creating such amazing tech. The reason she kept Darla flying and eventually got us home.” She raised her eyes up from the pad and stared pointedly at Bow. “ You need to have more faith in her.” Catra growled low in her throat before, glancing back down at the pad.

“Your right, your right...but she also tends to blow stuff up...” Bow whimpered.

Catra had to nod, “ But she also stops stuff from blowing up, too. Like Darla...on numerous occasions on the way back to Etheria.” She pointed out, again.

Bow nodded, “True...” Finally conceding.

“But you have to admit she can get carried away with her robots.” Glimmer pointed out.

Catra rocked back and forth agreeing reluctantly. Her latest obsession with Rodak was kinda creepy.

“She seems to like robots more than people.” Adora muttered, as she silently asked Glimmer for a piece of toast by hovering her hand over the plate. When Glimmer nodded with a fond smile, Adora grinned and snatched a piece of toast eagerly.

“I think she just feels more comfortable around them, she doesn't always understand us...hence the many social experiments and constantly recording our conversations.” Glimmer sighed heavily and closed her book.

“She's pulling away...she's been hiding in Darla instead of being here with us.” Bow huffed, propping his head up by bracing an elbow of the table, cupping his chin in his palm as he brooded.

“I think Hordak's sacrifice really shook her up, just give her some time.” Catra shrugged, tapping on the pad as she absently scrolled

through what Bow was researching.

“She can become rather single minded about her research...losing herself in it. She can be dangerous when she's in that state of mind. She would throw all caution aside just to complete her experiments, to find her answers...First Ones tech can be...kinda end of the worldy...and Entrapta likes to mess with it...she doesn't always think of the consequences.” Bow also pointed out, mumbling out his anxieties softly. “I am just worried about what she is going to find on Beast Island...

“Do you think Entrapta might know what's happening to me? Adora leaned over and whispered in Catra's ear.

“She was researching that viral data crystal that infected me....twice.” Adora ground out, glaring down at the table. She moaned, rubbing her fingertips against her forehead anxiously.

Catra grasped Adora's finger's and drew them away from her face. Staring at her, pleading for her to calm down and reassuring her with a smile that they would find a way to cure her.

“Catra...” Adora moaned, tears glistening in her eyes. She was so scared of her own magic, even thinking about it made her body clench and pulse quicken with sudden stress and anxiety.

“We got this...Adora....We got this.” Catra squeezed her hand.

Glimmer and Bow were confused, they stared nervously at the two of them.

“Entrapta has come a long way since her time in the Horde, it's not like I'm worried she is going to wreck the planet again.” Bow sighed, rubbing the back of his neck. Groaning as he remembered the cataclysmic destruction she had caused after messing with the Black Garnet.

“She's just so driven right now. She's way too eager to get to Beast Island...which to be honest is a scary place. I think she believes the database she found inside the Beacon that sent out

the madness signal might also have all the answers to developing Etheria's own tech.” Bow nodded, tapping his chin as he contemplated the idea. “But that Eternian drone is...complicated...I have never seen anything like it!

Catra sighed, tapping threw his screens on the pad reviewing the information and schematics of the Seeker Drone he had been looking at.

“It's Eternian tech.” Adora shrugged. “A thousand years more advanced than what we've got here on Etheria.”

“Yeah...it's not anything like the First Ones tech we have here. It is much more advanced, similar to Primes tech but much more volatile. Tinkering with it...I'm messing around with a bomb! One wrong poke and...Boom!” Bow’s eyes were wide and he flapped his arms for emphasis.

“Yeah, I got blown up by one back in the Fright Zone. It's not fun.” Catra groused.

“That happens to you a-lot, huh?” Bow smirked playfully .

Catra stuck her tongue out at him.

Glimmer snapped her head up at that. “Maybe you shouldn't mess with it then.” She declared, her tone heavily laced with worry.

Bow cast her a serious look, as she sighed in resignation. “That's not an option, Glimmer.” he stated.

“Well, not to add to the stress load or anything...but remember that viral data crystal that infected the sword?” Adora just jumped right back in. They both turned to regard her curiously.

“Well...looks like She-Ra may still be infected.” Adora huffed.

“What!!!” They both shouted in fear.

Adora and Catra dove right in, not noticing how Finn was absorbing every word they said. Filing it away so they could give a detailed report later to Peekablue.

“What were you reading?” Catra asked as she kept pace with Glimmer. Melog padded behind her, sniffing the air and keeping alert to their surroundings. The street were still muddy from Mermista's magical rainstorm. So Catra and Melog moved on nimble feet to avoid the puddles. Glimmer was barely able to hide her amused smile, as she watched them dance across the street. Their antic's causing them to lag behind Adora and Bow. As they moved down a wide avenue in the burnt out remains of the Merchant Quarter. The rubble and debris had been cleared out leaving only the hallowed out husks of taverns, shops and cafe's. Scaffolding had been erected along the sides of several larger buildings with worker's already moving along it's length. Catra took in the rebuilding efforts along the street with pride. Finding other workers hauling bags of mortar down side alley's, as other's emerged from alley's further down the street. Pushing wheel barrels full of stacked clay tiles, or cut stone. Etherians were such a resilient people. No matter how fiercely they got knocked down over the years they always came together to pick each other up and start over. She had seen it time and again through out the war, as the villages the Horde destroyed were eventually rebuilt...only to be destroyed again by Horde Prime.

The streets were rather busy for being so early in the morning. Teeming with traffic and the pounding noise of repairs. Heavy, iron wheeled push carts, covered in burlap. Weaved threw the crowds. While larger wagon's pulled by teams of horses, rumbled up the wide cobblestone street. The rattle of building materials, tools or equipment ringing from within. Other larger, flatbed style wagon's had long wooden beams tied up in huge bundles, that jutted off the back. A small group of kids ran after the lumber wagon, lunging for the wood and hanging off the ends. Laughing

and screaming as the beam's bounced them along the road, giving the faster more agile of the group a fun little ride. While the rest just trailed behind, pink cheeked and joyful at the new game they had found.

The sun had barely risen above the mountains below and Mystcor was hovering so much higher in the sky. That the sun rays had yet to crest over floating Island, postponing sunrise for just a little bit longer. So the sky stretching above was warming into a soft pink. Catra had yet to sing her morning song, waiting for those first brilliant rays of the sun to illuminate the sky over Mystacor. Only the soft hues of the coming sunrise amid the clouds showed it was about to be daybreak.

They had taken to the main thoroughfare, that ran threw the center of the enclosure. It was the only road cleared of enough debris to pass through. The repairs to the shops already underway, building supplies littered the streets. As the ex-horde soldier's assigned to help. Now blended in with the rest of the Etherian's. Dressed in the clothes of common tradesmen. No longer wearing armor but the leather pants and deep pocketed aprons of carpenter's, over plain cotton long sleeve shirts. They were scattered over scaffolds, repairing roofs and mortaring walls. Catra never stared to long at any of them, as she recognized only a few. Not wanting to be recognized in return. Pleased to see that they were moving forward. No longer defined by their past as soldier's, but now as citizens of the Scorpion Empire.

She was also working on shedding her past, one day she hoped she would also be free of it. It was then Glimmer finally answered her question.

“Aunt Casta has taken on my magical education, stating she needs to fix the damage Shadow Weaver caused. She was very disappointed that I had started my studies under Shadow Weaver's guidance.” Glimmer frowned.

“Well...I kinda agree with her. That wasn't one of your better decisions. ” Catra bumped her shoulder with her own.

“I was desperate...and scared...cut me some slack.” Glimmer glowered at her. “Your army was one advance away from conquering the planet!”

“I'm good at what I do!” Catra preened while grinning smugly.

“Having a spy in Bright Moon was cheating.” Glimmer punched her in the shoulder playfully.

Catra sighed and her smile soured.

“I'm sorry for all that...I had lost sight of what was really important to me then.”

“Nope...no more apologies.” Glimmer hip bumped her, making her stumble and lose her footing and hopefully her guilty thoughts. When Catra regained her feet, barely able to right herself before Glimmer had her in a headlock. In the very same manner, Adora used to. Grinding her knuckle into the top of her head. “We are done with feeling crappy about our past mistakes!” Glimmer announced, releasing her with a shove.

“All right...it's on Sparkles!” Catra shouted, a competitive grin pulling on her lips. She rushed forward, tossing her backpack at Adora. As Glimmer disappeared in a shower of glitter only to reappear in front of them, over the edge of a roof top. She pulled down one of her lower eyelids and stuck her tongue out at Catra. Teasing her playfully as she laughed.

“Come and get me! Kitty!” She taunted.

Adora caught Catra's pack against her chest with a sudden expelling of air. Laughing brightly as Catra darted through the crowd ahead, ducking and weaving threw them. Before leaping onto the side of the building that was still in heavy shadow. Glimmer was standing on the rooftop, scanning the crowds franticly. As Catra dug her claws into what remained of the

stonework and climbed upward. Intent on hunting and pouncing that smug grin right off Glimmer's face. The queen was now standing on the very edge of a crossbeam on the roof, watching the milling crowds below. As Catra slunk up onto the burnt remains of the roof top, her feet barely making a sound. Then dashed across the brittle and blackened timber, it groaned and creaked under her weight but held firm. Glimmer had her back to her, as she leaped at her. Glimmer spun around and squealed in fright, having lost track of Catra in the crowds below and not finding her in time. Her eyes flared in surprise as she exploded into a cloud of glitter. Catra's merely sailed off the edge of the roof. Soaring thru the air, all four limbs still splayed to tackle the Bright Moon Queen. Flying right into a cloud of sparkles as Glimmer faded away. Glimmer reappeared just over Catra's left shoulder. Hovering in the air for a second. She giggled, leaned over Catra's shoulder and gave her quick kiss on the cheek. Catra gasped in shock, eyes wide, then sneezed as she flew threw the cloud of magic glitter. Losing her concentration, Catra snapped her head back to see where she was falling, then hissed in fright. Landing off balance into a massive pile of hay.

“Catra...” Adora rushed to the hay pile, eyes sparkling with glee. To find her girl flat on her back in the hay, blowing pieces of straw out her bangs.

“Sparkles cheats!” Catra pouted, grasping Adora's offering hand. Allowing her to pull her out of the straw.

“Yes, she does.” Adora agreed, with a beaming smile. “We will teach her how to play chase properly, one day.”

Catra nodded, then smiled mischievously. Finding Glimmer was standing only a few feet away with her back turned, talking to Bow. Catra did not pass up chances to win, so she leaped. Glimmer spun around in surprise. She had thought the game was over. She raised her arms up in defense and cried out in alarm. As Catra slammed into her chest with all four limbs, knocking her onto her back, on the muddy ground.

Glimmer groaned and slowly opened her eyes, finding herself prone on her back. With a grinning magicat, crouching on her chest. Catra cackled and pressed the tip of her index finger onto her forehead. Then bounded off, prancing away triumphantly to reclaim her backpack from Adora.

“You ok...” Bow leaned over Glimmer.

“What just happened?” Glimmer rolled over onto her stomach, stunned and happy at the same time.

Adora stood a few feet away, smiling fondly down at her. “Catra likes you.” She stated, then dashed off to catch up to the magicat who was further down the street now with Melog in toe.

“I am starting to wonder if that's a good thing or a bad thing?” Glimmer laughed softly, as Bow pulled her up onto her feet.

“Last time she tackled me, I thought I was going to die.” Bow offered in a hushed, traumatized voice. Remembering how Catra had thrown him off a cliff, crouching on his stomach digging her claws into his flesh as they were falling to their deaths. It was in that moment that Bow came to understand how devious and cunning Catra was. She wanted to wear Glimmer down, have her use up all her magic so she could escape. Willing to do what ever it took to reclaim her freedom, no matter how reckless and crazy it may be. Back then he didn't understand Catra as well as he did now. That crazed, win at all cost attitude...death before submission approach. It had been engrained into her from a young age, just like Adora's indomitable will to push herself until her body broke under the strain. Both Catra and Adora reacted differently under extreme duress, but the core of it remained the same...survival.

Glimmer gave him a strange look, then remembered.

“Oh....yeah....she was an absolute nightmare!” Glimmer acknowledged with a nervous laugh.

Bow nodded. “So glad she's on our side now.” Glancing down at his chest and his arms where he still had small scars from trying to wrangle Catra so many years ago.

They both laughed at the shared traumatic memory of dealing with a very uncooperative cat, then jogged off to catch up to their friends.

They found Entrapta on the bridge of the ship, tinkering under the control panel. Rodak hovered nearby with various tools, clutched in his metal hands, tucked into the crook of his robotic arms. As the doors to the command deck hissed open his sharply angled head spun towards them.

[GET OUT!] He bellowed, his red visor-like eyes, glowing menacingly.

Catra hissed and her tail puffed out straight behind her. The sudden ear splitting yell, causing her to leap backward in terror, instinctively hiding behind Adora. Melog yowled at the robot, their mane sparking a deep crimson.

Glimmer stood frozen in the doorway, while Bow sighed heavily and walked toward Rodak in resignation. “Disarm, perimeter alarm, Rodak.”

[Disarming.] Rodak's strange, artificial voice responded.

Adora rubbed Catra's back, seeking to calm her down as Catra gave Rodak a death glare. Then stalked to the window at the end of the control board, hopping up on the end of the panel and glowering down at the burnt grass outside.

Adora took a deep breath and moved to sit in the command chair. As Entrapta pulled herself out of the main control panel.

“Oh...you're all here...already. Is it morning?” She glanced up at the front windows, startled to find that the sky was lighter.

“Did you sleep?” Bow braced his hands on his hips, giving Entrapta a stern look.

“Oh, of course...but not for long, cause I had a major break through with my attempts at rebuilding those ancient communications I downloaded from Arxia's data banks..” She rambled, pulling out her data pad from her hair and tapping away at the keys.

“Here...I managed to repair a short feed from the Arxia Outpost as the planet was being sent to Despondos....” Entrapta’s eager smile faltered, finding that they were all staring at her curiously. “The Fail Safe...Those three crystals...they are a huge data bank...like what’s on Beast Island...” Entrapta sought to explain. “Except this one had encoded messages...which I've figured out how to de-code...I hope to have more of those to show you soon. Anyway...this is what I got!” She finished, face lighting up with excitement. As she cued the message to play threw the ship's speakers.

[This is Arxia Outpost, the Weapon has been deployed. I repeat the Weapon has been deployed. But it is not stable. We need to abort the firing, the magic is tearing us apart. I repeat, abort the firing command.]A frantic and terrified male voice echoed through the Command deck.

“Razz told me a little about what happened that night, when the stars disappeared. The Heart had been activated and Etheria was being torn apart because of it. The magic was flowing into the Sword of Protection...also into Mara. She was scared and desperate...she had gone to Razz's hut to say goodbye. Razz had followed her through the Whispering Woods but lost track of her because of the massive magic storm raging throughout the forest. Mara ended up discarding the sword into the Whispering Woods so she wouidn't be forced to fire it.” Adora squeezed her eyes shut, reliving the excruciating pain of that raw, relentless onslaught of magic that nearly ripped her apart. With She-Ra's power shackled to the First Ones sword, her magic barrier against the Heart wasn't complete. With all that power being syphoned

into the blade of the Sword or Protection, she was forced to be a magic lightning rod to fire the weapon. The intense pain Mara had gone through, holding back all that magic, she had barely been able to resist it. Every muscle, every nerve had been electrified. She could barely form coherent thoughts when the magic was searing through her body. Everything had been a struggle, moving, speaking, thinking...the pain and misery Mara had gone in her last moments, to save Etheria....it shattered Adora completely.

"Bow and I found out the rest when we replayed her last transmission...it was for me..." Adora took a deep breath, her voice had begun to break with sorrow. "Then she took off on Darla towards the Crimson Waste, heading towards a place called Serenia? But she ended up using the last of Darla's power to create a portal and trap us in Despondos for a thousand years. Darla crashed into the dessert before she could get there.Mara tried to break the She-Ra line...but the Sorceress on Eternia kidnapped me and handed me over to Hordak, threw a portal Light Hope created, using the Heart's magic... from beneath the Crystal Castle..." Adora mused, valiantly trying to piece it all together.

Catra frowned, her eyes burning with hurt and disappointment. Bowing her head as she attempted to deal with the fact that Adora had never told her this.

"How..." Glimmer huffed, suddenly rather indigent. Knowing she was being left out of the loop once again.

"She's having dreams about her past, just like me." Catra offered in a curt, clipped tone barely concealing her raging emotions.

Adora looked pained for a moment as she looked at Glimmer, who was staring back at her with a hurt, confused expression. Adora quickly masked her guilt behind a facade of grim contemplation. She hated keeping things from Glimmer, the Sorceress of Eternia looked exactly like her mother...she was an Immortal...the same

race as Queen Angella. But was she related? Or did Immortals all look like that?

“So the Eternian's on Etheria wanted to stop the weapon from firing, they didn't know that the planet would tear itself apart.” Bow offered, wanting them to stay focused.

“Whatever they were firing at...the Eternian's in charge were willing to sacrifice a whole planet of people to attack that target.” Adora sighed, rubbing her fingers into her forehead in frustration. “Light Hope had been programmed.....to activate the weapon.” Adora released a long sigh, her heart heavy with grief. Light Hope had fought her programming to the bitter end, her love and loyalty to Mara proving to be more powerful.

Her own people had mined and destroyed planets as callously as Prime during the war...it hurt to know she came from such ruthless and selfishly driven race of people...the family waiting for her on Eternia...were they worth knowing or would she be happier just letting the past stay in the past...All those conflicting thoughts had been plaguing her relentlessly for days. Resurfaced like acid eating away at her insides. Jitsu had offered her idealistic bread crumbs about saving her own people from the civil war they had been trapped in for the last thousand years. She was their long lost princess, she had a duty to save her people.

Adora couldn't help but turn and stare at Catra, her gaze sad and introspective. Hoping she was far enough away not to hear everything she had just said. She regretted not telling Catra back on the skiff, about Mara and her attempt to reach Serenia. She didn't know why she hadn't told her? To wrapped up in the sweet moments they were sharing or perhaps, she had been scared...that Catra would leave her again. Driven to pursue her own ambitions over all else. Abandoning her...like she did at Thaymor, in the Crystal Castle, in the Portal and lastly before the Heart. She couldn't always count on Catra to stay...it hurt and she was not going to go through that again.

“But Mara knew, maybe that's why she pulled us into Despondos....to cut that signal and stop the weapon from going off.” Catra offered, burying her hurt deep down. Her disingenuous mask firmly in place, if Adora did not want her to know about Serenia then she would pretend not to know. Catching Adora's despondent look towards her, Catra gave her one of silent confusion.

“The sword channeled the magic, if Mara wasn't holding the sword...she could no longer be transformed into She-Ra. But all that magic from the heart was already released?” Adora muttered... “It was still going into her....but she was human now. It was the Heart that killed her...like it would have killed me...if I couldn't transform..” Her blue eyes grew stormy and haunted. Catra sucked in a cold breath. As Glimmer moved to Adora's side, with a concerned frown. Grasping Adora's shoulder wanting to ground her.

“But why didn't she just use the Fail Safe instead...then she would have shut down all the tech on the planet? She wouldn't have to let the Heart kill her...or move the planet? ” Adora huffed, turning her gaze back to the others and concealing her concern behind a solid wall of purpose. She might never get those answers, so she had to stop dwelling on what if's or what might have been's. Focus on the outcomes she could actively affect.

“Maybe Squadron Grayskull hadn't gotten the Failsafe downloaded yet, she might have been out of options if this was all going down at the same time. They said Mara had given them time and they had lost contact with Arxia a week before? So they must have had someone on Arxia to deliver the Failsafe....but maybe it wasn't in the data banks until Etheria was already in Despondos? ” Bow sighed, scratching the back of his head.

“Do you have any more communication's deciphered?” Adora asked Entrapta, her expression hopeful.

“This was the only meaningful one, the others seem to be just letters from Arxia's military staff back home. They were not all

from Eternia if that helps. Some were from other planets...ones we haven't seen yet.” Entrapta was staring up at the sky, wistfully.

“Can you send them to my Communicator pad?” Adora asked.

“Sure.” Entrapta stated, typing away at her pad.

Adora gave Glimmer's hand, upon her shoulder a quick squeeze. All of this talk about the Heart had made Glimmer upset, she was glaring at her feet. Trying to move past the guilt and anger at herself for activating the Heart and putting Adora through all that pain and misery. Giving Light Hope the power to send Etheria back threw a portal so that Prime could invade. All those terrible consequences for her actions still festered like an open wound, when the subject of the Heart came up. Glimmer nodded and paid Adora a thin, brittle smile. Then she lifted her hand off Adora's shoulder, crossing her arms stubbornly over her chest and moved to the opposite side of the deck to compose herself.

Adora leaned down over the chair's arm and pulled her own pad from her pack and set it on her lap. Her brows furrowed with more unanswered questions as she began to review the logs.

“Why were you going to Serenia? What is hiding out there in the Crimson Waste?” Adora muttered.

Catra’s ear’s twitched at the mention of Serenia again. She never looked back at Adora not wanting to let on she had overheard her mutterings. Keeping up the ruse of being distracted by what lay outside the window. But now she was curious...why was Mara heading to the scorched remains of the Savannah? It seems that in a thousand years time it would become the Crimson Waste? Why hadn’t Adora said anything about this to her? Catra’s ears folded down and her eyes narrowed, she didn’t like Adora keeping things from her. But Adora was not mean or cruel. There had to be a reason and she would get to the bottom of it, in time.

Entrapta strolled past Catra, a purple pigtail tapping the feline on the shoulder as she passed. Catra slipped off the panel and followed Entrapta to the back corner of the command deck.

“Your hair is different...” Entrapta commented, merely stating an observation with no real intention behind it.

“Yeah...my mane gets weird when it gets wet.” Catra shrugged, brushing her hand threw her fluffy curls with a growl.

“I like weird things.” Entrapta gave her an encouraging smile, before moving to the corner of the room. Catra smiled at her awkward complement, as she followed, looking down to notice the bronze scar her mask had left on the floor.

“I managed to blow torch your new addition to the deck off the floor.” Entrapta stated, “I am guessing that was your mask?”

Catra merely nodded.

"I might toss it in the incinerator, then. After I study it. I just wanted to check in though, if that's alright...cause that's what friends do.” She turned when they had got a discrete distance away from the others. Her hair wrapping around Catra's wrists, tentatively.

“It wasn't something, I wanted back.” Catra whispered sadly.

“Ah, I had noticed it weeks ago when Hordak and I had first started mapping the Velvet Glove after the transformation. I never touched it though, kinda forgot about it actually. Until Scorpia found it, she figured it was meaningful...I guess it wasn't. ” Entrapta smiled softly at her.

“Thank you, it's better just to leave the bad stuff behind us, right.” Catra gave her an answering smile.

Entrapta nodded, “We learned our lessons and are both trying to do better, now.”

“They are making us better.” Catra nodded towards their group of friends. “You take care of Arrows, out there. He's a little high strung when it comes to Beast Island, you have a much more level head in a crisis than him.”

“I shall.” Entrapta nodded, releasing her hands and sought to turn away.

“Seriously, ‘Trapta...how are you doing?” Catra reached out and placed a hand on her shoulder preventing her from retreating just yet.

“As you say...I am dealing.” Entrapta glanced over her shoulder, giving Catra a sad, weak smile.

Catra sighed and nodded. “I'm here....if you ever want to talk. Don't know how good I'd be at comforting you without Scorpia's guidance...but I can listen.”

“Thank you....my friend.” Entrapta nodded, tears shimmering in her eyes. She quickly cleared her throat and breezed out of the room with Rodak on her heels.

“Ok, let's get you two dropped off back in the Frigh....I mean Scorpania, then off to Beast Island!” Bow stated his voice growing in pitch and volume as he got more agitated. Headed towards the front control panels with a resigned sigh.

Glimmer moved briskly to his side, then made a small determined sound. Abruptly pushing herself up on her tiptoes, pressing a tender kiss to Bow lips. Bow was surprised at first by her sudden public show of affection, his arms wrapping around her waist instinctively. But quickly rolled with it, leaning against her and holding her close. They had been very discreet about their affection, since they started dating.

“Take care of yourself.” She whispered against his lips.

“I'll miss you...” Bow responded in a hushed voice, kissing her sweetly on the forehead. Just as she disappeared in a cloud of

sparkles.

As they had to do before while spying in Bright Moon, Double Trouble had searched Mystacor for a hidden room to retreat to when they had information to give. It was convenient that Double Trouble had lived and studied in Mystacor many years ago during their youth. They had explored nearly every part of the island, mapping the tunnels beneath the citadel and the many caverns hidden in the central mountain. So now they moved silently down a narrow, ancient corridor deep under the northern gates. First One’s writing was etched into the metal, the lyrical design flowing gracefully down the dimly lit hall. What power remained within Arxia's forgotten halls, hummed softly. Double Trouble wasn’t a very powerful sorcerer but they were competent enough to invoke simple spells. So they had conjured a ball of light that hovered in their palm as they strode deeper into the faint darkness of the First Ones outpost. This corridor led into a small abandoned cargo hold, long emptied of its contents.

It was cool and damp and smelled of mold. Lost and forgotten over the last thousand years, untouched by anyone but Double Trouble. This was their hideaway on Mystacor, where they would retreat to, to brood when their time at the academy wasn't going as planned. Where they would hide any treasures or books, that would aid them in their own research, to develop their own unique transformation magic. Double Trouble brushed their fingertips against the smooth metal wall of their lair as they passed through the narrow gap between two, thick, seized cargo doors. The walls inside were barren except for several crystal lamps, they had hung years ago from the rafter's above. They glowed a soft white, illuminating small portions of the room. Double Trouble huffed, staring up at the elegant teardrop lamps with dismay.

“Well, I guess it's been years. I should be thankful you all have a bit of a charge left. But this eerie, crypt-like atmosphere will not do.” Their movements were swift and delicate as they drew a light

glyph in front of them. Then with a flick of the wrist, multiplied the glyph into smaller more compact symbols, that they then tossed towards the lamps. Each crystal bloomed with light, illuminating the room fully.

Showing a colorfully decorated abode, filled with all the essentials to create a home. The far corner held a large nest of blankets, pillows and a plush pink fluffy mattress. A small kitchen was set up along another wall. With a portable hearth, that looked like a smooth metal oil drum, with a domed top that tapered into a narrow pipe to release vapor and smoke. The main body had a hole cut into the front with a chain link mesh and glass folding doors. A metal hammock hung underneath were a small fire could be lit. A large chest sat beside the drum, holding all Double Trouble cooking equipment. A set of shelves adorned the walls, currently filled with an assortment of provisions they had 'borrowed' from the Basilica's kitchen. With a small, round wooden table and two chairs. The far corner held an ancient, paper divider. The paper is painted in flowing black ink depicting a landscape of a mountain and a river. Behind the divider, Double Trouble had created a small bathroom, of a simple wooden tub and stacked crates with a large ceramic bowl for a sink. They had managed to create a comfortable little hideaway deep under the island. It wasn't much, but it was theirs and they were thankful to have it.

Acting and putting on a show for countless hours was tiring and they needed a place to relax and recharge. They moved towards the round mattress hidden under a mountain of fluffy pillows and flopped down, their slightly blood shot yellow eyes blinking tiredly. Their exhausted mind fell back upon thoughts of that sweet, simpleton they had just met.....Kyle. Double Trouble was intrigued by the sudden appearance of another Etherian who possessed the same rare magic.

They had felt unique and special for so long, but also lonely. They laughed softly as they remembered the odd, young man... So cute and so clueless...teaching him anything beyond just turning off the magic had been a struggle. Double Trouble had found it

frustrating but also highly amusing. The young man’s magic was slightly different then Double Troubles. He was not able to transform into other people, but merely change his own body into different materials. Such as steel... This Kyle would be sending them communications from time to time when he got into trouble with his powers. So Double Trouble had to be ready to revert back into character as Master's Elys apprentice...the Meadow land bee hybrid...Lyr. They had to come up with a name on the fly, when Kyle refused to just use their generic title of Apprentice. So now they had a double performance to worry about here on Mystacor.

With a long suffering sigh, Double Trouble pulled out their communication pad. Tapping in their call request to Peekablue. There was static then the call connected, a rough, faintly lit cave came into view over the screen. Followed by Peekablue's haggard face.

“Dare I ask, why are you hiding in some damp hole?” Double Trouble smirked.

“Late last night, a Scorpion Cruiser found Sweet Bee's airship. We had to split up.” Peekablue's voice was exhausted. “Been running all night with the kid, we just found some cover. Planning on a few hours of sleep before heading out, so make this quick.” He snapped, setting his pad down on a rock so Double Trouble could get a good look at their tiny hiding place.

Finn was crouched at the back of the cave, shivering. New bandages were wrapped around their wounded wrist, with a thin healing flowering vine knotted over the cloth. Sweet Bee must have given the kid some first aid when they got on board. The Princess was a bleeding heart just like the rest of them. Double Trouble smiled fondly at Finn, they liked the kid well enough. They knew in another life they had loved them, they had been family. It was a wistful thought, that they refused to dwell on. Getting attached to people never turned out well for anyone...lest of all them.

“Well, I got some good news and some bad. What do you want first?” Double Trouble offered, turning all business in an instant.

Peekablue huffed from out of view, “I gotta get a fire started DT, before the kid freezes. So whatever the news is, make it quick.”

“Wow, you are in a mood. Aren't you.” Double Trouble pouted, crossing their arms over their chest with disappointment.

“Hi, Auncle.” Finn waved, weakly. Their dark ears flapping happily for a moment. Wrapping their arms tight around their knees, that were pulled up against their chest. Their fluffy blonde tail tucked around their ankles, desperate to keep warm. Sporting a new piece of clothing, a small leather pouch, belted around their thigh. No doubt another gift from Sweet Bee.

Double Trouble offered them a small smile before taking a deep breath.

“Ok, here it is. Kitten and Adora are headed towards Scorpion Hill on some Horde camping trip. So that’s a heads up if you are anywhere near there. Also She-Ra is kinda messed up right now, so I doubt Adora will be transforming anytime soon until she finds what is going wrong with her magic.”

Finn's blue eyes widened in alarm, then the screen was picked up and Peekablue's concerned face filled the view.

“Screwed up!” he shouted in panic.

“She gets red eyes...when she tries to use her magic. Then she had a really whopper of a nightmare. Scared the crap out of me and herself. She kept calling out for someone...Despara?” Double Trouble shrugged.

Peekablue paled, his eyes darkening with trepidation. “We're currently on the southern fringe of the Whispering Woods. The Crimson Waste is just a few day's travel to the west...I was headed towards the Dark Edge...but that's gonna have to wait.” Peekablue eyes grew distant, his focus drawing inward. Images

flashed before him. An unforgiving heat beat down upon him, the sun's glare high overhead blinding him. The barren, arid landscape of the Crimson Waste stretched out before him, slowly changing into a golden savannah Low rolling hills of tall grass stretched towards a flat horizon, broken only by lone clusters of tall, spindle like trees. Their wide, canopies shielding only the ground right below them from the heat of the sun. A First Ones glyph...a star...Serenia. A huge sandstone monolith broken in two, surrounded by a lush forest all hidden away in a lush, sprawling valley. A flash of light exploded from the peek of the sandstone mountain.

" ***The future must be secured anew.*** " An eternal voice called out over the ancient landscape.

" ***Return that, which was stolen*** ." Another voice echoed with the first. As a glowing orb upon a crystal pillar dominated the vision.

" ***A bond broken and torn asunder."*** A third voice overlapped with the other two, creating a timeless sound that resonates deep in Peekablues soul. As the piercing wail of a baby's cry, the plaintive mewl of an infant magicat echoed in his mind.

" ***Balance once woven...now knotted and frayed."*** All three voices spoke as one. As a pair of slender swords with red crystals in elegant silver hilts shone upon a black backdrop. A huge, shield of pure light, with the golden star of She-Ra emblazoned on the front, with a blue crystal in its center.

"***Must be restored...the weave made whole once more."*** The voices grew louder, their cadence both demanding and desperate.

Two warriors, whose identity was hidden in shadow. Standing back to back, with a brilliant light glowing just behind them. Illuminating the background in a piercing array of vibrant color that quickly washed over them. Their once dark silhouettes absorb the light and then pulsing with its incredible power. Their shapes

turn translucent and fade away. Leaving only an echo of the incredible, fathomless magic they once wielded. It's timeless essence reverberated deep inside Peekablue's soul, causing him to bow slightly under it's power. It terrified and humbled him in a way he had never experienced before.

" ***The two shall come,***

One sleeping, lost to time.

One stolen, lost to space.

Child of Time, Child of Space.

Each born of magic, given form through blood and bone.

One shall walk Etheria, upon the dawn.

The other shall greet the twilight.

Both reaching for and sheltered by each other.

They shall ascend upon the final day,

Becoming part of the stars.

To usher in a new beginning.

Each gives sustenance to the other.

Space offers dreams of life-Eternity in Death.

Time offers the soul salvation-Strength in the weft, elegance in the weave.

A tapestry made whole, so shall be one to the other. "

The timeless voices faded away, leaving Peekablue exhausted and confused by the intensity of the farsight now leaving his body.

"Ohhhhh...did you just do your farsight thingy?" Double Trouble grinned gleefully, clapping their hands enthusiasticly.

Peekablue huffed, as he slowly came out of the trance. "I will steer clear of the ex-horde. Keep me informed when Adora and the Fire Princess make it back to Mystacor. Its seems, Etheria is not done with me yet."

"You got it boss!" Double Trouble gave him a curt, if sloppy salute before ending the call.

"Well back to my own work, I guess." Double Trouble heaved himself up off the soft cushion and walked across the room to a long, large metal table. It was an old work table they had found years ago stashed in the far corner of this cargo hold. They had spread out across the table, with several thick, books, codex's and sorcerer's diaries. All 'borrowed' from the deep magic archives, hidden and sealed away behind locked doors at the back of the Master's Library. But to Double Trouble nothing was ever off limits, they had devoted their life to uncovering secrets. It had only been a matter of time before they managed to sneak in. It only took a couple days to befriend the old archivist and figure out their character. Finally getting the chance to touch them. Double Trouble was able to disguise themselves as the keeper of the archives, after that. The guards let them in without suspicion, while the doddering old fool was happily distracted back in his quarter's by a favorite obsession of his. A brand new wooden and iron puzzle. Double Trouble had given them earlier that day as a

present. Giving Double Trouble more than enough time to explore the ancient tomes of dark magic and take what they needed.

They had their own leather bound book that they had been hauling around the Basilica for the last couple days. It was filled with all of their research and theories, glyphs and spell work. Each stone that was embedded in the back of the amulet had been drawn. The type of stone that it was, what thread of magic it could absorb and what spells it might be able to be used for. Yet each stone held a droplet of something deep inside, that was infused within the facets? The amulet sat on the table amid the piles of discarded papers with even more sketches on them and messy writing that was practically illegible. Double Trouble sat on a tall wooden stool, set before the table. Pulling over a heavy black leather bound book, that was stained in rusty splotches along the corners. The title was ancient, scratched into the leather in a rough, untidy scrawl. As if the spell caster who had penned the work within, may have been going insane at the time.

They idly fingered the amulet, while flipping through the book. Double Trouble had uncovered the catalyst to Finn's transformation within the amulets lotus design. It had only taken a day of focused meditation and a couple rather complicated magic detection spells. But as they held the amulet, their transformation into the Thaymorian boy had been totally by accident. It was then the secret of how the amulet worked had been revealed and it had completely disgusted them. The amulet itself had been bathed in the blood of that poor child.

"Blood-craft…." They muttered with revulsion. "How scary were things getting, to push me to dabble in this kind of nasty, dark magic..."

It was midday by the time Adora and Catra disembarked from Darla. The giant ship had landed on a crumbling tarmac inside a vast supply yard, on the far west side. Deep in the labyrinth of

bulbous shaped factories of the industrial sector. During the War, this tarmac would have been filled with crates, munitions and various equipment needed out on the front lines. Right now with the thousands of ex-horde setting up tent cities in all the open areas within the fortress. As they tore down the Fright Zone. This was the only place left for the giant ship to land safely. Entrapta was being a lot more careful about the damage the ship's thrusters could cause to the surroundings. The tarmac was ringed by massive tin and iron beam supply warehouses and a twelve foot tall chain link fence cut it off from the street. Broken down factories, built from scrap metal and what might have been the hulls of ancient Horde starships. Littered the area beyond. Various tubes lined the outer walls like varicose veins. Crawling up the curving structure and jutting upward, like slender metal stacks, mostly absent of fumes and smoke. A few still sputtered faintly, showing that some of the factories were still in use.

Adora walked with purpose down the ramp and onto the tarmac, her boots crunching softly on the grit of crumbled cement. Shielding her eyes with an arm as the sun overhead, beat down upon her. Catra hummed beside her, arching her back and closing her eyes enjoying the warmth. Catra followed her out onto the tarmac with Melog padding softly behind her.

“My mother told me our sun is called Adarion.” Catra stated with a shrug, “Since I am the Rune Bearer of fire. My magic comes from that star, I have a sacred duty to greet the sun every morning and say farewell every evening with song.”

“Is that why you disappeared this morning just after we took off.” Adora reached for her hand, the action was as natural as breathing now, just as it had been when they were little kids.

“Yeah, I figure I should find a place on the ship that will not disturb anyone else to sing.” Catra sighed, then moaned. “I went down to the cargo hold. That you had told me, Finn and Swift Wind had enjoyed singing in. Because of the echo. So I tried it. “ Her eyes drifted to the ground in silent admiration, as she reviewed the experience. Hearing her voice rebound all around

her as she sang had been disturbing at first, but the echo of her melody grew on her and in the end she had enjoyed herself. Melog's iridescent mane had rippled as she sang, their coat glowing a gentle lavender. Their magic gently affected by the power of her voice. She had admired their subtle change as much as her voice reverberating off the empty walls of the hold.

Adora glanced over to her, finding her smiling softly at her feet and swaying slightly as she remembered the beautiful acoustics within the cargo hold. Adora giggled and bumped her shoulder against hers.

“Have fun?” She asked, with a warm smile.

“Yes, actually. I think I like singing.” Catra nodded, then her gaze drew distant. “I also have to write my own song for the sun...so that I can complete my link to it's magic.” She admitted with a nervous giggle. “Right now I'm singing my mother's lullaby, a love song she used to sing me when I was a kitten.” Catra shrugged, casting Adora a small, sad smile.

“Well, your voice is amazing and I am sure your songwriting skills will be just as amazing.” Adora squeezed her hand, offering support and reassurance.

“You could hear me, all the way up on the Command deck?” Catra asked, suddenly bashful. Her cheeks were warming and eyes wide in surprise.

“No...I heard you singing in our dream.” Adora stated, placing a soft kiss on her cheek. A low, contented purr rumbled from Catra's chest at the affection.

Catra watched with a smirk as Adora's focus drew inward, she was making plans. “I'll get you a book, a really nice one...bound in leather or....maybe thick felt...yeah. A new quill, I saw this really fancy one back in Elberon, once.” She was growing more and more excited as she reviewed her options. “We could stop at

Elberon before heading to the Crystal Castle, so you can start writing down any lyrics that come to mind."

"Or I could just type them into my communicator pad for now." Catra chuckled. "We can go shopping together when we have time."

"Books are more practical. But whatever, I guess we can wait." Adora shrugged, a little disappointed.

"Ok, grandma. You are so old fashioned!" Catra bumped her shoulder against Adora's playfully. "Thank you for the overly complicated plan at getting me fancy things, though."

"Anytime." Adora bumped her back, appreciating her sarcastic if kind words.

The low hum of a small engine caught their attention and they moved further away from the ship. As they caught sight of the dust cloud, spitting out behind a small hover sled coming their way. That was known around the Fright Zone as a Runner. It was similar to a skiff, but didn't have a sail. With two mid-sized rotor blades jutting out on either side of the curved metal body, creating a cushion of air that the sled travelled on. As the sled approached the engine grew quiet and the rotors slowed down, the forward momentum cut out and the sled hovered a few feet away. They could see Lonnie manning the rudder, waving at them to climb aboard. With one last look back at Darla they sprinted for the Runner and climbed into the bow. Lonnie gave them each a brief nod, the motor was too loud to talk, as they sat down and set their packs beside them. Melog crouched down along the edge, resting their head against the shallow lip of the bow. Then Lonnie pulled up on the rudder, making the rotor blades speed up and then the sled was off, turning in a slow arc back towards the chain link fence and the street beyond.

The runner barely made it into the cluster of tents in the open field outside their old cadet barracks, before a small group of ex-horde converged upon the bow. They wore mismatched pieces of armor and tool belts around their waists. It was a strange mixture, but it showed that the Horde was slowly leaving their military mindset behind them.

“Lonnie! Lonnie!” A slender woman with short honey blonde hair, buzzed on either side of her head. Leaving a thin tail of hair running down the middle of her head and down her back. Rushed to the back of the sled, waving her arms. She had on black training pants matched with a sleeveless black halter top. The Horde issued light grey, chest armor was buckled over her chest and heavy hiking boots adorned her feet. Her arms were bare, except for a two leather bracer's on either wrist. Catra narrowed her eyes trying to place her, she might have been a scout during the war. She didn't even acknowledge Catra's presence, avidly ignoring her as she rushed past the bow. While her team hung back, as if staying out of range of an attack. They were all dressed in light armor as well, with stun baton hanging from utility belts.

“What's up, Soju?” Lonnie cut the engine and hopped off the sled. As the rest of Soju's team of four moved to surround Lonnie. Catra kept quiet just like the last time they were in the Fright Zone, trying to blend into the background. Lonnie seemed to have become Scorpia's second in command and pretty much took over what was left of the Horde army. After Catra nearly destroyed their home during her ‘little disagreement’ with Hordak. The survivors of the war were all coming back to rebuild their lives. After Catra nearly killed them all, with her constant assaults against the rebellion in those final days before Prime. That last, brutal fight with Hordak... had been so destructive...they had both been so full of rage at one another. It had quickly turned into a death match. She had blown up the forge and in a chain reaction most of the inner buildings of the fortress. From that a massive fire had broken out that burned down even more of the base. It was a perfect example of her reacting with no regard for others. Allowing her rage to consume her and lashing out at the world.

Intent on destroying everyone and everything that had caused her pain. And now several seasons later she was once again confronted by the consequences of her cruelty, her selfish disregard of others.

“Wait here, I'll take you to your tent in a couple minutes.” Lonnie advised them before jogging off with the group of ex-soldiers.

“It is still so weird being back here.” Adora settled down beside Catra.

Catra nodded, not really having the composure to speak without her voice wavering. She merely glanced with fake disinterest around the bustling camp. Keeping the guilt and shame that was still a heavy weight on her heart hidden. Watching the soldier's mill around. Some were heading off with tools or weapons for their shifts repairing or guarding the remains of the Fright Zone. With Tri-clops still out there spying on them, capable of attacking them with drones. Lonnie seemed to have all her bases covered to keep her people safe. Other's talked in small groups, still chewing, and choking back grey or brown ration bars. The atmosphere was far more relaxed, the aura lighter and more hopeful. As they laughed and joked with one another.

Catra sighed, resting her chin on her knees that were pulled up tight to her chest. She had been such a tyrant, as Hordaks second in command. Spreading fear and intolerance of failure among those under her command. The soldiers had been nervous, fearful and exhausted around her near the end of the war. She could tell, right away, that Lonnie was a much better leader then she ever was. The soldier's had a greater morale and were far more driven to prove their worth to their commander. They had been given a purpose far greater and more worthwhile then winning some stupid war.

Catra sat hunching her shoulders and staring mournfully down at the deck, scratching a claw into the metal. Lost to her thoughts

and seeking obscurity upon the deck of the Runner. As the crowds of ex-horde soldier's milled around them.

“Catra?” Adora noticed how Catra's mood had soured, how she was trying to make herself look small and unassuming.

“Our people have so much more hope now. They are happy and filled with a purpose to create...a new kingdom...for themselves. Seeing them like this...so driven and at ease. I couldn't have asked for a better outcome for the Horde after the war.” Adora commented lightly.

Catra smiled weakly and glanced up, laughing softly. She could always count on Adora to change her perspective when she started to spiral into dark thoughts.

“Yeah, Lonnie is doing a great job as their commander.” Catra nodded, sneaking a glance up at the camp. (much better than I did) She thought bitterly.

“Force Captain...” A meek, nervous voice filters weakly from over the edge of the bow.

Catra's ears flattened, this was the first time any of the Horde had sought to acknowledge her. The first time she had been back. The soldiers had outright ignored her, she thought the same was going to happen this time.

She moved tentatively towards the bow, finding a small fox hybrid standing before the sled. She had a long burnished orange mane tied back in a long braid. Her wide ears twitched nervously and her fluffy tail swished behind her anxiously. She was twirling her finger on her thigh as she rocked back and forth on her toes. She had a kind, round face with brilliant green eyes that shone like emeralds. Her sweet features are slightly marred by a jagged scar that cut down the left side of her chin. She was also wearing the similar lighter armored bracers of a scout on her wrists. With black hiking boots, thick brown cargo pants and the long sleeve training

top similar to Adora's. With blue accents on the shoulders. Showing the color of her cadet squad.

“Don't call me that.” Catra snapped, cringing as she watched the young hybrid flinch and take a few steps back.

“I...I...I...I just wanted to thank you for sending a recovery team out to Thaymor to retrieve us.” She swallowed. “I was so tired of running and fighting and....struggling...and...everyone hated us out there. I knew '**you**' cared about us...” She blurted out, then dashed away as fast as she could.

“She must have been with Grizzlor, I wonder how she found out it was me.” Catra cast Adora a questioning look over her shoulder before sitting back down.

“Soldier's talk...we know this.” Adora wrapped an arm around her shoulders and drew her in for a quick hug. Catra smiled softly, pulling up her knees and resting her chin there. Her tail thumped against the deck with agitation. It was nice to hear a thank you for a good deed. She had never been praised for doing good and it was happening more and more often. The validation she had always craved was finally happening. It was funny she had spent most of her life striving for acceptance and praise from those in power. Never realizing till she had hit rock bottom, that their option of her did not matter. It was her own opinion that mattered. Now her actions were driven by her own moral compass. She wanted to feel good and proud about herself, so she did good things. She was more kind and thoughtful of others. In doing that she was slowly changing the direction of her life. She was drawing more positive outcomes, such as gratitude and forgiveness and acceptance.

“She reminded me of Tama.” Adora muttered softly.

“Yeah...she was a fox hybrid too.” Catra nodded, tears moistening her eyes. It had been a very long time since she had thought of the little girl in their squad that had followed her and Adora around like a lost puppy.

Lonnie got them settled in a small tent near her own. It was spartan, with only two cots and nothing else. Adora had just rolled out her mattress on her own cot when Lonnie burst threw their tent flaps.

“You need to come talk to that man!” Lonnie hissed, pointing out the crack in the flaps. “He has been here less than two days and is driving me insane!”

“Jitsu?” Catra folded her arms over her chest, casting Adora a knowing look.

“He will not shut up! If he isn't singing vulgar songs, or chatting up the guards, he's doing weird dances in his cell...and I swear trying to cast spells?” Lonnie huffed. “You need to get him under control or I will restrain him more than just a couple shackles on his wrists.!”

“Rogelio is the only one allowed to guard our new prisoner.” Lonnie grumbled, as she led Adora and Catra down a long hallway that opened up into a cavern-like pit. That contained the Fright Zones holding cells. It had been a long time since Adora had infiltrated the prison to free Bow, it still looked the same. With multiple levels of dull green metal balcony’s, with the central command tower that rose up in the center of the pit. The adjustable walkways that hovered up and down the levels were already in use. With other soldier's moving along them carrying ration trays or changing guard positions along the cell blocks.

Catra surveyed the cells above her, as they crossed the bottom of the pit towards the Command tower's main doors. It was the most active she had seen the prison since her days as Force Captain. She shivered slightly, holding herself as harsh memories of her own time as a prisoner washed over her. Trapped in a cell for days

with only her rage and self loathing to keep her company. She had been ready to die then...at Hordak's hand. Eager even for the peace only death could provide. So very tired of being manipulated, abandoned, striving for validation from people who cared nothing about her. All her recent accomplishments had been overshadowed by one failure. Shadow's Weaver's betrayal had ripped out what was left of her heart and left her broken and empty inside. She had so many bad memories here. The terror and panic of nearly being trapped in the command tower to drown...while a chipped Mermista flooded the pit, laughing maniacally down at her from her perch at the top of the cell blocks. The grim thoughts that had crossed her mind, as she and Melog scrambled to the top of the control panels in the command tower seeking to stay above the water. At first she thought it was fitting that Mermista was the one to kill her, she had destroyed her kingdom...an eye for an eye. Then she thought of Adora and the second chance she had been given. She was finally getting everything she truly wanted...Adora was back in her life...she was wanted...and forgiven...and she was finally, finally feeling good again. She had hope and yearned to keep moving forward with Adora and her new friends.

She really wanted that...so she had swallowed her pride and called Glimmer to come save her. Melog had lowered their head, a low growl rumbling deep in their chest. Their mane had darkened, flowing in low placid waves around their head. They brushed up against Catra's leg, seeking to soothe her brooding anxiety..

“Catra...” Adora turned, catching her subtle unease. Her eyes were curious as to why Catra suddenly felt fearful and uncomfortable in the cells.

“It's nothing.” Catra jerked her arm away from Adora's inquiring touch. Offering her a ghost of a smile, to help sooth the hurt her rejection might cause.

“It's just the Fright Zone, right. So much bad here.” she deflected with an easily negligible whimper.

Adora merely nodded, leaving it at that. She didn't like being here either.

“So why is Rogelio the only one allowed to guard Jitsu?” Adora asked, as they stood on the lift ascending upward to level five.

“The guy's a chatterbox, he never shuts up. He ends up befriending the guards and nearly convinced one to let him out for a walk.” Lonnie waved a hand aggressively over her head in frustration.

“So since Rogelio is practically monosyllabic! He can't really understand us completely when we talk and we can't understand him that well when he talks. Jitsu can’t befriend him as easily. ” Catra nodded.

“Pretty much.” Lonnie turned to regard Catra with a smug, self satisfied smirk, walking backwards for a bit.

Adora raised an eyebrow in surprise, never thinking that a trained Horde soldier could be so easily won over by a charismatic prisoner. Jitzu had been rather talkative with her as well. He had a disarming sort of charm and laid back kind of personality. But when they had first met on the balcony outside Master Elys study. He had been focused on his objectives and nothing else. He had fought back with all that he had, but Catra had already burned him severely. So he had taken the beating She-Ra had dished out with a stoic resolve. If she had intended to kill him back then, he would have accepted that fate as well. It seemed he could shift his demeanor to suit his needs? Adora was suddenly feeling very unstable in her assessment of Jitsu? His friendly manner and words of loyalty to her earlier might just be a ploy to gain his freedom. Shadow Weaver's years of manipulation had been a harsh lesson in how devious a person could be to achieve their own ambitions. Adora was suddenly on guard in regards to Jitsu's true intentions.

As the lift slowed to a grinding halt, Lonnie led them down the narrow walkway around the cell block. Catra glanced inside the

cells, sealed by flickering energy barriers. Finding those strange cybernetic sorcerers huddling within, still wrapped up in the tattered remains of their dark robes.

“Those are the guys who cast the dark tendril spell?” Adora asked, her voice was soft and modulated as she tried to conceal her unease. She stared at the strange sorcerer, huddling within. He had pale, mottled grey skin that looked stretched too tight over his thin, boney face. The electronic components embedded over his left eye flickered. His eyes were hollow, sunken into his skull. A glowing lavender crystal was crudely attached to his forehead. Adora swallowed her revulsion at the gruesome sight, this Eternian sorcerer made.

“Yeah, they were working for that insect hybrid...Modoluk. He went threw the portal back to Eternia before I blew everything up.” Catra nodded, avoiding looking straight at the pale, sickly flesh, covering the sorcerer. Finding it rather qrotesque and unsettling. She focused on the back wall of the cell itself, it still looked like she was staring at it but she wasn't.

“Not surprised.” Lonnie quipped. “Jitsu told me those guys are called Husks, they're not alive.”

“What do you mean?” Adora asked, Jitsu had explained a little about them to her before but she couldn't grasp what he was saying.

“The guy Jitsu fights for...this Lord Skeletor...he's some kind of Necromancer. He merges tech and dark magic, with corpses and reanimates them.” Lonnie shivered with disgust.

Adora blinked, still not quite understanding, while Catra frowned in disgust.

“Come with me, we got a damaged Husk just a few cells away, I'll show you.” Lonnie beckoned.

The husk inside the cell was curled up tight against the back corner, hiding in the shadows there. What they could see of its

pale grey skin, under the tattered remains of it's robe. Was mottled and decayed, the skin peeling off from it's rotten muscles. The muscle was clotted with black ichor and old yellow puss. Stark white bone peeked out beneath the festering decay.

"When the power crystal on its forehead is damaged in any way, the husk's body starts to slowly degrade." Lonnie sighed, scowling at the rotting corpse with a mixture of pity and nausea.

"Are they in pain?" Adora asked, expression dire. Eyes full of concern for the wretched creature.

"I don't know, but when we find one like this? We just end it's misery." Lonnie heaved a breath, deactivating the force shield and walking into the cell. Adora and Catra followed resolutely behind her.

Watching in barely contained horror, as Lonnie crouched down in front of the poor creature. It moaned and slowly raised its head from it's arms. The skin on its face was already decayed to the point that it was peeling from it's skull. Revealing portions of the bone along its cheeks and forehead. It's cloudy grey eyes were sunken, staring up at Lonnie. The pupil was black and cracked, the iris pale and lifeless.

Adora gasped at the sight, turning to Catra. Finding her glaring down at the husk with a mixed expression of disgust and anguish. The husk had the exact same eyes as Shadow Weaver...it's skin was the same dull grey. A bleak, horrific theory running through Catra's mind. That the Spell of Obtainment may have taken Light Spinner's life, the parasitic dark magic reanimating the corpse. Creating a puppet, that the Nameless One sought to use to further it's agenda here in the realm of the living. Just like in the portal...when she had given up and let the energies devour her. The nameless one had recreated her, as a tainted...corrupted puppet for it to use to torture Adora. Catra had no time to dwell upon those terrible idea's as Lonnie merely reached out and yanked the cracked, dark purple crystal shard from it's forehead. As soon as the crystal detached it turned to dust, the body of the

husk soon followed. Leaving only a pile of ash behind in the vague shape of a body.

“Well, that's going to give me new and improved nightmares!” Catra gagged, turning and darting from the cell. As the heavy, musky scent of decay filled the small chamber.

Adora moaned and pressed her palm against her mouth, retreating out soon after. Unable to tolerate the sickening smell. Lonnie was more used to it, having disposed of many husks in the last twenty-four hours. She followed them out of the cell, her face a stern mask of disconnection to the grim task she had just performed.

“That was just awful.” Adora groaned, as they continued down the walkway towards Jitsu's cell.

“Disposed of another Husk, Commander?” Jitsu's voice called out, his tone rather light for such a somber task. “I can smell it from here, that stench doesn't really add to the ambience of my high class meal here.” he complained.

Lonnie merely groaned and rolled her eyes. Casting Adora a (See what I have to deal with) look. Rogelio was leaning against the doorframe, dressed in full Horde Infantry Armor. Arms crossed, glowering down at his feet. Absolutely bored out of his mind. He had a long handled, shock baton attached to his utility belt. So he could deal out punishments to his prisoner from a distance. The guards have already dealt with how lethal Jitsu could be if you got too close and revised protocol as to how to subdue the prisoner.

“Jitsu, I hear you have been a handful to deal with.” Adora moved into view of the force field, giving Jitsu a stern look.

“Merely trying to amuse myself, Princess.” He admitted with a huff. He sat at the back of the cell, his wrists chained to the wall, with long glowing green chains. A silver platter sat untouched in front of him with the typical grey ration bars and protein sludge

they usually got served at lunch time. A tall metal cup of water sat in it's holder on the side of the platter, mostly empty.

“I've spent most of my life in one prison or another, I've learned to make the best of it.” He shrugged.

Catra leaned against the side of the door frame out of view, she had no interest in engaging with the man who had nearly killed her. She kept her distance, an impartial observer in the wings. She obviously didn't trust him and Adora could sense that. Catra didn’t trust easily and certainly didn't believe the man would betray his own people so easily. Hordak and Shadow Weaver had hurt her, tortured her on numerous occasions to prove they were stronger, to keep her in her place beneath them. It only spurned her more to prove that she was smarter, stronger than them. She had laid in wait, pretending to be less then, until an opportunity struck and she took it. Destroying Shadow Weaver's power stone and her link to the Black Garnet. Destroying Hordak's power stone and his connection to his armor. Proving to both that they had no power over her any longer...why wouldn't Jitsu be exactly the same? The quest for power was a long drawn out game, with many little moves, all more cunning and devious then the ones before. Catra knew how that game was played, knew how to win and how absolutely pointless and hollow it was. What waited for you at the end was loneliness, guilt and misery. She never wanted to experience that ever again.

“Well, I suggest you tone it down. I don't know how long you are going to be in this cell. We are trying to track down Tri-clops, but until he is in custody it's not safe for you outside.” Adora advised, crossing her arms over her chest and sending him a baleful glare.

“It's not safe for me anywhere, Princess. Keeping me here is just making me bait, putting all these lovely people in harm's way. Tri-clops is not one to give up and he is not one to bargain. He was a bounty hunter long before Lord Skeletor took him on as a Weapons Master.” Jitsu crossed his arms behind his head.

Lonnie cast Adora a worried look. Adora paled, and rubbed the back of her neck.

“Then what do you suggest we do?” She asked pointedly.

“Give me back my weapons, release me. Let me defend myself with honor instead of cowering in here like a defenseless child.” Jitsu sat forward, beseeching her.

“I can't do that!” Adora shouted back. “Acting like a fool in your cell and pandering to your jailers, will not grant you freedom, so behave!” She finished, stomping away.

Leaving Jitsu stunned and blinking in confusion at her sudden royal outburst.

Adora cringed as Catra darted up beside her cackling softly.

“I just sounded like Glimmer...didn't I” She moaned.

“Oh, yeah, Princess! That was a perfect impression of a pissed off Queen of Bright Moon.” Catra laughed.

“Whatever it takes to get that guy to settle down.” Lonnie fell in stride behind them. “Relax, Adora. I got this handled. Jitsu is secured, the people of Scorpiana are trained soldiers in a heavily fortified military base, this Tri-clop fella is not getting too far.” she stated with pride.

“I blew up most of the Fright Zone, in one afternoon, Lonnie. How secure can you really say it is.” Catra shot back over her shoulder.

“Get over yourself Catra, All you did was blow up the Forge and a few ore refineries...ok and the Black Garnet Chamber...and a couple chemical plants..and more than a few militia warehouses. But most of the Fright Zone's outer defenses are still intact.” Lonnie shot back, but her confidence in their security was waning.

“How many troops have you got positioned on the perimeter walls in each sector, or working bots, even? I think most of our arsenal had been deployed and what was left got demolished in my little spat with Hordak. Are the energy cannons mounted along the ramparts still operational? Are all the watchtowers manned? How about the security cameras and spy drones, how many are still functioning? You got blind spots all over the Fright Zone, Lonnie. Like the service tunnels, the vents or the sewers? There is a huge freaking hole in the northern battlements. Thats how Adora and I got in last time, just sailed right on through in a skiff. ” Catra began to rattle off all the avenues Tri-clops could infiltrate with something as small as a drone or as huge as a tank.

Lonnie raised a finger and opened her mouth to retort. Then clamped it shut. “Ok, Force Captain, you are coming back to my tent for a while to help me figure out optimal troop placement and to prioritize the repairs of our surveillance and security systems.”

Catra laughed and nodded, while Adora beamed at her with pride. She might have been a cruel taskmaster as a commander, but she knew what she was doing to maximize the war effort.

Adora had spent the afternoon, freeing the rest of the animals trapped in stasis. The ex-horde had managed to erect the rest of the cages needed, in her absence. As evening descended over the ruins of the Fright Zone, the deep purple tones of dusk fell over what remained of this metal dystopia. That she had known as home for the entirety of her childhood. Adora found herself standing out on the tarmac beyond the hanger that stored the stasis pods. Staring up at the sky as the last embers of light faded below the massive towers and chemical stacks in the distance. It was Catra's beautiful, if haunted voice that called to her. Echoing upon the cool wind, that blew over the empty, cement field. Drawing her away from her duty, towards their platform that lay high above the Forge. She listened and her heart swelled with joy and ached with longing and sorrow as she sang to the final rays of the sun.

“Oh, Look to the skies, my Wildling.
Chase the sun, until forever comes.
and let your shadow's fall behind you.”

For we will be together again,
within the eternal flames of Adarion.

Oh, Look to the skies, my Wildling.
When daylight's fading, still your breath.
Be safe in the arms of love.

For we will be together again,
within the infinite starshine of Etheria.

Oh, Sing to the skies, my Wildling.
For destiny calls, to the brave.
The fire within will light your way.

For we will be together again,
Beneath the skies, of the Savannah.

Oh, Sing to the skies, my Wildling.

Chase the sun until forever comes,

and let your shadow's fall behind you.”

The beautiful melody echoed over the Fright Zone, drawing the soldier's under its tranquil spell. They drew still, mid task and cast their faces up to the darkening sky. Their conversations dwindled into silence, as they stood enraptured by the ebb and flow of Catra's voice upon the wind. Her voice was ethereal, having a powerful emotional impact on those who listened. Each soldier drew inward, reflecting upon themselves, their memories. Falling soberly upon their own thoughts, feeling the loss and yearning within the lyrics. Some were brought to tears, others held each other's hands or embraced. Seeking to convey silent support and comfort for their comrades in arms. The long war had never been one sided, they had lost friends, family, and lovers as well. As full darkness descended and the first of Etheria's greater moons rose above the horizon, Catra's voice faded away.

Leaving those below, lost and wishing to hear more.

Catra was leaning against the railing of their platform, her voice wavering on that final note as it faded into silence. When Catra slowly opened her eyes at the end of her song, she found Adora sitting upon the platform beside her. Her back leaning against the metal guardrail, her eyes were closed, a fond if sad smile pulling upon her lips. She was lounging easily, one leg drawn up and an arm braced over her knee. Her marron cloak was draped sideways over that raised arm, shielding half of her body from view. Her ponytail had loosened, freeing several strands of blonde hair. That fluttered lazily in the cool wind, blowing down from the barren hills of Horror Hall in the distance.

“That was so beautiful....and sad...” Adora spoke softly, as tears slipped down her cheek. She was reluctant to open her eyes, heaving a great sigh. After a few more calming breaths she finally opened her eyes. Her stare was distant, still wrapped up in her own bitter sweet memories.

“You heard it before...” Catra muttered, shyly picking at the petals of light blue daisies growing upon a vine that had twisted around the upper rail. She was bashful at having an audience, even if it was just Adora.

“I know...your mother's lullaby is just so...” Adora heaved another shaky breath unable to finish her sentence, casting her eyes upward to the dusk colored sky.

Catra offered her a small, understanding smile as she settled down beside her.

“I see you hauled up our packs and sleeping bags up here.” Adora waved a hand towards the two sleeping bags. The very same ones they had used in the hidden bunker during the final days of the war.

“Yeah, I couldn't sleep down there. It feels way too weird to be here as it is.” Catra huffed, as Adora subtly slipped her hand into hers, curling her fingers within Catra's.

“We don't belong here anymore.” Adora stated a few minutes later, leaning her head back to rest against the lower rail. Scanning the first few stars that shone high above amid the growing darkness of the coming night.

“Yeah...” Catra sighed, squeezing her hand. Leaving so much more unsaid.

Adora had sensed it, her unease and shame when they were down in the camp amid the ex-horde. Seen how the soldier's kept their distance, casting Catra nervous, scared glances. The fox hybrid had offered Catra gratitude for saving her and the lost soldier's under Grizzlor's command. They now had a safe place to

belong. To rebuild a kingdom they could be proud of, under Scorpia's rule. But Catra's interaction with her had been stiff and awkward. She didn't know how to proceed with seeking the ex-horde's forgiveness, or if they would be open to giving her a second chance. So she had made herself an outcast, retreating to their platform to remain a part from them.

Adora understood her need to retreat for now, until she felt more welcome among them. It hurt her heart to see Catra so torn up inside. The guilt and shame over how callously she had thrown those under her command relentlessly at the rebellion's forces. As if they were just pawns on a board game and not real people with thoughts and feelings. So many people had died on both sides of the war and Prime had taken even more lives during his occupation. There was just so much healing to be done...the scars of war upon all the people of Etheria ran far too deep and jagged still.

Perfuma had stated back in Plumeria, that only time could heal these scars. So Adora would have to learn patience to allow what she couldn't control time to fix itself.

Catra slowly leaned into her, resting her head on her shoulder. Adora held her, kissed the top of her head tenderly, cupping her cheek and rubbing her thumb soothingly along her cheekbone. As they watched night, fall over the Fright Zone. The endless blanket of starlight spreading over them.

“I miss them...our lost squad mates” Adora whispered, “I wonder if they are looking down upon us from those stars....just like your song said?”

“My mother told me she is in a place called the Eternal Realm. That perhaps the people of Etheria don't really die....maybe a part of them merely moves on to another sort of living?” Catra shrugged.

“Tama would have loved to see the stars.” Adora sniffed, valiantly trying to hold back her tears.

“Yeah, she would have.” Catra nodded, somberly. .

Tama

Chapter Notes

Warnings: Seizures, Grand Maul, Character death

Adora was weary, yet sleep remained elusive. Her thoughts were racing in an endless round, with no relief from the doubts and worries that plagued her. Laying beneath Catra, who had made herself comfortable. By draping herself over Adora's chest, tucking her face into her favorite nook, just beneath Adora's chin. Her ear pressed up against her chest, listening the comforting beat of her heart. With her arms draped over Adora's shoulder's, holding her close. Sharing a sleepless night, filled with heavy contemplations and sad memories. High atop their platform above what remained of the Fright Zone. Surrounded by flowering vines that were twisted around the rails. Small blossoms of pink and blush blue scenting the air with their sweet nectar. The universe above sparkled with a million stars, the five greater moons hanging heavy in the sky. Their smaller companion moons and satellites scattered over the heavens, creating a truly ethereal backdrop over their heads.

Catra and Adora snuggled together in one sleeping bag, leaving the other untouched nearby. Tangled in each other's arms, Catra shifted, resting her cheek against Adora's shoulder, her breath puffing in hot bursts against the blonde's collar bone. Half of her feline body was draped over Adora's pinning her down. Her tail had curled itself around Adora's thigh in an unconscious action of claim. Adora adjusted her arm around Catra's slender waist, holding her flush against her own body. The felines contented purr rumbled softly, echoed by Melog's who was now curled up at the base of the railing. As the night dragged on, Melog would come and go, but never leave for long. Adora figured they had gone on a recon around the base to make sure it was secure before settling down for a bit. Melog was very protective of Catra. Adora was grateful for them, if things went bad again and she had to leave Catra for whatever reason. Then she would never be truly

alone again as she had been before. It eased Adora's fears towards the future somewhat.

The moons hovered above them, bathing the platform in a gentle silvery glow. Adora had watched their slow trek across the sky for most the night. Unable to settle down and sleep. Her muscles are still humming with unspent energy, causing her to shift and twitch unconsciously. Her thoughts were just too loud. Screaming in her head that she needed to stay focused, stay on task and that going on this trip with her squad mates was dangerous, irresponsible. Some nights were just like this, for her. She took a deep breath and whistled it out and threw tight lips. She didn't know how to relax or let go of that need to control everything. Constantly shouldering far too much responsibility to protect others. To always be on guard to threats and be prepared at all times to act. This sense of duty and personal sacrifice to keep everyone safe and happy had defined her for far to long.

“Can't sleep?” Catra's voice was weak, barely a whisper. As if she was just surfacing from a deep slumber and was still a bit drowsy.

“I thought you had fallen asleep?” Adora answered, lightly brushing a strand of curly brunette hair off her temple and behind a furry ear. Giving the back of her ear a light scratch, making the feline moan pleasantly at the loving attention.

“Maybe, but I am also using you as a pillow and you are jerking around like you just got hit by a stun baton...so I knew you were awake and restless.” Catra sighed, pulling away to lean over her. Her eyes staring down at her full of concern and yearning for answers.

Adora heaved a great sigh and crossed an arm under her head, leaving her other arm wrapped lightly around Catra’s waist. Needing to hold her and ground herself.

Catra cupped her cheek with a gentle hand, urging her silently to confess what was bothering her. But Adora stubbornly remained

silent, pretending to be interested in the stars above. So she didn’t have to confront Catra's heavy gaze.

“Things have been crazy...I get that. We have a lot to handle right now. Problems just keep piling up and we're not tackling any of them fast enough.” Catra started, answering her own question. As she combed her claws repeatedly threw Adora's loose blonde hair, tucking it behind her ear. It was a tender and calming gesture she had used on her for years, when she was upset.

“I know, we promised Lonnie that we would go and pay our respects to the memorial. But I am having a hard time keeping it. I miss our old squad mates…I do...but their dead...going to some wooden effigy we built five years ago when we were kids, will not change that. I should be at the Crystal Castle, figuring out who this Despara is and why she is infecting my magic? But I feel horrible for even thinking that way...though. Cause Lonnie....Kyle...Rogelio and the rest of the squad will be there...and it's important that we go...we all grew up together....we're...family.” Adora moaned, her voice rambling away softly into nothing. Silently conceding to the enormous guilt and regret she felt towards her once comrades.

Catra sighed and leaned down, placing a tender kiss upon her forehead.

“Stop....spiraling. Adora. Going to the Crystal Castle...is not going to instantly solve this problem.” She advised gently.

“I know...I kinda broke the Castle when I blasted Light Hope into oblivion...” Adora huffed. “I might not be able to get any information about Despara anyway...but I need to try.” She pleaded, her lower lip quivering. As she struggled to hold back tears. Of both anguish and frustration at the whole impossible situation they were in.

Catra quickly leaned down and kissed her lovingly, needing to quell her fears and offer reassurance. Adora's lips were soft and encouraging, as she received Catra's love. Catra was reluctant to

pull away, deepening the kiss for a moment. Their quiet affection quickly heated up into something more passionate, leaving them both breathless a few minutes later. With a moan and a soft whimper Catra gathered herself and reluctantly pulled away.

“As long as you don't try and turn into She-Ra, I think we can hold out for a week before solving that problem.” Catra stated, then gave Adora's chest a light pat. “It's very important to Lonnie that we go.”

“I know...I know...” Adora moaned, thumping the back of her head against her arm in frustration. Casting her gaze despairingly towards the endless blanket of starlight. “We've been pretty terrible squad mates to those three.”

“You have no idea how horrible I treated them after you left.” Catra groused, adjusting herself at an angle in the sleeping bag. So she could rest the back of her head against Adora's shoulder to watch the stars as well.

Adora blew out another despondent breath...winding her arms over Catra’s bare belly needing to hold her tighter again. “I abandoned my family....as if they didn't matter.” She bemoaned, sadly.

“I turned into a power hungry tyrant. I was cruel and heartless. I put them in harm's way again and again, commanded them to continue to fight, battle after battle. Even though they were tired and wounded....because winning was more important than their lives to me.” Catra barked, in an angry clipped tone.

“We both suck....” Adora nodded.

“Yep....” Catra agreed, “But this is a start to making things right between us and them. We both want to repair that friendship...I had a real awakening being trapped on Primes Ship. I am not going to waste any chance I get to redeem myself to the people who matter.” She rolled over and started climbing on top of Adora and draping herself over her chest again.

“Lonnie, Kyle....Rogelio...the others...they all matter.” Adora echoed, softly. Grunting under Catra's weight. As Catra straddled her waist and settled herself on top of her chest. Adora nuzzled her face into velvet soft fur on Catra's neck, placing feather light kisses there. As Catra hummed and snuggled into her shoulder, taking a long, comforting sniff of Adora's loose hair as she wiggled and got comfortable.

Adora wrapped her arms around her true love's back and held her tight. Catra always knew what she needed most, when she was feeling upset.

“Sleep, dummy.” Catra mumbled, her purr starting up again. “We got one hell of a hike tomorrow and we do not need to be dragging ass.”

Adora moaned, wrapping her arms around Catra's back and holding her tight. The extra weight and warmth Catra provided calmed her quickly into a sleepy haze. It didn't take very long for her to fall asleep after that. Catra had pinned her like this many times growing up, whenever she was too stressed out to sleep. She knew how to comfort her best and Adora had missed her so very much. She had taken her for granted and only realized too late how much she needed her. She had regretted leaving her behind every day. Now that she had her back, she was never going to let go.

First Year of Junior Cadet training...

The sharp twittering noise grew louder as a small group of Horde kids crept into the cool shadows. At the very back of the storage warehouse. Little Catra led the way, moving on all fours, her tail snapping behind her. Wearing her red and white bodysuit and

grey pants. It had only been a couple months since her, Adora and Rogelio were moved out of the nursery and into the Red Squad Barracks. There they had met other little kids, who had graduated out of the nursery, from other childcare units. A boy named Kyle, who was small and wiry. Who followed Rogelio around like a lost foundling. A set of twin's Ami and Arron whose skin was very pale and had dark hair and dark blue eyes. They were both soft spoken and kinda creepy, only talking to each other in some strange made up language no one could understand. Another boy who came from the same childcare unit as Kyle, called Bryson. Who had spiky blonde hair and a rather bulky physique. As if the caregiver's back, in the nursery over fed him a bit. He was rather boisterous and full of zeal towards any order or task given by their Staff Sergeant. Which made him rather annoying to Catra but well liked by their superior. A squid hybrid called Otis, that mostly kept to himself and a Tauran, Atila. Who was the largest of the squad, with black hide and a thick mane of black hair he had cut short. So that it stood up like a mohawk on top of his head. With short, sharp, pointed horns, that stuck straight out his temples. He was gruff and a bit of a bully so Catra learned quickly to avoid him as much as possible. A few more foundlings their age had come over the last few months, found by Horde soldiers on patrol from all corners of the Etheria. A human boy with bleached blonde hair tinted a light green, called Max and a skinny black haired boy called Louis. Two human girls, one with short dark brunette hair, that hung over her eyes, called Levi. The other with long dirty blonde hair that she kept in a ponytail, called Sara. The four of them never spoke much and stuck together.

The last couple of foundlings to enter the barracks. Catra found the most intriguing at least. Was a dark skinned girl, called Lonnie. She was angry most of the time and lashed out rather violently when she was frustrated, even more so than Catra. With the most interesting hair she had ever seen. It was dark and curled tightly to the head. The other was a tiny fox hybrid, called Tama. She was the smallest of their entire squad, besides Catra. She barely reached Catra's shoulder in height, dainty and overly

thin, but very clumsy. With huge fluffy ears and an unruly head of curly red hair to match. She was a dreamer, so wrapped up in her imagination she was barely aware of her surroundings most of the time. Managing to trip over her own feet just walking down the corridors. She had a sweet round face and wide emerald green eyes that shine at night just like Catra's. When she arrived she was given Catra's old clothes from last season. So she now wore a white training shirt, with the red sleeves torn off and a frayed collar and hem. She wore grey pants with a hole in the back for her fluffy tail.

It didn't take long for their bunk room to fill up to capacity. Now their squad was fifteen strong and their Staff Sergeant was eager for them to prove their mettle. Catra had been excited to start training with Adora, but over the last six months her eagerness had waned. She spent most of her free time exploring the Fright Zone. Going on one adventure after another, with or without Adora. Finding all sorts of treasures and interesting places to explore, also several really good hiding places. Incase Shadow Weaver or their Staff Sergeant were hunting her down for punishments. She was a free thinker and rather stubborn so had difficulty following order's if she didn't understand why they were given. She would argue, lose her temper and lash out violently against the Staff Sergeant or other squad members. Which would get her extra chores or worse having to be reprimanded by Shadow Weaver for insubordination. That usually ended up as some kind of corporal punishment, that would leave her with bruises for days afterward. Of if she was lucky, just a verbal dressing down about how she needed to improve her attitude and be more like Adora. Other times, when she had really messed up. Resulted in very painful conditioning, as Shadow Weaver explained. That would be doled out by the power of the Black Garnet. The severity of her reprimand would be determined by the Sorceress' whims, so she never knew what to expect when she was sent to her chamber's for instructions. She had learned in the last six months to fear Shadow Weaver. Yet she still wanted to prove to the sorceress that she was worthy of praise, that she was strong and could achieve everything Adora could. She still

had hope that Shadow Weaver would give her the same affection and pride, that she offered Adora. She just had to earn it, just like Adora did. So she was as competitive as ever, with Adora. They became the top two junior cadets in the Red Squad. Adora was well liked by all the cadets, she was easy going and kind to everyone.

While Catra didn't quite fit in, she was standoffish and quick to become irritated by the other kids. They didn't understand her hybrid quirks and got frustrated by her as often as she got upset with them. At this point it seemed the squad tolerated Catra because she was Adora's best friend. Catra seemed perfectly fine with that, she only wanted to be friends with Adora anyway. Tama had become their shadow within a few days of arriving. Always tagging along on their adventures, chattering away about the most random things when they were headed to class. Adora liked her well enough, looking out for her in the same protective manner she did for Catra. Catra tried harder to get along with Tama than the other cadets, for Adora's sake. She didn't know if she liked her to the same degree as Adora, but Tama was a hybrid and she understood Catra in a way Adora never could.

After their morning drills and class, they got an hour to themselves before the afternoon exercises and more classes began. Catra had eaten her lunch quickly then disappeared to enjoy the free time. She reappeared several minutes later and dragged Adora from the mess hall. Excited to show her something. She had found in the barracks storage warehouse at the edge of their training yard. Tama had been eating with her and quickly followed in pursuit.

The storage shed was a huge tin building with a rounded roof, bolted together in curved, riveted segments. With a cement floor and thick metal girders that rose out of view over their heads. The warehouse smelled musty and damp. The massive, heavy, rolling doors that were usually shut when equipment or supplies were not being moved to the barracks. Had been left open a crack,, allowing Catra to enter and explore. All manner of yard equipment and mechanical tools sat near the front doors,

including a few hover sleds, called Runners. A shard of light filtered onto their rusty metal hulls, from the crack between the massive sliding doors. They had squeezed through that very same crack in the hangar doors to get inside. Moving as quietly as they could to the back of the warehouse. Where walls of wooden crates were stacked along the back corner of the cavernous building. Creating a makeshift labyrinth of sorts, with narrow twisting corridors.

Catra stopped suddenly and Adora, who couldn't see very well in the near darkness stumbled right into her backside. Her lumbering, booted feet, stepping right on Catra's bare heel.

"Owwww." Catra growled, hopping on her good foot, while rubbing her other foot tenderly. Shooting Adora a disgruntled look. Adora was wearing her white training shirt with the red short sleeves and grey pants with the darker grey patches over her knees.

"Sorry..." Adora muttered, following Catra's orders to be quiet. That she had commanded them before entering the warehouse.

"DORA! CAT!" Tama shouted, her sweet, high pitched voice echoing loudly off the metal roof. "I'm lost....come find me! This place is creepy!"

Catra's ears folded back at the sudden burst of sound. Then loud cawing echoed from the rafter's, followed by sharp flapping. A couple black shapes shot out of cover in the rafters, then dived down from the roof, soaring out through the shallow opening in the front doors.

"Awwww...." Catra moaned in disappointment..."There goes my surprise!" She stomped her foot, her toes claws scraping against the cement.

"Were those....birds?" Adora pointed towards the doors and spoke in awe. It was rare to see live animals from the Whispering Woods in the Fright Zone. Most didn't cross the wasteland to get to the

base, those that survived the migration across the barren land usually didn't last long. There was no natural vegetation for them to eat or take shelter in. The only animal that had managed to find a way to live in the base was rats and mice. Catra had lost her mind, chasing a mouse a few weeks back. Suddenly overwhelmed by her natural hunting instincts she just couldn't help herself. The tiny creature had eventually outsmarted poor Catra. Disappearing into the slates of a floor vent, seconds before Catra had run full speed into the wall. In a desperate attempt to catch it before it escaped. Unable to stop her momentum. She had slammed her face so hard into the vent, it had left imprints across her face and she fell back on her butt. Blinking lamely up at Adora, as she was now dazed by the sudden impact. It had been so funny, Adora was still laughing about it weeks later.

"Yeah....I wanted to show you...and just you! Tama ruins everything! Why do you let her follow us?" Catra snarled, curling her hands into fists and stomping off towards the pathetic sounds of whimpering and sniffling that was Tama.

"I don't...she just does..." Adora shrugged, walking beside her as they made their way back through the maze of crates. Catra rolled her eyes, if Adora wasn't so nice to her she would get the message to leave them alone. But Adora didn't have a mean bone in her body. Catra loved that about her, but it was also very annoying at times, in regards to Tama. Tama was sweet and kind just like Adora. She had a gentle spirit and cried easily. So she couldn't take being teased by the other cadets or yelled at by their superiors, when she messed up. Which was often. She was forgetful, always daydreaming, instead of doing her chores. Coming up with fantastical stories she couldn't wait to tell to the other kids in the barracks. Adora usually asked to be paired up with her, to help her stay on task and out of trouble. Which meant Catra was also enduring the same chores and struggling to not pull her mane out or yell at the absent minded fox. Whenever she would find Tama just standing there, leaning against her broom staring out the windows instead of working. She was naturally clumsy. Always messing up their exercises, during their combat drills, so that the squad ended up doing extra until she figured

them out. She wasn't strong or fast, so she held up their squad a-lot during morning laps making them late for breakfast. She struggled to stay still during class, getting into trouble with their instructors on a daily basis. Learning their letters and numbers was difficult and it took a-lot of extra tutoring on Adora's part, to help her keep up with her studies. After several months of this, Catra had slowly gotten used to Tama being their third wheel. She had come to tolerate her, even perhaps like her a little because she was so very sweet and kind. She would sneak Catra extra rations bars from the mess, a peace offering when she had irritated the cat hybrid to the end of her patience. Or keep her company after class, when she got into trouble and had to stay and do extra school work. Entertaining her with crazy stories, Catra knew they never really happened to her. But Tama would always say they were true. She had an incredible imagination!

The cool season was soon upon them, the mornings were becoming crisp and a cold breeze always awaited them when their Staff Sergeant, who was called Lazlo. Dragged them out of bed at the crack of Moonrise to run laps in the outdoor training yard. Catra's fur would fluff to keep her warm, while Adora's cheeks would become pink and she would shiver and wrap her arms around herself. Stomping her booted feet on the cement yard as they stood awaiting orders.

"I want twenty laps, then you can go to the mess for breakfast. I want you to show me some drive out there, no walking or dragging your feet. For a little added incentive, the cadet in last place will miss the morning meal!" Lazlo was a short, burly human, with a stout chest and thick arms and legs. He kept his dark hair shaved tight to his skull. He had a rugged face with a strong jaw, wrinkled and pock marked from enduring long days in the cold elements. He had been a Force Captain of a squad that had been in steady combat, keeping their supply lines near the Northern Reach open. He had been reassigned as a cadet

instructor after his whole squad had been wiped out by Rebel insurgence.

As young cadets they were not privy to the war, they only got to witness the aftermath. The wounded coming into the infirmary, the broken and haunted expression of Soldiers on leave or the re-commissioned officer's like Lazlo who were no longer useful out in the field. As such Lazlo now walked with a limp.

"Yes! Staff Sergeant!" The fifteen little cadets snapped a salute and filed out onto the yard to do their laps. Catra and Adora kept pace with each other near the front of the pack, casting each other confident smiles as they counted their laps. Knowing that as soon as they got to the last lap, they were going to race full speed around the yard to see who would win this time.

As they came up on the last lap, passing the Staff Sergeant who was standing by the heavy barracks doors. Catra cut Adora a smug almost arrogant smile, charging forward just before the finish line.

"Hey!" Adora cried, indignant at Catra's cheating head start.. She ducked her head, her blue eyes hardening with determination. Pumping her arms and legs, pushing her body to move faster. She closed the distance at the next bend in the yard.

Tama was trudging just ahead, in last place. Her skin was very pink under the velvet soft, light tan fur of her cheeks. Sweat dampening her forehead, dripping off her chin and rolling down her neck. Puffing for breath, the fox hybrid was struggling to keep moving.

Catra sped past her without a care, focused on winning. Knowing Adora was right on her heels.

Adora charged past Tama, casting her a brief, worried look over her shoulder as she passed. But didn't think too much about it, Tama was always last when they did laps. Refocusing on her mission of beating Catra she faced forward again. They quickly

passed a few of the squad just ahead of Tama. Adora taunted Catra with her laughter as she sped past the magicat further along the straight away. At the back of the yard along the chain link fence that separated their barracks from the rest of the base.

"You are not going to win this time!" Catra snarled, tucking her chin and lunging out on all fours. She cleared the distance in no time, speeding past Adora with her tail raised high, to help keep her balance.

"No fair!" Adora shouted, panting for breath as they raced past the last turn. She cried out in frustration, as Catra quickly pulled ahead cackling brightly.

"What's it like being slower than me?" Catra taunted, looking over her shoulder with a smirk as she finished the race.

When Adora crossed the finish line a few seconds later, she found Catra dancing with her hands over her head in triumph, then shooting her a victory pose with her fingers.

Adora was out of breath but she smiled happily at Catra and laughed.

"Cadet!" The Staff Sergeant bellowed, arms crossed angrily over his chest as he stormed over to the little magicat. Glowering down at Catra with disapproval.

"I prohibited you hybrids months ago from running on all fours, it places the rest of the squad at a disadvantage." He snapped, hovering over Catra and casting her in shadow. As the rising day moons glowed a brilliant red over the fence line. The chemical smog that hovered over the base, tainting the moons natural light. The unnatural red glow of the morning sky, a sinister back drop to Lazlo's rage.

Catra growled nervously and folded her ears back, shaking in fear under his fierce glare.

“It's ok...it just makes me want to work harder to get faster.” Adora moved swiftly to place herself between Catra and the Staff Sergeant.

“Adora, we expect all of our cadets to train the same.” He crouched down and placed a hand on Adora's shoulder giving her a fond smile.

“Catra, would you want to leave Adora behind like that when you are under heavy fire?” He turned and regarded Catra sternly.

“I would never leave Adora...ever!” Catra spat indignantly.

“But you just did...” He threw the truth back at her, with a exasperated look.

“I...I....I just wanted to win.” Catra pouted.

“Five more laps Cadet for breaking the rules.” He stood and pointed to the yard.

Catra felt terrible, her young mind now churning with the idea that if they had been in a real combat situation, she would have just put Adora's life in danger. But also angry that she wasn't allowed to use her hybrid talents to give her squad an advantage in combat. She grumbled and jogged back onto the open training yard not even looking at Adora. So full of shame and anger. Hating the look in Adora's eyes, that was so full of concern and sympathy that she was in trouble yet again.

The rest of the squad finished their laps and waited for her and Tama to finish. Catra kept passing Tama again and again as the fox hybrid had slowed down to a shuffling walk. Her fluffy tail had dropped low dusting the ground, her ears flopped limply as she struggled to keep moving. Catra was too focused on finishing and heading to breakfast she never paid much attention as to how pale and sick Tama was looking.

Catra finished her extra laps in no time and stood waiting with the rest of the squad for Tama.

“Come on Tama! We're hungry!” Lonnie screamed at the fox hybrid.

Adora looked concerned, casting Tama and their Staff Sergeant nervous glances.

“Run! Tama!” Another squad mate screamed. A young human boy, called Louis. Who's had short dark hair and warm hazel eyes. Usually soft spoken and shy, he had to be real hungry to draw attention to himself by shouting.

Then a few more of the squad began to chant “Run, Tama, Run!”

Catra stood pacing near the doors, her stomach growling. Watching the day moons ascend over the top of the fence as they waited for Tama. Breakfast in the mess hall would be over very soon.

Tama's face scrunched up in pained concentration as she struggled to lift her feet. She was puffing and hyperventilating by the time she rounded the last bend. Her legs were shaking so fiercely they were barely able to hold her weight. She stumbled, tried to regain her balance but failed and ended up flat on her face in the dirt.

“Tama!” Adora cried in fear, racing down the yard.

Catra was quickly in pursuit. Tama might annoy her at times, but they had spent a lot of time together and Catra had grown rather fond of her.

Tama had rolled onto her side and her whole body was now shivering and jerking violently.

“What's going on!” Adora screamed, hovering over Tama in panic. As Catra charged in at her side, casting the Staff Sergeant who was now running up to them a very scared look.

“I'll deal with this, go have your breakfast!” He shouted out his command, kneeling before Tama and bracing her head in his lap.

Spittle was foaming around Tama's tight lips, as she convulsed. Her tiny hands had curled up tight to her chest as if she was being crushed by some invisible force.

Adora didn't move, even when Catra pulled on her elbow.

“Dismissed!” Lazlo bellowed, his eyes burning with rage at their insubordination.

“As you command!” Catra shouted, dragging Adora away. She whimpered and sniffled, tears threatening as Catra guided her away to the mess.

When they got back, Tama was in her bunk sleeping. She stayed there for a few days, exhausted and delirious. Saying weird things that made no sense, barely lucid. Slurring her words when she tried to talk. As the the whole squad continued to check on her for the rest of the week.

Catra and Adora were scared and freaked out about what had happened to Tama and why she was acting so strange afterwards. But they tended to her as best they could as little first year cadets. Taking turns checking on her during the day, sneaking back to the barracks between class and training. Bringing Tama water and rations bars after every meal. In a few days time Tama was back to normal and following them around as before. But they treated her differently now, Catra was more tender and didn't yell at her when she messed things up for them. Adora became more protective and helpful, almost smothering, in her attempts to care for Tama in every way possible.

Tama never got upset or frustrated by how they seemed to coddle her now. She ignored it and just tried to prove to them in small ways that she could be independent.

Season's past and soon the Fright Zone was warming up again. Tama continued to have episodes just like the first one. They were not as scary for the other cadets to witness. Soon the Staff

Sergeant allowed Adora and Catra to care for her while she had them. Along with the warmer days, came the rains. The smog from the factories made the sky look a foreboding blood red at dusk, during the setting of the day moons. When a massive storm rolled in, with ear splitting thunder and flashing lightning that blanketed the sky in sudden violent bursts. The cadets huddled inside their barracks, too scared to even venture down the halls out of their bunk room for supper. As thunder rolled threateningly overhead, a deafening crash broke, just above them. The bunk room's thin tin roof vibrated, under the sudden burst of air pressure. Causing the little kids huddling in groups, to yelp, whimper and cry softly in fear as they hid beneath their cotton blue or grey blankets.

Catra's ears folded back and she cringed in pain, her arms wrapped comfortingly around Tama. Who was plastered to her front, her tiny arms wrapped around her chest, gripping her shoulder blades tight. Tama's fluffy copper-red ears were pressed tight against her head, eyes squeezed shut. Adora held the blanket over top of them both, kneeling over them and shielding them slightly with her larger body.

"It's gonna be ok....it's just a storm." Adora promised, trying to sound calm. But Catra could hear the slight waiver of fear in her tone. Catra sighed heavily, adjusting her hold around Tama's shoulder's, as she slowly opened her mismatched eyes. Glancing down with a strong smile of reassurance, finding the fox, staring wide eyed and unblinking once more. At the outer wall of the bunk room. Her stare fixed between her and Adora's bunk and Lonnie's.

Lonnie was holding a terrified Kyle tight in her arms, while Rogelio mimicked Adora's pose with their own blanket on the bunk beside them. Rogelio growled every time the thunder struck, blinking in pain. Storms were hard on the hybrids. The only other cadets like them was, Otis. A Selinean Squid hybrid, who was curled tight under their blanket on their top bunk. Only the tips of their blue tentacles could be seen, twitching and jerking in pain every time the bunk room shook. The other was a black hide, Tauran, called

Atila. Who was currently at the back of their bunk room, by the doors that led out to the yard. Pacing and glowering out at the storm as if he wanted to go out there and fight it!

Rain storms were not uncommon during the warm season, but they didn't happen as frequently in this arid wasteland then in other parts of Etheria. The rain always made the Fright Zone smell terrible. The air was so filled with chemical smog, the moisture created a toxic fog that hung over the base for at least a day after the storm. The streets would be slick with oily puddles and the alley between buildings would stink of mold and rot. Catra hated the rain, she was starting to hate a lot of things now that they were out of the nursery. She missed the freedom of being able to play whenever she wanted. Now she was considered a soldier and had responsibilities to train, go to school and do her chores. If she failed in any way there were consequences. Either by their Staff Sergeant or their guardian....Shadow Weaver.

Light flashed through the cracks between the bolts and rivets that bonded the tin walls of the bunk room together. Tama was transfixed on those brilliant flashes. The sudden strobing invades their safe haven every few minutes. She shivered against Catra, her tiny hands clutching the bigger hybrid's shoulder as she panted and whimpered in fright. Her fluffy ears twitching in tiny spasms, as Catra hummed soothingly against the top of her head. Tama wasn't scared, she felt safe. It was warm under the covers with Adora and Catra, she snuggled between them. The lights outside were so fascinating, she could not stop staring at the wall. She was starting to feel funny though, her body felt stiff and her lower lip was vibrating. It was slow at first, her shoulder's began to twitch. Bumping against Adora's chest, then her fingers clenched, her claws sinking deep into Catra's back.

"Owwww...." Catra yowled, trying to push away from Tama. But the Fox held tight, her mouth clamped shut and her eyes rolled back into head.

"She is having an episode!" Adora cried, backing off a bit as Catra leaned forward. Trying to lay Tama down flat on her mattress. As

her tiny body began to tremor and shake more violently.

“Get her off!” Catra screamed, now hovering over Tama on all fours. As she couldn't get Tama to release her. Trapped in an iron embrace with Tama's smaller body slamming against her front. Tama's forehead banging hard against her chin. Catra tried twisting her body and arching her neck away from Tama to no avail.

Adora tossed the blanket aside and was quick to pry Tama's fingers away from Catra's shoulder blades. Catra quickly scuttled away to the edge of the bed. As Adora pulled the fox's head into her lap.

Catra sat, holding her breath and staring down at Tama nervously. Usually it only took a couple minutes for Tama to calm down and fall asleep. But this time she just kept shaking! Her whole body was jumping off the mattress with such violence. Foam and blood was starting to burble out of the corners of her mouth and moisten Adora's lap.

Adora stared at Tama with barely restrained terror. Sniffling and gasping from time to time as she held back her sobs. Valiantly, cradling Tama's head with her palms, seeking to keep her safe from hurting herself more, not wanting her to strike her head against the metal sides of their bunk.

“Adora....” Catra muttered, clasping the taller blonde's shoulder with a hand and squeezing to get her attention.

“Go get help...” Adora breathed, holding Tama as steady as she could with her tiny arms.

“K...” Catra scrambled off the bunk and raced off down the short hall that connected their bunk room to the main barracks.

She ran at full speed down the corridor, turning sharply when the hall divided into several adjoining corridors. Slamming her shoulder into the wall with a resounding clang, barely keeping her cool. As she was slowly being overwhelmed by panic and fear. She

wanted to scream out for help, but the corridors were empty. She knew it would be useless to call out until she got to the mess hall. Her chest was burning and she was out of breath when she crashed threw the double swinging doors to the mess. Finding the large dining room, filled with cadets and soldier's. She didn't even scan the mass of Horde personnel but just stood in the doorway and screamed at the top of her lungs.

"Staff Sergeant, Lazlo! Shadow Weaver!"

She opened her eyes, finding the mass of cadets and soldier's sitting at the long metal tables, staring dumbstruck at her. She quickly scanned the crowds, not finding a familiar face at all. Then swallowed hard, silent tears of dread trailing down her cheeks. "Help...." She whimpered pathetically.

"Alright, Catra. What's going on?" Octavia's loud, abrasive voice that always seemed to have a frustrated tone towards her. Cut mercifully threw the roar of fear howling in her ears.

Catra snapped her gaze to the side, finding the towering bulk of the Octopus Hybrid, striding over to her. Her four dark green tentacles, attached to her back, snapped and writhed in agitation behind her. Dressed in her Force Captain aquatic armor. Of a copper yellow chest piece with a red Horde insignia on the front and black bottoms. Her leather boots striking the floor as she moved briskly over to the terrified junior cadet. Her deep foam green scales still shiny with moisture from walking out in the rain, she must have just finished a patrol before heading over to the mess for supper. Or maybe she just got back from a combat mission? Her fierce golden yellow eyes bore into her small, trembling frame, glowering down at her with thinly veiled annoyance. Catra had never been on good terms with Octavia and she didn't know why.

She couldn't remember if she had done something in the past to warrant such a sour attitude from her. The Force Captain just seemed to hate her for no reason. Her very existence seemed to annoy her. So she and Adora had taken it upon themselves to

tease and prank her, when they caught her on duty near their barracks. She was easy to piss off and it was fun pushing her buttons because of it. She was the perfect officer to bug, cause she never got violent, only chased them around the barracks which only heightened the exhilaration of danger.

"Tama's in trouble." Catra stated weakly, staring up at Octavia as she hovered over her. Her mismatched eyes pleaded for the adult to take charge and make everything alright again.

Octavia nodded, tapping her Force Captain badge to activate her homing signal and communication frequency.
"I need a medic to Red Squad's bunk room, asap!" She snapped, then jogged out of the mess with Catra at her heels.

When they got back to the barracks, Adora was cradling Tama in her lap. Brushing her reddish curly hair fondly behind a fluffy ear. Tama was oddly still, her arms and legs curled up near her body. Lay limp and lifeless.

"I think she fell asleep?" Adora muttered, glancing fearfully up at Octavia. Tears shimmered in her hopeful blue eyes. As the Force Captain knelt in front of her mattress, with a grim expression. The rest of the squad was hovering around Adora's bunk, looking distraught and jumping in fright as another roll of thunder echoed over the base. Atila's nostrils flared and he snorted, scowling up at the roof.

Catra climbed up onto the mattress, sniffing at Tama's neck lightly. There was something off about Tama...Catra lightly pressed the palm of her small hand against the fox hybrid's cheek. She was still warm, but her muscles were unnaturally relaxed. Catra swallowed and curled her knees up against her chest. As anxiety and fear rolled over her. Tama wasn't right?

Octavia sighed, pressing two fingertips to the fox hybrid's pulse point on her neck. Then slowly withdrew her hand. "Adora, get me Tama's blanket." She ordered, while double tapping her badge sending a silent signal to cancel the medic.

Adora nodded, setting Tama head down on the mattress gently. Then dashed off her bunk to retrieve the Fox's grey blanket from a few bunks away. Being given an order helped her steady her emotions and allow her to focus on a solid action to help. The tears in her blue eyes quickly dried, as she handed the blanket to Octavia. Backing off to stand nervously by the curved back metal post of their bunk.

Octavia wrapped Tama up tight, draping a corner of the blanket over the Fox's face. Then promptly picked Tama up and cradled her tiny body against her chest as if seeking to hide her from the squads prying eyes.

"I'll take Tama with me. ok." Octavia advised, her tone was soft, gentle even.

Catra narrowed her eyes, Octavia wasn't acting right, she was too nice.

"Is she alright?" Lonnie blurted out, she had come closer to Adora and Catra's bunk. Gripping the edge of the front bed post anxiously. Her eyes were hard. Eyebrows furrowed, staring up at Octavia with obvious distrust.

Octavia was about to answer when their Staff Sergeant strode into the bunk room.

"Come to Attention, Red Squad!" He bellowed.

The fourteen kids were quick to comply, already very well conditioned to obeying orders. They lined up at the edge of their bunks, standing ridged with their arms tight to their sides.

Lazlo regarded Octavia sternly and they seemed to communicate silently for a moment. Catra caught the obvious exchange, her mind spinning with what might be happening.

Lonnie was standing beside her, so she leaned towards the dark skinned girl.

“What's going on?” She hissed.

“There is something really wrong with Tama.” Lonnie hissed back, sniffing softly as she then cleared her throat and ducked her head to conceal the tears moistening her dark hazel eyes.

Catra's eye flew wide in panic, as she watched Octavia walk out of the bunk room with Tama in her arms.

“Alright, Squad leader!” Lazlo marched to stand in front of Adora. Shadow Weaver had made her prodigy their squad leader last season. Stating that it would be good practice for Adora to learn how to command others. Since she was on the fast track to become the youngest Force Captain in the Horde.

Adora snapped her feet together and saluted their Staff Sergeant crisply.

“I want you to lead your squad to the gymnasium. I will meet you there in a few minutes. I expect you all to be running laps until I get there.” He shouted his orders.

“As you command, Staff Sergeant!” Adora shouted back, turning on her heel. “Red Squad, Fall out!” She commanded, her voice cracking as she sought to swallow back her worry and fear over Tama. Trusting in those in power to take care of things that were out of her control.

Catra marched out of the bunk room after Adora with the rest of the squad trailing behind. Who were all now muttering theories about what the adults were going to do to help Tama.

Catra blinked back her own tears, she was scared and overwhelmed. She desperately wanted to reach out and hold Adora's hand. Stifling the urge, since physical contact like that while on duty was frowned upon and if they got caught both of them would be in trouble. Catra could feel Adora’s anxiety and sorrow, as she marched ahead of her. Keeping her head up, sniffling softly as she fought not to cry. Needing to stay in control of her emotions, so that her squad wasn't afraid. Catra glanced

over her shoulder as they marched down the hallways, deeper into the barracks compound. Finding Lonnie stone faced, staring at some distant point ahead of them. She had come to the Horde a few season's back like Tama, as a foundling. The soldier's had taken her along with a few other orphans after a raid near Seaworthy. She never talked about what happened in her village, but she seemed far more informed about what was happening to Tama.

"Lonnie...what's wrong with Tama?" Catra whispered roughly.

"She might be dead." Lonnie spat back. "Octavia's wrapped her up, just like the Horde wrapped up the dead in my village after they destroyed it."

"What's dead?" Catra spat back in obvious confusion. That was a word she did not recognize.

Lonnie huffed and rolled her eyes. "Your so dumb, go find out for yourself. I am not going to explain it." She snapped back, her voice wavering as silent, angry tears fell down her dark cheeks.

Catra narrowed her eyes and glared at Lonnie then broke rank and ran down a side hall, intent on tracking Octavia down.

"Hey...Catra....Come back!" Adora screamed, as she watched the feline race off around the bend of a side hall. Fearful that her friend was going to get caught disobeying orders and get into trouble.

It didn't take long for Catra's keen sense of smell to trace the sour fish scent of Octavia. Soon she was slinking silently a few meter's behind the octopus as she made her way towards the Black Garnet Chamber. Catra's heart was hammering in her chest as she ducked behind a wide metal pipe, when Octavia stopped in front of the sorceress's private room a few paces away from the chamber.

“Shadow Weaver....there has been a casualty.” Octavia, knocked on the door curtly.

A few moments later, the slender, insidiously threatening form of Shadow Weaver hovered in the open doorway.

Octavia pulled up the blanket to show her Tama, curled limply against her chest.

Shadow Weaver released a tired, apathetic breath. “I told them when they first brought the sickly child to me, that she was a lost cause. Dispose of it.” She pointed down the hall, waiting for Octavia to salute and walk away before departing her chamber. Moving at a brisk pace towards their bunk room, her dark robes fluttered like creeping shadows as she rushed past Catra's hiding place. Catra had learned to be wary of her guardian, never knowing what to expect or how she was going to react. Shadow Weaver was naturally cold and distant with her. Not offering any of the affection or comfort she gave Adora. She just figured she hadn't earned that kind of treatment yet. But that perhaps one day, Shadow Weaver would look kindly upon her as well. When Shadow Weaver moved out of sight down a side corridor. Catra swallowed hard then broke cover, scampering after Octavia.

The corridors were starting to warm up as Octavia approached the massive ore refinery complex, known as the Forge. Catra's ears folded back in fear...wondering anxiously why Octavia was taking Tama here instead of the infirmary? She hovered in the grand doorway, scanning the dark interior of the Forge with overwhelming trepidation.

The Forge was a massive, dark vault with sudden loud banging, that vibrated off the unseen walls. Followed by soft hissing and mournful howls that echoed from the dark. Filled with monstrous looking machinery, rusty gears, heavy chains, huge pipes that ran vertically up the walls and slowly turning wheels, Great lines of red glowing vats of molten metal, hanging threateningly high over

head, swinging and groaning as they were pulled towards various areas of the Forge. Disappearing into the gloom at the center of the room. Worker's dressed in full, heavy black leather armor silently moved within the deep shadow's. Their bulky, overly muscled bodies illuminated as if suddenly set on fire, by the bright flashes of light. Erupting from the mouth of the huge main furnace and smaller companion furnaces that sat on the far side of the great room. Great copper bellows, heaved and breathed life into the furnaces every few minutes causing the great flames within to flare. Illuminating the intricate forge works briefly. There were several smaller furnaces attached to the main furnace, with molten orange pipes with several conveyor belts filled with various things to be smelted. Some carried unrefined ore, others metal to be reused, one was piled high with refuse and organic garbage from the mess hall.

Catra shivered, her heart beating unbearably fast that her chest ached and the roar of fear had returned to howl in her ears. She watched bleakly as Octavia disappeared into the bowels of the forge. Striding with purpose across a huge walkway that connected the outer corridor to the working floor.

Catra was so overwhelmed by her fear, she squeezed her eyes shut tight and whimpered piteously. Giving herself a quick pep talk, 'that she needed to save Tama' from whatever cruel fate was in store for her.

Shadow Weaver wanted her disposed of...whatever that meant?

Catra settled her nerves as best she could and found her courage in the most unlikely of places....She narrowed her eyes, determined and full of rage. She leaped out of cover and dashed into the terrifying surroundings of the forge. Charging towards Octavia as the soldier crossed the central work floor towards a wide conveyor belt that led towards the massive open mouth of a furnace. The belt was filled with piles of rotting garbage and larger broken pieces of equipment, chunks of cement and other building scraps. Octavia heaved a resigned breath, glancing down at Tama with a grim look before tenderly setting the girl onto the

belt. Tama never moved as she was set down, laying absolutely still. As her body jerked forward and was pulled along with the garbage. Laying serenely beneath the death shroud of her squad blanket.

Catra screamed from behind Octavia, her mismatched eyes flying wide in alarm as she charged for the belt. Octavia swung around in surprise, finding the little magicat leaping onto the belt a few feet ahead of her. Catra's four tiny claws dug into the rubber, shredding the belt. As she sought to clear the distance between the debris littering the belt and Tama's body.

"Catra!" Octavia shouted in alarm, dashing down the side of the belt. As Catra leaped over a pile of broken equipment, soaring over the sharp metal to land a few feet away from Tama.

"Tama!" Catra screamed, "You have to wake up!" her eyes glistened with tears, her terrified face illuminated in sharp light and shadows from the inferno that was looming just ahead of her. She lunged desperately for Tama, as they closed in on the mouth of the furnace. The incredible heat, singeing the fur on her face and forcing her to squeeze her eyes shut. She was beyond scared, but refused to give into her panic. She was focused solely on pulling Tama's body off the belt. She reached out blindly, her claws latching onto the cotton of Tama's blanket. She yanked back with all her might, needing to pull Tama off the belt. But her tentative grip was suddenly dislodged completely as Octavia's tentacle wrapped around her waist and jerked her violently up into the air.

"NO!....no.no.no....Tama...come back...." Catra screamed wretchedly, writhing desperately in Octavia's grip. Opening her eyes to watch in horror as the last flutter of Tama's blanket turned to ash inside the furnace. Catra couldn't comprehend what had just happened, she hung limply in Octavia's tentacle for a moment. Panting and staring wide eyed at the furnace. Slowly coming to grips with the fact that she failed and Tama was gone forever.

Catra hissed with rage and twisted her body, slashing deeply into Octavia's restraining tentacle. Octavia howled in pain, releasing her. Catra landed on all fours, darting out of her tentacles range. As Octavia sought to grapple her with one of her unharmed tentacles. Octavia cradled her wounded tentacle close, as dark red blood oozed from ten jagged slashes along its length. Her yellow eyes were full of sympathy as she watched the little hybrid run off. Moving as fast as her little arms and legs could carry her. Blinded by tears and wailing in sorrow and guilt at not saving her friend.

"I hate you!" Catra screamed back at Octavia. "This place is evil!" She muttered, as she disappeared into the labyrinth corridors of the base. She understood the concept of Evil, Shadow Weaver had been telling them stories about the Evil Princesses and their terrible magic that could destroy the whole world. To find out that the adults she had believed were there to protect and care for her. Were capable of disposing of someone so callously, to toss them aside as if they were nothing....just garbage. It rocked her world to its very core. She couldn't trust the adults here....they would not protect her or care about her...if she proved to be weak or worthless to the Horde they would dispose of her just like Tama!

"Catra..." Adora's tender voice called from the archway to the bunk room. She had been searching for Catra, ever since Shadow Weaver had finished talking to her and left the gym. Going to Catra's current favorite hiding places first then doubling back to the bunkroom.

Catra didn't hear her, lost to the anguish now slowly crushing her. She had run all the way back to their barracks, so overwhelmed by fear, guilt and grief she had wrapped herself up completely in Adora's blue blanket. Desperate to hide and find someplace, or something to calm her, to make her feel safe. Surrounded by Adora's scent, the only person she found she could trust completely. The one who had found her, named her, protected her in the nursery. She was now Catra's whole world, her sanctuary

that she could always rely on to keep her safe. She couldn't afford to ever let anyone else in, her fragile heart could not survive losing another person she loved. Her weak, mournful cries and sniffling moans echoed throughout the bunk room. As she trembled in overwhelming fear under the blanket. Adora moved cautiously in front of her, lightly pulling back the blanket.

Catra hissed in sudden fright. Glaring up at Adora, both embarrassed and furious at being caught crying so hard. She hated crying, it was a weakness and the Horde did not tolerate it...Shadow Weaver did not tolerate it.

"Catra, it's ok. It's just me." Adora gave her a small, sympathetic smile. "Shadow Weaver told me everything. Tama is being taken care of. So everything is going to be ok."

Catra squeezed her eyes shut and ducked her head away. Refusing to look at Adora's hopeful smile and warm, compassionate blue eyes. She couldn't tell her....wouldn't ever tell her what happened to Tama. It would break her heart...it would be better to just let her be oblivious to what terrible things happened here in the Horde. She needed to protect her, Adora was too good, too kind to shoulder such burdens, it would ruin her. Catra wanted to keep Adora just as she was, perfect, strong and pure of heart. In this way, she could protect Adora...just as Adora always protected her. Catra quickly wiped away her tears with a corner of the blanket, glancing at Adora with a incredulous frown at her words. Shadow Weaver had lied to Adora, in the most devious of ways. Her vague caring words insinuated that Tama was going to be alright. When it obviously had a double meaning. As of this moment she didn't trust anyone here but Adora.

Adora saw the doubt in Catra's eyes and sought to reassure her.

"I doesn't matter what they do to us. You look out for me and I look out for you." Adora offered, pressing her hand in comfort against Catra's chest. Catra moaned, her eyes downcast wanting desperately to believe in those words but she was just so

disillusioned. Adora was not aware of what cruel end happened to Tama. She was assuming Tama just wasn't coming back because she needed special care somewhere else. Catra had no idea what exactly Shadow Weaver had told her and didn't have the courage to ask. It was better if she just kept it to herself, let Adora believe whatever made her feel comfortable about what happened to Tama.

"Nothing really bad can happen to us, as long as we have each other." Adora smiled, holding her close for a moment.

"You promise?" Catra whimpered, unable to hold her back, still too shaken to offer affection. But leaned her head against Adora's chest. Seeking to absorb the security and hope Adora provided.

"I promise." Adora responded, leaning her cheek against the top of Catra's head.

Catra sighed and snuggled under Adora's chin, needing her more than ever. Finally feeling safe, the anxiety and fear slowly fading away in her arms as she heard Adora's heartbeat. It was steady and strong, the most wonderful sound Catra had ever heard.

"Let's go back out there...K." Adora encouraged, standing up and walking out of the bunk room intent on leading Catra back to the gym so she could join the rest of the squad in their evening drills.

Catra heaved one last heavy breath and then stood and followed Adora resolutely back to the gym. She would continue to mourn in private for many seasons to come. Wondering if Adora and the rest of the Squad did the same. This was the first time they had lost one of their own.

Tama was gone...there was nothing more to be done. This was the first but not the last time. Catra would have to pick herself up and keep moving forward after losing someone she cared about.

Many seasons later, Catra caught Octavia alone. Guarding some militia bunker near their barracks. She had been harboring a-lot of pent up loathing towards the octopus since Tama's death. When confronted by her good fortune, she could not let the opportunity for vengeance pass. Snarling, she climbed up onto the railing. Crouched on the rail, glowering menacingly down at Octavia. As the octopus leaned casually against the closed door. Powerful arms crossed over her gold and red armor chest piece, whistling some pointless tune. Silent and self assured. Catra, lunged from the upper railing of the staircase that led down to the bunker. Slashing out Octavia's left eye and then sought to run away as soon as her feet hit the floor. It was the only time Octavia had fought back. Catching Catra off guard, Octavia had lunged out with lightning reflexes, her huge hand gripping the wrist of Catra's slashing hand before she could pull it back. Her long fingers wrapped around the wrist with a bone crushing force. As blood was oozing from her ruined eye. She screamed point blank in Catra's face. The heat from her breath and wind pressure from her bellow. Made Catra squint and her long, wild mane of brunette hair, fluttered back over her shoulder. Then Octavia tossed Catra against the wall with all her might. The little feline had cried in fear as her face struck the wall hard and then cackled with triumph. As she rebounded off the wall and scrambled up the stairs and down the corridor, soon out of sight.

Adora found her, cradling her sore hand and touching her tender nose, moaning in pain. The blonde asked what happened and Catra offered an obvious lie. That Octavia had hit her, for doing nothing but existing beside her. That she had called her a dumb face. Because obviously she had a dumb face!

Several hours later Catra would return with Adora and they would taunt Octavia from the relative safety of the upper stairwell. Finding the hybrid back at her post with a bandage over her eye.

"Octavia, your a dumb face!" Adora shouted in solidarity with Catra. Before grabbing the feline's hand and running off giggling down the corridor with Octavia chasing them as always.

Catra's memories of that time were a grim mixture of emotions. Ranging from grief and fear, slowly healing towards hope and the fantasies of a future. In which she and Adora might one day rule the Horde and change how the military did things. They were going to win the war, bring peace to Etheria. Keep the children they took in, safe, making sure they felt loved and cared for, offering them a better life then what they had. The following memories were bitter sweet, as all of those promises were abandoned when Adora left the Horde. Catra bowed her head with a sad smirk as she finished her morning serenade.

Stranger Danger

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Lonnie's tent was packed with people, when Adora and Catra arrived to set out on their trip. Catra had spent most of the afternoon yesterday, helping Lonnie better strategize the repair efforts over all. Allocating supplies and equipment for the fortifications being constructed along the battlements. Prioritizing the repairs that remained of the Hordes weapons and armor. The remaining factories were still undergoing reconstruction, their machinery only half operational. So manufacturing anything was not an option just yet, they needed to use what they had available. So Catra prioritized reorganizing the personnel, deploying smaller squads with more flexible shifts to maximize efficiency. Scouts and Infantry troops would man the battlements, with their camps set up close to the walls to cut down on transition time between relief personal. Which meant instituting resupply routes through the debris, which meant demolition and repair crews had to clear those streets so cargo transports could navigate down them. Lonnie was amazed how meticulous and concise Catra could organize what remained of the Horde military machine. She thought out every angle that could be used to infiltrate the base, every weakness in their defense, every hypothetical problem that could occur and planned ten steps ahead. It wasn’t perfect, the work and patrol shifts were pretty much 24/7 for the foreseeable future. So that what was left of the base could be defended, or provide better security inside the fortress so to protect the people inside. They also needed to get the forge and the barracks up and running before the cold season. So that the buildings the ex-horde took shelter in could be heated. They were on a tight schedule so sacrifices needed to be made, morale would be low, the soldier's would be working non-stop. But it would pay off in the end, they would have plenty of down time to rest when it was too cold to be outside.

But it had just been the two of them, working out the details. Lonnie had been adamant in not involving any other Force Captains or command personnel. Stating she would personally handle the redivision of repair squads and guard patrol changes herself. Catra understood her need to keep her help on the down low, most of the ex-horde still held a grudge. She had a long way to go to prove to them she wasn't a power hungry dictator any longer. The heated meeting currently happening around Lonnie's table was about the supply shipments and personnel assigned to rebuild villages around Bright Moon and Salineas coastline.

“Look, I know we need to focus on the repair efforts here. But we also need to fix the damage we caused and mend ties with the other kingdoms. Queen Scorpia demands that her people use their expertise and her kingdom's resources to rebuild Etheria. I agree with her. ” Lonnie huffed. “I need you guys to figure out who's going where and who's staying behind? Every little decision is not my responsibility.”

Lonnie glanced up as Adora and Catra entered her tent. They silently stood at the doorway not wanting to intrude. Melog sat primely beside Catra, sniffing the air with interest. Catra recognized the group of Force Captains, hovering around Lonnie, arguing amongst themselves. Grizzlor stood off to the side, arms folded glowering down at the org chart Lonnie was now brandishing at him like a weapon. He had four soldiers standing stiffly behind him. Each one dressed in full infantry armor, their horde symbol on their chest plate was crudely taken off with silver paint. Illustrating how Grizzlor had sought to have his men try to blend in with the rest of Etheria. No wanting to be associated with the Horde any longer.

Octavia yawned and scratched her scaly, webbed ear, tapping on her pad to review her own personnel chart. Her own set of three soldiers, wearing the aquatic armor of the Hordes Marine forces, stood nearby. They still wore dented chest pieces with the Horde Symbol. The soldier's looked exhausted and ready to drop. The last Catra knew of Octavia's Marine unit. They were stationed along the border supply routes, close to the Northern Reach. Their

orders were to move south at a steady pace towards Bright Moon. They would have been a part of the last contingent of troops to enter the battle and might have avoided the brunt of the fighting. Catra's army was wiped out by Glimmer's forces, thanks to Double Trouble's betrayal that day. She hadn't the courage yet to track down where the remains of that army lay. From personal accounts by other Etherian's she had overheard during her time freeing villages around the Whispering Woods. During the occupation. The Hordes 'Last stand', as they called it. Lay within a deep valley several miles to the west of Half Moon lake. They had been pinned down and ambushed on all sides, so their defeat had been swift and brutal.

Lazlo sat on a crate, his blue, lightly furred skin shiny with sweat. Yellow eyes blinking slowly with exhaustion. The tiny spikes on the top of his head vibrated with agitation at being chewed out by one of his own recently graduated cadets. He had two senior cadet squad leaders in tow. They were standing behind him, each wearing a similar colored jacket as Adora's old one. But in different colors, waiting in an at ease stance for their orders.

Catra narrowed her eyes, these three were the most senior officer's to survive the war and they did not seem to take Lonnie's leadership seriously at all. She had thought Lonnie had the ex-horde well in hand? But it seemed, boosting morale and playing nice worked well for the junior officer's. The younger soldier's she had seen yesterday seemed happy, relaxed and hopeful? But held no weight with the Senior Force Captains. Perhaps things were not going as smoothly as she had perceived in the upper ranks. That kind of easy going command, wasn't going to work with old school, hard as nails military types like these three. They needed solid orders they could depend on and a leader who wasn't a push over. Otherwise, Lonnie was going to have a coupe on her hands by the end of the cold season.

Lonnie needed to adjust how she commanded, these three needed to take her seriously? Otherwise these senior officers would try and take over command for themselves, thinking they could do a better job. The ex-horde would be divided into rival

factions and Scorpia's kingdom would crumble into chaos. Melog blinked, their mane tinting a pale yellow. As they glanced up at Catra, absorbing the waves of anxiety and doubt rippling through their link. Catra did not want that to happen. Scorpia was a Force Captain she must understand how to take command and hold onto it with an iron fist. But the whole time she had worked with the Scorpion, she had been more than happy to take orders and not call the shots. She was aggressive only in battle. In regards to dealing with other people, she would seek happy, peaceful resolution over confrontation. This wishy, washy chain of command must go much further than just Lonnie.

Catra groaned...suddenly wondering what had happened to Scorpia's squad before she was re-assigned to watch her? Perhaps, Hordak had taken them away from her because she had proven herself not fit to command? But why had she still been a Force Captain? Why wasn't she demoted or sent to Beast Island as a failure? It made no sense?

Catra had dealt with Octiavia, Grizzlor and Lazlo countless times during the war. They hadn't taken her seriously at first either. They were all the same rank and a pecking order had to be established. When each one had tried to dominate her in some way. Catra had put each one in their place early on. She would be no one’s whipping boy any longer. Grizzlor was an old veteran who saw everything in black and white, the right way to do things and the wrong. He didn't like change and definitely did not like how Hordak had just given a senior cadet not even graduated yet, a Force Captain's Badge. Just cause the raid upon Thaymor had been a success. It hadn't even been a very big target. Hordak had wanted the people culled and the village destroyed so they could set up a supply depot. Before pushing further into the Whispering Woods. Gizzlor had voiced his opinion behind closed doors, too much of a coward to take his grievance to either Shadow Weaver or Hordak. Spreading rumors that Catra was just a token Force Captain. That she hadn't earned her rank, that Adora had left and she was just the runner up. She had put Grizzlor in his place very quickly, not wanting him to continue to discredit her with the other soldier's behind her back. She had used her natural ability

for stealth to trail him for a few weeks. Since he liked to complain and degrade her with the other soldier's. It would only be a matter of time before he said something incriminating about Hordak or Shadow Weaver that she could use. In time she had him up on charges of spreading insubordination and inciting conflicts between squads. That earned him being locked in solitary for several weeks. He had an attitude adjustment about her after that, knowing she would have him under constant surveillance from now on. Sorting out Octavia, was much more straightforward. During their first mission together to the Salenias Sea Gate. All she had to do was threaten to slash out her other eye and end her military service, if she didn't show her the proper respect. Lazlo never left the base, she never had much to do with him. Since he was charged with training cadets, until the end of the war. When she had forced him to enlist the sophomore and senior cadets into the war effort, he had rejoined the active ranks to keep those cadets under his command as safe as possible. The junior cadets had been reassigned to work in the munition factories to keep the war effort well armed. Lazlo had gone straight to Hordak with his concerns about sending children to fight. But Hordak was already on board with her agenda. Catra had convinced him after their victory at Salineas to throw everything the Horde had at overtaking more territory until Bright Moon fell. That victory was assured thanks to Double Trouble's information about the Rebellion's troop deployments. But as always, Double Trouble's loyalty came with a price and Glimmer paid for it. Leaving Catra betrayed and her army destroyed. Double Trouble had given her one hell of a reality check that day. Then left her in the rubble of the Forge. She had lost everyone and everything that had once mattered. She had hit rock bottom...she had nothing to live for anymore. Barely lucid, the thought of death a seductive balm to ease the pain. Begging Glimmer to finish the job, Hordak had started and end her suffering.

Catra heaved a great sigh of shame, she had been such a deluded fool then. Casting a timid glance towards Adora. Her eyes

shimmering with grateful tears, for being saved, for being forgiven and for being loved.

As the argument began to grow more heated, their voices rose into frustrated shouts. Throwing blame and accusation against each other. Catra figured quickly Lonnie may need a little backup, maybe a bit of mentorship. As to how to get hard headed, cut throat soldier's, who didn't agree with you to do what you wanted. The hard part would be, not falling back into her old ways of fear and intimidation. She had already failed once, in regards to Grizzlor. She hoped to put in a better effort to resolve things without violence this time.

“What's going on ?” Catra folded her arms over her chest and called out to Lonnie, drawing everyone's attention instantly.

“We are attempting to strategize how we are going to implement the rebuilding and supply efforts to Bright Moon and Salineas. While still having enough personnel here to continue repairs and rebuilding Scorpania. The cold season will be upon us before we know it and our people can't still be in tents.” Lonnie sighed and grimaced as she stared down at the map laid out on her desk. The map of Etheria already had the transport routes and resupply depots. Catra had worked out with Scorpia and Mermista back at Mystacor.

“Mind if I help?” Catra offered, shrugging her shoulders. Trying to come off as easy going about the whole thing. Noticing quickly how Grizzlor stiffened, keeping his beady black eyes on her as if expecting a sneak attack. She couldn't blame him, their last encounter had been less than gentle. Octavia grumbled under her breath looking down with a sour frown. Lazlo sighed, pulling out his data pad, seeking to ignore her completely. She had been a tyrannical monster to all three of them near the end of the war. Demanding that they lead their squads into battle after battle without rest or resupply, expecting them to take territory no matter the cost. Neither of them approved of her offer of aid. Melog's ears drooped and they whined softly as they felt her shame and sense of rejection.

“I would mind.” Lazlo snarled, his cadet’s moved a little closer to his side for protection. Staring at their feet and avoiding eye contact with Catra. Melog turned their head to the side and then shook their mane abruptly as if shaking off something unwanted.

Lonnie palmed her face. “Catra...” she groaned, regretting getting the magicat involved yesterday. Her council, when it was just them, had been invaluable. Their encampments would be far more secure and protected from outside attacks. But the other's under her command did not want her around, least of all her input, as to how to command the personnel in the new Scorpion Forces.

Grizzlor shifted his weight, his officer’s hands straying to their stun batons. Octavia merely shrugged, striding forward to confront Catra. Her officer’s fell in behind her, their hands as well hovering over the handles of their weapons. Adora adjusted her stance, accessing the threats. As the aggression in the room quickly rises upon Catra's offer.

“Look....I'm sorry for how I treated you guys. How I abused my power to force you to do things you never wanted to do. ” Catra tried to defuse the coming confrontation, then regarded Lazlo with a pleading look to hear her out. “I regret many things...but right now I just want to help.”

Lazlo stood, his face a mask of cold neutrality. Moving with sharp purpose across the tent to stand before Catra. Hovering over her in the same intimidating manner he had used through her youth. Catra stood her ground, having to crane her neck upward to meet his stern yellow eyes.

“I have duties to attend to.” he stated, brushing past her and out of the tent.

Catra didn't miss the scorn and hatred in his eyes. What she had forced him to do, would never be forgiven. She had made him send children into battle that were not qualified to fight. She didn’t know how many cadets had died in the last days of the war

and was too frightened to check the morality records. That Lazlo would have had to record and transmit back to the base after every battle. She had betrayed him and his years of service to the cadet barracks. Literally spitting on all of his training for her to become an honorable soldier. Who fought to protect their comrades in arms, not put them in harms way. His commitment to her as a child tossed callously into the fire of her ambition. She slowly bowed her head in shame, blinking rapidly to clear the tears before they fell. She couldn't allow herself to look weak in front of the other Force Captains. But Lazlo....he had been one of the moral cornerstones of her childhood. Whenever she felt she had moved closer towards redemption, she would be confronted yet again with how much of a power hungry monster she had been. Melog whimpered and bowed their head, brushing their cheek against Catra's shin. Catra sighed and scratched them behind the ears. Finding solace for the moment in the repetitive movement of her fingers combing through the cool mist of Melog's dark, navy mane. Adora watched Lazlo leave, her eyes tearing up at how hurt and betrayed their old Staff Sergeant had looked towards Catra. She then turned to Catra with a questioning frown. There was so much Catra had yet to tell her about her time commanding the Horde. Catra looked so small, staring meekly at her feet. Her ears were folded down, her tail wrapped around her waist. Unable to lift her gaze from the floor, overcome by her inner demons once again.

"Look, Lonnie. We got things pretty much figured out as to who and how many we want to send out there. The issue is our personnel would be spread too thin so we are reluctant to send out anyone right now." Octavia sighed, returning her focus back onto Lonnie. Ignoring Catra completely, as if she didn't exist anymore.

Grizzlor cleared his throat, butting into Octavia's report. "We already sent what we have for skilled tradesmen and laborers to Mystacor. Until those people get back and help us train more people to do that kind of work. We can't spare enough tradesmen or workers from the factories, refineries or the forge to cover the rebuilding efforts in any more kingdoms. We have a long way to

go yet, retraining our people. All we've known is War? The majority of our people are soldier's. It's going to take some time to turn all those soldier's into farmers, builder's...you name it. Right now, we would have no one to keep the Fright...” Grizzlor cleared his throat again, “I mean Scorpania...on track with its own rebuilding.”

Lonnie sighed heavily. “ Scorpia wants us to send supplies and tradesmen out immediately.”

“Of course I do.” Scorpia's earnest voice invades the meeting.

Adora and Catra turned as the hulking scorpion hybrid ducked into the tent, with Perfuma and Glimmer in toe. Glimmer flashed them a brilliant smile as she entered. Staying back with them as Scorpia and Perfuma walked to the table to hear the full personal report from Grizzlor and Octavia. Scorpia must have already spoken with Lazlo before entering the tent because she never mentioned his absence.

Catra and Adora’s eyes widen in surprise, as they find Jitsu’s sword now sheathed upon Scorpia’s hip in a simple leather scabbard. Scorpia gave no indication that the red lightening crackling from the sword, snapping across her thigh hurt at all. The scorpion hybrid was completely impervious to the sword’s magic, her body absorbing it as easily as breathing.

“That’s Jitsu’s sword?” Adora leaned towards Glimmer, her tone silently asking how?

“After I left you guys on Darla and returned to the Basilica. I ran into Scorpia and Perfuma heading for breakfast. Scorpia already had the sword, stating Huntara gave it to her. She had heard stories that the Princess of the Black Garnet harnessed the magic of red lightning. So she figured her old magic would be compatible with it and that she was headed out. Got a lead on Tri-clops and wasn’t going to squander it.” Glimmer shrugged.

Adora and Catra nodded mutely.

Lonnie quickly directed Scorpia's attention to the map, with its various colored troop marker's. Grizzlor and Octavia crowded around the table as well offering their advice.

Catra sighed and rubbed the back of her neck nervously, she felt cast aside, unneeded and it hurt her pride. Unwilling to stick around and feel out of place she turned on her heel and exited the tent. Melog departed with her, padding close to her side, so their flank brushed against her hip. Adora and Glimmer were quick to follow.

“Why are you guys here?” Adora asked, as they found a couple crates just outside the tent to sit on.

Catra crouched in front of Adora, absently digging into her pack. Wanting to look busy and avoid having to make small talk. Her emotions were raw and she needed to calm down.

“Scorpia's had a long talk with Aunt Casta and decided she would be more useful here in her own kingdom, helping to rebuild Etheria then back at Mystacor since she hasn't managed to access her magic yet.” Glimmer shrugged.

Catra snapped her head up, “I might be able to help her?” She offered, feeling terrible about not reaching out to Scorpia in the last few days. “I was able to guide Mermista to her magic...sorta...” She cringed at the very wet and miserable aftermath of helping the Selineas Princess.

“Perfuma is trying to help, teaching her meditation techniques for focusing and such.” Glimmer pushed the toe of her boot into the dirt.

Catra nodded, that was how Adora managed to reconnect with her magic. It was a worthwhile approach.

Adora opened her mouth to speak, but her voice was interrupted by a sudden tone blaring from Glimmer's communication pad. The

Queen quickly unlatched the pad from her belt as a call activated on the screen.

“HELP!” Bows face filled the screen, his dark eyes wide in panic. As several explosions rocked the jagged, shadowy landscape in the background. The twisted, melted, corrupted chunks of tech surrounded by dark vines, was instantly illuminated. By massive clouds of fire and ash. That spread out like a molten hell-scape behind him. “Entrapta gone nuts!”

“What's going on!” Glimmer shouted into the pad, as both Adora and Catra huddled around her. Staring at the war zone on the screen in horror from just behind the Queen's shoulder's. The dark, ominous jungle behind Bow was on fire, smoke and acrid fumes rolled over the rocky beach front. The pale sand glinted in the sunlight with fragments of metal and shards of tech.

“We landed yesterday at the beach, everything was fine at first. Entrapta called her pet...her name's Michelle by the way.” Bow rambled, turning the screen so they could watch the huge, behemoth of a machine stampeding across the white sand. Chasing several people, dressed in strange light weight space suits down the beachfront. Their faces were covered by smooth helmets, their full visor's reflecting the hazardous coastline. The tallest of the aliens, turned and pointed a blaster back at Entrapta's robot. Sending off several shots of red laser fire back at the metal beast. It scorched the beast's metal hide but did little else to slow it down.

“THIEVES! INVADERS! THIS IS MY ISLAND!” Entrapta's voice screeched from inside the four legged behemoth. Who lowered it's massive head and flung the slowest of the running spacemen into the air. They flew away into the sky, screaming. Sailing over the heads of their companions and crashing hard, sending up a cloud of sand a few yards away.

“We found an alien ship a little further inland this morning, while heading towards the First Ones beacon. A group of people were loading tech from the island on board. Everything was going fine,

I was talking to their leader about their intentions then...Entrapta just lost it....Screaming at them to return the data crystals they stole. We got into a scuffle and they tried to take off. But she used her magic...over metal...and crashed the ship into the beach.” He panned the pad over to the twisted wreckage of the spaceship, which was still smoking. It looked nothing like Darla. The main body was a mesh-mash of wielded together bulkheads. Resembling a sharp, massive arrowhead. With a bulbous sphere attached to the front. It had three narrow cylinders attached on either side of the main hold and one on top. They might have been thrusters like on Darla, the back end still glowing a bright electric blue. Various tubes and cables protruded and snaked across the angled planes of the outer hull like veins. The ship itself looked patched together with spare parts from various other starships, reminiscent of the Fright Zones macabre architecture.

“Now she's just screaming and chasing the crew down....” Bow finished with a groan, moving swiftly to set the pad down on the floor. As he notched an arrow from a crouched position and let fly towards the stampeding metal beast. Just as another crew member screamed and went flying over the gnarled tree tops at the back of the beach front.

“Ok...on our way.” Glimmer stood up, as Catra and Adora instinctively placed their hands on her shoulders preparing to teleport. Melog brushed up against Catra, releasing a tense breath. Their mane already electrified with Catra's violent, aggressive emotions. Her friends were in trouble and she was primed to fight.

Lonnie exited the tent, her pack over her shoulder, just in time to see them disappear in a cloud of sparkles. She stood there for a moment, glaring at the fading cloud of glitter with irritation then huffed and strode away. It looked like they were heading out without them, yet again. She needed to meet up with Kyle and Rogelio before leaving. Their tent was on the far side of this encampment.

“Ughhhh, I really hate your magic....Sparkles.” Catra groaned, closing her eyes and falling to her knees as she sought to ground herself. She felt awful. Her stomach was flipping and her vision was swimming. Melog stood over her, keeping a close eye on the strange beachfront. Full of various chunks of metal that protruded out of the sand in all shapes and sizes like sharp knives.

Adora unsheathed her bow staff from her back, scanning the beach that stretched out before them. That trailed away into a rocky cliffs, filled with looming dark trees, vines and strange colorful shrubs. The corrupted hunks of tech are still glowing beneath the overgrowth. Creating an eerie, blinking aura that hovered like a ghostly specter in the dark unknown beyond the beach.

“Ok...Glim? I think your blink was a little off?” Catra muttered, not seeing Entrapta or the aliens anywhere.

“Nope.” Glimmer quipped, pointing ahead, at the wildly overgrown tree line, knotted with shriveled black vines.

As the bushes rustled violently, before three people in dull grey space suits exploded onto the beach. Charging towards them, the mirrored visor of their helmets now flipped up revealing the terrified faces of children!

“It's going to eat us!” The young man in the lead screamed. He was in his early teens, the tallest of the group of three. With fierce brown eyes, a long fringe of rusty red hair hung over his sharp eyebrows.

A burly looking boy ran behind him, hanging onto the hand of a smaller child. He had a kind, round face with deep brown eyes. The younger child behind him was fighting against his hold.

“We have to go back for Brojee! We can't leave him!” the child cried.

“Run! Litha...just run for now!” The older boy screamed back, his voice was low and raspy.

“What's the plan?” Catra shouted, as they ran full speed towards the kids. Melog raced alongside, ears swiveling in case more threats showed up.

“We gotta get Entrapta to calm down!” Glimmer stated, then blinked away. Reappearing on the broad metal head of Entrapta's robotic beast. One of Bow's net arrows was draped over the beast's rear end. Snapping and twisting uselessly. Several goo arrows were smeared across the beast's legs. Bow had tried everything in his arsenal to get the beast to stop it's rampage. Before, Entrapta had chased the alien crew out of range.

“Let's get those kids someplace safe.” Adora nodded towards Catra.

“As in....Catra gets those kids someplace safe, while I play the hero.” Catra snapped back with a bitter smirk.

“Pretty much.” Adora stated with a smug smile.

“NO! She-Ra!” Catra commanded, her eyes stern but playful.

“I promise...no, She-Ra...we don't need any more problems.” Adora responded, finishing her sentence in a bitter snarl, sprinting ahead.

“Follow me!” Catra waved for the three kids to come to her side.

They nodded in agreement as Adora charged past them. Spinning her bow staff to try and get Entrapta to halt.

Glimmer leaned over the beast's forehead and flashed the large glass cockpit. The beast skidded to a halt instantly as Entrapta saw Adora standing in her way and then was blinded by sparkles.

Forced to raise the cockpit roof. It slowly rose upward with a low whine. Revealing Entrapta with her mask flipped down, sitting in the large seat, hands on two lever's and feet on two petals.

“They were stealing very important and sensitive tech....I had to stop them!” Entrapta defended, glaring threateningly down at the three kids. As they dashed several yards away with Catra in the lead.

“They're just kids!” Adora shouted back glaring up at her furiously, waving a hand towards Catra and the group of children. That was now huddled behind the magicat further down the beach.

Entrapta took a deep breath, then flipped up her mask, staring at the kids as if really seeing them for the first time.

“Stand down Michelle.” Entrapta muttered. The metal beast rumbled in response, all four legs bending as the bulk of it's powerful body slowly eased down onto the sand. Entrapta then hopped out of the cockpit, all fire gone from her demeanor. She looked confused now, uncertain as she tapped her fingertips together shamefully before her stomach.

“We gotta go find Brojee.” The shortest kid whispered, pulling off their helmet. Revealing herself fully to Catra. As a little girl, with cute impish features. Sweet brown eyes and light brown hair pulled up into two, wild spiky buns on the sides of her head.

The two boys nodded, jogging off after the girl.

“Hey!” Catra yelled, as she spun around at the sudden sound of pounding feet. To find the three kids running off back into the trees at the top of the beach. Melog yowled and raced after the kids, gaining ground on them quickly. Catra was quickly in pursuit, clearing the distance easily as she ran on all fours.

The kids screamed and tried to run faster, making it just into the fringe of scrub grass and odd orange bushes with fat leaves at the edge of the beach. Before Catra and Melog cut them off at the tree line.

Catra stood in their way, arms outstretched, glaring each one down. Her mismatched eyes glowing slightly in the half light under the heavy canopy of leaves. Melog stood their ground in front of Catra, blue eyes narrowed to threatening slits. Tail lashing angrily in time with Catra's own tail.

The boys moved closer to each other, fists raised while the little girl hurled her helmet at Catra with all her might.

“You won't capture us, Mutant!” She screamed.

Catra raised her arm to deflect the helmet, it bounced off harmlessly and rolled against a twisted tree trunk.

“I am a magicat...not a mutant!” Catra snarled back. Melog growled, lowering themselves into a defensive crouch.

The little girl whimpered and cowered, taking a couple steps backward to hide behind the two boys.

“Look...we just came to collect a little scrap...we meant no harm.” The heavier set boy stated, glancing over his shoulder as Glimmer blinked into existence with Adora. They had left Entrapta on the beach to cool down.

“Brojee could be hurt...please let us go, so we can find him.” The little girl pleaded.

“Fine, but I'm going with you.” Catra shook a warning finger towards them. She could smell more than just the grease of scrap metal on their suits. It was an ancient, musty scent she had encountered only deep inside the First Ones ruin within the Whispering Woods. Entrapta's freak out might be warranted, these kids were doing more than just scavenging Beast Island.

The two boys shared a look then shrugged, heading off after the little girl deeper into the jungle.

“We'll meet you back at Darla.” Adora called, running after Catra into the underbrush.

Glimmer nodded, teleporting back to the ship. Finding Bow rummaging inside the busted cargo hold of the alien's ship. He is trying to find clues as to what set Entrapta off.

“Hey, Bow?” Glimmer called as she walked up the ramp, moving softly into the shadows of the hold.

Bow was tossing random pieces of scrap metal, wires and cables out of storage boxes, onto the floor.

“I don't get it...” Bow muttered, “What were these guys doing that got Entrapta so mad?”

“They were stealing Data Crystals.” Entrapta's voice burst out from the end of the ramp.

“How did you know that?” Bow huffed, stomping out of the hold and down the ramp.

“Data never lies.” Entrapta pulled out her pad, from a deep pocket at the hip of her overalls. She quickly began to call up a couple readings on the First Ones beacon that lay at the center of the Island.

“The energy inside the ruin is spiking at fifteen minute intervals.” Entrapta stated. “While I was here the first time I managed to get to the mainframe without setting off the security system. But these guys just waltzed right into there and started pulling it apart, taking whatever they could tear up and steal.” Entrapta snarled.

“Including data crystals.” Bow stated sadly.

“So what is with the energy spikes?” Glimmer asked.

“Whatever it is. It's not good.” Entrapta, glanced around in confusion. “I thought those little thieves were with you guys? Where is Adora and Catra, anyway?”

“They went with the kids to search for the crew member you sent flying into the jungle.” Glimmer put her hands on her hips in irritation.

“Oooops.” Entrapta giggled, “We better go get them, it's not safe to go too deep into the island right now....or ever....” Entrapta placed two fingers into her mouth and whistled sharply.

Her lumbering robotic beast charged out of the tree line and down the beach towards them.

“Good girl!” Entrapta exclaimed.

Bow groaned in dread. Glimmer cast him a curious look.

“I could just teleport us to their location?” She offered.

“It's safer to go in Michelle. Just in case we get attacked along the way. Not all the monsters left beast island, you know.”

Bow shivered and cringed, moaning with fear. Glimmer cast him a sympathetic look. While Entrapta turned and walked over to Michelle.

“Com'on!” She exclaimed as she climbed into the cockpit waving for them to crawl in with her.

“This place is weird...” Catra moaned, glancing nervously around the dark forest that now surrounded them. The massive clusters of trees and vines, seemed to have grown around one another and the corrupted chunks of tech. Forming a huge twisted black mass that loomed over them. Crowding close to the narrow path, in large menacing clusters. Creating such an overpowering oppressive presence, that hovered threateningly all around them. It was becoming claustrophobic. Adora reached back and clasped Catra's hand, keeping a wary eye on every shadow. Orange bulbous shrubs grew in various clumps along the narrow path they took. Their fat leaves waved sluggishly in the hot breeze that

blew through the jungle. The jungle grew in a thick, twisting dark mass of slick black bark that blocked huge portions of the path. Endless vines knotted around the strange trunks, hanging in heavy swathes from the looming branches over their heads, ominously ready to fall and entangle them. The vines had an odd effervescent glowing vein running along their length, giving the jungle an eerie, malicious undertone that was making Catra more and more uneasy the deeper they went.

“And scary...” Catra whimpered, her ears folding back as she was darting her gaze around. Twitching at every strange call, filtering out from the darkness beyond the mutated undergrowth. All the scary stories Shadow Weaver had told them about Beast Island's monstrous inhabitants echoing in the back of her mind. The enormous bulk of alien looking trees blocked out the sunlight almost completely. If there were Scorpers, or Razor fins...or Pooka laying in wait she wouldn't see them until they were right on top of them.

“And deadly, so stay alert.” Adora finished, keeping a close eye on the three kids who walked ahead of them. Adora's warning sent an electric charge of fear threw Catra's whole body, she was now primed to fight or run at the first hint of trouble. Melog growled low in their throat, their coat darkening and mane and tail flaring into a bright electric red.

The larger boy had pulled out, what looked like a smaller, sleeker version of a tracker pad from his utility belt. “Brojee activated his homing signal, so we should be able to find him in no time.” He offered the worried little girl walking beside him, a proud, reassuring grin.

The loud, abrasive sounds of the jungle began to ease, slowly falling silent as they moved deeper into the cloying trees and vines. Adora was thankful the discordant waves of the beacon's signal were silent. Enduring the eerie purgatory of this jungle. With its grey half light and curling mists, that held such a melancholy hue was enough. Catra sighed, pulling her hand away from Adora. Wrapping her arms around herself, wallowing in the

cruelty of her past self once more. She had sent Entrapta here...to this cursed island filled with deadly monsters. Terrified and alone, she had to constantly be alert, fighting everyday to stay alive. Until Adora came and rescued her. Catra shuttered and held herself more tightly. She had been so wrapped up in her destructive rage, her need to win. Jealous and resentful of Entrapta for gaining Hordak's approval. Making her feel second best yet again. She had lashed out in her anger not thinking things through. Entrapta had told her at the last moment that the portal might destroy the world, that all the warnings Adora had been spouting since the Crimson Waste were correct. She had been so sick of Adora! She got everything she wanted, everyone wanted Adora....Shadow Weaver left her for Adora. Adora was worthy, perfect, she was good and always won. By that point she was out of her mind with jealousy, with the need for revenge. This time....Hordak would like her more than Entrapta. She would show him her worth...and finally achieve the praise and accolades she deserved! This time Catra would win, she would finally beat Adora and show everyone that she was worth something, that she was powerful and no one would ever make her feel so broken and worthless and miserable ever again.

But of course things didn't go as planned, opening the portal was the biggest mistake she had ever made. The reality beyond that gate had given her the perfect life with Adora, one she had always dreamed of. Then ripped it away, forcing her to confront her true reality. The one in which Adora had left her, in which she wasn't good enough for anyone. Everything she ever wanted had been taken from her and no matter how hard she had worked to prove herself to those in power. It was never enough and Adora was always there to steal her victories. That final resolution that she wasn't worth anything to anyone, that she was evil...a monster. She had given up then, she just wanted it all to end...to know peace and stop feeling all those dark emotions that had been tearing her apart for years. To silence the voices inside that always tormented her. So she had offered herself up to the void....the Nameless One...allowed that dark magic to consume her. Then it had given her life once more in it's own tainted image.

A twisted, corrupted version of herself that was fed by malice and focused only on revenge. It had been exhilarating to feel all that dark power coursing through her, but also terrifying as she had quickly lost her true self to the merciless current of her destructive rage.

“Catra...” Adora's tender voice penetrated the fog of Catra's self loathing.

She jerked when she felt Adora's hand grip her shoulder and snapped her tearful eyes up for just a second. Adora's reassuring smile fell into a concerned frown at how stricken she looked.

“You're in your head...talk to me?” Adora demanded gently.

“Now is not the time for a heart to heart, princess.” Catra shrugged off her concern and quickened her pace. They had fallen behind the kids for the moment and she quickly caught up to them. As they moved into a more narrow bend in the path, blocked by thorny brambles and knotted vines. It was mid day now, but the canopy was so dense it blocked out most of the sunlight. Creating a murky world of near darkness below.

Adora rolled her eyes, Catra was avoiding, yet again. Not wanting to deal with her feelings, at least not the ones that made her feel weak. It was frustrating but understandable, she wasn't exactly the most open about her feelings when she was upset either. Adora sighed and squared her shoulders, she understood that this place could bring back some very awful memories...for both of them.

“Brojee's signal is just a little way up this way.” The dark haired boy declared, clipping his pad back onto his belt now that it was not needed.

“BROJEE!” The little girl bellowed, cupping her hands around her mouth as if that might make her voice louder.

An answering howl erupted from deeper in the jungle. Then a mournful call began to sound in response, that both Adora and

Catra knew well. It was the sudden sound of a thunderous stampede that had all of them ducking and diving for cover on the far side of the trail. As the dried bramble of vines and dead tree roots ahead of them, exploded as a massive creature rushed through it onto the path. It was huge and bulky like a bear. It's red eyes glowed menacingly, saliva dripping from its long snarling jaws. The head was thick, it's features were fierce like a wolf but ten times the size. With no ears or tail to speak of, it was just massive, well packed muscle and covered with a mat of thick black fur. Large spines protruded down its back, that stood up, trembling with pent up energy as if ready to fly from its body like razor sharp projectiles. It had four powerful paws that had long claws now digging into the earth as it swung it's head back and forth, it's snarling muzzle sniffing the air.

“Let's get out of here...” Litha whimpered, pulling on Adora's hand. The little girl was petrified and wanted to run. They were huddled out of view behind a nearby tree, with Adora hovering over her. Pressing the child up against the smooth bark, shielding her smaller frame with her body.

Adora shot Litha a hard look, freezing the little girl in place. Those beasts hunted in pairs, if they ran, before they noticed where the other beast was lurking. They might run right into the second beast and be killed instantly. Adora cut her eyes towards Catra. Who was hiding behind another tree nearby, with the two older boys and Melog. The boys were cowering behind her, glancing nervously around the trees debating if it would be safe to run. Melog was crouched low in the high grass near Catra, ears swiveling to catch any sound of approach. Their body had turned black, mane cracking a dark red. Catra had her back pressed against the tree and was licking her bottom lip. Debating the lower branches hanging over her head.

Adora caught her calculating look and shook her head vehemently.

Catra rolled her eyes, cupped her hands around her eyes and mimicked using binoculars. Pointed upwards into the trees, then

walked her fingers across her arm.

Adora frowned in confusion. “What?” She whispered back loudly.

Catra repeated the hand signals, slower and more methodical this time. Then waited for Adora to acknowledge she understood. Instead the blonde just stared in confusion, shaking her head more forcefully.

Catra huffed and slowly blinked her eyes towards Adora. She was just going to do what she wanted, trying to get Adora to understand her plan silently, with hand signals was beyond frustrating. With a confident smirk, she leaped upward into the branches.

“Catra....no....” Adora hissed, her worried blue eyes following Catra's graceful movements. As she leaped from branch to branch, crawling slowly over the beast's head along a thick bow that twisted into the canopy on the other side of the path.

Melog was shadowing her through the treetops, keeping a close eye on their surroundings. As a companion howl erupted from further behind them.

Adora snapped her eyes back to the foliage, pulling out her bow staff, adjusting her stance to defend the children. She-Ra could barely take on these beasts....how well was she going to defend these kids as just Adora. Her heart was hammering in her chest with fear. As the rustling became more pronounced, the orange fronds wobbled back and forth as the wide leaves were pushed aside. Revealing a terrified young man, who stumbles out and crumpled to his knees before Adora. His dark hair hung low over his forehead, thorns and twigs knotted in the mass of thick hair. He had been moving blindly around the jungle for most of the day, trying to stay hidden from the beasts currently hunting him.

“Brojee!” Litha breathed, scrambling past Adora and wrapping her tiny arms around the boy's neck with a happy, relieved giggle. His

dark blue eyes looked tired but determined, as he wrapped one arm around the little girl holding her close.

Adora nodded, shooting her gaze back up to the trees. Frantically searching for Catra, catching sight of her slinking down a tree trunk carefully, back onto the path a few meters back down the trail. Silently showing that it was clear and safe to return to the path back there.

“Ok, let's get out of here.” Adora pushed away from the tree and moved silently past the two boys cowering behind the tree nearby. The four kids were quick to fall in line behind her, moving as quickly and as silently as they could. As Adora slowly picked through the overgrowth. Pushing branches, heavy with strange pink leaves out of their path so the kids could keep moving. Ducking and weaving around dried out thorny brambles until they were far enough away to return to the trail.

As soon as Adore immerged from the underbrush, she rushed to Catra's side. Quickly pulling her into a tight hug. Catra hummed against her chest, holding her just as tight.

After her last battle with one of those beasts she had no intention of confronting one again.

“I was able to survey the jungle for a few miles from up there. It's mate is further north, heading towards us so I suggest we get a move on.” Catra pulled away, clutching Adora's hand and pulling her down the trail. Several more long howls vibrated over the tree line. Forcing the group to move faster down the trail, casting nervous glances behind them.

“I could see more of those beasts in the distance near the center of the island...there looks to be a First Ones ruin there. Some kind of tall, slender, spire-like structure? ” Catra stated, as they burst from the trees, breaking into a full run down the beach.

“That was the Beacon, that sent out the madness signal. “ Adora nodded.

Catra's eyes widened in fear at the prospect of a signal that drove one insane.

In time, when they had put a good amount of distance between them and the jungle. They stopped running and started to walk. The kids trailed further behind, silent and brooding.

“Those kids were in there at some point, poking around.” Catra leaned into Adora, whispering heavily against Adora's cheek.

Adora cast her an alarmed look.

“I can smell the stench of First Ones all over their suits.” Catra countered.

Adora instinctively raised an arm and sniffed her armpit.

Catra groaned, punching her in the arm. “You are such an idiot!” She drawled.

Adora laughed brightly, as they headed towards the gleaming metal, floating just off shore in the water, that was Darla. The busted, smoking hunk of metal that was the kids ship was buried into the sand nearby.

A flash of light burst into the air, with a shower of sparkles. Just beside Brojee, making the young man jump and yelp believing he was about to be attacked again.

“Thank the Stars!” Glimmer exclaimed, hopping on her toes and quickly wrapping her arms around Catra and Adora.

“We found where those Beasts came from.” Catra chucked a thumb towards the jungle bitterly. They had given Glimmer a report the night they spent at Bright Moon before heading to Dryl.

“Juliet and Bright Moon's guard managed to find the dead beast and the immobile one you guys left in the Woods. She has buried the dead one and the other is locked up behind a containment

spell in the royal stables. She nicknamed them Laser Bears.” Glimmer shrugged. “The guards are still going on nightly patrols, but they haven't found any more wandering around the woods.”

“That’s a good name for them.” Adora shrugged, crossing her arms approvingly.

“That's good, they shouldn't try to engage with them. Adora and I barely managed to survive a battle with those bears, they nearly killed poor Melog.” Catra moaned, giving Melog a grateful pat on the head.

All four of the kids screamed and ducked behind Adora and Catra as the huge metal behemoth that had been attacking them stomped up the beach towards them.

“Good! You found him!” Entrapta's voice exploded from the robot, as it slowly lowered its massive head to the sand. The curved glass cockpit creaked then pulled up, revealing Entrapta at the controls and poor Bow once more folded up in discomfort on the floor by her feet.

Catra snickered behind a hand, at how uncomfortable Bow looked, all curled up like a wadded piece of paper.

“It was way worse when I was in there with King Micah the first time we were here.” Adora leaned over and whispered. Rolling her shoulder at the painful memory of squeezing herself behind Entrapta's chair with Micah.

Catra was amazed they could all fit, chuckling softly. “You guys are so dumb.” She muttered.

Entrapta hopped out, landing hard on her boots. The sand puffing up and rolling away as she stomped angrily over to Brojee. Her hand outstretched as she glared up at the taller young man.

“Data Crystals!” She accused sharply.

Brojee pulled back and puffed out his chest, glaring down at her indignantly.

“I have no idea what you are talking about.” He responded, crossing his arms over his chest. Refusing to answer her accusation.

“Here we go again.” Bow groaned as he climbed out of the cockpit. His movements were clumsy as he had to manoeuvre around the levers and foot petals. Falling ungracefully in a heap to the sand.

Glimmer rushed to his side to help him stand.

“Fine, your ship is going to need repairs so you're not going anywhere.” Entrapta shrugged, walking away with a confidant stride. She whistled for Michelle to follow her as she headed back down the beach.

“What's going on?” Adora asked Bow, who released a long suffering sigh. Pulling out his tracker pad to show her and Catra the energy readings coming off the First Ones beacon at the center of the island.

“Entrapta believes these kids stole data crystals from the ruin and set off the security protocols.” He showed them the spikes in energy.

“Well, Last time, I stole a data crystal. Your castle tried to kill me with spiders.” Catra offered. “So it totally explains the Laser Bears.”

Adora nodded, “The first ones had their relics protected by security beasts. Those giant centipedes back at the Northern Reach were protecting tech as well”

“That Entrapta stole and used to power the portal.” Catra countered, with a grimace. “Perhaps we should return that to the Northern Reach some time. I'm sure those things are still terrorizing the area.”

Glimmer groaned and rolled her eyes. “Seriously!”

Catra merely shrugged. “Lets just stay focused on fixing this problem for now. Laser Bears on the mainland are not good for the locals.”

“Right.” Bow nodded. “So we need to return what they stole and turn off the security program.” His focus was drawn inward. “So we can access the mainframe inside the beacon and steal this First Ones tech for ourselves.”

“That's not hypocritical of you at all.” Catra groused.

“It's my island!” Bow snarked with a teasing grin. Trying to lighting the hypocrisy of the whole situation.

Catra rolled her eyes.

Adora watched the kids trudge down the beach to their busted ship, she felt sorry for them and curious about them as well.

“I want to find out how they found Etheria and why they are taking scrap from Beast Island?” Adora called back to Catra, Bow and Glimmer. As she moved towards the kids, as if pulled by some unseen force.

Adora walked up beside Brojee and offered him a warm, disarming smile.

“I'm Adora.” She introduced herself.

“Brojee. This is my little sister Litha and our friends. Caz and Drissi.” He nodded towards the three younger kids walking a few yards away.

“Sorry about your ship.” She offered.

“Yeah.” he breathed, not making eye contact. A few moments later he looked up, his deep blue eyes focused ahead with a dark and distant look.

“We never meant any harm. We're just Scrappers. We land on planets and collect junk and anything else that might fetch a good price.” He stated. “We're just trying to get by.”

“How did you find Etheria?” Adora asked.

“Our ship has a program that searches the galaxy for tech signatures. This island gave off a huge flare on our sensors, so we came to investigate. Finding an ancient First Ones ruin that was still intact was an amazing find. There isn't much left of the First Ones in the universe anymore. Between Horde Prime destroying planets, Lord Skeletor's forces pillaging them for magic relics and Emperor Flogg....enslaving what was left of the Horde ravaged worlds. We're all just trying to survive.” he gave Adora a bitter smirk.

Adora understood a little about the struggle out there, from her brief conversation with the Star Siblings back in the crystal caves.

“Well, you don't have to worry about Horde Prime anymore. I took care of him.” Adora advised proudly.

Brojee looked her up and down with a confused frown.

“Well...She-Ra took care of him...she just rents my body.” Adora chuckled, trying to make light of the vast amounts of magical power she laid claim to.

Brojee’s jaw dropped, the grim veil of worry that had been etched in his blue eyes lifted. Replaced by a faint glow of hope. Then it all crumbled away in moments into fear and distrust.

“Are you serious?” He breathed. “That's a bit hard to believe.” His brows furrowed as his lips thinned with disbelief. As all his positive feelings dissolved into skepticism.

Adora huffed, not liking the jaded lack of trust. She needed to prove herself. Give this young man back his hope for the future. She reached out with her hand without thinking it through.

Focused only on giving this young man hope, her eyes glowed a brilliant blue and the Sword of Protection formed in her hand.

“ADORA!” Catra screamed in terror. Knowing that She-Ra’s magic would soon follow, transforming Adora.

The sword dissolved and Adora’s eyes widened in sudden fear. Then she bowed her head and cringed.

“Sorry! Sorry!” She shouted back, heart hammering in terror against her chest. That was incredibly stupid, she could have easily transformed into the infected version of She-Ra.

Bow and Glimmer jogged up beside her and gave her concerned looks. While Catra's stern presence hovered behind her. The heat of her angry glare burning into her shoulder blades.

Adora never looked back, knowing how foolish she had acted and duly chastised for it.

“Thank you for freeing us from Prime!” Brojee exclaimed, offering her a beaming smile of gratitiude.

His three younger crewmates stopped mid stride and turned in amazement to Adora.

“You destroyed Prime?” Caz gasped in astonishment.

Adora merely nodded with a proud smile.

“He’s really, really, gone!” Litha hopped on her toes, her eyes shining with happiness and relief.

“Yes. Adora destroyed him a few weeks back, after our planet’s rebellion defeated his forces.” Glimmer stated, grinning with pride at Adora. Who was now seeking to act humble, by rubbing the back of her neck and blushing.

“That’s amazing! I am going to get on the com-stream and get the word out!” Drissi pumped his fists in the air. Whooping and

hollering for joy, doing an excited dance of triumph.

“Be careful what frequencies you use. I only want you casting on friendly channels!” Brojee confronted Drissi with a stern look.

“Right, right.” Drissi nodded. “I will be careful.”

“We do not want to draw unwanted attention to this planet.” Brojee kept on, as if he had to push his concerns to make Drissi take it seriously.

“We already have an Eternian problem.” Catra groused.

“Eternian’s aren’t all bad.” Brojee turned to regard her with a shrug. “King Randor has been funding the Rebellion against Skeletor for years now.”

Adora’s eyes flew wide in surprise as a smile spread over her face. Turning to confront Catra, with hope gleaming in her eyes that her family wasn’t as bad as Jitsu had led them to believe.

“Wow...She-Ra…..I’ve heard of her...she has been missing for a thousand years. So you're a Master of the Universe.” Brojee grinned, bowing his head slightly in supplication. “There aren't many of you left out there either.”

Adora's eyes widened in shock. “There are more people out there like me....are they First Ones?”

“Not all....He-Man is a First One...he is from Eternia. Last we heard of him, he was on Primus with his rebels, trying to bring peace between two waring factions there.” Brojee answered, tapping his chin.

“Wow....” Adora breathed, the universe waiting for them out there seemed so exciting. She couldn't wait to get out there and start doing some good herself....her excitement soon soured. As she remembered her magic was cursed somehow and needed to get that figured out first.

“The tech scattered out here along the beach and along the perimeter of the jungle, is pretty generic. Pieces of slag from ancient spaceships and war machinery. But near the ruin! That's were all the good stuff is.” Brojee sighed, “So we got greedy and started dismantling the outer halls. Taking motherboards, processing units. I don't know anything about data crystals, but maybe the stuff we took was enough to set off the security system.”

“Well Entrapta and I already went through your hold and we didn't find anything important enough to set off the Ruin.” Bow stated, coming up beside Brojee on his other side. Subtly boxing him in between Adora. Bow was silently asserting himself, as Glimmer moved in behind Brojee. The three of them were intimidating the young man. It was a subtle group effort, Catra wondered if the three even realized what they were doing? Brojee suddenly looked nervous and uncomfortable, glancing from Adora to Bow and then over his shoulder to Glimmer.

Catra took note of how Bow's demeanor was more stiff, as if acting like this was really out of his comfort zone. But time was not on their side, they had more pressing problems to deal with by the name of Triclops. They needed to get Beast Island locked back down so he could work on the Drone. Brojee cut his eyes towards Bow and swallowed.

“Catra and I already tangled with a couple of those Laser Bears back on the mainland. They nearly killed us. We need to shut off the security protocol and contain those beasts, before more lives are threatened. They are searching from something you stole?” Adora stated, her eyes searching Brojee's hard expression for understanding, for compassion.

“Whatever. Crap happens. Life’s hard for everyone. Learn to deal!” Caz stated snidely, pulling off his helmet. Scrubbing his hand roughly threw this spikey, red hair.

“Those Bears are not our fault!” Drissi shouted, yanking off his helmet. To reveal short dark hair, cut close to his scalp. His voice

wavering with doubt and guilt.

“Stop trying to make us feel bad.” Caz hung his head, his thick fringe of red hair falling over his eyes.

Litha said nothing, her head hanging low, watching as the sand moved aside. As she shuffled the toes of her boots threw the pale white beach.

“We're just surviving,” Brojee sighed. “But I'm responsible for these kids. If they took something, I'll find out.” He turned and regarded Adora with a sad frown. “We never meant to cause any harm.”

Adora nodded, slowing down to allow Brojee to stride ahead and catch up to his crew.

Chapter End Notes

Well, that the end of part two. I hope you all enjoyed it. I will be posting the next part soon. Thank you all for leaving comments and Kudos I really appreciate them.

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!